

Cypher System Reference Document

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Cypher System Reference Document

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Contents

I Core Rules 7

1 Introduction 9

1.1	How to Play the Cypher System	9
1.1.1	When Do You Roll?	9
1.1.2	Task Difficulty	9
1.1.3	Combat	9
1.1.4	Special Rolls	10
1.1.5	Glossary	10
1.1.6	Range and speed	10
1.1.7	Experience Points	11
1.1.8	Cyphers	11
1.1.9	Other Dice	11
1.1.10	Creating Your Character	11
1.1.11	Pool, Edge and Effort	12
1.1.12	Character Tiers	13
1.1.13	Character Descriptor, Type, and Focus	13
1.1.14	Special Abilities	14
1.1.15	Skills	14
1.1.16	Type	15
1.1.17	Player Intrusion	15
1.1.18	Defense Task	15

2 Types 19

2.1	Warrior	19
2.1.1	Warrior Stat Pools	19
2.1.2	Warrior Background Connection	19
2.1.3	Warrior Player Intrusions	19
2.1.4	First-tier Warrior	19
2.1.5	Second-tier Warrior	20
2.1.6	Third-tier Warrior	20
2.1.7	Fourth-tier Warrior	20
2.1.8	Fifth-tier Warrior	21
2.1.9	Sixth-tier Warrior	21
2.1.10	Warrior Example	21
2.2	Adept	21
2.2.1	Adept Player Intrusions	22
2.2.2	Adept Stat Pools	22
2.2.3	Adept Background Connection	22
2.2.4	First-tier Adept	22
2.2.5	Second-tier Adept	22
2.2.6	Third-tier Adept	22
2.2.7	Fourth-tier Adept	23
2.2.8	Fifth-tier Adept	23
2.2.9	Sixth-tier Adept	23
2.2.10	Adept Example	24
2.3	Explorer	24
2.3.1	Explorer Player Intrusions	24
2.3.2	Explorer Stat Pools	24
2.3.3	Explorer Background Connection	24
2.3.4	First-Tier Explorer	24
2.3.5	Second-Tier Explorer	25

2.3.6	Third-Tier Explorer	26
2.3.7	Fourth-Tier Explorer	26
2.3.8	Fifth-Tier Explorer	26
2.3.9	Sixth-Tier Explorer	26
2.3.10	Explorer Example	26
2.4	Speaker	27
2.4.1	Speaker Player Intrusions	27
2.4.2	Speaker Stat Pools	27
2.4.3	Speaker Background Connection	27
2.4.4	First-Tier Speaker	27
2.4.5	Second-Tier Speaker	27
2.4.6	Third-Tier Speaker	28
2.4.7	Fourth-Tier Speaker	28
2.4.8	Fifth-Tier Speaker	28
2.4.9	Sixth-Tier Speaker	29
2.4.10	Speaker Example	29

3 Fantasy Character Options 31

3.1	Prepared vs. Spontaneous Spellcasting	32
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4 Further Customization 33

4.1	Modifying Type Aspects	33
4.2	Drawbacks and Penalties	33
4.3	Flavors	33
4.3.1	Stealth Flavor	33
4.3.2	Technology Flavor	34
4.3.3	Magic Flavor	35
4.3.4	Combat Flavor	35
4.3.5	Skills and Knowledge Flavor	36

5 Descriptor 37

5.1	Descriptors	37
5.1.1	Appealing	38
5.1.2	Beneficent	38
5.1.3	Brash	38
5.1.4	Calm	38
5.1.5	Chaotic	39
5.1.6	Charming	39
5.1.7	Clever	39
5.1.8	Clumsy	39
5.1.9	Craven	40
5.1.10	Creative	40
5.1.11	Cruel	40
5.1.12	Dishonorable	41
5.1.13	Doomed	41
5.1.14	Empathic	41
5.1.15	Exiled	42
5.1.16	Fast	42
5.1.17	Foolish	42
5.1.18	Graceful	42
5.1.19	Guarded	43
5.1.20	Hardy	43
5.1.21	Hideous	43
5.1.22	Honorable	43
5.1.23	Impulsive	44
5.1.24	Inquisitive	44
5.1.25	Intelligent	44
5.1.26	Intuitive	45
5.1.27	Jovial	45
5.1.28	Kind	45
5.1.29	Learned	45
5.1.30	Lucky	46
5.1.31	Mad	46

5.1.32	Mechanical	46	6.4.37	Grows to Towering Heights	60
5.1.33	Mysterious	46	6.4.38	Has a Thousand Faces	60
5.1.34	Mystical	47	6.4.39	Helps Their Friends	60
5.1.35	Naive	47	6.4.40	Howls at the Moon	60
5.1.36	Perceptive	47	6.4.41	Hunts	60
5.1.37	Resilient	47	6.4.42	Ignores Physical Distance	60
5.1.38	Risk-taking	48	6.4.43	Infiltrates	60
5.1.39	Rugged	48	6.4.44	Interprets the Law	60
5.1.40	Sharp-eyed	48	6.4.45	Is Idolized by Millions	61
5.1.41	Skeptical	48	6.4.46	Is Licensed to Carry	61
5.1.42	Stealthy	49	6.4.47	Is Wanted by the Law	61
5.1.43	Strong	49	6.4.48	Keeps a Magic Ally	61
5.1.44	Strong-willed	49	6.4.49	Leads	61
5.1.45	Swift	49	6.4.50	Learns Quickly	61
5.1.46	Tongue-tied	49	6.4.51	Lives in the Wilderness	61
5.1.47	Tough	50	6.4.52	Looks for Trouble	61
5.1.48	Vicious	50	6.4.53	Loves the Void	62
5.1.49	Virtuous	50	6.4.54	Masters Defense	62
5.1.50	Weird	50	6.4.55	Masters Spells	62
5.2	Customizing Descriptors	51	6.4.56	Masters the Swarm	62
5.3	Species as descriptor	51	6.4.57	Masters Weaponry	62
6	Focus	53	6.4.58	Metes Out Justice	62
6.1	Choosing Foci	53	6.4.59	Moves Like a Cat	62
6.2	Focus Connections	53	6.4.60	Moves Like the Wind	62
6.3	Story Behind the Focus	55	6.4.61	Murders	63
6.4	Foci	55	6.4.62	Needs No Weapon	63
6.4.1	Abides in Stone	55	6.4.63	Never Says Die	63
6.4.2	Absorbs Energy	55	6.4.64	Operates Undercover	63
6.4.3	Awakens Dreams	56	6.4.65	Performs Feats of Strength	63
6.4.4	Battles Robots	56	6.4.66	Pilots Starcraft	63
6.4.5	Bears a Halo of Fire	56	6.4.67	Plays Too Many Games	63
6.4.6	Blazes With Radiance	56	6.4.68	Rages	63
6.4.7	Brandishes an Exotic Shield	56	6.4.69	Rides the Lightning	64
6.4.8	Builds Robots	56	6.4.70	Runs Away	64
6.4.9	Calculates the Incalculable	56	6.4.71	Sailed Beneath the Jolly Roger	64
6.4.10	Channels Divine Blessings	56	6.4.72	Scavenges	64
6.4.11	Commands Mental Powers	57	6.4.73	Sculpts Hard Light	64
6.4.12	Conducts Weird Science	57	6.4.74	Sees Beyond	64
6.4.13	Consorts with the Dead	57	6.4.75	Separates Mind From Body	64
6.4.14	Controls Beasts	57	6.4.76	Shepherds the Community	64
6.4.15	Controls Gravity	57	6.4.77	Shepherds Spirits	65
6.4.16	Copies Superpowers	57	6.4.78	Shreds the Walls of the World	65
6.4.17	Crafts Illusions	57	6.4.79	Shrinks to Minute Size	65
6.4.18	Crafts Unique Objects	57	6.4.80	Siphons Power	65
6.4.19	Dances with Dark Matter	58	6.4.81	Slays Monsters	65
6.4.20	Defends the Gate	58	6.4.82	Soars on Amazing Wings	65
6.4.21	Defends the Weak	58	6.4.83	Solves Mysteries	65
6.4.22	Descends From Nobility	58	6.4.84	Speaks for the Land	65
6.4.23	Doesn't Do Much	58	6.4.85	Stands Like a Bastion	66
6.4.24	Drives Like A Maniac	58	6.4.86	Stretches	66
6.4.25	Emerged From the Obelisk	58	6.4.87	Takes Animal Shape	66
6.4.26	Employs Magnetism	58	6.4.88	Talks to Machines	66
6.4.27	Entertains	58	6.4.89	Throws With Deadly Accuracy	66
6.4.28	Exists in Two Places at Once	59	6.4.90	Thunders	66
6.4.29	Exists Partially Out of Phase	59	6.4.91	Touches The Sky	66
6.4.30	Explores Dark Places	59	6.4.92	Travels Through Time	66
6.4.31	Fights Dirty	59	6.4.93	Was Foretold	67
6.4.32	Fights With Panache	59	6.4.94	Wears a Sheen of Ice	67
6.4.33	Flies Faster Than a Bullet	59	6.4.95	Wears Power Armor	67
6.4.34	Focuses Mind Over Matter	59	6.4.96	Wields Invisible Force	67
6.4.35	Fuses Flesh and Steel	59	6.4.97	Wields Two Weapons at Once	67
6.4.36	Fuses Mind and Machine	59	6.4.98	Works for a Living	67
			6.4.99	Works Miracles	67

6.4.100 Works the Back Alleys	67	7.25 Abilities—Y	168
6.4.101 Works the System	68	7.26 Abilities—Z	169
6.4.102 Would Rather Be Reading	68		
6.4.103 Uses Wild Magic	68	8 Equipment	171
6.4.104 Walks the Wild Woods	68	8.1 Currency and Prices	171
6.4.105 Wields an Enchanted Weapon	68	8.2 Price Categories	171
6.5 Creating New Foci	68	8.3 Using The Price Categories	171
6.5.1 Focus Categories	68	8.4 Level of Equipment	171
6.5.2 Choosing Abilities By Relative Power	69	8.5 Armor	172
6.5.3 Balancing Activities	69	8.5.1 Using Armor	172
6.5.4 Ability Guidelines are not Prescriptive	69	8.5.2 Fantasy Armor Descriptions	172
6.5.5 Ability Swap	69	8.6 Weapons	173
6.5.6 Concept and Category	69	8.6.1 Fantasy Weapons Descriptions	173
6.5.7 Abilities That Reference Other Abilities	69	8.6.2 Explosive Weapons	175
6.5.8 Creating Brand-New Abilities	70	8.7 Adventuring Equipment Descriptions	175
6.5.9 Choose GM Intrusions	70	8.8 Miscellaneous Items and Services	176
6.5.10 Focus Categories	70	8.9 Fantasy Clothing Descriptions	177
6.6 Customizing Foci	78	8.10 Animal And Gear Descriptions	177
7 Abilities	79	9 Cyphers & Artifacts	179
7.1 Ability Categories and Relative Power	79	9.1 CYPHERS	179
7.1.1 Attack Skill	79	9.2 Artifacts	179
7.1.2 Companion	80	9.2.1 Finding, Identifying, and Using Artifacts	179
7.1.3 Control	81		
7.1.4 Craft	81	10 Rules of the Game	181
7.1.5 Cure	82	10.1 Key Concepts	181
7.1.6 Environment	83	10.2 Taking Action	182
7.1.7 Information	83	10.3 Determining Task Stat	182
7.1.8 Meta	84	10.4 Determining Task Difficulty	182
7.1.9 Movement	87	10.5 Modifying The Difficulty	182
7.1.10 Protection	87	10.6 Skills	183
7.1.11 Senses	89	10.7 Assets	183
7.1.12 Social	90	10.8 Effort	183
7.1.13 Special Attack	90	10.9 Rolling the Die	183
7.1.14 Support	92	10.10 The Player Always Rolls	183
7.1.15 Task	93	10.11 Special Rolls	183
7.1.16 Transform	95	10.12 GM Intrusion	184
7.2 Abilities—A	97	10.13 Minor Effect	184
7.2.1 Animal Form Minor Abilities Table	98	10.14 Major Effect	184
7.3 Abilities—B	101	10.15 Retrying a Task after failure	184
7.4 Abilities—C	105	10.16 Initial Cost	185
7.5 Abilities—D	110	10.17 Distance	185
7.6 Abilities—E	115	10.18 Other Distances	185
7.7 Abilities—F	119	10.19 Timekeeping	185
7.8 Abilities—G	123		
7.9 Abilities—H	126	11 Encounters, Rounds, And Initiative	187
7.10 Abilities—I	128	11.1 A Closer Look At Situations That Don't In-	
7.11 Abilities—J	132	volve PCs	187
7.12 Abilities—K	133	11.2 Actions	187
7.13 Abilities—L	134	11.2.1 Action: Attack	188
7.14 Abilities—M	136	11.2.2 Action: Activate a Special Ability	194
7.15 Abilities—N	141	11.2.3 Action: Move	194
7.16 Abilities—O	142	11.2.4 Action: Wait	195
7.17 Abilities—P	144	11.2.5 Action: Defend	195
7.18 Abilities—Q	147	11.2.6 Action: Do Something Else	195
7.19 Abilities—R	148		
7.20 Abilities—S	152	II Appendices	197
7.21 Abilities—T	159	List of Tables	199
7.22 Abilities—U	163		
7.23 Abilities—V	164	Index	201
7.24 Abilities—W	165		

Part I

Core Rules

Chapter 1

Introduction

1.1 How to Play the Cypher System

The rules of the Cypher System are quite straightforward at their heart, as all of gameplay is based around a few core concepts.

This chapter provides a brief explanation of how to play the game, and it's useful for learning the game. Once you understand the basic concepts, you'll likely want to reference Rules of the Game for a more in-depth treatment.

The Cypher System uses a twenty-sided die (1d20) to determine the results of most actions. Whenever a roll of any kind is called for and no die is specified, roll a d20.

The game master sets a difficulty for any given task. There are ten degrees of difficulty. Thus, the difficulty of a task can be rated on a scale of 1 to 10.

Each difficulty has a target number associated with it. The target number is always three times the task's difficulty, so a difficulty 1 task has a target number of 3, but a difficulty 4 task has a target number of 12. To succeed at the task, you must roll the target number or higher. See the Task Difficulty table for guidance in how this works.

Character skills, favorable circumstances, or excellent equipment can decrease the difficulty of a task. For example, if a character is trained in climbing, they turn a difficulty 6 climb into a difficulty 5 climb. This is called easing the difficulty by one step (or just easing the difficulty, which assumes it's eased by one step). If they are specialized in climbing, they turn a difficulty 6 climb into a difficulty 4 climb. This is called easing the difficulty by two steps. Decreasing the difficulty of a task can also be called easing a task. Some situations increase, or hinder, the difficulty of a task. If a task is hindered, it increases the difficulty by one step.

A skill is a category of knowledge, ability, or activity relating to a task, such as climbing, geography, or persuasiveness. A character who has a skill is better at completing related tasks than a character who lacks the skill. A character's level of skill is either trained (reasonably skilled) or specialized (very skilled). If you are trained in a skill relating to a task, you ease the difficulty of that task by one step. If you are specialized, you ease the difficulty by two steps. A skill can never decrease a task's difficulty by more than two steps.

Anything else that reduces difficulty (help from an ally, a particular piece of equipment, or some other advantage) is referred to as an asset. Assets can never decrease a task's difficulty by more than two steps.

You can also decrease the difficulty of a given task by applying Effort. (Effort is described in more detail in the Rules of the Game chapter.) To sum up, three things can decrease a

task's difficulty: skills, assets, and Effort.

If you can ease a task so its difficulty is reduced to 0, you automatically succeed and don't need to make a roll.

1.1.1 When Do You Roll?

Any time your character attempts a task, the GM assigns a difficulty to that task, and you roll a d20 against the associated target number.

When you jump from a burning vehicle, swing an axe at a mutant beast, swim across a raging river, identify a strange device, convince a merchant to give you a lower price, craft an object, use a power to control a foe's mind, or use a blaster rifle to carve a hole in a wall, you make a d20 roll.

However, if you attempt something that has a difficulty of 0, no roll is needed—you automatically succeed. Many actions have a difficulty of 0. Examples include walking across the room and opening a door, using a special ability to negate gravity so you can fly, using an ability to protect your friend from radiation, or activating a device (that you already understand) to erect a force field. These are all routine actions and don't require rolls.

Using skill, assets, and Effort, you can ease the difficulty of potentially any task to 0 and thus negate the need for a roll. Walking across a narrow wooden beam is tricky for most people, but for an experienced gymnast, it's routine. You can even ease the difficulty of an attack on a foe to 0 and succeed without rolling.

If there's no roll, there's no chance for failure. However, there's also no chance for remarkable success (in the Cypher System, that usually means rolling a 19 or 20, which are called special rolls; the Rules of the Game chapter also discusses special rolls).

1.1.2 Task Difficulty

1.1.3 Combat

Making an attack in combat works the same way as any other roll: the GM assigns a difficulty to the task, and you roll a d20 against the associated target number.

The difficulty of your attack roll depends on how powerful your opponent is. Just as tasks have a difficulty from 1 to 10, creatures have a level from 1 to 10. Most of the time, the difficulty of your attack roll is the same as the creature's level. For example, if you attack a level 2 bandit, it's a level 2 task, so your target number is 6.

It's worth noting that players make all die rolls. If a character attacks a creature, the player makes an attack roll. If a creature attacks a character, the player makes a defense roll.

The damage dealt by an attack is not determined by a roll—it's a flat number based on the weapon or attack used. For example, a spear always does 4 points of damage.

Your Armor characteristic reduces the damage you take from attacks directed at you. You get Armor from wearing physical armor (such as a leather jacket in a modern game or chainmail in a fantasy setting) or from special abilities. Like weapon damage, Armor is a flat number, not a roll. If you're attacked, subtract your Armor from the damage you take. For example, a leather jacket gives you +1 to Armor, meaning that you take 1 less point of damage from attacks. If a mugger hits you with a knife for 2 points of damage while you're wearing a leather jacket, you take only 1 point of damage. If your Armor

reduces the damage from an attack to 0, you take no damage from that attack.

When you see the word “Armor” capitalized in the game rules (other than in the name of a special ability), it refers to your Armor characteristic—the number you subtract from incoming damage. When you see the word “armor” with a lowercase “a,” it refers to any physical armor you might wear. Typical physical weapons come in three categories: light, medium and heavy.

Light weapons inflict only 2 points of damage, but they ease attack rolls because they are fast and easy to use. Light weapons are punches, kicks, clubs, knives, handaxes, rapiers, small pistols, and so on. Weapons that are particularly small are light weapons.

Medium weapons inflict 4 points of damage. Medium weapons include swords, battleaxes, maces, crossbows, spears, pistols, blasters, and so on. Most weapons are medium. Anything that could be used in one hand (even if it’s often used in two hands, such as a quarterstaff or spear) is a medium weapon.

Heavy weapons inflict 6 points of damage, and you must use two hands to attack with them. Heavy weapons are huge swords, great hammers, massive axes, halberds, heavy crossbows, blaster rifles, and so on. Anything that must be used in two hands is a heavy weapon.

1.1.4 Special Rolls

When you roll a natural 19 (the d20 shows “19”) and the roll is a success, you also have a minor effect. In combat, a minor effect inflicts 3 additional points of damage with your attack, or, if you’d prefer a special result, you could decide instead that you knock the foe back, distract them, or something similar. When not in combat, a minor effect could mean that you perform the action with particular grace. For example, when jumping down from a ledge, you land smoothly on your feet, or when trying to persuade someone, you convince them that you’re smarter than you really are. In other words, you not only succeed but also go a bit further.

When you roll a natural 20 (the d20 shows “20”) and the roll is a success, you also have a major effect. This is similar to a minor effect, but the results are more remarkable. In combat, a major effect inflicts 4 additional points of damage with your attack, but again, you can choose instead to introduce a dramatic event such as knocking down your foe, stunning them, or taking an extra action. Outside of combat, a major effect means that something beneficial happens based on the circumstance. For example, when climbing up a cliff wall, you make the ascent twice as fast. When a roll grants you a major effect, you can choose to use a minor effect instead if you prefer.

In combat (and only in combat), if you roll a natural 17 or 18 on your attack roll, you add 1 or 2 additional points of damage, respectively. Neither roll has any special effect options—just the extra damage.

(For more information on special rolls and how they affect combat and other interactions, see Rules of the Game.)

Rolling a natural 1 is always bad. It means that the GM introduces a new complication into the encounter.

1.1.5 Glossary

Game master (GM): The player who doesn’t run a character, but instead guides the flow of the story and runs all the NPCs.

Nonplayer character (NPC): Characters run by the GM. Think of them as the minor characters in the story, or the villains or opponents. This includes any kind of creature as well as people.

Party: A group of player characters (and perhaps some NPC allies).

Player character (PC): A character run by a player rather than the GM. Think of the PCs as the main characters in the story.

Player: The players who run characters in the game.

Session: A single play experience. Usually lasts a few hours. Sometimes one adventure can be accomplished in a session. More often, one adventure is multiple sessions.

Adventure: A single portion of the campaign with a beginning and an end. Usually defined at the beginning by a goal put forth by the PCs and at the end by whether or not they achieve that goal.

Campaign: A series of sessions strung together with an overarching story (or linked stories) with the same player characters. Often, but not always, a campaign involves a number of adventures.

Character: Anything that can act in the game. Although this includes PCs and human NPCs, it also technically includes creatures, aliens, mutants, automatons, animate plants, and so on. The word “creature” is usually synonymous.

1.1.6 Range and speed

Distance is simplified into four categories: immediate, short, long, and very long.

Immediate distance from a character is within reach or within a few steps. If a character stands in a small room, everything in the room is within immediate distance. At most, immediate distance is 10 feet (3 m).

Short distance is anything greater than immediate distance but less than 50 feet (15 m) or so.

Long distance is anything greater than short distance but less than 100 feet (30 m) or so.

Very long distance is anything greater than long distance but less than 500 feet (150 m) or so. Beyond that range, distances are always specified—1,000 feet (300 m), a mile (1.5 km), and so on.

The idea is that it’s not necessary to measure precise distances. Immediate distance is right there, practically next to the character. Short distance is nearby. Long distance is farther off. Very long distance is really far off.

All weapons and special abilities use these terms for ranges. For example, all melee weapons have immediate range—they are close-combat weapons, and you can use them to attack anyone within immediate distance. A thrown knife (and most other thrown weapons) has short range. A bow has long range. An Adept’s Onslaught ability also has short range.

A character can move an immediate distance as part of another action. In other words, they can take a few steps over to the control panel and activate a switch. They can lunge across a small room to attack a foe. They can open a door and step through.

A character can move a short distance as their entire action for a turn. They can also try to move a long distance as their entire action, but the player might have to roll to see if the character slips, trips, or stumbles as the result of moving so far so quickly.

For example, if the PCs are fighting a group of cultists, any character can likely attack any cultist in the general melee—they're all within immediate range. Exact positions aren't important. Creatures in a fight are always moving, shifting, and jostling, anyway. However, if one cultist stayed back to fire a pistol, a character might have to use their entire action to move the short distance required to attack that foe. It doesn't matter if the cultist is 20 feet (6 m) or 40 feet (12 m) away—it's simply considered short distance. It does matter if the cultist is more than 50 feet (15 m) away because that distance would require a long or very long move.

(Many rules in this system avoid the cumbersome need for precision. Does it really matter if the ghost is 13 feet away from you or 18? Probably not. That kind of needless specificity only slows things down and draws away from, rather than contributes to, the story.)

1.1.7 Experience Points

Experience points (XP) are rewards given to players when the GM intrudes on the story (this is called GM intrusion) with a new and unexpected challenge. For example, in the middle of combat, the GM might inform the player that they drop their weapon. However, to intrude in this manner, the GM must award the player 2 XP. The rewarded player, in turn, must immediately give one of those XP to another player and justify the gift (perhaps the other player had a good idea, told a funny joke, performed an action that saved a life, and so on).

Alternatively, the player can refuse the GM intrusion. If they do so, they don't get the 2 XP from the GM, and they must also spend 1 XP that they already have. If the player has no XP to spend, they can't refuse the intrusion.

The GM can also give players XP between sessions as a reward for making discoveries during an adventure. Discoveries are interesting facts, wondrous secrets, powerful artifacts, answers to mysteries, or solutions to problems (such as where the kidnappers are keeping their victim or how the PCs repair the starship). You don't earn XP for killing foes or overcoming standard challenges in the course of play. Discovery is the soul of the Cypher System.

Experience points are used primarily for character advancement (for details, see the Creating Your Character chapter), but a player can also spend 1 XP to reroll any die roll and take the better of the two rolls.

1.1.8 Cyphers

Cyphers are abilities that have a single use. In many campaigns, cyphers aren't physical objects—they might be a spell cast upon a character, a blessing from a god, or just a quirk of fate that gives them a momentary advantage. In some campaigns, cyphers are physical objects that characters can carry. Whether or not cyphers are physical objects, they are part of the character (like equipment or a special ability) and are things characters can use during the game. The form that physical cyphers take depends on the setting. In a fantasy world they might be wands or potions, but in a science fiction game they could be alien crystals or prototype devices.

Characters will find new cyphers frequently in the course of play, so players shouldn't hesitate to use their cypher abilities. Because cyphers are always different, the characters will always have new special powers to try.

1.1.9 Other Dice

In addition to a d20, you'll need a d6 (a six-sided die). Rarely, you'll need to roll a number between 1 and 100 (often called a d100 or d% roll), which you can do by rolling a d20 twice, using the last digit of the first roll as the "tens" place and the last digit of the second roll as the "ones" place. For example, rolling a 17 and a 9 gives you 79, rolling a 3 and an 18 gives you 38, and rolling a 20 and a 10 gives you 00 (also known as 100). If you have a d10 (a ten-sided die), you can use it instead of the d20 to roll numbers between 1 and 100.

(A d6 is used most often for recovery rolls and to determine the level of cyphers.)

1.1.10 Creating Your Character

This section explains how to create characters to play in a Cypher System game. This involves a series of decisions that will shape your character, so the more you understand what kind of character you want to play, the easier character creation will be. The process involves understanding the values of three game statistics and choosing three aspects that determine your character's capabilities.

Character Stats

Every player character has three defining characteristics, which are typically called "statistics" or "stats." These stats are Might, Speed, and Intellect. They are broad categories that cover many different but related aspects of a character.

Might Might defines how strong and durable your character is. The concepts of strength, endurance, constitution, hardness, and physical prowess are all folded into this one stat. Might isn't relative to size; instead, it's an absolute measurement. An elephant has more Might than the mightiest tiger, which has more Might than the mightiest rat, which has more Might than the mightiest spider.

Might governs actions from forcing doors open to walking for days without food to resisting disease. It's also the primary means of determining how much damage your character can sustain in a dangerous situation. Physical characters, tough characters, and characters interested in fighting should focus on Might.

(Might could be thought of as Might/Health because it governs how strong you are and how much physical punishment you can take.)

Speed Speed describes how fast and physically coordinated your character is. The stat embodies quickness, movement, dexterity, and reflexes. Speed governs such divergent actions as dodging attacks, sneaking around quietly, and throwing a ball accurately. It helps determine whether you can move farther on your turn. Nimble, fast, or sneaky characters will want good Speed stats, as will those interested in ranged combat.

(Speed could be thought of as Speed/Agility because it governs your overall swiftness and reflexes.)

Intellect This stat determines how smart, knowledgeable, and likable your character is. It includes intelligence, wisdom, charisma, education, reasoning, wit, willpower, and charm. Intellect governs solving puzzles, remembering facts, telling convincing lies, and using mental powers. Characters interested in

communicating effectively, being learned scholars, or wielding supernatural powers should stress their Intellect stat.

(Intellect could be thought of as Intellect/Personality because it governs both intelligence and charisma.)

1.1.11 Pool, Edge and Effort

Each of the three stats has two components: Pool and Edge. Your Pool represents your raw, innate ability, and your Edge represents knowing how to use what you have. A third element ties into this concept: Effort. When your character really needs to accomplish a task, you apply Effort.

(Your stat Pools, as well as your Effort and Edge, are determined by the character type, descriptor, and focus that you choose. Within those guidelines, however, you have a lot of flexibility in how you develop your character.)

Pool Your Pool is the most basic measurement of a stat. Comparing the Pools of two creatures will give you a general sense of which creature is superior in that stat. For example, a character who has a Might Pool of 16 is stronger (in a basic sense) than a character who has a Might Pool of 12. Most characters start with a Pool of 9 to 12 in most stats—that's the average range.

When your character is injured, sickened, or attacked, you temporarily lose points from one of your stat Pools. The nature of the attack determines which Pool loses points. For example, physical damage from a sword reduces your Might Pool, a poison that makes you clumsy reduces your Speed Pool, and a psionic blast reduces your Intellect Pool. You can also spend points from one of your stat Pools to decrease a task's difficulty (see Effort, below). You can rest to recover lost points from a stat Pool, and some special abilities or cyphers might allow you to recover lost points quickly.

Edge Although your Pool is the basic measurement of a stat, your Edge is also important. When something requires you to spend points from a stat Pool, your Edge for that stat reduces the cost. It also reduces the cost of applying Effort to a roll.

For example, let's say you have a mental blast ability, and activating it costs 1 point from your Intellect Pool. Subtract your Intellect Edge from the activation cost, and the result is how many points you must spend to use the mental blast. If using your Edge reduces the cost to 0, you can use the ability for free.

Your Edge can be different for each stat. For example, you could have a Might Edge of 1, a Speed Edge of 1, and an Intellect Edge of 0. You'll always have an Edge of at least 1 in one stat. Your Edge for a stat reduces the cost of spending points from that stat Pool, but not from other Pools. Your Might Edge reduces the cost of spending points from your Might Pool, but it doesn't affect your Speed Pool or Intellect Pool. Once a stat's Edge reaches 3, you can apply one level of Effort for free.

A character who has a low Might Pool but a high Might Edge has the potential to perform Might actions consistently better than a character who has a Might Edge of 0. The high Edge will let them reduce the cost of spending points from the Pool, which means they'll have more points available to spend on applying Effort.

Effort When your character really needs to accomplish a task, you can apply Effort. For a beginning character, applying Effort requires spending 3 points from the stat Pool appropriate

to the action. Thus, if your character tries to dodge an attack (a Speed roll) and wants to increase the chance for success, you can apply Effort by spending 3 points from your Speed Pool. Effort eases the task by one step. This is called applying one level of Effort.

You don't have to apply Effort if you don't want to. If you choose to apply Effort to a task, you must do it before you attempt the roll—you can't roll first and then decide to apply Effort if you rolled poorly.

Applying more Effort can lower a task's difficulty further: each additional level of Effort eases the task by another step. Applying one level of Effort eases the task by one step, applying two levels eases the task by two steps, and so on. However, each level of Effort after the first costs only 2 points from the stat Pool instead of 3. So applying two levels of Effort costs 5 points (3 for the first level plus 2 for the second level), applying three levels costs 7 points (3 plus 2 plus 2), and so on.

Every character has an Effort score, which indicates the maximum number of levels of Effort that can be applied to a roll. A beginning (first-tier) character has an Effort of 1, meaning you can apply only one level of Effort to a roll. A more experienced character has a higher Effort score and can apply more levels of Effort to a roll. For example, a character who has an Effort of 3 can apply up to three levels of Effort to reduce a task's difficulty.

When you apply Effort, subtract your relevant Edge from the total cost of applying Effort. For example, let's say you need to make a Speed roll. To increase your chance for success, you decide to apply one level of Effort, which will ease the task. Normally, that would cost 3 points from your Speed Pool. However, you have a Speed Edge of 2, so you subtract that from the cost. Thus, applying Effort to the roll costs only 1 point from your Speed Pool.

What if you applied two levels of Effort to the Speed roll instead of just one? That would ease the task by two steps. Normally, it would cost 5 points from your Speed Pool, but after subtracting your Speed Edge of 2, it costs only 3 points.

Once a stat's Edge reaches 3, you can apply one level of Effort for free. For example, if you have a Speed Edge of 3 and you apply one level of Effort to a Speed roll, it costs you 0 points from your Speed Pool. (Normally, applying one level of Effort would cost 3 points, but you subtract your Speed Edge from that cost, reducing it to 0.)

Skills and other advantages also ease a task, and you can use them in conjunction with Effort. In addition, your character might have special abilities or equipment that allow you to apply Effort to accomplish a special effect, such as knocking down a foe with an attack or affecting multiple targets with a power that normally affects only one.

(When applying Effort to melee attacks, you have the option of spending points from either your Might Pool or your Speed Pool. When making ranged attacks, you may spend points only from your Speed Pool. This reflects that with melee you sometimes use brute force and sometimes use finesse, but with ranged attacks, it's always about careful targeting.)

Effort and Damage Instead of applying Effort to ease your attack, you can apply Effort to increase the amount of damage you inflict with an attack. For each level of Effort you apply in this way, you inflict 3 additional points of damage. This works for any kind of attack that inflicts damage, whether a sword, a crossbow, a mind blast, or something else.

When using Effort to increase the damage of an area attack, such as the explosion created by an Adept's Concussion ability, you inflict 2 additional points of damage instead of 3 points. However, the additional points are dealt to all targets in the area. Further, even if one or more of the targets resist the attack, they still take 1 point of damage.

Multiple Uses of Effort and Edge If your Effort is 2 or higher, you can apply Effort to multiple aspects of a single action. For example, if you make an attack, you can apply Effort to your attack roll and apply Effort to increase the damage.

The total amount of Effort you apply can't be higher than your Effort score. For example, if your Effort is 2, you can apply up to two levels of Effort. You could apply one level to an attack roll and one level to its damage, two levels to the attack and no levels to the damage, or no levels to the attack and two levels to the damage.

You can use Edge for a particular stat only once per action. For example, if you apply Effort to a Might attack roll and to your damage, you can use your Might Edge to reduce the cost of one of those uses of Effort, not both. If you spend 1 Intellect point to activate your mind blast and one level of Effort to ease the attack roll, you can use your Intellect Edge to reduce the cost of one of those things, not both.

Character Stats

A beginning character is fighting a giant rat. The PC stabs their spear at the rat, which is a level 2 creature and thus has a target number of 6. The character stands atop a boulder and strikes downward at the beast, and the GM rules that this helpful tactic is an asset that eases the attack by one step (to difficulty 1). That lowers the target number to 3. Attacking with a spear is a Might action; the character has a Might Pool of 11 and a Might Edge of 0. Before making the roll, they decide to apply a level of Effort to ease the attack. That costs 3 points from their Might Pool, reducing the Pool to 8. But the points are well spent. Applying the Effort lowers the difficulty from 1 to 0, so no roll is needed—the attack automatically succeeds.

Another character is attempting to convince a guard to let them into a private office to speak to an influential noble. The GM rules that this is an Intellect action. The character is third tier and has an Effort of 3, an Intellect Pool of 13, and an Intellect Edge of 1. Before making the roll, they must decide whether to apply Effort. They can choose to apply one, two, or three levels of Effort, or apply none at all. This action is important to them, so they decide to apply two levels of Effort, easing the task by two steps. Thanks to their Intellect Edge, applying the Effort costs only 4 points from their Intellect Pool (3 points for the first level of Effort plus 2 points for the second level minus 1 point for their Edge). Spending those points reduces their Intellect Pool to 9. The GM decides that convincing the guard is a difficulty 3 (demanding) task with a target number of 9; applying two levels of Effort reduces the difficulty to 1 (simple) and the target number to 3. The player rolls a d20 and gets an 8. Because this result is at least equal to the target number of the task, they succeed. However, if they had not applied some Effort, they would have failed because their roll (8) would have been less than the task's original target number (9).

1.1.12 Character Tiers

Every character starts the game at the first tier. Tier is a measurement of power, toughness, and ability. Characters can advance up to the sixth tier. As your character advances to higher tiers, you gain more abilities, increase your Effort, and can improve a stat's Edge or increase a stat. Generally speaking, even first-tier characters are already quite capable. It's safe to assume that they've already got some experience under their belt. This is not a "zero to hero" progression, but rather an instance of competent people refining and honing their capabilities and knowledge. Advancing to higher tiers is not really the goal of Cypher System characters, but rather a representation of how characters progress in a story.

To progress to the next tier, characters earn experience points (XP) by pursuing character arcs, going on adventures, and discovering new things—the system is about both discovery and exploration, as well as achieving personal goals. Experience points have many uses, and one use is to purchase character benefits. After your character purchases four character benefits, they advance to the next tier. Each benefit costs 4 XP, and you can purchase them in any order, but you must purchase one of each kind of benefit (and then advance to the next tier) before you can purchase the same benefit again. The four character benefits are as follows.

Increasing Capabilities: You gain 4 points to add to your stat Pools. You can allocate the points among the Pools however you wish.

Moving Toward Perfection: You add 1 to your Might Edge, your Speed Edge, or your Intellect Edge (your choice).

Extra Effort: Your Effort score increases by 1.

Skills: You become trained in one skill of your choice, other than attacks or defense. As described in Rules of the Game, a character trained in a skill treats the difficulty of a related task as one step lower than normal. The skill you choose for this benefit can be anything you wish, such as climbing, jumping, persuading, or sneaking. You can also choose to be knowledgeable in a certain area of lore, such as history or geology. You can even choose a skill based on your character's special abilities. For example, if your character can make an Intellect roll to blast an enemy with mental force, you can become trained in using that ability, easing the task of using it. If you choose a skill that you are already trained in, you become specialized in that skill, easing related tasks by two steps instead of one.

(Skills are a broad category of things your character can learn and accomplish. For a list of sample skills, see below.)

Other Options: Players can also spend 4 XP to purchase other special options in lieu of gaining a new skill. Selecting any of these options counts as the skill benefit necessary to advance to the next tier. The special options are as follows:

- Reduce the cost for wearing armor. This option lowers the Speed cost for wearing armor by 1.
- Add 2 to your recovery rolls.
- Select a new type-based ability from your tier or a lower tier.

1.1.13 Character Descriptor, Type, and Focus

To create your character, you build a simple statement that describes them. The statement takes this form: "I am a [fill in an adjective here] [fill in a noun here] who [fill in a verb here]."

Thus: “I am an adjective noun who verbs.” For example, you might say, “I am a Rugged Warrior who Controls Beasts” or “I am a Charming Explorer who Focuses Mind Over Matter.”

In this sentence, the adjective is called your descriptor.

The noun is your character type.

The verb is called your focus.

Even though character type is in the middle of the sentence, that’s where we’ll start this discussion. (Just as in a sentence, the noun provides the foundation.) Your character type is the core of your character. In some roleplaying games, it might be called your character class. Your type helps determine your character’s place in the world and relationship with other people in the setting. It’s the noun of the sentence “I am an adjective noun who verbs.”

You can choose from four character types: Warriors, Adepts, Explorers, and Speakers.

Your descriptor defines your character—it colors everything you do. Your descriptor places your character in the situation (the first adventure, which starts the campaign) and helps provide motivation. It’s the adjective of the sentence “I am an adjective noun who verbs.”

Unless your GM says otherwise, you can choose from any of the character descriptors.

Focus is what your character does best. Focus gives your character specificity and provides interesting new abilities that might come in handy. Your focus also helps you understand how you relate with the other player characters in your group. It’s the verb of the sentence “I am an adjective noun who verbs.” There are many character foci. The ones you choose from will probably depend on the setting and genre of your game.

(You can use the Flavors chapter to slightly modify character types to customize them for different genres.)

1.1.14 Special Abilities

Character types and foci grant PCs special abilities at each new tier. Using these abilities usually costs points from your stat Pools; the cost is listed in parentheses after the ability name. Your Edge in the appropriate stat can reduce the cost of the ability, but remember that you can apply Edge only once per action. For example, let’s say an Adept with an Intellect Edge of 2 wants to use their Onslaught ability to create a bolt of force, which costs 1 Intellect point. They also want to increase the damage from the attack by using a level of Effort, which costs 3 Intellect points. The total cost for their action is 2 points from their Intellect Pool (1 point for the bolt of force, plus 3 points for using Effort, minus 2 points from their Edge).

Sometimes the point cost for an ability has a + sign after the number. For example, the cost might be given as “2+ Intellect points.” That means you can spend more points or more levels of Effort to improve the ability further, as explained in the ability description.

Many special abilities grant a character the option to perform an action that they couldn’t normally do, such as projecting rays of cold or attacking multiple foes at once. Using one of these abilities is an action unto itself, and the end of the ability’s description says “Action” to remind you. It also might provide more information about when or how you perform the action.

Some special abilities allow you to perform a familiar action—one that you can already do—in a different way. For example, an ability might let you wear heavy armor, reduce the difficulty of Speed defense rolls, or add 2 points of fire damage

to your weapon damage. These abilities are called enablers. Using one of these abilities is not considered an action. Enablers either function constantly (such as being able to wear heavy armor, which isn’t an action) or happen as part of another action (such as adding fire damage to your weapon damage, which happens as part of your attack action). If a special ability is an enabler, the end of the ability’s description says “Enabler” to remind you.

Some abilities specify a duration, but you can always end one of your own abilities anytime you wish.

(Because the Cypher System covers so many genres, not all of the descriptors, types, and foci might be available for players. The GM will decide what’s available in their particular game and whether anything is modified, and they’ll let the players know.)

1.1.15 Skills

Sometimes your character gains training in a specific skill or task. For example, your focus might mean that you’re trained in sneaking, in climbing and jumping, or in social interactions. Other times, your character can choose a skill to become trained in, and you can pick a skill that relates to any task you think you might face.

The Cypher System has no definitive list of skills. However, the following list offers ideas:

- Astronomy
- Balancing
- Biology
- Botany
- Carrying
- Climbing
- Computers
- Deceiving
- Disguise
- Escaping
- Geography
- Geology
- Healing
- History
- Identifying
- Initiative
- Intimidation
- Jumping
- Leatherworking
- Lockpicking
- Machinery
- Metalworking
- Perception
- Persuasion
- Philosophy

- Physics
- Pickpocketing
- Piloting
- Repairing
- Riding
- Smashing
- Sneaking
- Stealth
- Swimming
- Vehicle driving
- Woodworking

You could choose a skill that incorporates more than one of these areas (interacting might include deceiving, intimidation, and persuasion) or that is a more specific version of one (hiding might be sneaking when you're not moving). You could also make up more general professional skills, such as baker, sailor, or lumberjack. If you want to choose a skill that's not on this list, it's probably best to run it past the GM first, but in general, the most important thing is to choose skills that are appropriate to your character.

Remember that if you gain a skill that you're already trained in, you become specialized in that skill. Because skill descriptions can be nebulous, determining whether you're trained or specialized might take some thinking. For example, if you're trained in lying and later gain an ability that grants you skill with all social interactions, you become specialized in lying and trained in all other types of interactions. Being trained three times in a skill is no better than being trained twice (in other words, specialized is as good as it gets).

Only skills gained through character type abilities or other rare instances allow you to become skilled with attack or defense tasks.

If you gain a special ability through your type, your focus, or some other aspect of your character, you can choose it in place of a skill and become trained or specialized in that ability. For example, if you have a mind blast, when it's time to choose a skill to be trained in, you can select your mind blast as your skill. That would ease the attack every time you used it. Each ability you have counts as a separate skill for this purpose. You can't select "all mind powers" or "all spells" as one skill and become trained or specialized in such a broad category.

In most campaigns, fluency in a language is considered a skill. So if you want to speak French, that's the same as being trained in biology or swimming.

1.1.16 Type

Character type is the core of your character. Your type helps determine your character's place in the world and relationship with other people in the setting. It's the noun of the sentence "I am an adjective noun who verbs."

(In some roleplaying games, your character type might be called your character class.)

You can choose from four character types: Warrior, Adept, Explorer, and Speaker. However, you may not want to use these

generic names for them. This chapter offers a few more specific names for each type that might be more appropriate to various genres. You'll find that names like "Warrior" or "Explorer" don't always feel right, particularly in games set in modern times. As always, you're free to do as you wish. (Your type is who your character is. You should use whatever name you want for your type, as long as it fits both your character and the setting.)

Since the type is the basis upon which your whole character is built, it's important to consider how the type relates to the chosen setting. To help with this, types are actually general archetypes. A Warrior, for example, might be anyone from a knight in shining armor to a cop on the streets to a grizzled cybernetic veteran of a thousand futuristic wars.

To further massage the four types for better use in various settings, different methods called flavors are presented in Flavors to help slightly tailor the types toward fantasy, science fiction, or other genres (or to address different character concepts).

Finally, more fundamental options for further customization are provided at the end of this chapter.

1.1.17 Player Intrusion

A player intrusion is the player choosing to alter something in the campaign, making things easier for a player character. Conceptually, it is the reverse of a GM intrusion: instead of the GM giving the player XP and introducing an unexpected complication for a character, the player spends 1 XP and presents a solution to a problem or complication. What a player intrusion can do usually introduces a change to the world or current circumstances rather than directly changing the character. For instance, an intrusion indicating that the cypher just used still has an additional use would be appropriate, but an intrusion that heals the character would not. If a player has no XP to spend, they can't use a player intrusion.

A few player intrusion examples are provided under each type. That said, not every player intrusion listed there is appropriate for all situations. The GM may allow players to come up with other player intrusion suggestions, but the GM is the final arbiter of whether the suggested intrusion is appropriate for the character's type and suitable for the situation. If the GM refuses the intrusion, the player doesn't spend the 1 XP, and the intrusion doesn't occur.

Using an intrusion does not require a character to use an action to trigger it. A player intrusion just happens.

(Player intrusions should be limited to no more than one per player per session.)

1.1.18 Defense Task

Defense tasks are when a player makes a roll to keep something undesirable from happening to their PC. The type of defense task matters when using Effort.

Might defense: Used for resisting poison, disease, and anything else that can be overcome with strength and health.

Speed defense: Used for dodging attacks and escaping danger. This is by far the most commonly used defense task.

Intellect defense: Used for fending off mental attacks or anything that might affect or influence one's mind.

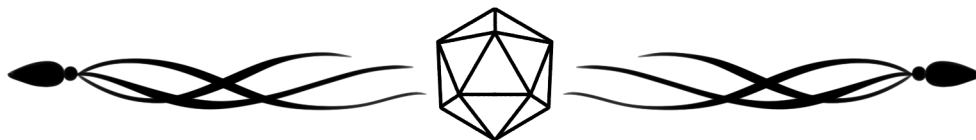


Table 1.1: Task Difficulty

Task Difficulty	Description	Target Number	Guidance
0	Routine	0	Anyone can do this basically every time.
1	Simple	3	Most people can do this most of the time.
2	Standard	6	Typical task requiring focus, but most people can usually do this.
3	Demanding	9	Requires full attention; most people have a 50/50 chance to succeed.
4	Difficult	12	Trained people have a 50/50 chance to succeed.
5	Challenging	15	Even trained people often fail.
6	Intimidating	18	Normal people almost never succeed.
7	Formidable	21	Impossible without skills or great effort.
8	Heroic	24	A task worthy of tales told for years afterward.
9	Immortal	27	A task worthy of legends that last lifetimes.
10	Impossible	30	A task that normal humans couldn't consider (but one that doesn't break the laws of physics).

Chapter 2

Types

2.1 Warrior

Fantasy/Fairy tale: Warrior, fighter, swordsman, knight, barbarian, soldier, myrmidon, valkyrie

Modern/Horror/Romance: police officer, soldier, watchman, detective, guard, brawler, tough, athlete

Science fiction: security officer, warrior, trooper, soldier, merc

Superhero/Post-Apocalyptic: hero, brick, bruiser

You're a good ally to have in a fight. You know how to use weapons and defend yourself. Depending on the genre and setting in question, this might mean wielding a sword and shield in the gladiatorial arena, an AK-47 and a bandolier of grenades in a savage firefight, or a blaster rifle and powered armor when exploring an alien planet.

Individual Role: Warriors are physical, action-oriented people. They're more likely to overcome a challenge using force than by other means, and they often take the most straightforward path toward their goals.

Group Role: Warriors usually take and deal the most punishment in a dangerous situation. Often it falls on them to protect the other group members from threats. This sometimes means that warriors take on leadership roles as well, at least in combat and other times of danger.

Societal Role: Warriors aren't always soldiers or mercenaries. Anyone who is ready for violence, or even potential violence, might be a Warrior in the general sense. This includes guards, watchmen, police officers, sailors, or people in other roles or professions who know how to defend themselves with skill.

Advanced Warriors: As warriors advance, their skill in battle—whether defending themselves or dishing out damage—increases to impressive levels. At higher tiers, they can often take on groups of foes by themselves or stand toe to toe with anyone.

2.1.1 Warrior Stat Pools

Table 2.1: Warrior Stat Pools

Stat	Pool Starting Value
Might	10
Speed	10
Intellect	8

You get 6 additional points to divide among your stat Pools however you wish.

2.1.2 Warrior Background Connection

Your type helps determine the connection you have to the setting. Roll a d20 or choose from the following list to determine a specific fact about your background that provides a connection to the rest of the world. You can also create your own fact.

2.1.3 Warrior Player Intrusions

You can spend 1 XP to use one of the following player intrusions, provided the situation is appropriate and the GM agrees.

Perfect Setup: You're fighting at least three foes and each one is standing in exactly the right spot for you to use a move you trained in long ago, allowing you to attack all three as a single action. Make a separate attack roll for each foe. You remain limited by the amount of Effort you can apply on one action.

Old Friend: A comrade in arms from your past shows up unexpectedly and provides aid in whatever you're doing. They are on a mission of their own and can't stay longer than it takes to help out, chat for a while after, and perhaps share a quick meal. **Weapon Break:** Your foe's weapon has a weak spot. In the course of the combat, it quickly becomes damaged and moves two steps down the object damage track.

2.1.4 First-tier Warrior

First-tier warriors have the following abilities:

Effort: Your Effort is 1.

Physical Nature: You have a Might Edge of 1 and a Speed Edge of 0, or you have a Might Edge of 0 and a Speed Edge of 1. Either way, you have an Intellect Edge of 0.

Cypher Use: You can bear two cyphers at a time.

Weapons: You become practiced with light, medium, and heavy weapons and suffer no penalty when using any kind of weapon. Enabler.

Starting Equipment: Appropriate clothing and two weapons of your choice, plus one expensive item, two moderately priced items, and up to four inexpensive items.

Special Abilities: Choose four of the abilities listed below. You can't choose the same ability more than once unless its description says otherwise. The full description for each listed ability can be found in Abilities, which also has descriptions for flavor and focus abilities in a single vast catalog.

- Bash
- Combat Prowess
- Control the Field
- Improved Edge
- No Need for Weapons
- Overwatch
- Physical Skills
- Practiced in Armor
- Quick Throw
- Swipe
- Trained Without Armor

Table 2.2: Warrior Background Connection

d20	Background
1	You were in the military and have friends who still serve. Your former commander remembers you well.
2	You were the bodyguard of a wealthy woman who accused you of theft. You left her service in disgrace.
3	You were the bouncer in a local bar for a while, and the patrons there remember you.
4	You trained with a highly respected mentor. They regard you well, but they have many enemies.
5	You trained in an isolated monastery. The monks think of you as a brother, but you're a stranger to all others.
6	You have no formal training. Your abilities come to you naturally (or unnaturally).
7	You spent time on the streets and were in prison for a while.
8	You were conscripted into military service, but you deserted before long.
9	You served as a bodyguard to a powerful criminal who now owes you their life.
10	You worked as a police officer or constable of some kind. Everyone knows you, but their opinions of you vary.
11	Your older sibling is an infamous character who has been disgraced.
12	You served as a guard for someone who traveled extensively. You know a smattering of people in many locations.
13	Your best friend is a teacher or scholar. They are a great source of knowledge.
14	You and a friend both smoke the same kind of rare, expensive tobacco. The two of you get together weekly to chat and smoke.
15	Your uncle runs a theater in town. You know all the actors and watch all the shows for free.
16	Your craftsman friend sometimes calls on you for help. However, they pay you well.
17	Your mentor wrote a book on martial arts. Sometimes people seek you out to ask about its stranger passages.
18	Someone you fought alongside in the military is now the mayor of a nearby town.
19	You saved the lives of a family when their house burned down. They're indebted to you, and their neighbors regard you as a hero.
20	Your old trainer still expects you to come back and clean up after their classes; when you do, they occasionally share interesting rumors.

2.1.5 Second-tier Warrior

Choose two of the abilities listed below (or from a lower tier) to add to your repertoire. In addition, you can replace one of your lower-tier abilities with a different one from a lower tier.

- Crushing Blow
- Hemorrhage
- Reload
- Skill With Attacks
- Skill With Defense
- Successive Attack

2.1.6 Third-tier Warrior

Choose three of the abilities listed below (or from a lower tier) to add to your repertoire. In addition, you can replace one of your lower-tier abilities with a different one from a lower tier.

- Deadly Aim
- Energy Resistance
- Experienced in Armor
- Expert Cypher Use
- Fury
- Lunge
- Reaction
- Seize the Moment
- Slice

- Spray
- Trick Shot
- Vigilance

2.1.7 Fourth-tier Warrior

Choose two of the abilities listed below (or from a lower tier) to add to your repertoire. In addition, you can replace one of your lower-tier abilities with a different one from a lower tier.

- Amazing Effort
- Capable Warrior
- Experienced Defender
- Feint
- Increased Effects
- Momentum
- Pry Open
- Snipe
- Tough As Nails

2.1.8 Fifth-tier Warrior

Choose three of the abilities listed below (or from a lower tier) to add to your repertoire. In addition, you can replace one of your lower-tier abilities with a different one from a lower tier.

- Adroit Cypher Use
- Arc Spray
- Improved Success
- Jump Attack
- Mastery in Armor
- Mastery With Attacks
- Mastery With Defense
- Parry

(Remember that at higher tiers, you can choose special abilities from lower tiers. This is sometimes the best way to ensure that you have exactly the character you want. This is particularly true with abilities that grant skills, which can usually be taken multiple times.)

2.1.9 Sixth-tier Warrior

Choose two of the abilities listed below (or from a lower tier) to add to your repertoire. In addition, you can replace one of your lower-tier abilities with a different one from a lower tier.

- Again and Again
- Finishing Blow
- Magnificent Moment
- Murderer
- Spin Attack
- Weapon and Body

2.1.10 Warrior Example

Ray wants to create a Warrior character for a modern campaign. He decides that the character is an ex-military fellow who is fast and strong. He puts 3 of his additional points into his Might Pool and 3 into his Speed Pool; his stat Pools are now Might 13, Speed 13, and Intellect 8. As a first-tier character, his Effort is 1, his Might Edge is 1, and his Speed Edge and Intellect Edge are both 0. His character is not particularly smart or charismatic.

He wants to use a large combat knife (a medium weapon that inflicts 4 points of damage) and a .357 Magnum (a heavy pistol that inflicts 6 points of damage but requires the use of both hands). Ray decides not to wear armor, as it's not really appropriate to the setting, so for his first ability, he chooses Trained Without Armor so he eases Speed defense actions. For his second ability, he chooses Combat Prowess so he can inflict extra damage with his big knife.

Ray wants to be fast as well as tough, so he selects Improved Edge. This gives him a Speed Edge of 1. He rounds out his character with Physical Skills and chooses swimming and running.

The Warrior can bear two cyphers. The GM decides that Ray's first cypher is a pill that restores 6 points of Might when swallowed, and his second is a small, easily concealed grenade that explodes like a firebomb when thrown, inflicting 3 points of damage to all within immediate range.

Ray still needs to choose a descriptor and a focus. Looking ahead to the descriptor rules, Ray chooses Strong, which increases his Might Pool to 17. He also becomes trained in jumping and breaking inanimate objects. (If he had chosen jumping as one of his physical skills, the Strong descriptor would have made him specialized in jumping instead of trained.) Being Strong also gives Ray an extra medium or heavy weapon. He chooses a baseball bat that he'll use in a pinch. He keeps it in the trunk of his car.

For his focus, Ray chooses Masters Weaponry. This gives him yet another weapon of high quality. He chooses another combat knife and asks the GM if he could use it in his left hand—not to make attacks, but as a shield. This will ease his Speed defense rolls if he has both knives out (the “shield” counts as an asset). The GM agrees. During the game, Ray's Warrior will be hard to hit—he is trained in Speed defense rolls, and his extra knife eases his defense rolls by another step. Thanks to his focus, he also inflicts 1 additional point of damage with his chosen weapon. Now he inflicts 6 points of damage with his blade. Ray's character is a deadly combatant, likely starting the game with a reputation as a knife fighter. For his character arc, Ray chooses Defeat a Foe. That foe, he decides, is none other than someone in his company who was once a friend but went rogue.

2.2 Adept

Fantasy/Fairy tale: wizard, mage, sorcerer, cleric, druid, seer, diabolist, fey-touched

Modern/Horror/Romance: psychic, occultist, witch, practitioner, medium, fringe scientist

Science fiction: psion, psionist, telepath, seeker, master, scanner, ESPer, abomination

Superhero/Post-Apocalyptic: mage, sorcerer, power-wielder, master, psion, telepath

You master powers or abilities outside the experience, understanding, and sometimes belief of others. They might be magic, psychic powers, mutant abilities, or just a wide variety of intricate devices, depending on the setting. (“Magic” here is a term used very loosely. It's a catch-all for the kinds of wondrous, possibly supernatural things that your character can do that others cannot. It might actually be an expression of technological devices, channeling spirits, mutations, psionics, nanotechnology, or any number of other sources.)

Individual Role: Adepts are usually thoughtful, intelligent types. They often think carefully before acting and rely heavily on their supernatural abilities.

Group Role: Adepts are not powerful in straightforward combat, although they often wield abilities that provide excellent combat support, both offensively and defensively. They sometimes possess abilities that facilitate overcoming challenges. For example, if the group must get through a locked door, an Adept might be able to destroy it or teleport everyone to the other side.

Societal Role: In settings where the supernatural is rare, strange, or feared, Adepts are likely rare and feared as well. They remain hidden, shadowy figures. When this is not the

case, Adepts are more likely to be common and forthright. They might even take leadership roles.

Advanced Adepts: Even at low tiers, Adept powers are impressive. Higher-tier Adepts can accomplish amazing deeds that can reshape matter and the environment around them. (Adepts are almost always emblematic of the paranormal or superhuman in some way—wizards, psychics, or something similar. If the game you’re playing has none of that, an Adept could be a charlatan mimicking such abilities with tricks and hidden devices, or a gadgeteer character with a “utility belt” full of oddments. Or a game like that might not have Adepts. That’s okay too.)

2.2.1 Adept Player Intrusions

When playing an Adept, you can spend 1 XP to use one of the following player intrusions, provided the situation is appropriate and the GM agrees.

Advantageous Malfunction: A device being used against you malfunctions. It might harm the user or one of their allies for a round, or activate a dramatic and distracting side effect for a few rounds.

Convenient Idea: A flash of insight provides you with a clear answer or suggests a course of action with regard to an urgent question, problem, or obstacle you’re facing.

Inexplicably Unbroken: An inactive, ruined, or presumed-destroyed device temporarily activates and performs a useful function relevant to the situation. This is enough to buy you some time for a better solution, alleviate a complication that was interfering with your abilities, or just get you one more use out of a depleted cypher or artifact.

2.2.2 Adept Stat Pools

Table 2.3: Adept Stat Pools

Stat	Pool Starting Value
Might	7
Speed	9
Intellect	12

You get 6 additional points to divide among your stat Pools however you wish.

2.2.3 Adept Background Connection

Your type helps determine the connection you have to the setting. Roll a d20 or choose from the following list to determine a specific fact about your background that provides a connection to the rest of the world. You can also create your own fact.

2.2.4 First-tier Adept

First-tier Adepts have the following abilities:

Effort: Your Effort is 1.

Genius: You have an Intellect Edge of 1, a Might Edge of 0, and a Speed Edge of 0.

Expert Cypher Use: You can bear three cyphers at a time. Starting Equipment: Appropriate clothing, plus two expensive items, two moderately priced items, and up to four inexpensive items of your choice.

Weapons: You can use light weapons without penalty. You have an inability with medium weapons and heavy weapons; your attacks with medium and heavy weapons are hindered.

Special Abilities: Choose four of the abilities listed below. You can’t choose the same ability more than once unless its description says otherwise. The full description for each listed ability can be found in Abilities, which also has descriptions for flavor and focus abilities in a single vast catalog. (Adept abilities require at least one free hand unless the GM says otherwise.)

- Distortion
- Erase Memories
- Far Step
- Hedge Magic
- Magic Training
- Onslaught
- Push
- Resonance Field
- Scan
- Shatter
- Ward

2.2.5 Second-tier Adept

Choose one of the abilities listed below (or from a lower tier) to add to your repertoire. In addition, you can replace one of your lower-tier abilities with a different one from a lower tier.

- Adaptation
- Cutting Light
- Hover
- Mind Reading
- Retrieve Memories
- Reveal
- Stasis

2.2.6 Third-tier Adept

Choose two of the abilities listed below (or from a lower tier) to add to your repertoire. In addition, you can replace one of your lower-tier abilities with a different one from a lower tier.

- Adroit Cypher Use
- Countermeasures
- Energy Protection
- Fire and Ice
- Force Field Barrier
- Sensor
- Targeting Eye

Table 2.4: Adept Background Connection

d20	Background
1	You served as an apprentice for an Adept respected and feared by many people. Now you bear their mark.
2	You studied in a school infamous for its dark, brooding instructors and graduates.
3	You learned your abilities in the temple of an obscure god. Its priests and worshippers, although small in number, respect and admire your talents and potential.
4	While traveling alone, you saved the life of a powerful person. They remain indebted to you.
5	Your mother was a powerful Adept while she lived, helpful to many locals. They look upon you kindly, but they also expect much from you.
6	You owe money to a number of people and don't have the funds to pay your debts.
7	You failed disgracefully at your initial studies with your teacher and now proceed on your own.
8	You learned your skills faster than your teachers had ever seen before. The powers that be took notice and are paying close attention.
9	You killed a well-known criminal in self-defense, earning the respect of many and the enmity of a dangerous few.
10	You trained as a Warrior, but your Adept predilections eventually led you down a different path. Your former comrades don't understand you, but they respect you.
11	While studying to be an Adept, you worked as an assistant for a bank, making friends with the owner and the clientele.
12	Your family owns a large vineyard nearby known to all for its fine wine and fair business dealings.
13	You trained for a time with a group of influential Adepts, and they still look upon you with fondness.
14	You worked the gardens in the palace of an influential noble or person of wealth. They wouldn't remember you, but you made friends with their young daughter.
15	An experiment you conducted in the past went horribly awry. The locals remember you as a dangerous and foolhardy individual.
16	You hail from a distant place where you were well known and regarded, but people here treat you with suspicion.
17	People you meet seem put off by the strange birthmark on your face.
18	Your best friend is also an Adept. You and your friend share discoveries and secrets readily.
19	You know a local merchant very well. Since you give them so much business, they offer you discounts and special treatment.
20	You belong to a secretive social club that gathers monthly to drink and talk.

2.2.7 Fourth-tier Adept

Choose one of the abilities listed below (or from a lower tier) to add to your repertoire. In addition, you can replace one of your lower-tier abilities with a different one from a lower tier.

- Death Touch
- Exile
- Invisibility
- Matter Cloud
- Mind Control
- Projection
- Rapid Processing
- Regeneration
- Reshape
- Wormhole

2.2.8 Fifth-tier Adept

Choose two of the abilities listed below (or from a lower tier) to add to your repertoire. In addition, you can replace one of your lower-tier abilities with a different one from a lower tier.

- Absorb Energy
- Concussion

- Conjuraton
- Create
- Dust to Dust
- Knowing the Unknown
- Master Cypher Use
- Teleportation
- True Senses

2.2.9 Sixth-tier Adept

Choose one of the abilities listed below (or from a lower tier) to add to your repertoire. In addition, you can replace one of your lower-tier abilities with a different one from a lower tier.

- Control Weather
- Earthquake
- Move Mountains
- Traverse the Worlds
- Usurp Cypher

2.2.10 Adept Example

Jen wants to create an Adept—a sorcerer for a fantasy campaign. She decides to be somewhat well rounded, so she puts 2 of her additional points into each stat Pool, giving her a Might Pool of 9, a Speed Pool of 11, and an Intellect Pool of 14. Her Adept is smart and quick. She has an Intellect Edge of 1, a Might Edge of 0, and a Speed Edge of 0. As a first-tier character, her Effort is 1. As her initial abilities, she chooses Onslaught and Ward, giving her a strong offense and defense. She also chooses Magic Training and rounds out her character with Scan, which she hopes will be useful in gaining insight and information. For this character, Onslaught, Ward, and Scan are all spells she has mastered through years of training and study.

She can bear three cyphers. The GM gives her a potion that acts as a short-range teleporter, a small charm that restores 5 points to her Intellect Pool, and a fluid-filled flask that explodes like a fiery bomb. Jen's sorcerer is skilled with light weapons, so she chooses a dagger. For her descriptor, Jen chooses Graceful, which adds 2 points to her Speed Pool, bringing it to 13. That descriptor means she is trained in balancing and anything requiring careful movements, physical performing arts, and Speed defense tasks. Perhaps she is a dancer. In fact, she begins to develop a backstory that involves graceful, lithe movements that she incorporates into her spells. For her focus, she chooses Leads. This gives her training in social interactions, which again helps round her out—she's good in all kinds of situations. Moreover, she has the Good Advice ability, which enables her to be a focal point of her group.

Her spells and focus abilities cost Intellect points to activate, so she's glad to have a lot of points in her Intellect Pool. In addition, her Intellect Edge will help reduce those costs. If she uses her Onslaught force blast without applying Effort, it costs 0 Intellect points and deals 4 points of damage. Her Intellect Edge will allow her to save points to devote toward applying Effort for other purposes, perhaps to boost the accuracy of Onslaught.

For her character arc, Jen chooses Aid a Friend. She decides that when her sorcerer character was young, she had a magical mentor. That mentor was later taken prisoner by a demon, so her character is always looking for clues on how to find the demon and release her friend from bondage.

(GMs are always free to pre-select a type's special abilities at a given tier to reinforce the setting. In the fantasy setting of Jen's sorcerer, the GM might have said that all sorcerers (Adepts) start with Magic Training as one of their tier 1 abilities. This doesn't make the character any less powerful or special, but it says something about her role in the world and expectations in the game.)

2.3 Explorer

Fantasy/Fairy tale: Explorer, adventurer, delver, mystery seeker

Modern/Horror/Romance: athlete, explorer, adventurer, drifter, detective, scholar, spelunker, trailblazer, investigative reporter

Science fiction: Explorer, adventurer, wanderer, planetary specialist, xenobiologist

Superhero/Post-Apocalyptic: adventurer, crimefighter

You are a person of action and physical ability, fearlessly facing the unknown. You travel to strange, exotic, and dangerous places, and discover new things. This means you're physical but also probably knowledgeable.

Individual Role: Although Explorers can be academics or well studied, they are first and foremost interested in action. They face grave dangers and terrible obstacles as a routine part of life.

Group Role: Explorers sometimes work alone, but far more often they operate in teams with other characters. The Explorer frequently leads the way, blazing the trail. However, they're also likely to stop and investigate anything intriguing they stumble upon.

Societal Role: Not all Explorers are out traipsing through the wilderness or poking about an old ruin. Sometimes, an Explorer is a teacher, a scientist, a detective, or an investigative reporter. In any event, an Explorer bravely faces new challenges and gathers knowledge to share with others.

Advanced Explorers: Higher-tier Explorers gain more skills, some combat abilities, and a number of abilities that allow them to deal with danger. In short, they become more and more well-rounded, able to deal with any challenge.

2.3.1 Explorer Player Intrusions

When playing an Explorer, you can spend 1 XP to use one of the following player intrusions, provided the situation is appropriate and the GM agrees.

Fortuitous Malfunction: A trap or a dangerous device malfunctions before it can affect you.

Serendipitous Landmark: Just when it seems like the path is lost (or you are), a trail marker, a landmark, or simply the way the terrain or corridor bends, rises, or falls away suggests to you the best path forward, at least from this point.

Weak Strain: The poison or disease turns out not to be as debilitating or deadly as it first seemed, and inflicts only half the damage that it would have otherwise.

2.3.2 Explorer Stat Pools

Table 2.5: Explorer Stat Pools

Stat	Pool Starting Value
Might	10
Speed	9
Intellect	9

You get 6 additional points to divide among your stat Pools however you wish.

2.3.3 Explorer Background Connection

Your type helps determine the connection you have to the setting. Roll a d20 or choose from the following list to determine a specific fact about your background that provides a connection to the rest of the world. You can also create your own fact.

2.3.4 First-Tier Explorer

First-tier Explorers have the following abilities:

Effort: Your Effort is 1.

Table 2.6: Explorer Background Connection

d20	Background
1	You were a star high school athlete. You're still in great shape, but those were the glory days, man.
2	Your brother is the lead singer in a really popular band.
3	You have made a number of discoveries in your explorations, but not all opportunities to capitalize on them have panned out yet.
4	You were a cop, but you gave it up after encountering corruption on the force.
5	Your parents were missionaries, so you spent much of your young life traveling to exotic places.
6	You served in the military with honor.
7	You received assistance from a secretive organization, which paid for your schooling. Now they seem to want a lot more from you.
8	You went to a prestigious university on an athletic scholarship, but you excelled in class as well as on the field.
9	Your best friend from your youth is now an influential member of the government.
10	You used to be a teacher. Your students remember you fondly.
11	You worked as a small-time criminal operative until you were caught and served some time in jail, after which you tried to go straight.
12	Your greatest discovery to date was stolen by your arch-rival.
13	You belong to an exclusive organization of Explorers whose existence is not widely known.
14	You were kidnapped as a small child under mysterious circumstances, although you were recovered safely. The case still has some notoriety.
15	When you were young, you were addicted to narcotics, and now you are a recovering addict.
16	While exploring a remote location, you saw something strange you've never been able to explain.
17	You own a small bar or restaurant.
18	You published a book about some of your exploits and discoveries, and it has achieved some acclaim.
19	Your sister owns a store and gives you a hefty discount.
20	Your father is a high-ranking officer in the military with many connections.

Physical Nature: You have a Might Edge of 1, a Speed Edge of 0, and an Intellect Edge of 0.

Cypher Use: You can bear two cyphers at a time. Starting Equipment: Appropriate clothing and a weapon of your choice, plus two expensive items, two moderately priced items, and up to four inexpensive items.

Weapons: You can use light and medium weapons without penalty. You have an inability with heavy weapons; your attacks with heavy weapons are hindered.

Special Abilities: Choose four of the abilities listed below. You can't choose the same ability more than once unless its description says otherwise. The full description for each listed ability can be found in Abilities, which also has descriptions for flavor and focus abilities in a single vast catalog.

- Block
- Danger Sense
- Decipher
- Endurance
- Find the Way
- Fleet of Foot
- Improved Edge
- Knowledge Skills
- Muscles of Iron
- No Need for Weapons
- Physical Skills
- Practiced in Armor

- Practiced With All Weapons
- Surging Confidence
- Trained Without Armor

2.3.5 Second-Tier Explorer

Choose four of the abilities listed below (or from a lower tier) to add to your repertoire. In addition, you can replace one of your lower-tier abilities with a different one from a lower tier.

- Curious
- Danger Instinct
- Enable Others
- Escape
- Eye for Detail
- Foil Danger
- Hand to Eye
- Investigative Skills
- Quick Recovery
- Range Increase
- Skill With Defense
- Stand Watch
- Travel Skills
- Wreck

2.3.6 Third-Tier Explorer

Choose three of the abilities listed below (or from a lower tier) to add to your repertoire. In addition, you can replace one of your lower-tier abilities with a different one from a lower tier.

- Controlled Fall
- Experienced in Armor
- Expert Cypher Use
- Ignore the Pain
- Obstacle Running
- Resilience
- Run and Fight
- Seize the Moment
- Skill With Attacks
- Stone Breaker
- Think Your Way Out
- Trapfinder
- Wrest From Chance

2.3.7 Fourth-Tier Explorer

Choose two of the abilities listed below (or from a lower tier) to add to your repertoire. In addition, you can replace one of your lower-tier abilities with a different one from a lower tier.

- Capable Warrior
- Expert Skill
- Increased Effects
- Read the Signs
- Runner
- Subtle Steps
- Tough As Nails

2.3.8 Fifth-Tier Explorer

Choose three of the abilities listed below (or from a lower tier) to add to your repertoire. In addition, you can replace one of your lower-tier abilities with a different one from a lower tier.

- Adroit Cypher Use
- Free to Move
- Group Friendship
- Hard to Kill
- Jump Attack
- Mastery With Defense
- Parry
- Physically Gifted
- Take Command
- Vigilant

2.3.9 Sixth-Tier Explorer

Choose three of the abilities listed below (or from a lower tier) to add to your repertoire. In addition, you can replace one of your lower-tier abilities with a different one from a lower tier.

- Again and Again
- Inspire Coordinated Actions
- Mastery in Armor
- Mastery With Attacks
- Negate Danger
- Share Defense
- Spin Attack
- Wild Vitality

2.3.10 Explorer Example

Sam decides to create an Explorer character for a science fiction campaign. This character will be a hardy soul who explores alien worlds. They put 3 additional points into their Might Pool, 2 into their Speed Pool, and 1 into their Intellect Pool; their stat Pools are now Might 13, Speed 11, and Intellect 10. As a first-tier character, their Effort is 1, their Might Edge is 1, and their Speed Edge and Intellect Edge are 0. Their character is fairly well-rounded so far.

Sam immediately leaps in and starts choosing abilities. They pick Danger Sense and Surging Confidence, thinking those abilities will be generally useful. They also choose Practiced in Armor, reasoning that the character wears high-tech medium armor when exploring. Last, they choose Knowledge Skills and select geology and biology to help during interplanetary explorations.

Sam's Explorer can bear two cyphers, which in this setting involve nanotechnology. The GM decides that one is a nanite injector that grants a +1 bonus to Might Edge when used, and the other is a device that can create one simple handheld object the user wishes.

Sam's Explorer is not really geared toward fighting, but sometimes the universe is a dangerous place, so they note that they're carrying a medium blaster as well. Sam still needs a descriptor and a focus. Looking to the Descriptor chapter, they choose Hardy, which increases their Might Pool to 17. They also heal more quickly and can operate better when injured. They're trained in Might defense but have an inability with initiative; however, it's effectively canceled out by their Danger Sense (and vice versa). Sam could go back and select something else instead of Danger Sense, but they like it and decide to keep it. Overall, the descriptor ends up making the character tough but a little slow.

For their focus, Sam chooses Explores Dark Places (in this case, weird ruins of alien civilizations). This gives the character a bunch of additional skills: searching, listening, climbing, balancing, and jumping. They're quite the capable Explorer.

For their character arc, Sam chooses Enterprise. Exploring alien places sometimes turns up strange relics, and Sam figures they might be able to set up a service to reliably transport these items to responsible third parties, rather than allow them to fall into the hands of pirates and rich private collectors. For a small fee, of course.

2.4 Speaker

Fantasy/Fairy tale: bard, speaker, skald, emissary, priest, advocate

Modern/Horror/Romance: diplomat, charmer, face, spinner, manipulator, minister, mediator, lawyer

Science fiction: diplomat, empath, glam, consul, legate

Superhero/Post-Apocalyptic: charmer, mesmerist, puppet master

You're good with words and good with people. You talk your way past challenges and out of jams, and you get people to do what you want.

Individual Role: Speakers are smart and charismatic. They like people and, more important, they understand them. This helps speakers get others to do what needs to be done.

Group Role: The Speaker is often the face of the group, serving as the person who speaks for all and negotiates with others. Combat and action are not a Speaker's strong suits, so other characters sometimes have to defend the Speaker in times of danger.

Societal Role: Speakers are frequently political or religious leaders. Just as often, however, they are con artists or criminals. Advanced Speakers: Higher-tier speakers use their abilities to control and manipulate people as well as aid and nurture their friends. They can talk their way out of danger and even use their words as weapons.

2.4.1 Speaker Player Intrusions

When playing a Speaker, you can spend 1 XP to use one of the following player intrusions, provided the situation is appropriate and the GM agrees.

Friendly NPC: An NPC you don't know, someone you don't know that well, or someone you know but who hasn't been particularly friendly in the past chooses to help you, though doesn't necessarily explain why. Maybe they'll ask you for a favor in return afterward, depending on how much trouble they go to.

Perfect Suggestion: A follower or other already-friendly NPC suggests a course of action with regard to an urgent question, problem, or obstacle you're facing.

Unexpected Gift: An NPC hands you a physical gift you were not expecting, one that helps put the situation at ease if things seem strained, or provides you with a new insight for understanding the context of the situation if there's something you're failing to understand or grasp.

2.4.2 Speaker Stat Pools

Table 2.7: Speaker Stat Pools

Stat	Pool Starting Value
Might	8
Speed	9
Intellect	11

You get 6 additional points to divide among your stat Pools however you wish.

2.4.3 Speaker Background Connection

Your type helps determine the connection you have to the setting. Roll a d20 or choose from the following list to

determine a specific fact about your background that provides a connection to the rest of the world. You can also create your own fact.

2.4.4 First-Tier Speaker

First-tier speakers have the following abilities:

Effort: Your Effort is 1.

Genius: You have an Intellect Edge of 1, a Might Edge of 0, and a Speed Edge of 0.

Cypher Use: You can bear two cyphers at a time.

Weapons: You can use light weapons without penalty. You have an inability with medium and heavy weapons; your attacks with medium and heavy weapons are hindered.

Starting Equipment: Appropriate clothing and a light weapon of your choice, plus two expensive items, two moderately priced items, and up to four inexpensive items.

Special Abilities: Choose four of the abilities listed below. You can't choose the same ability more than once unless its description says otherwise. The full description for each listed ability can be found in Abilities, which also has descriptions for flavor and focus abilities in a single vast catalog. (Some Speaker abilities, like Mind Reading or True Senses, imply a supernatural element. If this is inappropriate to the character or the setting, these abilities can be replaced with something from the stealth flavor, or the GM can slightly modify them so they are based in extraordinary talents and insight rather than the supernatural.)

- Anecdote
- Babel
- Demeanor of Command
- Encouragement
- Enthral
- Erase Memories
- Fast Talk
- Inspire Aggression
- Interaction Skills
- Practiced With Medium Weapons
- Spin Identity
- Terrifying Presence
- Understanding

2.4.5 Second-Tier Speaker

Choose two of the abilities listed below (or from a lower tier) to add to your repertoire. In addition, you can replace one of your lower-tier abilities with a different one from a lower tier.

- Basic Follower
- Calm Stranger
- Disincentivize
- Gather Intelligence
- Impart Ideal

Table 2.8: Speaker Background Connection

d20	Background
1	One of your parents was a famous entertainer in their early years and hoped you would excel in the same medium.
2	When you were a teenager, one of your siblings went missing and is presumed dead. The shock rent your family, and it's something you've never gotten over.
3	You were inducted into a secret society that claims to hold and protect esoteric knowledge opposing the forces of evil.
4	You lost one of your parents to alcoholism. They may still be alive, but you'd be hard pressed to find forgiveness.
5	You have no memory of anything that happened to you before the age of 18.
6	Your grandparents raised you on a farm far from bustling urban centers. You like to think the instruction they gave you prepared you for anything.
7	As an orphan, you had a difficult childhood, and your entry into adulthood was challenging.
8	You grew up in extreme poverty, among criminals. You still have some connections with the old neighborhood.
9	You served as an envoy for a powerful and influential person in the past, and they still look upon you with favor.
10	You have an annoying rival who always seems to get in your way or foil your plans.
11	You've worked yourself into the position of spokesperson for an organization or company of some importance.
12	Your neighbors were murdered, and the mystery remains unsolved.
13	You have traveled extensively, and during that time you accumulated quite a collection of strange souvenirs.
14	Your childhood sweetheart ended up with your best friend (now your ex-best friend).
15	You are part of a maligned minority, but you work to bring the injustice of your status to public attention.
16	You're part owner of a local bar, where you're something of a whiz in creating specialty cocktails.
17	You once ran a con that cheated important people out of money, and they want revenge.
18	You used to act in a traveling theater, and they remember you fondly (as do people in the places you visited).
19	You are in a close romantic relationship with someone in local politics.
20	Someone out there tries to pose as you, using your identity, often for nefarious ends. You've never met the culprit, but you'd certainly like to.

- Inspiring Ease
- Interaction Skills
- Practiced in Armor
- Skill With Defense
- Speedy Recovery
- Unexpected Betrayal

2.4.6 Third-Tier Speaker

Choose three of the abilities listed below (or from a lower tier) to add to your repertoire. In addition, you can replace one of your lower-tier abilities with a different one from a lower tier.

- Accelerate
- Blend In
- Discerning Mind
- Expert Cypher Use
- Expert Follower
- Grand Deception
- Lead by Inquiry
- Mind Reading
- Oratory
- Perfect Stranger
- Quick Wits
- Telling

2.4.7 Fourth-Tier Speaker

Choose two of the abilities listed below (or from a lower tier) to add to your repertoire. In addition, you can replace one of your lower-tier abilities with a different one from a lower tier.

- Anticipate Attack
- Confounding Banter
- Feint
- Heightened Skills
- Psychosis
- Read the Signs
- Spur Effort
- Strategize
- Suggestion

2.4.8 Fifth-Tier Speaker

Choose three of the abilities listed below (or from a lower tier) to add to your repertoire. In addition, you can replace one of your lower-tier abilities with a different one from a lower tier.

- Adroit Cypher Use
- Discipline of Watchfulness
- Experienced in Armor
- Flee
- Foul Aura
- Knowing the Unknown

- Regeneration
- Skill With Attacks
- Stimulate

2.4.9 Sixth-Tier Speaker

Choose two of the abilities listed below (or from a lower tier) to add to your repertoire. In addition, you can replace one of your lower-tier abilities with a different one from a lower tier.

- Assume Control
- Battle Management
- Crowd Control
- Inspiring Success
- Recruit Deputy
- Shatter Mind
- True Senses
- Word of Command

2.4.10 Speaker Example

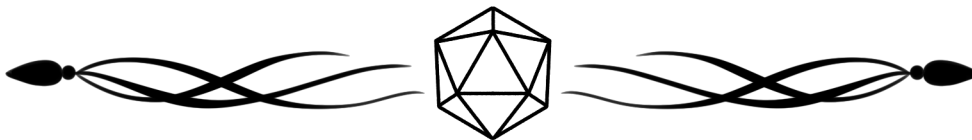
Mary wants to create a Speaker for a Lovecraftian horror campaign. She puts 3 of her additional stat points into her Intellect Pool and 3 into her Speed Pool; her stat Pools are now Might 8, Speed 12, and Intellect 14. As a first-tier character, her Effort is 1, her Might Edge and Speed Edge are 0, and her Intellect Edge is 1. She's smart and charismatic but not particularly tough.

Mary chooses Fast Talk and Spin Identity to help get into places and learn things she wants to know. She's a bit of a con artist. She's good to her friends, however, and chooses Encouragement as well. Mary rounds out her first-tier abilities with Interaction Skills (deceiving and persuasion).

A Speaker normally starts with two cyphers, but the GM rules that characters in this campaign start with only one—something creepy relating to their background. Mary's cypher is an odd pocket watch given to her by her grandfather. She doesn't know how or why, but when activated, the watch allows her to take twice as many actions for three rounds.

Mary's character carries a small knife hidden in her bag in case of trouble. As a light weapon, it inflicts 2 points of damage, but attacks with it are eased. Mary chooses Resilient for her descriptor and decides that she can probably learn the truth behind some of the strange things that she's heard about without feeling too much trauma if it's horrible. Resilient increases her Might Pool to 10 and her Intellect Pool to 16. She's trained in Might and Intellect defense actions and gains an extra recovery roll each day. At first, Mary is sad that her descriptor gives her an inability in knowledge and puzzle tasks, but then she realizes that the flaw fits her character well—she's better at getting people to tell her what she needs to know than at figuring out the information herself. For her focus, Mary chooses Moves Like a Cat, granting her a final Speed Pool of 18 and training in balance. In the end, she's graceful and quick, charismatic, and hardier than she initially thought thanks to her drive. She's ready to investigate the weird.

For her character arc, Mary chooses Fall From Grace. She decides she's had an obsession with a strange tome that's been in her family for generations, and her character is drawn to its strange languages and rituals.



Chapter 3

Fantasy Character Options

In some cases, the ideas here require minor changes to the flavor described in the character options; you should work with your GM to make sure these changes are suitable for the campaign. Most of the foci in this section appear in the Cypher System; foci with an asterisk (*) are found later in this document. Some of these options recommend swapping out a type ability for an ability from one of the character flavors such as combat, magic, or stealth.

Alchemist: In the sense that an alchemist is someone who makes magical items or similar types of things, Adept and Explorer are appropriate type choices for academic alchemists. For a general sort of alchemist who makes potions of magical effects, choose the Masters Spells focus (instead of spells, you learn potions). For one who transforms into a powerful and dangerous creature, choose Howls at the Moon. For one who loves throwing bombs, choose Bears a Halo of Fire. For a healer, choose Works Miracles.

Assassin/Spy: Explorer and Warrior are good type choices for an assassin character. Appropriate foci are Masters Weaponry, Moves Like a Cat, Murders, and Works the Back Alleys.

Barbarian: A barbarian character is probably a Warrior or (to focus a little more on skills than combat) an Explorer. Good foci to choose from are Lives in the Wilderness, Masters Weaponry, Needs No Weapon, Never Says Die, Performs Feats of Strength, and Rages.

Bard: Bards in fantasy fiction and games are troubadours, minstrels, and storytellers, perhaps with a supernatural element. Bards are usually Explorers or Speakers. Appropriate foci are Entertains, Helps Their Friends, Infiltrates, and Masters Spells.

Cleric or Priest: Academic clerics are usually Adepts or Speakers, but martial clerics are often Warriors (perhaps with magic flavor). For a typical cleric with a versatile set of abilities, choose the Channels Divine Blessings focus.

Cleric (death): Consorts With the Dead, Shepherds Spirits

Cleric (knowledge): Learns Quickly, Sees Beyond, Would Rather Be Reading

Cleric (life): Defends the Weak, Shepherds the Community, Works Miracles

Cleric (light): Blazes With Radiance, Channels Divine Blessings

Cleric (storm): Rides the Lightning, Thunders

Cleric (trickery): Takes Animal Shape* (also see options for rogues)

Cleric (war): Masters Weaponry (also see options for fighters)

Druid: As a very specific sort of nature priest, a druid character is usually an Adept or Explorer (in either case probably using the magic flavor). A typical druid probably has Channels Divine Blessings or Lives in the Wilderness as a focus, but for more specific options, see the following foci:

Druid (animal companion): Controls Beasts, Masters the Swarm

Druid (elemental): Abides in Stone, Bears a Halo of Fire, Moves Like the Wind, Rides the Lightning, Wears a Sheen of Ice

Druid (nature affinity): Speaks for the Land

Druid (transformation): Abides in Stone, Takes Animal Shape*, Walks the Wild Woods*

Fighter: Fighters almost always have the Warrior type, but some are Explorers. A typical fighter probably has a direct focus like Masters Weaponry or Wields an Enchanted Weapon*. For additional options based on choosing a specific fighting role, see the following:

Fighter (guardian): Brandishes an Exotic Shield, Defends the Gate, Masters Defense, Never Says Die, Stands Like a Bastion.

Fighter (melee): Fights Dirty, Fights With Panache, Looks For Trouble, Needs No Weapon, Wields Two Weapons at Once

Fighter (ranged): Is Licensed to Carry, Throws With Deadly Accuracy
Gunslinger: A gunslinger is probably a Warrior or Explorer, but some are Speakers with combat flavor. Appropriate foci are Is Licensed to Carry, Masters Weaponry, Sailed Beneath the Jolly Roger, and Wields an Enchanted Weapon*.

Inquisitor: Inquisitors are usually Explorers, Speakers, or Warriors, depending on whether their inclinations are for having many skills, being good at interacting with people, or combat. Appropriate foci are Infiltrates, Metes Out Justice, and Operates Undercover.

Merchant: An Explorer with a focus dealing with social interactions, like Entertains or Leads, would make a good merchant character, but the more obvious choice would be a Speaker.

Monk or Martial Artist: As masters of unarmed combat, monks are usually Warriors or Explorers (perhaps with a combat flavor). Appropriate foci are Fights With Panache, Needs No Weapon, and Throws With Deadly Accuracy.

Paladin/Holy Knight/Paragon: As holy warriors who mix martial prowess and magic, paladins are usually Warriors or Explorers (in either case, perhaps modified with the magic flavor). Good foci for this type of character include Defends the Gate, Defends the Weak, Metes Out Justice, Slays Monsters, and Wields an Enchanted Weapon*.

Ranger: Rangers mix combat and skills, and therefore are usually Explorers (perhaps with combat flavor) or Warriors (perhaps with skills and knowledge flavor). Appropriate foci for a ranger are Controls Beasts, Hunts, Lives in the Wilderness, Slays Monsters, Throws With Deadly Accuracy, and Wields Two Weapons at Once.

Rogue or Thief: Most rogue-type characters are Explorers, but an interaction-focused rogue could easily be a Speaker (perhaps with stealth flavor). Good foci for rogues are Explores Dark Places, Fights Dirty, Hunts, Infiltrates, Is Wanted by the Law, Moves Like a Cat, Sailed Beneath the Jolly Roger, and Works the Back Alleys.

Sorcerer: Sorcerers, for our purpose here, are mages who have inherent magical abilities (as opposed to wizards, who

study long and hard to get their spells). Most sorcerers are Adepts, but some are Explorers or Speakers. The Masters Spells focus gives a typical sorcerer an effective set of abilities, and most foci choices provide a themed set of spells. For sorcerers of various magical bloodlines, see the following:

Sorcerer (angel): Blazes With Radiance, Channels Divine Blessings, Keeps a Magic Ally

Sorcerer (destiny): Descends From Nobility, Was Foretold

Sorcerer (dragon): Bears a Halo of Fire, Rides the Lightning, Wears a Sheen of Ice

Sorcerer (elemental): Abides in Stone, Bears a Halo of Fire, Employs Magnetism, Moves Like the Wind, Rides the Lightning, Wears a Sheen of Ice

Sorcerer (fey): Takes Animal Shape*

Sorcerer (fiend): Bears a Halo of Fire, Keeps a Magic Ally

Sorcerer (undead): Consorts With the Dead, Shepherds Spirits

Trickster or Con Artist: These clever folks are typically Speakers, although they could be Adepts if they are very magical (or Explorers if they aren't magical at all). Foci choices include Fights Dirty, Works the Back Alleys, or Entertains.

War-wizard: For those unusual characters who use a mix of weapon attacks and spells, play a Warrior with magic flavor or an Expert with combat or magic flavor. Appropriate foci include Fights With Panache, Masters Weaponry, and Wields an Enchanted Weapon*.

Warlock or Witch: For the purposes of this list, warlocks and witches are mages who gain magical power from pacts they make with otherworldly entities. Most warlocks are Adepts, but Explorers and Speakers (perhaps with magic flavor) can be interesting options. Fun foci for a warlock include Dances With Dark Matter, Keeps a Magic Ally, Masters the Swarm, Separates Mind From Body, and Was Foretold, but (depending on the patron and pact) most sorcerer and wizard foci work just as well.

Wild Mage: Those who use chaotic magic are usually Adepts, but a dabbler might be an Explorer or Speaker with the magic flavor. The best focus that suits this theme is Uses

Wild Magic*.

Wizard: For the purposes of this list, wizards study magical lore at length to learn the ways of spellcasting (as opposed to sorcerers, warlocks, and so on). Wizards are usually Adepts, but a person-oriented wizard might be a Speaker (perhaps with the magic flavor). For a generalist wizard who has a variety of spells, choose the Masters Spells focus. For more specific kinds of wizards, see the following:

Wizard (abjurer): Absorbs Energy, Focuses Mind Over Matter, Wears a Sheen of Ice

Wizard (conjurer or summoner): Controls Beasts, Keeps a Magic Ally

Wizard (diviner): Learns Quickly, Sees Beyond, Separates Mind From Body, Solves Mysteries

Wizard (enchanter): Commands Mental Powers, Leads

Wizard (evoker): Bears a Halo of Fire, Blazes With Radiance, Rides the Lightning, Thunders, Wears a Sheen of Ice

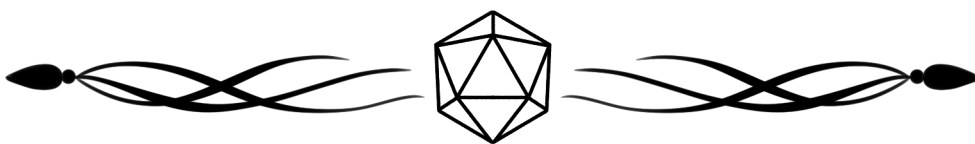
Wizard (illusionist): Awakens Dreams, Crafts Illusions

Wizard (necromancer): Consorts With the Dead, Shepherds Spirits

Wizard (transmuter): Controls Gravity, Focuses Mind Over Matter, Takes Animal Shape*

3.1 Prepared vs. Spontaneous Spellcasting

Magical characters get their abilities (which might be spells, rituals, or something else) from their type and focus, and they can use these abilities as they see fit as long as they spend the required Pool points. This technically makes them more like spontaneous casters. If you'd like to play something more like a prepared-caster wizard with a large selection of abilities that you narrow down each day, consider a spellcasting-oriented focus like Channels Divine Blessings, Masters Spells, or Speaks for the Land, and consider augmenting it with the optional spellcasting rule.



Chapter 4

Further Customization

The rules in this section are more advanced and always involve the GM. They can be used by the GM to tailor a type to better fit the genre or setting, or by a player and a GM to tweak a character to fit a concept.

4.1 Modifying Type Aspects

The following aspects of the four character types can be modified at character creation. Other abilities should not be changed.

Stat Pools: Each character type has a starting stat Pool value. A player can exchange points between their Pools on a one-for-one basis. For example, they can trade 2 points of Might for 2 points of Speed. However, no starting stat Pool should be higher than 20.

Edge: A player can start with an Edge of 1 in whichever stat they wish.

Cypher Use: If a character gives up the ability to bear one cypher, they gain an additional skill of their choice.

Weapons: Some types have static first-tier abilities that let them use light, medium, and/or heavy weapons without a penalty. Warriors can use all weapons, Explorers can use light and medium weapons, and Adepts and Speakers can use light weapons. Any one of these weapon abilities can be sacrificed to gain training in a different skill of the player's choice.

4.2 Drawbacks and Penalties

In addition to other customization options, a player can choose to take drawbacks or penalties to gain further advantages.

Weakness: A weakness is, essentially, the opposite of Edge. If you have a weakness of 1 in Speed, all Speed actions that require you to spend points cost 1 additional point from your Pool. At any time, a player can give their character a weakness in one stat and, in exchange, gain +1 to their Edge in one of the other two stats. So a PC can take a weakness of 1 in Speed to gain +1 to their Might Edge. Normally, you can have a weakness only in a stat in which you have an Edge of 0. Further, you can't have more than one weakness, and you can't have a weakness greater than 1 unless the additional weakness comes from another source (such as a disease or disability arising from actions or conditions in the game).

Inabilities: Inabilities are like negative skills. They make one type of task harder by hindering it. If a character chooses to take an inability, they gain a skill of their choice. Normally, a character can have only one inability unless the additional inability comes from another source (such as a descriptor or a

disease or disability arising from actions or conditions in the game).

4.3 Flavors

Flavors are groups of special abilities the GM and players can use to alter a character type to make it more to their liking or more appropriate to the genre or setting. For example, if a player wants to create a magic-using thief character, she could play an Adept with stealth flavoring. In a science fiction setting, a Warrior might also have knowledge of machinery, so the character could be flavored with technology.

At a given tier, abilities from a flavor are traded one for one with standard abilities from a type. So to add the Danger Sense stealth flavor ability to a Warrior, something else—perhaps Bash—must be sacrificed. Now that character can choose Danger Sense as they would any other first-tier warrior ability, but they can never choose Bash.

The GM should always be involved in flavoring a type. For example, they might know that for their science fiction game, they want a type called a “Glam,” which is a Speaker flavored with certain technology abilities—specifically those that make the character a flamboyant starship pilot. Thus, they exchange the first-tier abilities Spin Identity and Inspire Aggression for the technology flavor abilities Datajack and Tech Skills so the character can plug into the ship directly and can take piloting and computers as skills.

In the end, flavor is mostly a tool for the GM to easily create campaign-specific types by making a few slight alterations to the four base types. Although players may wish to use flavors to get the characters they want, remember that they can also shape their PCs with descriptors and foci very nicely. The flavors available are stealth, technology, magic, combat, and skills and knowledge.

The full description for each listed ability can be found in the Abilities chapter, which also contains descriptions for type and focus abilities in a single vast catalog.

4.3.1 Stealth Flavor

Characters with the stealth flavor are good at sneaking around, infiltrating places they don't belong, and deceiving others. They use these abilities in a variety of ways, including combat. An Explorer with stealth flavor might be a thief, while a Warrior with stealth flavor might be an assassin. An Explorer with stealth flavor in a superhero setting might be a crimefighter who stalks the streets at night.

First-tier Stealth Abilities

- Danger Sense
- Goad
- Legerdemain
- Opportunist
- Stealth Skills

Second-tier Stealth Abilities

- Contortionist
- Find an Opening

- Get Away
- Sense Ambush
- Surprise Attack

Third-tier Stealth Abilities

- Evanesce
- From the Shadows
- Gambler
- Inner Defense
- Misdirect
- Run and Fight
- Seize the Moment

Fourth-tier Stealth Abilities

- Ambusher
- Debilitating Strike
- Outwit
- Preternatural Senses
- Tumbling Moves

Fifth-tier Stealth Abilities

- Assassin Strike
- Mask
- Return to Sender
- Uncanny Luck

Sixth-tier Stealth Abilities

- Exploit Advantage
- Spring Away
- Thief's Luck
- Twist of Fate

4.3.2 Technology Flavor

Characters with a flavor of technology typically are from science fiction or at least modern-day settings (although anything is possible). They excel at using, dealing with, and building machines. An Explorer with technology flavor might be a starship pilot, and a Speaker flavored with technology could be a technopriest. Some of the less computer-oriented abilities might be appropriate for a steampunk character, while a modern-day character could use some of the abilities that don't involve starships or ultratech.

First-tier Technology Abilities

- Datajack
- Hacker
- Machine Interface
- Scramble Machine
- Tech Skills
- Tinker

Second-tier Technology Abilities

- Distant Interface
- Machine Efficiency
- Overload Machine
- Serv-0
- Serv-0 Defender
- Serv-0 Repair
- Tool Mastery

Third-tier Technology Abilities

- Mechanical Telepathy
- Serv-0 Scanner
- Ship Footing
- Shipspeak
- Spray

Fourth-tier Technology Abilities

- Machine Bond
- Robot Fighter
- Serv-0 Aim
- Serv-0 Brawler
- Serv-0 Spy

Fifth-tier Technology Abilities

- Control Machine
- Jury-Rig
- Machine Companion

Sixth-tier Technology Abilities

- Information Gathering
- Master Machine

4.3.3 Magic Flavor

You know a little about magic. You might not be a wizard, but you know the basics—how it works, and how to accomplish a few wondrous things. Of course, in your setting, “magic” might actually mean psychic powers, mutant abilities, weird alien tech, or anything else that produces interesting and useful effects. An Explorer flavored with magic might be a wizard-hunter, and a Speaker with magical flavor might be a sorcerer-bard. Although an Adept flavored with magic is still an Adept, you might find that swapping some of the type’s basic abilities with those given here tailors the character in desirable ways.

First-tier Magic Abilities

- Blessing of the Gods
- Closed Mind
- Entangling Force
- Hedge Magic
- Magic Training
- Mental Link
- Premonition

Second-tier Magic Abilities

- Concussive Blast
- Fetch
- Force Field
- Lock
- Repair Flesh

Third-tier Magic Abilities

- Distance Viewing
- Fire Bloom
- Fling
- Force at Distance
- Summon Giant Spider

Fourth-tier Magic Abilities

- Elemental Protection
- Ignition
- Pry Open

Fifth-tier Magic Abilities

- Create
- Divine Intervention
- Dragon’s Maw
- Fast Travel
- True Senses

Sixth-tier Magic Abilities

- Relocate
- Summon Demon
- Traverse the Worlds
- Word of Death

4.3.4 Combat Flavor

Combat flavor makes a character more martial. A Speaker with combat flavor in a fantasy setting would be a battle bard. An Explorer with combat flavor in a historical game might be a pirate. An Adept flavored with combat in a science fiction setting could be a veteran of a thousand psychic wars.

First-tier Combat Abilities

- Danger Sense
- Practiced in Armor
- Practiced With Medium Weapons

Second-tier Combat Abilities

- Bloodlust
- Combat Prowess
- Trained Without Armor

Third-tier Combat Abilities

- Practiced With All Weapons
- Skill With Attacks
- Skill With Defense
- Successive Attack

Fourth-tier Combat Abilities

- Capable Warrior
- Deadly Aim
- Fury
- Misdirect
- Spray

Fifth-tier Combat Abilities

- Experienced Defender
- Hard Target
- Parry

Sixth-tier Combat Abilities

- Greater Skill With Attacks
- Mastery in Armor
- Mastery With Defense

4.3.5 Skills and Knowledge Flavor

This flavor is for characters in roles that call for more knowledge and more real-world application of talent. It's less flashy and dramatic than supernatural powers or the ability to hack apart multiple foes, but sometimes expertise or know-how is the real solution to a problem.

A Warrior flavored with skills and knowledge might be a military engineer. An Explorer flavored with skills and knowledge could be a field scientist. A Speaker with this flavor might be a teacher.

First-tier Skills and Knowledge Abilities

- Interaction Skills
- Investigative Skills
- Knowledge Skills
- Physical Skills
- Travel Skills

Second-tier Skills and Knowledge Abilities

- Extra Skill
- Tool Mastery

- Understanding

Third-tier Skills and Knowledge Abilities

- Flex Skill
- Improvise

Fourth-tier Skills and Knowledge Abilities

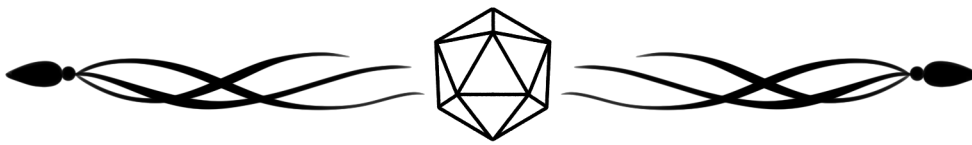
- Multiple Skills
- Quick Wits
- Task Specialization

Fifth-tier Skills and Knowledge Abilities

- Practiced With Medium Weapons
- Read the Signs

Sixth-tier Skills and Knowledge Abilities

- Skill With Attacks
- Skill With Defense



Chapter 5

Descriptor

Your descriptor defines your character—it flavors everything you do. The differences between a Charming Explorer and a Vicious Explorer are considerable. The descriptor changes the way those characters go about every action. Your descriptor places your character in the situation (the first adventure, which starts the campaign) and helps provide motivation. It is the adjective of the sentence “I am an adjective noun who verbs.”

Descriptors offer a one-time package of extra abilities, skills, or modifications to your stat Pools. Not all of a descriptor’s offerings are positive character modifications. For example, some descriptors have inabilities—tasks that a character isn’t good at. You can think of inabilities as negative skills—instead of being one step better at that kind of task, you’re one step worse. If you become skilled at a task that you have an inability with, they cancel out. Remember that characters are defined as much by what they’re not good at as by what they are good at.

Descriptors also offer a few brief suggestions for how your character got involved with the rest of the group on their first adventure. You can use these, or not, as you wish.

This section details fifty descriptors. Choose one of them for your character. You can pick any descriptor you wish regardless of your type. At the end of this chapter, a few options are provided for Customizing Descriptors, including making a character’s species their descriptor. (Your descriptor matters most when you are a beginning character. The benefits (and perhaps drawbacks) that come from your descriptor will eventually be overshadowed by the growing importance of your type and focus. However, the influence of your descriptor will remain at least somewhat important throughout your character’s life.)

5.1 Descriptors

- Appealing
- Beneficent
- Brash
- Calm
- Chaotic
- Charming
- Clever
- Clumsy
- Craven
- Creative
- Cruel
- Dishonorable
- Doomed
- Empathic
- Exiled
- Fast
- Foolish
- Graceful
- Guarded
- Hardy
- Hideous
- Honorable
- Impulsive
- Inquisitive
- Intelligent
- Intuitive
- Jovial
- Kind
- Learned
- Lucky
- Mad
- Mechanical
- Mysterious
- Mystical
- Naive
- Perceptive
- Resilient
- Risk-Taking
- Rugged
- Sharp-Eyed
- Skeptical
- Stealthy
- Strong
- Strong-Willed
- Swift
- Tongue-Tied
- Tough
- Vicious
- Virtuous
- Weird

5.1.1 Appealing

You're attractive to others, but perhaps more important, you are likeable and charismatic. You've got that "special something" that draws others to you. You often know just the right thing to say to make someone laugh, put them at ease, or spur them to action. People like you, want to help you, and want to be your friend.

You gain the following characteristics:

Charismatic: +2 to your Intellect Pool.

Skill: You are trained in pleasant social interactions.

Resistant to Charms: You're aware of how others can manipulate and charm people, and you notice when those tactics are used on you. Because of this awareness, you are trained in resisting any kind of persuasion or seduction if you wish it.

Initial Link to the Starting Adventure: From the following list of options, choose how you became involved in the first adventure.

1. You met a total stranger (one of the other PCs) and charmed them so much that they invited you along.
2. The PCs were looking for someone else, but you convinced them that you were perfect instead.
3. Pure happenstance—because you just go along with the flow of things and everything usually works out.
4. Your charismatic ways helped get one of the PCs out of a difficult spot a long time ago, and they always ask you to join them on new adventures.

5.1.2 Beneficent

Helping others is your calling. It's why you're here. Others delight in your outgoing and charitable nature, and you delight in their happiness. You're at your best when you're aiding people, either by explaining how they can best overcome a challenge or by demonstrating how to do so yourself.

You gain the following characteristics:

Generous: Allies who have spent the last day with you add +1 to their recovery rolls.

Altruistic: If you're standing next to a creature that takes damage, you can intercede and take 1 point of that damage yourself (reducing the damage inflicted on the creature by 1 point). If you have Armor, it does not provide a benefit when you use this ability.

Skill: You're trained in all tasks related to pleasant social interaction, putting other people at ease, and gaining trust.

Helpful: Whenever you help another character, that character gains the benefit as if you were trained even if you are not trained or specialized in the attempted task.

Inability: While you are alone, all Intellect and Speed tasks are hindered.

Initial Link to the Starting Adventure: From the following list of options, choose how you became involved in the first adventure.

1. Even though you didn't know most of the other PCs beforehand, you invited yourself along on their quest.
2. You saw the PCs struggling to overcome a problem and selflessly joined them to help.
3. You're nearly certain the PCs will fail without you.
4. The choice was between your tattered life and helping others. You haven't looked back since.

5.1.3 Brash

You're a self-assertive sort, confident in your abilities, energetic, and perhaps a bit irreverent toward ideas that you don't agree with. Some people call you bold and brave, but those you've put in their place might call you puffed up and arrogant. Whatever. It's not in your nature to care what other people think about you, unless those people are your friends or family. Even someone as brash as you knows that friends sometimes have to come first.

You gain the following characteristics:

Energetic: +2 to your Speed Pool.

Skill: You are trained in initiative.

Bold: You are trained in all actions that involve overcoming or ignoring the effects of fear or intimidation.

Initial Link to the Starting Adventure: From the following list of options, choose how you became involved in the first adventure.

1. You noticed something weird going on, and without much thought, you jumped in with both feet.
2. You showed up when and where you did on a dare because, hey, you don't back down from dares.
3. Someone called you out, but instead of walking into a fight, you walked into your current situation.
4. You told your friend that nothing could scare you, and nothing you saw would change your mind. They brought you to your current point.

5.1.4 Calm

You've spent most of your life in sedentary pursuits—books, movies, hobbies, and so on—rather than active ones. You're well versed in all manner of academia or other intellectual pursuits, but nothing physical. You're not weak or feeble, necessarily (although this is a good descriptor for characters who are elderly), but you have no experience in more physical activities.

(Calm is a great descriptor for characters who never intended to have adventures but were thrust into them, a trope that occurs often in modern games and particularly in horror games.)

You gain the following characteristics:

Bookish: +2 to your Intellect Pool.

Skills: You are trained in four nonphysical skills of your choice.

Trivia: You can come up with a random fact pertinent to the current situation when you wish it. This is always a matter of fact, not conjecture or supposition, and must be something you could have logically read or seen in the past. You can do this one time, although the ability is renewed each time you make a recovery roll.

Inability: You're just not a fighter. All physical attacks are hindered.

Inability: You're not the outdoorsy type. All climbing, running, jumping, and swimming tasks are hindered.

Initial Link to the Starting Adventure: From the following list of options, choose how you became involved in the first adventure.

1. You read about the current situation somewhere and decided to check it out for yourself.
2. You were in the right (wrong?) place at the right (wrong?) time.
3. While avoiding an entirely different situation, you walked into your current situation.
4. One of the other PCs dragged you into it.

5.1.5 Chaotic

Danger doesn't mean much to you, mainly because you don't think much about repercussions. In fact, you enjoy sowing surprises, just to see what will happen. The more unexpected the result, the happier you are. Sometimes you are particularly manic, and for the sake of your companions, you restrain yourself from taking actions that you know will lead to disaster.

You gain the following characteristics:

Tumultuous: +4 to your Speed Pool.

Skill: You are trained in Intellect defense actions.

Chaotic: Once after each ten-hour recovery roll, if you don't like the first result, you can reroll a die roll of your choice. If you do, and regardless of the outcome, the GM presents you with a GM intrusion.

Inability: Your body is a bit worn from occasional excesses. Might defense tasks are hindered.

Initial Link to the Starting Adventure: From the following list of options, choose how you became involved in the first adventure.

1. Another PC recruited you while you were on your best behavior, before realizing how chaotic you were.
2. You have reason to believe that being with the other PCs will help you gain control over your erratic behavior.
3. Another PC released you from captivity, and to thank them, you volunteered to help.
4. You have no idea how you joined the PCs. You're just going along with it for now until answers present themselves.

5.1.6 Charming

You're a smooth talker and a charmer. Whether through seemingly supernatural means or just a way with words, you can convince others to do as you wish. Most likely, you're physically attractive or at least highly charismatic, and others enjoy listening to your voice. You probably pay attention to your appearance, keeping yourself well groomed. You make friends easily. You play up the personality facet of your Intellect stat; intelligence is not your strong suit. You're personable, but not necessarily studious or strong-willed.

You gain the following characteristics:

Personable: +2 to your Intellect Pool.

Skill: You're trained in all tasks involving positive or pleasant social interaction.

Skill: You're trained when using special abilities that influence the minds of others.

Contact: You have an important contact who is in an influential position, such as a minor noble, the captain of the town guard/police, or the head of a large gang of thieves. You and the GM should work out the details together.

Inability: You were never good at studying or retaining facts. Any task involving lore, knowledge, or understanding is hindered.

Inability: Your willpower is not one of your strong points. Defense actions to resist mental attacks are hindered.

Additional Equipment: You've managed to talk your way into some decent discounts and bonuses in recent weeks. As a result, you have enough cash jangling in your pocket to purchase a moderately priced item.

Initial Link to the Starting Adventure: From the following list of options, choose how you became involved in the first adventure.

1. You convinced one of the other PCs to tell you what they were doing.

2. You instigated the whole thing and convinced the others to join you.

3. One of the other PCs did a favor for you, and now you're repaying that obligation by helping them with the task at hand.

4. There is a reward involved, and you need the money.

5.1.7 Clever

You're quick-witted, thinking well on your feet. You understand people, so you can fool them but are rarely fooled. Because you easily see things for what they are, you get the lay of the land swiftly, size up threats and allies, and assess situations with accuracy. Perhaps you're physically attractive, or maybe you use your wit to overcome any physical or mental imperfections.

You gain the following characteristics:

Smart: +2 to your Intellect Pool.

Skill: You're trained in all interactions involving lies or trickery.

Skill: You're trained in defense rolls to resist mental effects.

Skill: You're trained in all tasks involving identifying or assessing danger, lies, quality, importance, function, or power.

Inability: You were never good at studying or retaining trivial knowledge. Any task involving lore, knowledge, or understanding is hindered.

Additional Equipment: You see through the schemes of others and occasionally convince them to believe you—even when, perhaps, they should not. Thanks to your clever behavior, you have an additional expensive item.

Initial Link to the Starting Adventure: From the following list of options, choose how you became involved in the first adventure.

1. You convinced one of the other PCs to tell you what they were doing.
2. From afar, you observed that something interesting was going on.
3. You talked your way into the situation because you thought it might earn some money.
4. You suspect that the other PCs won't succeed without you.

5.1.8 Clumsy

Graceless and awkward, you were told that you'd grow out of it, but you never did. You often drop things, trip over your own feet, or knock things (or people) over. Some people get frustrated by this quality, but most find it funny and even a little charming.

(Some players may not want to be defined by a "negative" quality like Clumsy, but in truth, even this kind of descriptor has enough advantages that it makes for capable and talented characters. What negative descriptors really do is make more interesting and complex characters that are often great fun to play.)

You gain the following characteristics:

Butterfingers: -2 to your Speed Pool.

Thick-Muscled: +2 to your Might Pool.

Inelegant: You have a certain lovable charm. You are trained in all pleasant social interactions when you express a lighthearted, self-deprecating manner. Dumb Luck: The GM can introduce a GM intrusion on you, based on your clumsiness, without awarding you any XP (as if you had rolled a 1 on a d20 roll). However, if this happens, 50% of the time, your

clumsiness works to your advantage. Rather than hurting you (much), it helps you, or it hurts your enemies. You slip, but it's just in time to duck an attack. You fall down, but you trip your enemies as you crash into their legs. You turn around too quickly, but you end up knocking the weapon from your foe's hand. You and the GM should work together to determine the details. If the GM wishes, they can use GM intrusions based on your clumsiness normally (awarding XP).

Skill: You've got a certain bull-like quality. You are trained in tasks involving breaking things.

Inability: Any task that involves balance, grace, or hand-to-eye coordination is hindered.

Initial Link to the Starting Adventure: From the following list of options, choose how you became involved in the first adventure.

1. You were in the right place at the right time.
2. You had a piece of information that the other PCs needed to make their plans.
3. A sibling recommended you to the other PCs.
4. You stumbled into the PCs as they were discussing their mission, and they took a liking to you.

5.1.9 Craven

Courage fails you at every turn. You lack the willpower and resolve to stand fast in the face of danger. Fear gnaws at your heart, chewing away at your mind, driving you to distraction until you cannot bear it. Most times, you back down from confrontations. You flee from threats and vacillate when faced with difficult decisions.

Yet for all that fear dogs you and possibly shames you, your cowardly nature proves to be a useful ally from time to time. Listening to your fears has helped you escape danger and avoid taking unnecessary risks. Others may have suffered in your place, and you might be the first to admit this fact, but secretly you feel intense relief from having avoided an unthinkable and terrible fate.

(Descriptors like Craven, Cruel, and Dishonorable might not be appropriate for every group. These are villainous traits and some people want their PCs to be entirely heroic. But others don't mind a little moral greyness thrown into the mix. Still others see things like Craven and Cruel as traits to overcome as their characters develop (probably earning them different descriptors).)

You gain the following characteristics:

Furtive: +2 to your Speed Pool.

Skill: You're trained in stealth-based tasks.

Skill: You're trained in running actions.

Skill: You're trained in any action taken to escape danger, flee from a dangerous situation, or wheedle your way out of trouble.

Inability: You do not willingly enter dangerous situations. Any initiative actions (to determine who goes first in combat) are hindered.

Inability: You fall to pieces when you have to undertake a potentially dangerous task alone. Any such task (such as attacking a creature by yourself) is hindered.

Additional Equipment: You have a good luck charm or protective device to keep you out of harm's way.

Initial Link to the Starting Adventure: From the following list of options, choose how you became involved in the first adventure.

1. You believe that you're being hunted, and you have hired one of the other PCs as your protector.
2. You seek to escape your shame and take up with capable individuals in the hopes of repairing your reputation.
3. One of the other PCs bullied you into coming along.
4. The group answered your cries for help when you were in trouble.

5.1.10 Creative

Maybe you have a notebook where you write down ideas so you can develop them later. Perhaps you email yourself ideas that strike you out of the blue so you can sort them in an electronic document. Or maybe you just sit down, stare at your screen and, by indomitable force of will, produce something from nothing. However your gift works, you're creative—you code, write, compose, sculpt, design, direct, or otherwise create narratives that enthrall other people with your vision.

You gain the following characteristics:

Inventive: +2 to your Intellect Pool.

Original: You're always coming up with something new. You're trained in any task related to creating a narrative (such as a story, play, or scenario). This includes deception, if the deception involves a narrative you're able to tell.

Skill: You are naturally inventive. You are trained in one specific creative skill of your choice: writing, computer coding, composing music, painting, drawing, and so on.

Skill: You love solving riddles and the like. You are trained in puzzle-solving tasks.

Skill: To be creative requires that you always be learning. You are trained in any task that involves finding out something new, such as when you're digging through a library, data bank, news archive, or similar collection of knowledge.

Inability: You're inventive but not charming. All tasks related to pleasant social interaction are hindered.

Initial Link to the Starting Adventure: From the following list of options, choose how you became involved in the first adventure.

1. You were doing research for a project and convinced the PCs to bring you along.
2. You're looking for new markets for the results of your creative output.
3. You fell in with the wrong crowd, but they grew on you.
4. A creative life is often one beset with financial hurdles. You joined the PCs because you hoped it would be profitable.

5.1.11 Cruel

Misfortune and suffering do not move you. When another endures hardship, you find it hard to care, and you may even enjoy the pain and difficulty the person experiences if they've done you wrong in the past. Your cruel streak may derive from bitterness brought about by your own struggles and disappointments. You might be a hard pragmatist, doing what you feel you must even if others are worse for it. Or you could be a sadist, delighting in the pain you inflict.

Being cruel does not necessarily make you a villain. Your cruelty may be reserved for those who cross you or other people useful to you. You might have become cruel as the result of an intensely awful experience. Abuse and torture, for example, can strip away compassion for other living beings.

As well, you need not be cruel in every situation. In fact, others might see you as personable, friendly, and even helpful.

But when angered or frustrated, your dual nature reveals itself, and those who have earned your scorn are likely to suffer for it.

You gain the following characteristics:

Cunning: +2 to your Intellect Pool.

Cruelty: When you use force, you can choose to maim or deliver painful injuries to draw out your foe's suffering. Whenever you inflict damage, you can choose to inflict 2 fewer points of damage to ease your next attack against that foe.

Skill: You're trained in tasks related to deception, intimidation, and persuasion when you interact with characters experiencing physical or emotional pain.

Inability: You have a hard time connecting with others, understanding their motives, or sharing their feelings. Any task to ascertain another character's motives, feelings, or disposition is hindered.

Additional Equipment: You have a valuable memento from the last person you destroyed. The memento is moderately priced, and you can sell it or trade it for an item of equal or lesser value.

Initial Link to the Starting Adventure: From the following list of options, choose how you became involved in the first adventure.

1. You suspect that you might gain a long-term advantage from helping the other PCs and may be able to use that advantage against your enemies.
2. By joining the PCs, you see an opportunity to grow your personal power and status at the expense of others.
3. You hope to make another PC's life more difficult by joining the group.
4. Joining the PCs gives you an opportunity to escape justice for a crime you committed.

5.1.12 Dishonorable

There is no honor among thieves—or betrayers, backstabbers, liars, or cheats. You are all of these things, and either you don't lose any sleep over it, or you deny the truth to others or to yourself. Regardless, you are willing to do whatever it takes to get your own way. Honor, ethics, and principles are merely words. In your estimation, they have no place in the real world.

You gain the following characteristics:

Sneaky: +4 to your Speed Pool.

Just Desserts: When the GM gives another player an experience point to award to someone for a GM intrusion, that player cannot give it to you.

Skill: You are trained in deception.

Skill: You are trained in stealth.

Skill: You are trained in intimidation.

Inability: People don't like or trust you. Pleasant social interactions are hindered.

Initial Link to the Starting Adventure: From the following list of options, choose how you became involved in the first adventure.

1. You are interested in what the PCs are doing, so you lied to them to get into their group.
2. While skulking about, you overheard the PCs' plans and realized that you wanted in.
3. One of the other PCs invited you, having no idea of what you're truly like.
4. You bullied your way in with intimidation and bluster.

5.1.13 Doomed

You are quite certain that your fate is leading you, inextricably, toward a terrible end. This fate might be yours alone, or you might be dragging along the people closest to you.

You gain the following characteristics:

Jumpy: +2 to your Speed Pool.

Skill: Always on the lookout for danger, you are trained in perception-related tasks.

Skill: You are defense minded, so you are trained in Speed defense tasks.

Skill: You are cynical and expect the worst. Thus, you are resistant to mental shocks. You are trained in Intellect defense tasks having to do with losing your sanity or equanimity.

Doom: Every other time the GM uses GM intrusion on your character, you cannot refuse it and do not get an XP for it (you still get an XP to award to another player). This is because you are doomed. The universe is a cold, uncaring place, and your efforts are futile at best.

Initial Link to the Starting Adventure: From the following list of options, choose how you became involved in the first adventure.

1. You attempted to avoid it, but events seemed to conspire to draw you to where you are.
2. Why not? It doesn't matter. You're doomed no matter what you do.
3. One of the other PCs saved your life, and now you're repaying that obligation by helping them with the task at hand.
4. You suspect that the only hope you have of avoiding your fate might lie on this path.

5.1.14 Empathic

Other people are open books to you. You may have a knack for reading a person's tells, those subtle movements that convey an individual's mood and disposition. Or you may receive information in a more direct way, feeling a person's emotions as if they were tangible things, sensations that lightly brush against your mind. Your gift for empathy helps you navigate social situations and control them to avoid misunderstandings and prevent useless conflicts from erupting.

The constant bombardment of emotions from those around you likely takes a toll. You might move with the prevailing mood, swinging from giddy happiness to bitter sorrow with little warning. Or you might close yourself off and remain inscrutable to others out of a sense of self-preservation or an unconscious fear that everyone else might learn how you truly feel.

You gain the following characteristics:

Open Mind: +4 to your Intellect Pool.

Skill: You're trained in tasks involving sensing other emotions, discerning dispositions, and getting a hunch about people around you.

Skill: You're trained in all tasks involving social interaction, pleasant or otherwise.

Inability: Being so receptive to others' thoughts and moods makes you vulnerable to anything that attacks your mind. Intellect defense rolls are hindered.

Initial Link to the Starting Adventure: From the following list of options, choose how you became involved in the first adventure.

1. You sensed the commitment to the task the other PCs have and felt moved to help them.
2. You established a close bond with another PC and can't bear to be parted from them.

3. You sensed something strange in one of the PCs and decided to join the group to see if you can sense it again and uncover the truth.

4. You joined the PCs to escape an unpleasant relationship or negative environment.

5.1.15 Exiled

You have walked a long and lonely road, leaving your home and your life behind. You might have committed a heinous crime, something so awful that your people forced you out, and if you dare return, you face death. You might have been accused of a crime you didn't commit and now must pay the price for someone else's wicked deed. Your exile might be the result of a social gaffe—perhaps you shamed your family or a friend, or you embarrassed yourself in front of your peers, an authority, or someone you respect. Whatever the reason, you have left your old life behind and now strive to make a new one.

You gain the following characteristics:

Self-Reliant: +2 to your Might Pool.

Loner: You gain no benefit when you get help with a task from another character who is trained or specialized in that task.

Skill: You're trained in all tasks involving sneaking.

Skill: You're trained in all tasks involving foraging, hunting, and finding safe places to rest or hide.

Inability: Living on your own for as long as you have makes you slow to trust others and awkward in social situations. Any task involving social interaction is hindered.

Additional Equipment: You have a memento from your past—an old picture, a locket with a few strands of hair inside, or a lighter given to you by someone important. You keep the object close at hand and pull it out to help you remember better times.

Initial Link to the Starting Adventure: From the following list of options, choose how you became involved in the first adventure.

1. The other PCs earned your trust by helping you when you needed it. You accompany them to repay them.

2. While exploring on your own, you discovered something strange. When you traveled to a settlement, the PCs were the only ones who believed you, and they have accompanied you to help you deal with the problem.

3. One of the other PCs reminds you of someone you used to know.

4. You have grown weary of your isolation. Joining the other PCs gives you a chance to belong.

5.1.16 Fast

You're fleet of foot. Because you're quick, you can accomplish tasks more rapidly than others can. You're not just quick on your feet, however—you're quick with your hands, and you think and react quickly. You even talk quickly.

You gain the following characteristics:

Energetic: +2 to your Speed Pool.

Skill: You are trained in running.

Fast: You can move a short distance and still take another action in the same round, or you can move a long distance as your action without needing to make any kind of roll.

Inability: You're a sprinter, not a long-distance runner. You don't have a lot of stamina. Might defense rolls are hindered.

Initial Link to the Starting Adventure: From the following list of options, choose how you became involved in the first adventure.

1. You jumped in to save one of the other PCs who was in dire need.

2. One of the other PCs recruited you for your unique talents.

3. You're impulsive, and it seemed like a good idea at the time.

4. This mission ties in with a personal goal of your own.

5.1.17 Foolish

Not everyone can be brilliant. Oh, you don't think of yourself as stupid, and you're not. It's just that others might have a bit more . . . wisdom. Insight. You prefer to barrel along headfirst through life and let other people worry about things. Worrying's never helped you, so why bother? You take things at face value and don't fret about what tomorrow might bring.

People call you "idiot" or "numbskull," but it doesn't faze you much.

(It can be liberating and really fun to play a foolish character. In some ways, the pressure to always do the right, smart thing is off. On the other hand, if you play such a character as a bumbling moron in every situation, that can become annoying to everyone else at the table. As with everything, moderation is the key.)

You gain the following characteristics:

Unwise: -4 to your Intellect Pool.

Carefree: You succeed more on luck than anything. Every time you roll for a task, roll twice and take the higher result.

Intellect Weakness: Any time you spend points from your Intellect Pool, it costs you 1 more point than usual.

Inability: Any Intellect defense task is hindered.

Inability: Any task that involves seeing through a deception, an illusion, or a trap is hindered.

Initial Link to the Starting Adventure: From the following list of options, choose how you became involved in the first adventure.

1. Who knows? Seemed like a good idea at the time.

2. Someone asked you to join up with the other PCs. They told you not to ask too many questions, and that seemed fine to you.

3. Your parent (or a parental/mentor figure) got you involved to give you something to do and maybe "teach you some sense."

4. The other PCs needed some muscle who wouldn't overthink things.

5.1.18 Graceful

You have a perfect sense of balance, moving and speaking with grace and beauty. You're quick, lithe, flexible, and dexterous. Your body is perfectly suited to dance, and you use that advantage in combat to dodge blows. You might wear garments that enhance your agile movement and sense of style.

You gain the following characteristics:

Agile: +2 to your Speed Pool.

Skill: You're trained in all tasks involving balance and careful movement.

Skill: You're trained in all tasks involving physical performing arts.

Skill: You're trained in all Speed defense tasks.

Initial Link to the Starting Adventure: From the following list of options, choose how you became involved in the first adventure.

1. Against your better judgment, you joined the other PCs because you saw that they were in danger.
2. One of the other PCs convinced you that joining the group would be in your best interests.
3. You're afraid of what might happen if the other PCs fail.
4. There is reward involved, and you need the money.

5.1.19 Guarded

You conceal your true nature behind a mask and are loath to let anyone see who you really are. Protecting yourself, physically and emotionally, is what you care about most, and you prefer to keep everyone else at a safe distance. You may be suspicious of everyone you meet, expecting the worst from people so you won't be surprised when they prove you right. Or you might just be a bit reserved, careful about letting people through your gruff exterior to the person you really are. No one can be as reserved as you are and make many friends. Most likely, you have an abrasive personality and tend to be pessimistic in your outlook. You probably nurse an old hurt and find that the only way you can cope is to keep it and your personality locked down.

You gain the following characteristics:

Suspicious: +2 to your Intellect Pool.

Skill: You are trained in all Intellect defense tasks.

Skill: You are trained in all tasks involving discerning the truth, piercing disguises, and recognizing falsehoods and other deceptions.

Inability: Your suspicious nature makes you unlikeable. Any task involving deception or persuasion is hindered.

Initial Link to the Starting Adventure: From the following list of options, choose how you became involved in the first adventure.

1. One of the PCs managed to overcome your defenses and befriend you.
2. You want to see what the PCs are up to, so you accompany them to catch them in the act of some wrongdoing.
3. You have made a few enemies and take up with the PCs for protection.
4. The PCs are the only people who will put up with you.

5.1.20 Hardy

Your body was built to take abuse. Whether you're pounding down stiff drinks while holding up a bar in your favorite watering hole or trading blows with a thug in a back alley, you keep going, shrugging off hurts and injuries that might slow or incapacitate a lesser person. Neither hunger nor thirst, cut flesh nor broken bone can stop you. You just press on through the pain and continue.

As fit and healthy as you are, the signs of wear show in the myriad scars crisscrossing your body, your thrice-broken nose, your cauliflower ears, and any number of other disfigurements you wear with pride.

You gain the following characteristics:

Mighty: +4 to your Might Pool.

Fast Healer: You halve the time it takes to make a recovery roll (minimum one action).

Almost Unstoppable: While you are impaired on the damage track, you function as if you were hale. While you are debilitated, you function as if you were impaired. In other words,

you don't suffer the effects of being impaired until you become debilitated, and you never suffer the effects of being debilitated. You still die if all your stat Pools are 0.

Skill: You are trained in Might defense actions.

Inability: Your big, strong body is slow to react. Any task involving initiative is hindered.

Ponderous: When you apply Effort when making a Speed roll, you must spend 1 extra point from your Speed Pool.

Initial Link to the Starting Adventure: From the following list of options, choose how you became involved in the first adventure.

1. The PCs recruited you after learning about your reputation as a survivor.
2. You joined the PCs because you want or need the money.
3. The PCs offered you a challenge equal to your physical power.
4. You believe the only way the PCs will succeed is if you are along to protect them.

5.1.21 Hideous

You are physically repugnant by almost any human standard. You might have had a serious accident, a harmful mutation, or just poor genetic luck, but you are incontrovertibly ugly.

You've more than made up for your appearance in other ways, however. Because you have to hide your appearance, you excel at sneaking about unnoticed or disguising yourself. But perhaps most important, being ostracized while others socialized, you took the time growing up to develop yourself as you saw fit—you grew strong or quick, or you honed your mind.

You gain the following characteristics:

Versatile: You get 4 additional points to divide among your stat Pools.

Skill: You are trained in intimidation and any other fear-based interactions, if you show your true face.

Skill: You are trained in disguise and stealth tasks.

Inability: All tasks relating to pleasant social interaction are hindered.

Initial Link to the Starting Adventure: From the following list of options, choose how you became involved in the first adventure.

1. One of the other PCs approached you while you were in disguise, recruiting you while believing you were someone else.
2. While skulking about, you overheard the other PCs' plans and realized you wanted in.
3. One of the other PCs invited you, but you wonder if it was out of pity.
4. You bullied your way in with intimidation and bluster.

5.1.22 Honorable

You are trustworthy, fair, and forthright. You try to do what is right, to help others, and to treat them well. Lying and cheating are no way to get ahead—these things are for the weak, the lazy, or the despicable. You probably spend a lot of time thinking about your personal honor, how best to maintain it, and how to defend it if challenged. In combat, you are straightforward and offer quarter to any foe.

You were likely instilled with this sense of honor by a parent or a mentor. Sometimes the distinction between what is and isn't honorable varies with different schools of thought, but in broad strokes, honorable people can agree on most aspects of what honor means.

You gain the following characteristics:

Stalwart: +2 to your Might Pool.

Skill: You are trained in pleasant social interactions.

Skill: You are trained in discerning people's true motives or seeing through lies.

Initial Link to the Starting Adventure: From the following list of options, choose how you became involved in the first adventure.

1. The PCs' goals appear to be honorable and commendable.
2. You see that what the other PCs are about to do is dangerous, and you'd like to help protect them.
3. One of the other PCs invited you, hearing of your trustworthiness.
4. You asked politely if you could join the other PCs in their mission.

5.1.23 Impulsive

You have a hard time tamping down your enthusiasm. Why wait when you can just do it (whatever it is) and get it done? You deal with problems when they arise rather than plan ahead. Putting out the small fires now prevents them from becoming one big fire later. You are the first to take risks, to jump in and lend a hand, to step into dark passages, and to find danger.

Your impulsiveness likely gets you into trouble. While others might take time to study the items they discover, you use such items without hesitation. After all, the best way to learn what something can do is to use it. When a cautious explorer might look around and check for danger nearby, you have to physically stop yourself from bulling on ahead. Why fuss around when the exciting thing is just ahead?

(Impulsive characters get into trouble. That's their thing, and that's fine. But if you're constantly dragging your fellow PCs into trouble (or worse, getting them seriously hurt or killed), that will be annoying, to say the least. A good rule of thumb is that impulsiveness doesn't always mean a predilection for doing the wrong thing. Sometimes it's the urge to do the right thing.)

You gain the following characteristics:

Reckless: +2 to your Speed Pool.

Skill: You're trained in initiative actions (to determine who goes first in combat).

Skill: You're trained in Speed defense actions.

Inability: You'll try anything once, but quickly grow bored after that. Any task that involves patience, willpower, or discipline is hindered.

Initial Link to the Starting Adventure: From the following list of options, choose how you became involved in the first adventure.

1. You heard what the other PCs were up to and suddenly decided to join them.
2. You pulled everyone together after you heard rumors about something interesting you want to see or do.
3. You blew all of your money and now find yourself strapped for cash.
4. You're in trouble for acting recklessly. You join the other PCs because they offer a way out of your problem.

5.1.24 Inquisitive

The world is vast and mysterious, with wonders and secrets to keep you amazed for several lifetimes. You feel the tugging

on your heart, the call to explore the wreckage of past civilizations, to discover new peoples, new places, and whatever bizarre wonders you might find along the way. However, as strongly as you feel the pull to roam the world, you know there is danger aplenty, and you take precautions to ensure that you are prepared for any eventuality. Research, preparation, and readiness will help you live long enough to see everything you want to see and do everything you want to do.

You probably have a dozen books and travelogues about the world on you at any time. When not hitting the road and looking around, you spend your time with your nose in a book, learning everything you can about the place you're going so you know what to expect when you get there.

You gain the following characteristics:

Smart: +4 to your Intellect Pool.

Skill: You are eager to learn. You are trained in any task that involves learning something new, whether you're talking to a local to get information or digging through old books to find lore.

Skill: You have made a study of the world. You are trained in any task involving geography or history.

Inability: You tend to fixate on the details, making you somewhat oblivious to what's going on around you. Any task to hear or notice dangers around you is hindered.

Inability: When you see something interesting, you hesitate as you take in all the details. Initiative actions (to determine who goes first in combat) are hindered.

Additional Equipment: You have three books on whatever subjects you choose.

Initial Link to the Starting Adventure: From the following list of options, choose how you became involved in the first adventure.

1. One of the PCs approached you to learn information related to the mission, having heard you were an expert.
2. You have always wanted to see the place where the other PCs are going.
3. You were interested in what the other PCs were up to and decided to go along with them.
4. One of the PCs fascinates you, perhaps due to a special or weird ability they have.

5.1.25 Intelligent

You're quite smart. Your memory is sharp, and you easily grasp concepts that others might struggle with. This aptitude doesn't necessarily mean that you've had years of formal education, but you have learned a great deal in your life, primarily because you pick things up quickly and retain so much.

You gain the following characteristics:

Smart: +2 to your Intellect Pool.

Skill: You're trained in an area of knowledge of your choice.

Skill: You're trained in all actions that involve remembering or memorizing things you experience directly. For example, instead of being good at recalling details of geography that you read about in a book, you can remember a path through a set of tunnels that you've explored before.

Initial Link to the Starting Adventure: From the following list of options, choose how you became involved in the first adventure.

1. One of the other PCs asked your opinion of the mission, knowing that if you thought it was a good idea, it probably was.
2. You saw value in what the other PCs were doing.

3. You believed that the task might lead to important and interesting discoveries.
4. A colleague requested that you take part in the mission as a favor.

5.1.26 Intuitive

You are often tickled by a sense of knowing what someone will say, how they will react, or how events might unfold. Maybe you have a mutant sense, maybe you can see just a few moments ahead through time, or maybe you're just good at reading people and extrapolating a situation. Whatever the case, many who look into your eyes immediately glance away, as if afraid of what you might see in their expression.

You gain the following characteristics:

Innate: +2 to your Intellect Pool.

Skill: You are trained in perception tasks.

Know What to Do: You can act immediately, even if it's not your turn. Afterward, on your next regular turn, any action you take is hindered. You can do this one time, although the ability is renewed each time you make a recovery roll.

Initial Link to the Starting Adventure: From the following list of options, choose how you became involved in the first adventure.

1. You just knew you had to come along.
2. You convinced one of the other PCs that your intuition is invaluable.
3. You felt that something terrible would happen if you didn't go.
4. You're confident the reason you arrived at this point will soon become clear.

5.1.27 Jovial

You're cheerful, friendly, and outgoing. You put others at ease with a big smile and a joke, possibly one at your own expense, though lightly ribbing your companions who can take it is also one of your favorite pastimes. Sometimes people say you never take anything seriously. That's not true, of course, but you have learned that to dwell on the bad too long quickly robs the world of joy. You've always got a new joke in your back pocket because you collect them like some people collect bottles of wine.

You gain the following characteristics:

Witty: +2 to your Intellect Pool.

Skill: You're convivial and set most people at ease with your attitude. You are trained in all tasks related to pleasant social interaction.

Skill: You have an advantage in figuring out the punch lines of jokes you've never heard before. You are trained in all tasks related to solving puzzles and riddles.

Initial Link to the Starting Adventure: From the following list of options, choose how you became involved in the first adventure.

1. You solved a riddle before realizing that answering it would launch you into the adventure.
2. The other PCs thought you'd bring some much-needed levity to the team.
3. You decided that all fun and no work was not the best way to get through life, so you joined up with the PCs.
4. It was either go with the PCs or face up to a circumstance that was anything but jovial.

5.1.28 Kind

It's always been easy for you to see things from the point of view of other people. That ability has made you sympathetic to what they really want or need. From your perspective, you're just applying the old proverb that "it's easier to catch flies with honey than with vinegar," but others simply see your behavior as kindness. Of course, being kind takes time, and yours is limited. You've learned that a small fraction of people don't deserve your time or kindness—true sadists, narcissists, and similar folk will only waste your energy. So you deal with them swiftly, saving your kindness for those who deserve it and can benefit from your attention.

You gain the following characteristics:

Emotionally Intuitive: +2 to your Intellect Pool.

Skill: You know what it's like to go a mile in someone else's shoes. You're trained in all tasks related to pleasant social interaction and discerning the dispositions of others.

Karma: Sometimes, strangers just help you out. To gain the aid of a stranger, you must use a one action, ten-minute, or one-hour recovery roll (without gaining its healing benefit), and the GM determines the nature of the aid you gain. Usually, the act of kindness isn't enough to turn a bad situation completely around, but it may moderate a bad situation and lead to new opportunities. For example, if you are captured, a guard loosens your bonds slightly, brings you water, or delivers a message.

Inability: Being kind comes with a few risks. All tasks related to detecting falsehoods are hindered.

Initial Link to the Starting Adventure: From the following list of options, choose how you became involved in the first adventure.

1. A PC needed your help, and you agreed to come along as a kindness.
2. You gave the wrong person access to your money, and now you need to make some back.
3. You're ready to take your benevolence on the road and help more people than you could if you didn't join the PCs.
4. Your job, which seemed like it would be personally rewarding, is the opposite. You join the PCs to escape the drudgery.

5.1.29 Learned

You have studied, either on your own or with an instructor. You know many things and are an expert on a few topics, such as history, biology, geography, mythology, nature, or any other area of study. Learned characters typically carry a few books around with them and spend their spare time reading.

You gain the following characteristics:

Smart: +2 to your Intellect Pool.

Skill: You're trained in three areas of knowledge of your choice.

Inability: You have few social graces. Any task involving charm, persuasion, or etiquette is hindered.

Additional Equipment: You have two additional books on topics of your choice.

Initial Link to the Starting Adventure: From the following list of options, choose how you became involved in the first adventure.

1. One of the other PCs asked you to come along because of your knowledge.
2. You need money to fund your studies.
3. You believed that the task might lead to important and interesting discoveries.

4. A colleague requested that you take part in the mission as a favor.

5.1.30 Lucky

You rely on chance and timely good luck to get you through many situations. When people say that someone was born under a lucky star, they mean you. When you try your hand at something new, no matter how unfamiliar the task is, as often as not you find a measure of success. Even when disaster strikes, it's rarely as bad as it could be. More often, small things seem to go your way, you win contests, and you're often in the right place at the right time.

You gain the following characteristics:

Luck Pool: You have one additional Pool called Luck that begins with 3 points, and it has a maximum value of 3 points. When spending points from any other Pool, you can take one, some, or all of the points from your Luck Pool first. When you make a recovery roll to recover points to any other Pool, your Luck Pool is also refreshed by the same number of points. When your Luck Pool is at 0 points, it does not count against your damage track. **Enabler.**

Advantage: When you use 1 XP to reroll a d20 for any roll that affects only you, add 3 to the reroll.

Initial Link to the Starting Adventure: From the following list of options, choose how you became involved in the first adventure.

1. Knowing that lucky people notice and take active advantage of opportunities, you became involved in your first adventure by choice.
2. You literally bumped into someone else on this adventure through sheer luck.
3. You found a briefcase lying alongside the road. It was battered, but inside you found a lot of strange documents that led you here.
4. Your luck saved you when you avoided a speeding vehicle by a fortuitous fall through an opening in the ground (a manhole, if in a modern setting). Beneath the ground, you found something you couldn't ignore.

5.1.31 Mad

You have delved too deeply into subjects people were not meant to know. You are knowledgeable in things beyond the scope of most, but this knowledge has come at a terrible price. You are likely in questionable physical shape and occasionally shake with nervous tics. You sometimes mutter to yourself without realizing it.

You gain the following characteristics:

Knowledgeable: +4 to your Intellect Pool.

Fits of Insight: Whenever such knowledge is appropriate, the GM feeds you information although there is no clear explanation as to how you could know such a thing. This is up to the GM's discretion, but it should happen as often as once each session.

Erratic Behavior: You are prone to acting erratically or irrationally. When you are in the presence of a major discovery or subjected to great stress (such as a serious physical threat), the GM can introduce a GM intrusion that directs your next action without awarding XP. You can still pay 1 XP to refuse the intrusion. The GM's influence is the manifestation of your madness and thus is always something you would not likely do otherwise, but it is not directly, obviously harmful to you unless

there are extenuating circumstances. (For example, if a foe suddenly leaps out of the darkness, you might spend the first round babbling incoherently or screaming the name of your first true love.)

Skill: You are trained in one area of knowledge (probably something weird or esoteric).

Inability: Your mind is quite fragile. Tasks to resist mental attacks are hindered.

Initial Link to the Starting Adventure: From the following list of options, choose how you became involved in the first adventure.

1. Voices in your head told you to go.
2. You instigated the whole thing and convinced the others to join you.
3. One of the other PCs obtained a book of knowledge for you, and now you're repaying that favor by helping them with the task at hand.
4. You feel compelled by inexplicable intuition.

5.1.32 Mechanical

You have a special talent with machines of all kinds, and you're adept at understanding and, if need be, repairing them. Perhaps you're a bit of an inventor, creating new machines from time to time. You get called "techie," "tech," "mech," "gear-head," "motor-head," or any of a number of other nicknames. Mechanics usually wear practical work clothes and carry around a lot of tools.

You gain the following characteristics:

Smart: +2 to your Intellect Pool.

Skill: You're trained in all actions involving identifying or understanding machines.

Skill: You're trained in all actions involving using, repairing, or crafting machines.

Additional Equipment: You start with a variety of machine tools.

Initial Link to the Starting Adventure: From the following list of options, choose how you became involved in the first adventure.

1. While repairing a nearby machine, you overheard the other PCs talking.
2. You need money to buy tools and parts.
3. It was clear that the mission couldn't succeed without your skills and knowledge.
4. Another PC asked you to join them.

5.1.33 Mysterious

The dark figure lurking silently in the corner? That's you. No one really knows where you came from or what your motives are—you play things close to the vest. Your manner perplexes and confounds others, but that doesn't make you a poor friend or ally. You're just good at keeping things to yourself, moving about unseen, and concealing your presence and identity.

You gain the following characteristics:

Skill: You are trained in all stealth tasks.

Skill: You are trained in resisting interrogation or tricks to get you to talk.

Confounding: You pull talents and abilities seemingly out of nowhere. You can attempt one task in which you have no training as if you were trained, attempt a task that you are trained in as if specialized, or gain a free level of Effort with

a task that you are specialized in. This ability refreshes every time you make a recovery roll, but the uses never accumulate.

Inability: People never know where they stand with you. Any task involving getting people to believe or trust you is hindered.

Initial Link to the Starting Adventure: From the following list of options, choose how you became involved in the first adventure.

1. You just showed up one day.
2. You convinced one of the other PCs that you had invaluable skills.
3. Some equally mysterious figure told you where to be and when (but not why) to join the group.
4. Something—a feeling, a dream—told you where to be and when to join the group.

5.1.34 Mystical

You think of yourself as mystical, attuned with the mysterious and the paranormal. Your true talents lie with the supernatural. You likely have experience with ancient lore, and you can sense and wield the supernatural—though whether that means “magic,” “psychic phenomena,” or something else is up to you (and probably up to those around you as well). Mystical characters often wear jewelry, such as a ring or an amulet, or have tattoos or other marks that show their interests.

You gain the following characteristics:

Smart: +2 to your Intellect Pool.

Skill: You're trained in all actions involving identifying or understanding the supernatural. **Sense Magic:** You can sense whether the supernatural is active in situations where its presence is not obvious. You must study an object or location closely for a minute to get a feel for whether a mystical touch is at work.

Spell: You can perform Hedge Magic as a spell when you have a free hand and can pay the Intellect point cost.

Inability: You have a manner or an aura that others find a bit unnerving. Any task involving charm, persuasion, or deception is hindered.

Initial Link to the Starting Adventure: From the following list of options, choose how you became involved in the first adventure.

1. A dream guided you to this point.
2. You need money to fund your studies.
3. You believed the mission would be a great way to learn more about the supernatural.
4. Various signs and portents led you here.

5.1.35 Naive

You've lived a sheltered life. Your childhood was safe and secure, so you didn't get a chance to learn much about the world—and even less chance to experience it. Whether you were training for something, had your nose in a book, or just were sequestered in a secluded place, you haven't done much, met many people, or seen many interesting things so far. That's probably going to change soon, but as you go forward into a larger world, you do so without some of the understanding that others possess about how it all works.

You gain the following characteristics:

Fresh: You add +1 to your recovery rolls.

Incorruptible: You are trained in Intellect defense tasks and all tasks that involve resisting temptation.

Skill: You're wide-eyed. You are trained in perception tasks.

Inability: Any task that involves seeing through deceptions or determining someone's secret motive is hindered.

Initial Link to the Starting Adventure: From the following list of options, choose how you became involved in the first adventure.

1. Someone told you that you should get involved.
2. You needed money, and this seemed like a good way to earn some.
3. You believed that you could learn a lot by joining the other PCs.
4. Sounded like fun.

5.1.36 Perceptive

You miss little. You pick out the small details in the world around you and are skilled at making deductions from the information you find. Your talents make you an exceptional sleuth, a formidable scientist, or a talented scout.

As adept as you are at finding clues, you have no skill at picking up on social cues. You overlook an offense that your deductions give or how uncomfortable your scrutiny can make the people around you. You tend to dismiss others as being intellectual dwarfs compared to you, which avails you little when you need a favor.

You gain the following characteristics:

Smart: +2 to your Intellect Pool.

Skill: You have an eye for detail. You are trained in any task that involves finding or noticing small details.

Skill: You know a little about everything. You are trained in any task that involves identifying objects or calling to mind a minor detail or bit of trivia.

Skill: Your skill at making deductions can be imposing. You are trained in any task that involves intimidating another creature.

Inability: Your confidence comes off as arrogance to people who don't know you. Any task involving positive social interactions is hindered.

Additional Equipment: You have a bag of light tools.

Initial Link to the Starting Adventure: From the following list of options, choose how you became involved in the first adventure.

1. You overheard the other PCs discussing their mission and volunteered your services.
2. One of the PCs asked you to come along, believing that your talents would be invaluable to the mission.
3. You believe that the PCs' mission is somehow related to one of your investigations.
4. A third party recruited you to follow the PCs and see what they were up to.

5.1.37 Resilient

You can take a lot of punishment, both physically and mentally, and still come back for more. It takes a lot to put you down. Neither physical nor mental shocks or damage have a lasting effect. You're tough to faze. Unflappable. Unstoppable.

You gain the following characteristics:

Resistant: +2 to your Might Pool, and +2 to your Intellect Pool.

Recover: You can make an extra recovery roll each day. This roll is just one action. So you can make two recovery

rolls that each take one action, one roll that takes ten minutes, a fourth roll that takes one hour, and a fifth roll that requires ten hours of rest.

Skill: You are trained in Might defense tasks.

Skill: You are trained in Intellect defense tasks.

Inability: You're hardy but not necessarily strong. Any task involving moving, bending, or breaking things is hindered.

Inability: You have a lot of willpower and mental fortitude, but you're not necessarily smart. Any task involving knowledge or figuring out problems or puzzles is hindered.

Initial Link to the Starting Adventure: From the following list of options, choose how you became involved in the first adventure.

1. You saw that the PCs clearly need someone like you to help them out.
2. Someone asked you to watch over one of the PCs in particular, and you agreed.
3. You are bored and desperately in need of a challenge.
4. You lost a bet—unfairly, you think—and had to take someone's place on this mission.

5.1.38 Risk-taking

It's part of your nature to question what others think can't or shouldn't be done. You're not insane, of course—you wouldn't attempt to leap across a mile-wide chasm just because you were dared. There's impossible and then there's the just barely possible. You like to push the latter further than others, because it gives you a rush of satisfaction and pleasure when you succeed. The more you succeed, the more you find yourself looking for that next risky challenge to try yourself against.

You gain the following characteristics:

Nimble: +4 to your Speed Pool.

Skill: You're adept at leveraging risk, and you are trained in tasks that involve some element of chance, such as playing games or choosing between two or three apparently equal options.

Pressing Your Luck: You can choose to automatically succeed on one task without rolling, as long as the task's difficulty is no higher than 6. When you do so, however, you also trigger a GM intrusion as if you had rolled a 1. The intrusion doesn't invalidate the success, but it probably qualifies it in some fashion. You can do this one time, although the ability renews each time you make a ten-hour recovery roll.

Inability: You may be nimble, but you're not sneaky. Tasks related to sneaking and staying quiet are hindered.

Initial Link to the Starting Adventure: From the following list of options, choose how you became involved in the first adventure.

1. It seemed like there were equal odds that the other PCs wouldn't succeed, which sounded good to you.
2. You think the tasks ahead will present you with unique and fulfilling challenges.
3. One of your biggest risks failed to go your way, and you need money to help pay that debt.
4. You bragged that you never saw a risk you didn't like, which is how you reached your current point.

5.1.39 Rugged

You're a nature lover accustomed to living rough, pitting your wits against the elements. Most likely, you're a skilled hunter, gatherer, or naturalist. Years of living in the wild have left their

mark with a worn countenance, wild hair, or scars. Your clothing is probably much less refined than the garments worn by city dwellers.

You gain the following characteristics:

Skill: You're trained in all tasks involving climbing, jumping, running, and swimming.

Skill: You're trained in all tasks involving training, riding, or placating natural animals.

Skill: You're trained in all tasks involving identifying or using natural plants.

Inability: You have no social graces and prefer animals to people. Any task involving charm, persuasion, etiquette, or deception is hindered.

Additional Equipment: You carry an explorer's pack with rope, two days' rations, a bedroll, and other tools needed for outdoor survival.

Initial Link to the Starting Adventure: From the following list of options, choose how you became involved in the first adventure.

1. Against your better judgment, you joined the other PCs because you saw that they were in danger.
2. One of the other PCs convinced you that joining the group would be in your best interests.
3. You're afraid of what might happen if the other PCs fail.
4. There is reward involved, and you need the money.

5.1.40 Sharp-eyed

You're perceptive and well aware of your surroundings. You notice the little details and remember them. You can be difficult to surprise.

You gain the following characteristics:

Skill: You're trained in initiative actions.

Skill: You're trained in perception actions.

Find the Flaw: If an opponent has a straightforward weakness (takes extra damage from fire, can't see out of their left eye, and so on), the GM will tell you what it is.

Initial Link to the Starting Adventure: From the following list of options, choose how you became involved in the first adventure.

1. You heard about what was going on, saw a flaw in the other PCs' plan, and joined up to help them out.
2. You noticed that the PCs have a foe (or at least a tail) they weren't aware of.
3. You saw that the other PCs were up to something interesting and got involved.
4. You've been noticing some strange things going on, and this all appears related.

5.1.41 Skeptical

You possess a questioning attitude regarding claims that are often taken for granted by others. You're not necessarily a "doubting Thomas" (a skeptic who refuses to believe anything without direct personal experience), but you've often benefited from questioning the statements, opinions, and received knowledge presented to you by others.

You gain the following characteristics:

Insightful: +2 to your Intellect Pool.

Skill: You're trained in identifying.

Skill: You're trained in all actions that involve seeing through a trick, an illusion, a rhetorical ruse designed to evade the issue, or a lie. For example, you're better at keeping your

eye on the cup containing the hidden ball, sensing an illusion, or realizing if someone is lying to you (but only if you specifically concentrate and use this skill).

Initial Link to the Starting Adventure: From the following list of options, choose how you became involved in the first adventure.

1. You overheard other PCs holding forth on a topic with an opinion you were quite skeptical about, so you decided to approach the group and ask for proof.
2. You were following one of the other PCs because you were suspicious of him, which brought you into the action.
3. Your theory about the nonexistence of the supernatural can be invalidated only by your own senses, so you came along.
4. You need money to fund your research.

5.1.42 Stealthy

You're sneaky, slippery, and fast. These talents help you hide, move quietly, and pull off tricks that require sleight of hand. Most likely, you're wiry and small. However, you're not much of a sprinter—you're more dexterous than fleet of foot.

You gain the following characteristics:

Quick: +2 to your Speed Pool.

Skill: You're trained in all stealth tasks.

Skill: You're trained in all interactions involving lies or trickery.

Skill: You're trained in all special abilities involving illusions or trickery.

Inability: You're sneaky but not fast. All movement-related tasks are hindered.

Initial Link to the Starting Adventure: From the following list of options, choose how you became involved in the first adventure.

1. You attempted to steal from one of the other PCs. That character caught you and forced you to come along with them.
2. You were tailing one of the other PCs for reasons of your own, which brought you into the action.
3. An NPC employer secretly paid you to get involved.
4. You overheard the other PCs talking about a topic that interested you, so you decided to approach the group.

5.1.43 Strong

You're extremely strong and physically powerful, and you use these qualities well, whether through violence or feats of prowess. You likely have a brawny build and impressive muscles.

You gain the following characteristics:

Very Powerful: +4 to your Might Pool.

Skill: You're trained in all actions involving breaking inanimate objects.

Skill: You're trained in all jumping actions.

Additional Equipment: You have an extra medium weapon or heavy weapon.

Initial Link to the Starting Adventure: From the following list of options, choose how you became involved in the first adventure.

1. Against your better judgment, you joined the other PCs because you saw that they were in danger.
2. One of the other PCs convinced you that joining the group would be in your best interests.
3. You're afraid of what might happen if the other PCs fail.
4. There is reward involved, and you need the money.

5.1.44 Strong-willed

You're tough-minded, willful, and independent. No one can talk you into anything or change your mind when you don't want it changed. This quality doesn't necessarily make you smart, but it does make you a bastion of willpower and resolve. You likely dress and act with unique style and flair, not caring what others think.

You gain the following characteristics:

Willful: +4 to your Intellect Pool.

Skill: You're trained in resisting mental effects.

Skill: You're trained in tasks requiring incredible focus or concentration.

Inability: Willful doesn't mean brilliant. Any task that involves figuring out puzzles or problems, memorizing things, or using lore is hindered.

Initial Link to the Starting Adventure: From the following list of options, choose how you became involved in the first adventure.

1. Against your better judgment, you joined the other PCs because you saw that they were in danger.
2. One of the other PCs convinced you that joining the group would be in your best interests.
3. You're afraid of what might happen if the other PCs fail.
4. There is reward involved, and you need the money.

5.1.45 Swift

You move quickly, able to sprint in short bursts and work with your hands with dexterity. You're great at crossing distances quickly but not always smoothly. You are likely slim and muscular.

You gain the following characteristics:

Fast: +4 to your Speed Pool.

Skill: You're trained in initiative actions (to determine who goes first in combat).

Skill: You're trained in running actions.

Inability: You're fast but not necessarily graceful. Any task involving balance is hindered.

Initial Link to the Starting Adventure: From the following list of options, choose how you became involved in the first adventure.

1. Against your better judgment, you joined the other PCs because you saw that they were in danger.
2. One of the other PCs convinced you that joining the group would be in your best interests.
3. You're afraid of what might happen if the other PCs fail.
4. There is reward involved, and you need the money.

5.1.46 Tongue-tied

You've never been much of a talker. When forced to interact with others, you never think of the right thing to say—words fail you entirely, or they come out all wrong. You often end up saying precisely the wrong thing and insult someone unintentionally. Most of the time, you just keep mum. This makes you a listener instead—a careful observer. It also means that you're better at doing things than talking about them. You're quick to take action.

You gain the following characteristics:

Actions, Not Words: +2 to your Might Pool, and +2 to your Speed Pool.

Skill: You are trained in perception.

Skill: You are trained in initiative (unless it's a social situation).

Inability: All tasks relating to social interaction are hindered.

Inability: All tasks involving verbal communication or relaying information are hindered.

Initial Link to the Starting Adventure: From the following list of options, choose how you became involved in the first adventure.

1. You just tagged along and no one told you to leave.
2. You saw something important the other PCs did not and (with some effort) managed to relate it to them.
3. You intervened to save one of the other PCs when they were in danger.
4. One of the other PCs recruited you for your talents.

5.1.47 Tough

You're strong and can take a lot of physical punishment. You might have a large frame and a square jaw. Tough characters frequently have visible scars.

You gain the following characteristics:

Resilient: +1 to Armor.

Healthy: Add 1 to the points you regain when you make a recovery roll.

Skill: You're trained in Might defense actions.

Additional Equipment: You have an extra light weapon.

Initial Link to the Starting Adventure: From the following list of options, choose how you became involved in the first adventure.

1. You're acting as a bodyguard for one of the other PCs.
2. One of the PCs is your sibling, and you came along to watch out for them.
3. You need money because your family is in debt.
4. You stepped in to defend one of the PCs when that character was threatened. While talking to them afterward, you heard about the group's task.

5.1.48 Vicious

You try to hide what's inside, fold it into yourself when everything inside you screams to let go, make them pay, make them hurt, and make them bleed. Sometimes you succeed for your friends—smiling like they smile, laughing when they laugh, and sometimes even having other emotions of your own. But it's always there, that feeling of frantic glee mixed with hate that sometimes leaps out of you when you confront a foe. Violence your friends can tolerate, but you sometimes worry they will also learn that you are cruel.

You gain the following characteristics:

Skill: You are trained in tracking creatures. If a creature has wronged you, the tracking task is eased.

Bloodthirsty: Once you begin fighting, you see only red. You inflict 2 additional points of damage with any attack.

Berserk: Once you begin fighting, it's hard for you to stop. In fact, it's a difficulty 2 Intellect task to do so, even if your foe surrenders or you've run out of foes. If the latter occurs and you fail to stop, you attack the nearest ally within short range.

Additional Equipment: You have a record that you use to list those who've wronged you.

Initial Link to the Starting Adventure: From the following list of options, choose how you became involved in the first adventure.

1. Another PC saw you take down a mean drunk in a tavern, not realizing you were the one who started the fight.

2. You wanted to get away from a bad situation, so you went with the other PCs.

3. You want to change, and you hope that being with the other PCs will help you calm yourself.

4. One of the other PCs asked you to come along, believing that your viciousness could be harnessed for the benefit of the mission.

5.1.49 Virtuous

Doing the right thing is a way of life. You live by a code, and that code is something you attend to every day. Whenever you slip, you reproach yourself for your weakness and then get right back on track. Your code probably includes moderation, respect for others, cleanliness, and other characteristics that most people would agree are virtues, while you eschew their opposites: sloth, greed, gluttony, and so on.

You gain the following characteristics:

Dauntless: +2 to your Might Pool.

Skill: You are trained in discerning people's true motives or seeing through lies.

Skill: Your adherence to a strict moral code has hardened your mind against fear, doubt, and outside influence. You are trained in Intellect defense tasks.

Initial Link to the Starting Adventure: From the following list of options, choose how you became involved in the first adventure.

1. The PCs are doing something virtuous, and you're all about that.
2. The PCs are on the road to perdition, and you see it as your task to set them on the proper moral route.
3. One of the other PCs invited you, hearing of your virtuous ways.
4. You put virtue before sense and defended someone's honor in the face of an organization or power far greater than you. You joined the PCs because they offered aid and friendship when, out of fear of reprisals, no one else would.

5.1.50 Weird

You aren't like anyone else, and that's fine with you. People don't seem to understand you—they even seem put off by you—but who cares? You understand the world better than they do because you're weird, and so is the world you live in. The concept of "the weird" is well known to you. Strange devices, ancient locales, bizarre creatures, storms that can transform you, living energy fields, conspiracies, aliens, and things most people can't even name populate the world, and you thrive on them. You have a special attachment to it all, and the more you discover about the weirdness in the world, the more you might discover about yourself. Weird characters might be mutants or people born with strange qualities, but sometimes they started out "normal" and adopted the weird by choice.

You gain the following characteristics:

Inner Light: +2 to your Intellect Pool.

Distinctive Physical Quirk: You have a unique physical aspect that is, well, bizarre. Depending on the setting, this can vary greatly. You might have purple hair or metal spikes on your head. Perhaps your hands don't connect to your arms, although they move as if they do. Maybe a third eye stares out from the side of your head, or superfluous tendrils grow from

your back. Whatever it is, your quirk might be a mutation, a supernatural trait (a blessing or curse), a feature with no explanation, or just a really wild tattoo that draws a lot of attention.

A Sense for the Weird: Sometimes—at the GM’s discretion—weird things relating to the supernatural or its effects on the world seem to call out to you. You can sense them from afar, and if you get within long range of such a thing, you can sense whether it is overtly dangerous or not.

Skill: You are trained in supernatural knowledge.

Inability: People find you unnerving. All tasks relating to pleasant social interaction are hindered.

Initial Link to the Starting Adventure: From the following list of options, choose how you became involved in the first adventure.

1. It seemed weird, so why not?
2. Whether the other PCs realize it or not, their mission has to do with something weird that you know about, so you got involved.
3. As an expert in the weird, you were specifically recruited by the other PCs.
4. You felt drawn to join the other PCs, but you don’t know why.

5.2 Customizing Descriptors

Under the normal rules, each descriptor is based on some modification of the following guidelines:

Some descriptors offer +4 to one stat Pool and either two narrow skills or one broad skill.

Other descriptors offer +2 to one stat Pool and either three narrow skills or one narrow skill and one broad skill.

A broad skill covers many areas (such as all interactions). A narrow skill covers fewer areas (such as deceptive interactions). Combat-related skills, such as defense or initiative, are considered broad skills in this sense.

Regardless, you can add an additional skill if it is balanced by an inability.

You can add other non-skill abilities by eyeballing them and trying to equate them to the value of a skill, if possible. If the descriptor seems lacking, add a moderately priced item as additional equipment to balance things out.

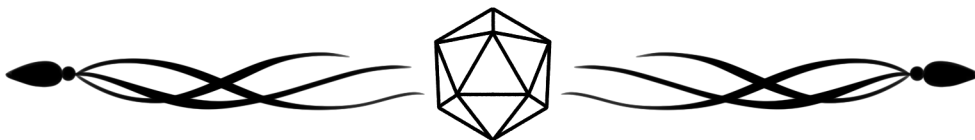
With this general information, you can customize a descriptor, but keep in mind that a heavily customized descriptor isn’t a descriptor if it no longer says one thing about a character. It’s better to use this information to create a new descriptor that fits exactly how the player wants to portray the character.

5.3 Species as descriptor

Sometimes, in settings that have alien or fantasy species, players want to play a member of that species rather than the default (which is usually “human”). Most of the time, this choice is one of flavor rather than game mechanics. If you’re a 7-foot-tall furry Rigellian with three eyes, that’s great, but it doesn’t change your stats or skills (though it may have roleplaying challenges).

However, sometimes being a nonhuman results in more substantive changes. A PC ogre in a fantasy setting might have the Strong or Tough descriptor, or perhaps it has a descriptor simply called Ogre, which is similar to Strong or Tough but more pronounced (with greater Might but even greater drawbacks). This would mean that instead of being a Tough Warrior who Controls Beasts, the character is an Ogre Warrior who Controls Beasts.

The Genre chapter offers a few species descriptors, but many GMs will want to create their own as suits their setting. It can’t be stressed enough, however, that nine times out of ten, in most genres, species differences aren’t significant enough to warrant this treatment. The differences between a Mysterious character and a Virtuous one are probably greater than those between an Alpha Centauran and an Earthling.



Chapter 6

Focus

Focus is what makes a character unique. No two PCs in a group should have the same focus. A focus gives a character benefits when they create their character and each time they ascend to the next tier. It's the verb of the sentence "I am an adjective noun who verbs."

This chapter contains nearly a hundred sample foci, such as Bears a Halo of Fire, Would Rather Be Reading, and Pilots Starcraft. These foci can be chosen and used as presented by a player, or by the GM who adds them to a list of available foci for their players in their next campaign.

In addition, the latter half of this chapter provides tools for the GM or an enterprising player to create their own custom foci that perfectly match the needs of a given game or campaign, as presented in Creating New Foci.

6.1 Choosing Foci

Not all foci are appropriate for every genre. The Genre chapter provides guidance, but this section offers some broad generalizations. Obviously, the GM can include whatever foci are available in their setting. Foci end up being an important distinction in this case, because Commands Mental Powers, for example, makes it clear that psychic abilities exist in the setting, just as Howls at the Moon implies the existence of lycanthropes like werewolves, and Pilots Starcraft, of course, requires starships available to pilot.

When a focus is chosen for a character, they get a special connection to one or more of their fellow PCs, a first-tier ability, and perhaps additional starting equipment: one or two pieces of equipment that might be required for the character to use their ability, or that might pair well with the focus. For instance, a character that can build things needs a set of tools. A character that's constantly on fire needs a set of clothes that are immune to flame. A character that draws runes to cast spells needs writing implements. A character that slays monsters with a sword needs a sword. And so on. That said, many foci don't require additional equipment.

Each focus also offers one or more suggestions—GM intrusions—for possible effects or consequences of really good or really bad die rolls. A couple of foci presented in this chapter provide a "type swap option" that allows a player to swap an ability that would otherwise be gained from their type for the indicated ability instead. A player doesn't have to make the swap; they merely have the option. For instance, the focus Loves the Void provides the option to gain the ability Have Spacesuit, Will Travel instead of a type ability.

As a character progresses to a new tier, a focus grants more abilities. Each tier's benefit is usually labeled Action or Enabler.

If an ability is labeled Action, a character must take an action to use it. If an ability is labeled Enabler, it makes other actions better or gives some other benefit, but it's not an action. An ability that allows a character to blast foes with lasers is an action. An ability that grants additional damage when an attack is made is an enabler. An enabler is used in the same turn as another action, and often as part of another action.

Each tier's benefits are independent of and cumulative with benefits from other tiers (unless indicated otherwise). So if a first-tier ability grants +1 to Armor and a fourth-tier ability also grants +1 to Armor, when the character reaches fourth tier, a total of +2 to Armor is granted. At tier 3 and tier 6, the character is asked to choose one ability from the two options provided.

Finally, you can choose whether you want to expand the story behind the focus (though that's not mandatory).

6.2 Focus Connections

Choose a connection that goes well with the focus. If you're a GM choosing (or creating) one or more foci for your players, choose up to four of the following connections.

1. Pick one other PC. For reasons unknown to you, that character is completely immune to your focus abilities, whether you use them for help or for harm.
2. Pick one other PC. You knew of that character years ago, but you don't think they knew you.
3. Pick one other PC. You're always trying to impress them, but you're not sure why.
4. Pick one other PC. That character has a habit that annoys you, but you're otherwise quite impressed with their abilities.
5. Pick one other PC. That character shows potential in appreciating your particular paradigm, fighting style, or other focus-provided attribute. You would like to train them, but you're not necessarily qualified to teach (that's up to you), and they might not be interested (that's up to them).
6. Pick one other PC. If they are within immediate range when you're in a fight, sometimes they provide an asset, and sometimes they accidentally hinder your attack rolls (50% chance either way, determined per fight).
7. Pick one other PC. You once saved their life, and they clearly feel indebted to you. You wish they didn't; it's just part of the job.
8. Pick one other PC. That character recently mocked you in some fashion that really hurt your feelings. How you deal with this (if at all) is up to you.
9. Pick one other PC. That character knows you have suffered at the hands of robotic entities in the past. Whether you hate robots now is up to you, which may affect your relationship with the character if they are friendly with robots or have robotic parts.
10. Pick one other PC. That character comes from the same place you do, and you knew each other as children.
11. Pick one other PC. In the past, they taught you a few tricks to use in a fight.

12. Pick one other PC. That character doesn't seem to approve of your methods.
13. Pick one other PC. Long ago, the two of you were on opposite sides of a fight. You won, though you "cheated" in their eyes (but from your perspective, all's fair in a fight). They may be ready for a rematch, though that's up to them.
14. Pick one other PC. You are always trying to impress that character with your skill, wit, appearance, or bravado. Perhaps they are a rival, perhaps you need their respect, or perhaps you're romantically interested in them.
15. Pick one other PC. You fear that character is jealous of your abilities and worry that it might lead to problems.
16. Pick one other PC. You accidentally caught them in a trap you set, and they had to get free on their own.
17. Pick one other PC. You were once hired to track down someone who was close to that character.
18. Pick two PCs (preferably ones who are likely to get in the way of your attacks). When you miss with an attack and the GM rules that you struck someone other than your target, you hit one of these two characters.
19. Pick one other PC. You're not sure how or from where, but that character has a line on bottles of rare alcohol and can get them for you for half price.
20. Pick one other PC. You recently had a possession go missing, and you're becoming convinced that they took it. Whether or not they did is up to them.
21. Pick one other PC. They always seem to know where you are, or at least in what direction you are in relation to them.
22. Pick one other PC. Seeing you use your focus abilities seems to trigger an unpleasant memory in that character. That memory is up to the other PC, although they may not be able to consciously recall it.
23. Pick one other PC. Something about them interferes with your abilities. When they stand next to you, your focus abilities cost 1 additional point.
24. Pick one other PC. Something about them complements your abilities. When they stand next to you, the first focus ability you use in any 24-hour period costs 2 fewer points.
25. Pick one other PC. You have known that character for a while, and they helped you gain control of your focus-related abilities.
26. Pick one other PC. Sometime in that character's past, they had a devastating experience while attempting something that you do as a matter of course thanks to your focus. Whether they choose to tell you about it is up to them.
27. Pick one other PC. Their occasional clumsiness and loud behavior irritate you.
28. Pick one other PC. In the recent past, while practicing, you accidentally hit them with an attack, wounding them badly. It is up to them to decide whether they resent or forgive you.
29. Pick one other PC. They owe you a significant amount of money.
30. Pick one other PC. In the recent past, while escaping a threat, you accidentally left that character to fend for themselves. They survived, but just barely. It is up to the player of that character to decide whether they resent you or have decided to forgive you.
31. Pick one other PC. Recently, they accidentally (or perhaps intentionally) put you in a position of danger. You're fine now, but you're wary around them.
32. Pick one other PC. From your perspective, they seem nervous around a specific idea, person, or situation. You would like to teach them how to be more comfortable with their fears (if they will let you).
33. Pick one other PC. They called you a coward once.
34. Pick one other PC. That character always recognizes you or your handiwork, whether you're in disguise or are long gone when they arrive on the scene.
35. Pick one other PC. You inadvertently caused an accident that put them into a sleep so deep they didn't wake for three days. Whether they forgive you or not is up to them.
36. Pick one other PC. You are pretty sure you are related in some fashion.
37. m Pick one other PC. You accidentally learned something they were trying to keep a secret.
38. Pick one other PC. They are especially sensitive to the use of your flashier focus abilities, and occasionally they become dazzled for a few rounds, which hinders their actions.
39. Pick one other PC. They appear to have a treasured item that was once yours, but that you lost in a game of chance years ago.
40. Pick one other PC. If it wasn't for you, that character would have failed a past test of mental achievement.
41. Pick one other PC. Based on a couple of comments you've overheard, you suspect that they don't hold your area of training or favorite hobby in the highest regard.
42. Pick one other PC whose focus intertwines with yours. This odd connection affects them in some way. For example, if the character uses a weapon, your focus ability sometimes improves their attack in some fashion.
43. Pick one other PC. They are deathly afraid of heights. You would like to teach them how to be more comfortable with their feet off the ground. They must decide whether or not to take you up on your offer.
44. Pick one other PC. They are skeptical of your claims about something momentous that happened in your past. They might even attempt to discredit you or discover the "secret" behind your story, though that's up to them.

45. Pick one other PC. They have a knack for being able to recognize where your plans or schemes have a weak spot.
46. Pick one other PC. That character's face is so intriguing to you in a way you don't understand that you sometimes find yourself sketching their likeness in the dirt or using some other medium you have access to.
47. Pick one other PC. That character has an extra item of regular equipment you gave them, either something you made or an item you just wanted to give them. (They choose the item.)
48. Pick one other PC. They commissioned you to do a job for them. You've already been paid but haven't yet completed the job.
49. Pick one other PC. You worked together in the past, and the job ended badly.
50. Pick one other PC. While they stand next to you and use their action to concentrate on helping you, one of your focus ability's ranges is doubled.

6.3 Story Behind the Focus

The foci in this book have been purposely stripped down to basics so they have the widest possible application across multiple genres. A single descriptive sentence or two summarizes each one. After you choose a focus, you have the option to expand its presentation by adding more story and description relevant to the world or to the character.

For instance, if you choose Operates Undercover, the summarizing description is "Under the guise of someone else, you seek to find answers the powerful do not want divulged." If you choose Conducts Weird Science, the summary is "Your preternatural insight and ability make you a scientist capable of amazing feats." These descriptions provide what you need to know to use the focus.

However, if you wish (and only if you wish; there is no requirement to do so), you can add more to those descriptions in a fashion that's relevant for your game. For example, if you choose both Operates Undercover and Conducts Weird Science for use in a modern genre such as horror, urban fantasy, espionage, or something similar, you might expand the descriptions as shown in the following examples.

Operates Undercover: Espionage is not something you know anything about. At least, that's what you want everyone to believe, because in truth, you've been trained as a spy or covert agent. You might work for a government or for yourself. You might be a police detective or a criminal. You could even be an investigative reporter.

Regardless, you learn information that others attempt to keep secret. You collect rumors and whispers, stories and hard-won evidence, and you use that knowledge to aid your own endeavors and, if appropriate, provide your employers with the information they desire. Alternatively, you might sell what you have learned to those willing to pay a premium.

You probably wear dark colors—black, charcoal grey, or midnight blue—to help blend into the shadows, unless the cover you've chosen requires you to look like someone else.

Conducts Weird Science: You could be a respected scientist, having been published in several peer-reviewed journals. Or you might be considered a crank by your contemporaries,

pursuing fringe theories on what others consider to be scant evidence. Truth is, you have a particular gift for sifting the edges of what's possible. You can find new insights and unlock odd phenomena with your experiments. Where others see a crackpot cornucopia, you sift the conspiracy theories for revelation. Whether you conduct your enquiries as a government contractor, a university researcher, a corporate scientist, or an indulger of curiosity in your own garage lab following your muse, you push the boundaries of what's possible.

You probably care more about your work than trivialities such as your appearance, polite or proper behavior, or social norms, but then again, an eccentric like you might turn the tables on that stereotype too.

If you want to go even further, you could determine where a character's focus abilities come from. Depending on the genre, they could derive those abilities from advanced and persistent training, via magical runes, through cybernetic parts, from their genetic heritage, or because of their access to advanced technology. For instance, a character might be able to blast targets with lightning because they got zapped by strange radiation or because they picked up a lightning gun. On the other hand, it might be because their intense training allowed them to learn lightning magic. The possibilities are nearly endless, and up to you to include or forgo. Because however a focus's abilities were gained, it's also enough that they just work.

6.4 Foci

The full description for each focus ability listed in this section is found in the Abilities chapter, which has descriptions for type, flavor, and focus abilities in a single vast catalog.

6.4.1 Abides in Stone

Your flesh is made of hard mineral, making you a hulking, difficult-to-harm humanoid.

Tier 1: Golem Body

Tier 1: Golem Healing

Tier 2: Golem Grip

Tier 3: Trained Basher

Tier 3: Golem Stomp or Weaponization

Tier 4: Deep Reserves

Tier 5: Specialized Basher

Tier 5: Still As a Statue

Tier 6: Ultra Enhancement or Mind Surge

GM Intrusions: Creatures of stone sometimes forget their own strength or weight. A walking statue can terrify common folk.

6.4.2 Absorbs Energy

You can harness kinetic energy and transform it into other kinds of energy.

Tier 1: Absorb Kinetic Energy

Tier 1: Release Energy

Tier 2: Energize Object

Tier 3: Absorb Pure Energy or Improved Absorb Kinetic Energy

Tier 4: Overcharge Energy

Tier 5: Energize Creature

Tier 6: Energize Crowd or Overcharge Device

GM Intrusions: Energy goes to ground in a destructive way. Some predators feed directly on energy. An unintended item is drained of energy.

6.4.3 Awakens Dreams

You can pull images from dreams and bring them to life in the waking world.

- Tier 1: Dreamcraft
- Tier 1: Oneirochemistry
- Tier 2: Dream Thief
- Tier 3: Dream Becomes Reality or Enhanced Intellect
- Tier 4: Daydream
- Tier 5: Nightmare
- Tier 6: Chamber of Dreams or Reactive Field

GM Intrusions: An unexpected sleepwalking episode puts the character into a dangerous situation. A nightmare breaks free of a dream.

6.4.4 Battles Robots

You excel in battling robots, automatons, and machine entities.

- Tier 1: Machine Vulnerabilities
- Tier 1: Tech Skills
- Tier 2: Defense Against Robots
- Tier 2: Machine Hunting
- Tier 3: Disable Mechanisms or Surprise Attack
- Tier 4: Robot Fighter
- Tier 5: Drain Power
- Tier 6: Deactivate Mechanisms or Lethal Damage

GM Intrusions: The robot explodes upon defeat. Other robots come after the character for revenge.

6.4.5 Bears a Halo of Fire

You can sheath your body in flames, which protects you and harms your foes.

- Tier 1: Shroud of Flame
- Tier 2: Hurl Flame
- Tier 3: Wings of Fire or Fiery Hand of Doom
- Tier 4: Flameblade
- Tier 5: Fire Tendrils
- Tier 6: Fire Servant or Inferno Trail

GM Intrusions: Fire burns flammable material. Fire spreads out of control. Primitive creatures fear fire and often attack what they fear.

6.4.6 Blazes With Radiance

You can create light, sculpt it, bend it away from you, or gather it to use as a weapon.

- Tier 1: Enlightened
- Tier 1: Illuminating Touch
- Tier 2: Dazzling Sunburst
- Tier 3: Burning Light or Skill With Defense
- Tier 4: Sunlight
- Tier 5: Disappear
- Tier 6: Living Light or Defensive Field

GM Intrusions: Allies are accidentally dazzled or blinded. Bright flashes draw guards.

6.4.7 Brandishes an Exotic Shield

You deploy an amazing shield of pure force that provides protection and some offensive options.

- Tier 1: Force Field Shield
- Tier 1: Force Bash
- Tier 2: Enveloping Shield
- Tier 3: Healing Pulse or Throw Force Shield
- Tier 4: Energized Shield
- Tier 5: Force Wall
- Tier 6: Bouncing Shield or Shield Burst

GM Intrusions: The shield is temporarily lost. A foe temporarily ends up with the shield.

6.4.8 Builds Robots

Your robotic creations do as they are commanded.

(The word “robot” is used in this focus, though the robot you create might look very different from one created by someone else, depending on the genre. Steampunk robots, organic robots, or even magical golems are all feasible “robots.”)

- Tier 1: Robot Assistant
- Tier 1: Robot Builder
- Tier 2: Robot Control
- Tier 3: Expert Follower or Skill With Defense
- Tier 4: Robot Upgrade
- Tier 5: Robot Fleet
- Tier 6: Robot Evolution or Robot Upgrade

GM Intrusions: The robot is hacked, gains a mind of its own, or unexpectedly detonates.

6.4.9 Calculates the Incalculable

Awesome mathematical ability allows you to model the world in real time, giving you an edge over everyone.

- Tier 1: Predictive Equation
- Tier 1: Higher Mathematics
- Tier 2: Predictive Model
- Tier 3: Subconscious Defense or Enhanced Intellect
- Tier 4: Cognizant Offense
- Tier 5: Greater Enhanced Intellect
- Tier 5: Further Mathematics
- Tier 6: Knowing the Unknown or Greater Enhanced Intellect

GM Intrusions: Too many predicted results threaten to overwhelm and stun the character. A result points to imminent disaster.

6.4.10 Channels Divine Blessings

A devout follower of a divine being, you channel some of your deity’s power to achieve wonders.

- Tier 1: Blessing of the Gods
- Tier 2: Enhanced Intellect
- Tier 3: Divine Radiance or Fire Bloom
- Tier 4: Overawe
- Tier 5: Divine Intervention
- Tier 6: Divine Symbol or Summon Demon

GM Intrusions: A demon investigates divine magic use. A rival cult has issues with the character’s teachings.

6.4.11 Commands Mental Powers

You have honed the power of your mind to perform amazing psychic deeds.

- Tier 1: Telepathic
- Tier 2: Mind Reading
- Tier 3: Psychic Burst or Psychic Suggestion
- Tier 4: Use Senses of Others
- Tier 5: Precognition
- Tier 6: Mind Control or Telepathic Network

GM Intrusions: Something glimpsed in the target's mind is horrifying. A feedback loop allows the target to read the character's mind.

6.4.12 Conducts Weird Science

Your preternatural insight and ability make you a scientist capable of amazing feats.

- Tier 1: Lab Analysis
- Tier 1: Knowledge Skills
- Tier 2: Modify Device
- Tier 3: Better Living Through Chemistry or Incredible Health
- Tier 4: Knowledge Skills
- Tier 4: Just a Bit Mad
- Tier 5: Weird Science Breakthrough
- Tier 6: Incredible Feat of Science
- Tier 6: Inventor or Defensive Field

GM Intrusions: Creations get out of control. Side effects cannot always be predicted. Weird science terrifies people and can draw the media. When a device created or modified by weird science is depleted, it detonates.

6.4.13 Consorts with the Dead

The dead answer your questions, and their reanimated corpses serve you.

- Tier 1: Speaker for the Dead
- Tier 2: Necromancy
- Tier 3: Reading the Room or Repair Flesh
- Tier 4: Greater Necromancy
- Tier 5: Terrifying Gaze
- Tier 6: True Necromancy or Word of Death

GM Intrusions: The character's necromantic reputation precedes them. A corpse seeks revenge for being reanimated.

6.4.14 Controls Beasts

Your ability to communicate and lead beasts is uncanny.

- Tier 1: Beast Companion
- Tier 2: Soothe the Savage
- Tier 2: Communication
- Tier 3: Mount or Stronger Together
- Tier 4: Beast Eyes
- Tier 4: Improved Companion
- Tier 5: Beast Call
- Tier 6: As If One Creature or Control the Savage

GM Intrusions: The community is reluctant to welcome dangerous animals. Out-of-control beasts become a real hazard.

6.4.15 Controls Gravity

You can sway the attraction of gravity itself.

- Type Swap Option: Weighty
- Tier 1: Hover
- Tier 2: Enhanced Speed Edge
- Tier 3: Define Down or Gravity Cleave
- Tier 4: Field of Gravity
- Tier 5: Flight
- Tier 6: Improved Gravity Cleave or Weight of the World

GM Intrusions: Onlookers react with unreasoning fear. A weird interaction sends an ally or object careening into the sky.

6.4.16 Copies Superpowers

You can copy others' skills, abilities, and superpowers.

- Tier 1: Flex Skill
- Tier 1: Flex Skill
- Tier 2: Copy Power
- Tier 3: Steal Power or Wildcard Powers
- Tier 4: Improved Copying
- Tier 5: Power Memory
- Tier 6: Amazing Copying or Multiple Copying

GM Intrusions: A copied power ends unexpectedly or goes out of control. A copied power doesn't bring secondary powers with it (like gaining superspeed without protection from air friction, or not being immune to the heat from your own fire bolts).

6.4.17 Crafts Illusions

You fashion images from light that are so perfect they seem real.

- Tier 1: Minor Illusion
- Tier 2: Illusory Disguise
- Tier 3: Cast Illusion or Major Illusion
- Tier 4: Illusory Selves
- Tier 5: Terrifying Image
- Tier 6: Grandiose Illusion or Permanent Illusion

GM Intrusions: The illusion isn't believable. The illusion is pierced at just the wrong moment.

6.4.18 Crafts Unique Objects

You're an inventor of strange and useful objects.

- Tier 1: Crafter
- Tier 1: Master Identifier
- Tier 2: Artifact Tinkerer
- Tier 2: Quick Work
- Tier 3: Master Crafter or Built-In Weaponry
- Tier 4: Cyphersmith
- Tier 5: Innovator
- Tier 6: Inventor or Fusion Armor

GM Intrusions: The object malfunctions, breaks, or suffers catastrophic or unexpected failure.

(Cyphersmith works only in a setting where the cyphers are physical objects. If this isn't the case, this ability should probably be replaced with something akin to Weird Science Breakthrough from the Conducts Weird Science focus.)

6.4.19 Dances with Dark Matter

You can manipulate shadow and “dark” matter.

- Tier 1: Ribbons of Dark Matter
- Tier 2: Void Wings
- Tier 3: Dark Matter Shroud or Dark Matter Strike
- Tier 4: Dark Matter Shell
- Tier 5: Windwracked Traveler
- Tier 6: Dark Matter Structure or Embrace the Night
- GM Intrusions: Dark matter skulks away as if possessed by a mind of its own.

6.4.20 Defends the Gate

Everyone wants you on their side when it comes to a fight because nothing gets by you.

- Tier 1: Fortified Position
- Tier 1: Rally to Me
- Tier 2: Mind for Might
- Tier 3: Fortification Builder or Divert Attacks
- Tier 4: Greater Enhanced Might
- Tier 5: Reinforcing Field
- Tier 6: Generate Force Field or Stun Attack
- GM Intrusions: A strategically important structure collapses. The enemy attacks from an unexpected direction.

6.4.21 Defends the Weak

You stand up for the helpless, the weak, and the unprotected.

- Tier 1: Courageous
- Tier 1: Warding Shield
- Tier 2: Devoted Defender
- Tier 2: Insight
- Tier 3: Dual Wards or True Guardian
- Tier 4: Combat Challenge
- Tier 5: Willing Sacrifice
- Tier 6: Resuscitate or True Defender
- GM Intrusions: A character focused on protecting others may periodically leave themselves vulnerable to attacks.

6.4.22 Descends From Nobility

A descendent of wealth and power, you carry a noble title and the abilities granted by a privileged upbringing.

- Type Swap Option: Retinue
- Tier 1: Privileged Nobility
- Tier 2: Trained Interlocutor
- Tier 3: Advanced Command or Noble's Courage
- Tier 4: Expert Follower
- Tier 5: Asserting Your Privilege
- Tier 6: Able Assistance or Mind of a Leader
- GM Intrusions: Debts incurred by a family are owed by the character. A long-lost sibling seeks to disinherit rivals. An assassin finds the character.

6.4.23 Doesn't Do Much

You're a slacker, but you know a little about a lot of things.

- Tier 1: Life Lessons
- Tier 2: Totally Chill
- Tier 3: Skill With Attacks or Improvise
- Tier 4: Life Lessons
- Tier 4: Greater Skill With Defense
- Tier 5: Greater Enhanced Potential

Tier 6 Drawing on Life's Experiences or Quick Wits

GM Intrusions: New situations are confounding and stressful. Past actions (or inactions) come back to haunt the character.

6.4.24 Drives Like A Maniac

Whether balancing on two wheels, jumping another vehicle, or driving head-on toward an oncoming enemy car, you don't think about the risks when you're behind the wheel.

(Someone who Drives Like a Maniac needs access to a vehicle.)

- Tier 1: Driver
- Tier 1: Driving on the Edge
- Tier 2: Car Surfer
- Tier 2: Stare Them Down
- Tier 3: Expert Driver or Enhanced Speed Edge
- Tier 4: Sharp-Eyed
- Tier 4: Enhanced Speed
- Tier 5: Something in the Road
- Tier 6: Trick Driver or Lethal Damage

GM Intrusions: The engine develops a knock. The bridge on the road ahead is out. The windshield shatters. Someone unexpectedly runs in front of the vehicle.

6.4.25 Emerged From the Obelisk

Your body, hard as crystal, gives you a suite of unique abilities, gained after an interaction with a floating crystalline obelisk.

- Tier 1: Crystalline Body
- Tier 2: Hover
- Tier 3: Inhabit Crystal or Immovable
- Tier 4: Crystal Lens
- Tier 5: Resonant Frequency
- Tier 6: Resonant Quake or Return to the Obelisk

GM Intrusions: Cyphers and artifacts react unexpectedly in the character's hands.

6.4.26 Employs Magnetism

You command metal and the power of magnetism.

- Tier 1: Move Metal
- Tier 2: Repel Metal
- Tier 3: Destroy Metal or Guide Bolt
- Tier 4: Magnetic Field
- Tier 5: Command Metal
- Tier 6: Diamagnetism or Iron Punch

GM Intrusions: The metal twists, bends, or produces shrapnel. A lapse in concentration might cause something to slip or drop at just the wrong time.

6.4.27 Entertains

You perform, mostly for the benefit of others.

- Tier 1: Levity
- Tier 2: Inspiring Ease
- Tier 3: Knowledge Skills or Greater Enhanced Potential
- Tier 4: Calm
- Tier 5: Able Assistance
- Tier 6: Master Entertainer or Vindictive Performance

GM Intrusions: The audience is annoyed or offended. Musical instruments break. Paints dry in their pots. The words to a poem or song are forgotten.

6.4.28 Exists in Two Places at Once

You exist in two places at once.

- Tier 1: Duplicate
- Tier 2: Share Senses
- Tier 3: Superior Duplicate or Resilient Duplicate
- Tier 4: Damage Transference
- Tier 5: Coordinated Effort
- Tier 6: Multiplicity or Resilient Duplicate

GM Intrusions: Perceiving the world from two different places disorients the character, causing momentary vertigo, nausea, or confusion.

6.4.29 Exists Partially Out of Phase

A bit translucent, you're slightly out of phase and can move through solid objects.

- Tier 1: Walk Through Walls
- Tier 2: Defensive Phasing
- Tier 3: Phased Attack or Phase Door
- Tier 4: Ghost
- Tier 5: Untouchable
- Tier 6: Enhanced Phased Attack or Phase Foe

GM Intrusions: The character is sent phasing into an unexpected dimension. The character becomes lost in a large solid.

6.4.30 Explores Dark Places

You're the archetypal treasure hunter, scavenger, and finder of lost things.

- Tier 1: Superb Explorer
- Tier 2: Superb Infiltrator
- Tier 2: Eyes Adjusted
- Tier 3: Nightstrike or Slippery Customer
- Tier 4: Hard-Won Resilience
- Tier 5: Dark Explorer
- Tier 6: Blinding Attack or Embraced by Darkness

GM Intrusions: Possessions fall out of pockets or bags in the dark; maps get lost; information gained fails to include an important detail.

6.4.31 Fights Dirty

You'll do anything to win a fight: bite, scratch, kick, trick, and worse.

- Tier 1: Tracker
- Tier 1: Stalker
- Tier 2: Sneak
- Tier 2: Quarry
- Tier 3: Betrayal or Surprise Attack
- Tier 4: Mind Games
- Tier 4: Capable Warrior
- Tier 5: Using the Environment
- Tier 6: Twisting the Knife or Murderer

GM Intrusions: People look poorly upon those who cheat or fight without honor. Sometimes a dirty trick backfires.

6.4.32 Fights With Panache

You're a swashbuckling daredevil who fights with flamboyant style that's entertaining to watch.

- Tier 1: Attack Flourish
- Tier 2: Quick Block
- Tier 3: Acrobatic Attack or Flamboyant Boast

Tier 4: Block for Another

Tier 4: Fast Kill

Tier 5: Using the Environment

Tier 6: Agile Wit or Return to Sender

GM Intrusions: The display comes off looking silly, clumsy, or unattractive.

6.4.33 Flies Faster Than a Bullet

You can fly, and you're superstrong, hard to hurt, and fast too. Is there anything you can't do?

- Tier 1: Hover
- Tier 2: Greater Enhanced Potential
- Tier 3: Hidden Reserves or See Through Matter
- Tier 4: Blink of an Eye
- Tier 4: Up to Speed
- Tier 5: Not Dead Yet
- Tier 6: Burning Light or Ignore Affliction

GM Intrusions: A nemesis finds the character. A strange material is found to nullify the character's abilities.

6.4.34 Focuses Mind Over Matter

You can telekinetically move objects with your mind without physically touching them.

- Tier 1: Divert Attacks
- Tier 2: Telekinesis
- Tier 3: Cloak of Opportunity or Enhance Strength
- Tier 4: Apportation
- Tier 5: Psychokinetic Attack
- Tier 6: Improved Apportation or Reshape

GM Intrusions: One mental slip, and moving objects drop or fragile objects break. Sometimes the wrong item moves, falls, or breaks.

6.4.35 Fuses Flesh and Steel

Your body is part machine.

- Tier 1: Enhanced Body
- Tier 2: Interface
- Tier 3: Sensing Package or Weaponization
- Tier 4: Fusion
- Tier 5: Deep Reserves
- Tier 6: Mind Surge or Ultra Enhancement

GM Intrusions: People in most societies are afraid of someone who is revealed to have mechanical parts.

6.4.36 Fuses Mind and Machine

Electronic aids implanted in your brain make you a mental powerhouse.

- Tier 1: Enhanced Intellect
- Tier 1: Knowledge Skills
- Tier 2: Network Tap
- Tier 3: Action Processor or Machine Telepathy
- Tier 4: Greater Enhanced Intellect
- Tier 4: Knowledge Skills
- Tier 5: See the Future
- Tier 6: Machine Enhancement or Mind Surge

GM Intrusions: Machines malfunction and shut down. Powerful machine intelligences can take control of lesser thinking machines. Some people don't trust a person who isn't fully organic.

6.4.37 Grows to Towering Heights

For brief periods, you can grow larger and, with enough experience, to towering heights.

- Tier 1: Enlarge
- Tier 1: Freakishly Large
- Tier 2: Bigger
- Tier 2: Advantages of Being Big
- Tier 3: Huge or Throw
- Tier 4: Grab
- Tier 5: Gargantuan
- Tier 6: Colossal or Lethal Damage

GM Intrusions: Rapid growth knocks over furnishings or smashes through ceilings or hanging lights. An enlarged character breaks through the floor.

6.4.38 Has a Thousand Faces

You can change your appearance to look like anyone else.

- Tier 1: Face Morph
- Tier 1: Interaction Skills
- Tier 2: Body Morph
- Tier 2: War Flesh
- Tier 3: Disguise Other or Resilience
- Tier 4: Ageless
- Tier 4: Think Your Way Out
- Tier 5: Memory Becomes Action
- Tier 6: Divide Your Mind or Infer Thoughts

GM Intrusions: Part of the disguise slips. An NPC thinks the disguised character is someone they know very well.

6.4.39 Helps Their Friends

You love your friends and help them out of any difficulty, no matter what.

- Type Swap Option: Advice From a Friend
- Tier 1: Friendly Help
- Tier 1: Courageous
- Tier 2: Weather the Vicissitudes
- Tier 3: Buddy System or Skill With Attacks
- Tier 4: In Harm's Way
- Tier 4: Enhanced Physique
- Tier 5: Inspire Action
- Tier 6: Deep Consideration or Skill With Defense

GM Intrusions: Others sometimes have ulterior motives. The law takes an undue interest. Even when everything goes right, repercussions follow.

6.4.40 Howls at the Moon

For brief periods, you become a fearsome and powerful creature with control issues.

- Tier 1: Beast Form
- Tier 2: Controlled Change
- Tier 3: Bigger Beast Form or Greater Beast Form
- Tier 4: Greater Controlled Change
- Tier 5: Enhanced Beast Form
- Tier 6: Lethal Damage or Perfect Control

GM Intrusions: The change happens in an uncontrolled fashion. People are terrified of monsters.

6.4.41 Hunts

You are a stalking hunter who excels at bringing down your selected quarry.

- Tier 1: Attack Flourish
- Tier 1: Tracker
- Tier 2: Quarry
- Tier 2: Sneak
- Tier 3: Horde Fighting or Sprint and Grab
- Tier 4: Surprise Attack
- Tier 5: Hunter's Drive
- Tier 6: Greater Skill With Attacks or Multiple Quarry

GM Intrusions: The quarry notices the character. The quarry isn't as vulnerable as it seemed.

6.4.42 Ignores Physical Distance

You can teleport from one place to another by briefly passing through a parallel dimension.

- Tier 1: Dimensional Squeeze
- Tier 2: Opportunist
- Tier 3: Defensive Blinking or Teleportation Burst
- Tier 4: Short Teleportation
- Tier 5: Medium Teleportation
- Tier 6: Teleportation or Teleportive Wound

GM Intrusions: A teleport goes awry, landing the character in a dangerous place. Inertia (such as from falling) continues through the teleport, injuring the character.

6.4.43 Infiltrates

Subtlety, guile, and stealth allow you to get in where others can't.

- Tier 1: Stealth Skills
- Tier 1: Sense Attitudes
- Tier 2: Impersonate
- Tier 2: Flight Not Fight
- Tier 3: Awareness or Skill With Attacks
- Tier 4: Invisibility
- Tier 5: Evasion
- Tier 6: Brainwashing or Spring Away

GM Intrusions: Spies are treated harshly when caught. Allies disavow infiltrators who get caught. Some secrets are better left unknown.

6.4.44 Interprets the Law

You excel at winning others over to your views.

- Tier 1: Opening Statement
- Tier 1: Knowledge of the Law
- Tier 2: Debate
- Tier 3: Able Assistance or Enhanced Intellect Edge
- Tier 4: Castigate
- Tier 5: No One Knows Better
- Tier 6: Greater Enhanced Potential or Legal Intern

GM Intrusions: Onlookers react badly to a know-it-all. A distraction or interruption throws the character's argument off the rails.

6.4.45 Is Idolized by Millions

You're a celebrity and most people adore you.

Tier 1: Entourage

Tier 1: Celebrity Talent

Tier 2: Perks of Stardom

Tier 3: Incredible Health or Skill With Attacks

Tier 4: Captivate With Starshine

Tier 4: Expert Follower

Tier 5: Do You Know Who I Am?

Tier 6: Transcend the Script or Improved Companion

GM Intrusions: Fans are endangered or hurt on your behalf. Someone in your entourage betrays you. Your show, tour, contract, or other event is canceled. The media posts photos of you in an embarrassing situation.

6.4.46 Is Licensed to Carry

You carry a gun and you know how to use it in a fight.

(Although Is Licensed to Carry is designed with modern firearms in mind, it could apply to flintlock weapons, futuristic laser blasters, or other ranged weapons.)

Tier 1: Gunner

Tier 1: Practiced With Guns

Tier 2: Careful Shot

Tier 3: Trained Gunner or Damage Dealer

Tier 4: Snap Shot

Tier 5: Arc Spray

Tier 6: Special Shot or Lethal Damage

GM Intrusions: Misfire or jam! The attack fails and the action is lost, plus an additional action is needed to fix the problem.

6.4.47 Is Wanted by the Law

"WANTED, DEAD OR ALIVE" posters (or their equivalent) have appeared featuring your face. It's up to you whether it's a mistake that snowballed out of control or you actually would kill someone just for looking at you.

Tier 1: Enhanced Speed

Tier 1: Danger Sense

Tier 2: Surprise Attack

Tier 3: Outlaw Reputation or Successive Attack

Tier 4: Fast Kill

Tier 5: Band of Desperados

Tier 6: Not Dead Yet or Lethal Damage

GM Intrusions: Most people do not take well to discovering a wanted outlaw in their midst.

6.4.48 Keeps a Magic Ally

An allied magic creature bound to an object (such as a minor djinn in a lamp, or a ghost in a pipe) is your friend, protector, and weapon.

Tier 1: Bound Magic Creature

Tier 2: Object Bond

Tier 2: Hidden Closet

Tier 3: Minor Wish or Mount

Tier 4: Improved Object Bond

Tier 5: Moderate Wish

Tier 6: Object Bond Mastery or Trust to Luck

GM Intrusions: The creature unexpectedly disappears into its bound object. The bound object cracks. The creature disagrees and doesn't do as asked. The creature says it's leaving unless a task is performed for it.

6.4.49 Leads

Your natural leadership capability allows you to command others, including a loyal band of followers.

Tier 1: Natural Charisma

Tier 1: Good Advice

Tier 2: Enhanced Potential

Tier 2: Basic Follower

Tier 3: Advanced Command or Expert Follower

Tier 4: Captivate or Inspire

Tier 5: Greater Enhanced Potential

Tier 6: Band of Followers or Mind of a Leader

GM Intrusions: Followers fail, betray, lie, become corrupted, get kidnapped, or die.

6.4.50 Learns Quickly

You deal with bad situations as they arise, learning new lessons each time.

Tier 1: Enhanced Intellect

Tier 1: There's Your Problem

Tier 2: Quick Study

Tier 3: Hard to Distract

Tier 3: Enhanced Intellect Edge or Flex Skill

Tier 4: Pay It Forward

Tier 5: Enhanced Intellect

Tier 5: Learned a Few Things

Tier 6: Two Things at Once or Skill With Defense

GM Intrusions: Accidents and mistakes are great teachers.

6.4.51 Lives in the Wilderness

You can survive in badlands where others perish.

Tier 1: Wilderness Life

Tier 1: Enhanced Might

Tier 2: Living Off the Land

Tier 2: Wilderness Explorer

Tier 3: Animal Senses and Sensibilities or Wilderness Encouragement

Tier 4: Wilderness Awareness

Tier 5: The Wild Is on Your Side

Tier 6: One With the Wild or Wild Camouflage

GM Intrusions: People in cities and towns sometimes disparage those who look (and smell) like they live in the wilds, as if they were ignorant or barbaric.

6.4.52 Looks for Trouble

You're a scrapper and love a good fight.

Tier 1: Fists of Fury

Tier 1: Wound Tender

Tier 2: Protector

Tier 2: Straightforward

Tier 3: Skill With Attacks or Greater Enhanced Potential

Tier 4: Knock Out

Tier 5: Mastery With Attacks

Tier 6: Greater Enhanced Might or Lethal Damage

GM Intrusions: Weapons break or fly from even the strongest grip. Brawlers trip and fall. Even the battlefield can work against you with things falling or collapsing.

6.4.53 Loves the Void

When it's just you, your spacesuit, and the panorama of stars wheeling out forever and always, you are at peace.

Type Swap Option: Have Spacesuit, Will Travel

Tier 1: Vacuum Skilled

Tier 1: Microgravity Adept

Tier 2: Enhanced Speed Edge

Tier 2: Enhanced Physique

Tier 3: Space Fighting or Fusion Armor

Tier 4: Silent As Space

Tier 4: Push Off and Throw

Tier 5: Microgravity Avoidance

Tier 6: Weightless Shot or Reactive Field

GM Intrusions: Spacesuits develop glitches. Air refill cartridges sometimes misreport capacity. Micrometeorites are common in space.

6.4.54 Masters Defense

You use protective equipment and practiced techniques to avoid becoming hurt in a fight.

Tier 1: Shield Master

Tier 2: Sturdy

Tier 2: Practiced in Armor

Tier 3: Dodge and Resist or Dodge and Respond

Tier 4: Tower of Will

Tier 4: Experienced in Armor

Tier 5: Nothing but Defend

Tier 6: Defense Master or Wear It Well

GM Intrusions: Shields break when hit, as do weapons used to parry. Armor straps break.

6.4.55 Masters Spells

By specializing in spellcasting and keeping a spellbook, you can quickly cast spells of arcing lightning, rolling fire, creeping shadow, and summoning.

Tier 1: Arcane Flare

Tier 2: Ray of Confusion

Tier 3: Fire Bloom or Summon Giant Spider

Tier 4: Soul Interrogation

Tier 5: Granite Wall

Tier 6: Summon Demon or Word of Death

GM Intrusions: The spell goes wrong. The summoned creature turns on the caster. A rival spellcaster is drawn to the magic use.

6.4.56 Masters the Swarm

Insects. Rats. Bats. Even birds. You master one type of small creature that obeys you.

Tier 1: Influence Swarm

Tier 2: Control Swarm

Tier 3: Living Armor or Skill With Attacks

Tier 4: Call Swarm

Tier 5: Gain Unusual Companion

Tier 6: Deadly Swarm or Skill With Defense

GM Intrusions: A command is misunderstood. Control is erratic or is lost. Bites and stings are not uncommon for masters of the swarm.

6.4.57 Masters Weaponry

You are a master user of a particular type of weapon, be it a sword, whip, dagger, gun, or something else.

(Someone who Masters Weaponry might have additional equipment, including a high-quality weapon.)

Tier 1: Weapon Master

Tier 1: Weapon Crafter

Tier 2: Weapon Defense

Tier 3: Rapid Attack or Disarming Strike

Tier 4: Never Fumble

Tier 5: Extreme Mastery

Tier 6: Murderer or Deadly Strike

GM Intrusions: Weapons break. Weapons can be stolen. Weapons can be dropped or forced out of your hand.

6.4.58 Metes Out Justice

You right wrongs, protect the innocent, and punish the guilty.

Tier 1: Make Judgment

Tier 1: Designation

Tier 2: Defend the Innocent

Tier 2: Improved Designation

Tier 3: Defend All the Innocent or Punish the Guilty

Tier 4: Find the Guilty

Tier 4: Greater Designation

Tier 5: Punish All the Guilty

Tier 6: Damn the Guilty or Inspire the Innocent

GM Intrusions: Guilt or innocence can be complicated. Some people resent the presumption of a self-appointed judge. Passing judgment makes enemies.

6.4.59 Moves Like a Cat

Lithe, flexible, and graceful, you move quickly and smoothly, and never seem to be where danger is.

Tier 1: Greater Enhanced Speed

Tier 1: Balance

Tier 2: Movement Skills

Tier 2: Safe Fall

Tier 3: Hard to Hit

Tier 3: Enhanced Speed Edge or Greater Enhanced Speed

Tier 4: Quick Strike

Tier 5: Slippery

Tier 6: Perfect Speed Burst or Greater Enhanced Speed

GM Intrusions: Even a cat can be clumsy. A jump isn't quite as easy as it looks. An escape move is so overzealous that it sends the character right into harm's way.

6.4.60 Moves Like the Wind

You can move so fast that you become a blur.

Tier 1: Greater Enhanced Speed

Tier 1: Fleet of Foot

Tier 2: Hard to Hit

Tier 3: Speed Burst or Greater Enhanced Speed

Tier 4: Blink of an Eye

Tier 5: Hard to See

Tier 6: Perfect Speed Burst or Incredible Running Speed

GM Intrusions: Surfaces can be slick or offer hidden obstacles. The movement of other creatures can be unpredictable, and the character might run into them.

6.4.61 Murders

You're an assassin, whether by trade, by inclination, or because it was that or be killed yourself. (Someone who Murders might have additional equipment, including three doses of a level 2 blade poison that inflicts 5 points of damage.)

- Tier 1: Surprise Attack
- Tier 1: Assassin Skills
- Tier 2: Quick Death
- Tier 2: Infiltrator
- Tier 3: Awareness or Poison Crafter
- Tier 4: Better Surprise Attack
- Tier 5: Damage Dealer
- Tier 6: Escape Plan or Murderer

GM Intrusions: Most people do not react well to a professional killer.

6.4.62 Needs No Weapon

Powerful punches, kicks, elbows, knees, and full body movements are all the weapons you need.

- Tier 1: Fists of Fury
- Tier 1: Flesh of Stone
- Tier 2: Advantage to Disadvantage
- Tier 2: Unarmed Fighting Style
- Tier 3: Moving Like Water or Greater Enhanced Potential
- Tier 4: Divert Attacks
- Tier 5: Stun Attack
- Tier 6: Master of Unarmed Fighting Style or Lethal Damage

GM Intrusions: Striking certain foes hurts you as much as it hurts them. Opponents with weapons have greater reach. Complicated martial arts moves can knock you off balance.

6.4.63 Never Says Die

You never quit, can shrug off a beating, and always come back for more.

- Tier 1: Improved Recovery
- Tier 1: Push on Through
- Tier 2: Ignore the Pain
- Tier 3: Blood Fever or Hidden Reserves
- Tier 4: Increasing Determination or Outlast the Foe
- Tier 5: Not Dead Yet
- Tier 6: Final Defiance or Ignore Affliction

GM Intrusions: Sometimes, it's equipment or weapons that give out.

6.4.64 Operates Undercover

Under the guise of someone else, you seek to find answers the powerful do not want divulged.

(Someone who Operates Undercover might have additional equipment that includes a disguise kit.)

- Tier 1: Investigate
- Tier 2: Disguise
- Tier 3: Agent Provocateur or Run and Fight
- Tier 4: Pull a Fast One
- Tier 5: Using What's Available

Tier 6: Trust to Luck or Deadly Strike

GM Intrusions: Bad luck can ruin the best plans. Disguises fail. Allies are revealed to be agents, too.

6.4.65 Performs Feats of Strength

A muscled prodigy, you can haul incredible weight, hurl your body through the air, and punch through doors.

- Tier 1: Athlete
 - Tier 1: Enhanced Might Edge
 - Tier 2: Feat of Strength
 - Tier 3: Iron Fist or Throw
 - Tier 4: Greater Enhanced Might
 - Tier 5: Brute Strike
 - Tier 6: Greater Enhanced Might or Jump Attack
- GM Intrusions: It's easy to break delicate things or hurt someone accidentally.

6.4.66 Pilots Starcraft

You're a crack starship pilot.

- Tier 1: Pilot
- Tier 1: Flex Lore
- Tier 2: Salvage and Comfort
- Tier 2: Mentally Tough
- Tier 3: Expert Pilot
- Tier 3: Ship Footing or Machine Companion
- Tier 4: Sensor Array
- Tier 4: Enhanced Speed
- Tier 5: Like the Back of Your Hand
- Tier 6: Incomparable Pilot
- Tier 6: Remote Control or Skill With Attacks

GM Intrusions: Starcraft get lost, break down, and are attacked in space. An alien stowaway is found.

6.4.67 Plays Too Many Games

Lessons, reflexes, and strategies you've learned by playing too many games have applications in the real world, where people who don't play enough toil and live their dreary lives.

- Tier 1: Game Lessons
- Tier 1: Gamer
- Tier 2: Zero Dark Eyes
- Tier 2: Resist Tricks
- Tier 3: Sniper's Aim or Enhanced Speed Edge
- Tier 4: Mind Games
- Tier 4: Enhanced Intellect
- Tier 5: Gamer's Fortitude
- Tier 6: Mind Surge or Gaming God

GM Intrusions: Missed attacks strike the wrong target. Equipment breaks. Sometimes people react negatively to someone who has lived most of their life in imaginary game worlds.

6.4.68 Rages

When you go berserk, everyone fears you.

- Tier 1: Frenzy
- Tier 2: Greater Enhanced Might
- Tier 2: Movement Skills
- Tier 3: Power Strike or Unarmored Fighter
- Tier 4: Greater Frenzy
- Tier 5: Attack and Attack Again
- Tier 6: Greater Enhanced Potential or Lethal Damage

GM Intrusions: It's easy for a berserker to lose control and attack friend as well as foe.

6.4.69 Rides the Lightning

You create and discharge electrical power.

- Tier 1: Shock
 - Tier 1: Charge
 - Tier 2: Bolt Rider
 - Tier 3: Electric Armor or Drain Charge
 - Tier 4: Bolts of Power
 - Tier 5: Electrical Flight
 - Tier 6: Flash Across the Miles or Wall of Lightning
- GM Intrusions: Targets other than those intended are shocked. Objects explode.

6.4.70 Runs Away

Your first instinct is to run from danger, and you've gotten very good at it.

- Tier 1: Go Defensive
 - Tier 2: Enhanced Speed
 - Tier 2: Quick to Flee
 - Tier 3: Incredible Running Speed or Greater Enhanced Speed
 - Tier 4: Increasing Determination
 - Tier 4: Quick Wits
 - Tier 5: Go to Ground
 - Tier 6: Burst of Escape or Skill With Defense
- GM Intrusions: Quick movements sometimes lead to dropped items, slipping on uneven ground, or going the wrong way by accident.

6.4.71 Sailed Beneath the Jolly Roger

You sailed with a crew of dread pirates, but you've decided to end your days as a pirate and join some other cause. The question is, will your past let you go so easily?

- Tier 1: Ignore the Pain
- Tier 1: Sailor
- Tier 2: Taking Advantage
- Tier 2: Fearsome Reputation
- Tier 3: Skill With Attacks or Skill With Defense
- Tier 4: Sea Legs
- Tier 4: Movement Skills
- Tier 5: Lost in the Chaos
- Tier 6: Duel to the Death or Successive Attack

GM Intrusions: The dangers of the high seas are many, including severe storms and disease. Other pirates sometimes get ahead through betrayal. A pirate tracks down former sailing mates to find hidden treasure.

6.4.72 Scavenges

When not running and hiding, you sift the ruins of civilization for useful remnants to ensure your survival.

- Tier 1: Post-Apocalyptic Survivor
- Tier 1: Ruin Lore
- Tier 2: Junkmonger
- Tier 3: Taking Advantage or Incredible Health
- Tier 4: Know Where to Look
- Tier 5: Recycled Cyphers
- Tier 6: Artifact Scavenger or Reactive Field

GM Intrusions: An item made with recycled junk breaks. Someone shows up claiming that the useful item or piece of junk scavenged belongs to them. A recycled cypher explodes.

6.4.73 Sculpts Hard Light

You create physical objects out of hard light that you can use for offense and defense.

- Tier 1: Automatic Glow
- Tier 1: Temporary Light
- Tier 2: Entangling Force
- Tier 3: Harder Light or Sculpt Light
- Tier 4: Greater Enhanced Intellect
- Tier 5: Improved Sculpt Light
- Tier 6: Defensive Field or Flight

GM Intrusions: A hard light object disappears early. A hard light object cannot affect a certain creature or color.

6.4.74 Sees Beyond

You have a psychic sense that allows you to see what others cannot.

- Tier 1: See the Unseen
 - Tier 2: See Through Matter
 - Tier 3: Find the Hidden or Sensor
 - Tier 4: Remote Viewing
 - Tier 5: See Through Time
 - Tier 6: Mental Projection or Total Awareness
- GM Intrusions: Some secrets are too terrible to know.

6.4.75 Separates Mind From Body

You can project your mind out of your body to see faraway places and learn secrets that would otherwise remain hidden.

- Tier 1: Third Eye
- Tier 2: Open Mind
- Tier 2: Sharp Senses
- Tier 3: Roaming Third Eye or Find the Hidden
- Tier 4: Sensor
- Tier 5: Psychic Passenger
- Tier 6: Mental Projection or Improved Sensor

GM Intrusions: Reuniting mind and body can sometimes be disorienting and require a character to spend a few moments to get their bearings.

6.4.76 Shepherds the Community

You keep the place where you live safe from all danger.

- Tier 1: Community Knowledge
- Tier 1: Community Activist
- Tier 2: Skill With Attacks
- Tier 3: Shepherd's Fury or Skill With Defense
- Tier 4: Greater Enhanced Potential
- Tier 5: Evasion
- Tier 6: Greater Skill With Attacks or Protective Wall

GM Intrusions: People in the community misunderstand the character's motives. Rivals try to oust the character.

6.4.77 Shepherds Spirits

Wandering souls, nature spirits, and elemental beings aid and support you.

(In some settings, the Shepherds Spirits focus applies to only one kind of spirit, such as spirits of the deceased, nature spirits, and so on.)

Tier 1: Question the Spirits

Tier 2: Spirit Accomplice

Tier 3: Command Spirit or Preternatural Senses

Tier 4: Wraith Cloak

Tier 5: Call Dead Spirit

Tier 6: Call Otherworldly Spirit or Infuse Spirit

GM Intrusions: Some people don't trust those who deal with spirits. The dead sometimes don't want shepherding.

6.4.78 Shreds the Walls of the World

Speed plus phasing gives you a unique ability to evade danger and simultaneously inflict damage.

Tier 1: Phase Sprint

Tier 1: Disrupting Touch

Tier 2: Scratch Existence

Tier 3: Invisible Phasing or Walk Through Walls

Tier 4: Phase Detonation

Tier 5: Very Long Sprinting

Tier 6: Shred Existence or Untouchable While Moving

GM Intrusions: Moving so quickly while sprinting sometimes leads to stumbles on unexpected, exotic obstacles.

6.4.79 Shrinks to Minute Size

You can shrink down to the size of a bug and, with enough experience, even smaller.

Tier 1: Shrink

Tier 1: Beneath Notice

Tier 2: Smaller

Tier 2: Advantages of Being Small

Tier 3: Enlarge or Quick Switch

Tier 4: Small Flight

Tier 5: Shrink Others

Tier 6: Bigger or Tiny

GM Intrusions: A creature thinks the small character is potential food. The small character gets trapped in a tiny space or under a falling object.

A character who Shrinks to Minute Size who chooses to learn abilities like Enlarge will never be quite as big as one who Grows to Towering Heights, but they can enjoy the advantages of being big or small as needed.

6.4.80 Siphons Power

You suck power out of machines and creatures alike in order to empower yourself.

(Robots and other living machines should be treated as creatures, not machines, for the purposes of siphoning power from them.)

Tier 1: Drain Machine

Tier 2: Drain Creature

Tier 3: Drain at a Distance or Unraveling Consumption

Tier 4: Store Energy

Tier 5: Share the Power

Tier 6: Explosive Release or Sun Siphon

GM Intrusions: Drained power also transmits something unwanted—compulsions, afflictions, or alien thoughts. Siphoned power can overload the character, causing feedback.

6.4.81 Slays Monsters

You kill monsters.

(Although wielding a sword in a setting where people usually do not carry such weapons is fine, you can change the Slays Monsters sword-related abilities to use a different weapon, such as a gun with silver bullets.)

Tier 1: Practiced With Swords

Tier 1: Monster Bane

Tier 1: Monster Lore

Tier 2: Will of Legend

Tier 3: Trained Slayer

Tier 3: Improved Monster Bane or Misdirect

Tier 4: Fight On

Tier 5: Greater Skill With Attacks (swords)

Tier 6: Murderer or Heroic Monster Bane

GM Intrusions: The monster laid a trap or set an ambush. The monster has previously undisclosed abilities. The monster's mother vows revenge.

6.4.82 Soars on Amazing Wings

Many superheroes can fly, and some even have wings. You can use your wings for movement, attacks, and defense.

Tier 1: Hover

Tier 1: Flight Exertion

Tier 2: Wing Weapons

Tier 3: Acrobatic Attack or Flying Companion

Tier 4: Hard to Hit

Tier 5: Up to Speed

Tier 6: Hard Target or Defense Master

GM Intrusions: A wing gets hurt or restrained, causing the character to fall. Flying high makes the character an obvious target for an unexpected foe.

6.4.83 Solves Mysteries

You're a master of deduction, using evidence to find the answer.

Tier 1: Investigator

Tier 1: Sleuth

Tier 2: Out of Harm's Way

Tier 3: You Studied or Skill With Attacks

Tier 4: Draw Conclusion

Tier 5: Defuse Situation

Tier 6: Seize the Initiative or Greater Skill With Defense

GM Intrusions: Evidence disappears, red herrings confuse, and witnesses lie. Initial research can be faulty.

6.4.84 Speaks for the Land

Your spiritual connection to nature and the environment grants you mystical abilities.

Tier 1: Seeds of Fury

Tier 1: Wilderness Lore

Tier 2: Grasping Foliage

Tier 3: Soothe the Savage or Communication

Tier 4: Moon Shape

Tier 5: Insect Eruption

Tier 6: Call the Storm or Earthquake

GM Intrusions: An injured natural (but dangerous) creature is discovered. Someone's poaching wildlife for their skins, leaving the carcasses to rot. A tree falls in the forest, one of the last elder trees.

6.4.85 Stands Like a Bastion

Your armor, along with your size, strength, incredible training, or machine enhancement, makes you difficult to move or hurt.

(Some characters who Stand Like a Bastion might already be experts in armor. They can choose a different tier 1 ability instead of Practiced in Armor.)

Tier 1: Practiced in Armor

Tier 1: Experienced Defender

Tier 2: Resist the Elements

Tier 3: Unmovable

Tier 3: Greater Enhanced Might or Practiced With All Weapons

Tier 4: Living Wall

Tier 5: Hardiness

Tier 5: Mastery in Armor

Tier 6: Lethal Damage or Shield Training

GM Intrusions: Armor is damaged. Small foes conspire in ingenious ways.

6.4.86 Stretches

Your body is elastic and rubbery, able to stretch to great lengths and compress when struck.

Tier 1: Contortionist

Tier 1: Far Step

Tier 2: Elastic Grip

Tier 2: Safe Fall

Tier 3: Bypass Barrier or Misdirect

Tier 4: Resilience

Tier 5: Free to Move

Tier 6: Break the Ranks or Not Dead Yet

GM Intrusions: An attack or effect interferes with the character's elasticity. A stretched limb becomes overstressed and weak.

6.4.87 Takes Animal Shape

You can transform yourself into an animal.

Tier 1: Animal Shape

Tier 2: Communication

Tier 2: Soothe the Savage

Tier 3: Bigger Animal Shape or Greater Beast Form

Tier 4: Animal Scrying

Tier 5: Hard to Kill

Tier 6: Blurring Speed or Lend Animal Shape

GM Intrusions: The character unexpectedly changes form. An NPC is frightened by or aggressive toward the shapeshifter. The transformation takes longer than expected.

Greater Beast Form applies to using Animal Shape.

6.4.88 Talks to Machines

You use your organic brain like a computer, interfacing "wirelessly" with any electronic device. You can control and influence them in ways that others can't.

Tier 1: Machine Affinity

Tier 1: Distant Interface

Tier 2: Coaxing Power

Tier 2: Charm Machine

Tier 3: Intelligent Interface or Command Machine

Tier 4: Machine Companion

Tier 4: Robot Fighter

Tier 5: Information Gathering

Tier 6: Control Machine or Improved Machine Companion

GM Intrusions: The machine malfunctions or acts unpredictably.

6.4.89 Throws With Deadly Accuracy

Everything that leaves your hand goes exactly where you'd like it to go and at the range and speed to make the perfect impact.

Tier 1: Precision

Tier 2: Careful Aim

Tier 3: Quick Throw or Skill With Defense

Tier 4: Everything Is a Weapon

Tier 4: Specialized Throwing

Tier 5: Whirlwind of Throws

Tier 6: Lethal Damage or Mastery With Defense

GM Intrusions: Missed attacks strike the wrong target. Ricochets can be dangerous. Improvised weapons break.

6.4.90 Thunders

You emit destructive sound and manipulate soundscapes.

Tier 1: Thunder Beam

Tier 2: Sound Conversion Barrier

Tier 3: Nullify Sound or Echolocation

Tier 4: Shattering Shout

Tier 5: Subsonic Rumble

Tier 5: Amplify Sounds

Tier 6: Earthquake or Lethal Vibration

GM Intrusions: Loud noises attract attention.

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6.4.91 Touches The Sky

You can summon storms or break them apart.

Tier 1: Hover

Tier 2: Wind Armor

Tier 3: Bolts of Power or Storm Seed

Tier 4: Windrider

Tier 5: Cold Burst

Tier 6: Control Weather or Wind Chariot

GM Intrusions: An ally is accidentally struck by a fork of lightning. An unexpected grounding effect inflicts damage. The weather is seeded by a much smaller effect, and a storm grows out of control.

6.4.92 Travels Through Time

You can see through time, try to reach through it, and eventually even travel through it.

(Although all character choices are subject to GM approval, Travels Through Time is a focus that the GM and player should probably have a long conversation about ahead of time, so the player knows the rules of time travel (if any) that exist in the GM's setting. A character with this focus can drastically alter a setting, if the rules of time travel allow it.)

Tier 1: Anticipation

Tier 2: See History

Tier 3: Temporal Acceleration or Time Loop

Tier 4: Temporal Dislocation

Tier 5: Time Doppelganger

Tier 6: Call Through Time or Time Travel

GM Intrusions: Paradoxes are created. Others remember past events differently.

6.4.93 Was Foretold

You are the “chosen one,” and prophecy, prediction, prognostication, or some other method of determination expects great things of you one day.

Tier 1: Interaction Skills

Tier 1: Knowing

Tier 2: Destined for Greatness

Tier 3: Overcome All Obstacles or Hard-Won Resilience

Tier 4: Center of Attention

Tier 5: Show Them the Way

Tier 6: As Foretold in Prophecy or Greater Enhanced Potential

GM Intrusions: An enemy described in prophecy appears. Unbelievers threaten to ruin the moment. The character gains a reputation in outside circles as a fraud.

6.4.94 Wears a Sheen of Ice

You command the wintery power of cold and ice.

Tier 1: Ice Armor

Tier 2: Frost Touch

Tier 3: Freezing Touch or Ice Creation

Tier 4: Resilient Ice Armor

Tier 5: Cold Burst

Tier 6: Ice Storm or Winter Gauntlets

GM Intrusions: Ice makes surfaces slippery. Extreme cold causes objects to crack and break.

6.4.95 Wears Power Armor

Tier 1: Powered Armor

Tier 1: Enhanced Might

Tier 2: Heads-Up Display

Tier 3: Fusion Armor or Incredible Health

Tier 4: Force Blast

Tier 5: Field-Reinforced Armor

Tier 6: Masterful Armor Modification (Jet Assisted Flight) or Masterful Armor Modification (Cypher Pod)

GM Intrusions: The armor won't come off. The armor acts under its own power. The armor suffers a momentary power loss. NPCs are scared by the power armor.

6.4.96 Wields Invisible Force

You bend light and manipulate beams of force for offense and defense.

Tier 1: Vanish

Tier 2: Entangling Force

Tier 2: Sharp Senses

Tier 3: Force Field Barrier or Multi-Vanish

Tier 4: Invisibility

Tier 5: Defensive Field

Tier 6: Concussion or Generate Force Field

GM Intrusions: Invisibility partially fades, revealing the character's presence. A force field is pierced by an unusual or unexpected attack.

6.4.97 Wields Two Weapons at Once

You bear steel with both hands, ready to take on any foe.

Tier 1: Dual Light Wield

Tier 2: Double Strike

Tier 2: Infiltrator

Tier 3: Dual Medium Wield or Precise Cut

Tier 4: Dual Defense

Tier 5: Dual Distraction

Tier 6: Disarming Attack or Spin Attack

GM Intrusions: A blade snaps in two or a weapon flies loose from its bearer's grip.

6.4.98 Works for a Living

You take great satisfaction in a job well done, whether it's coding, building houses, or mining asteroids.

Tier 1: Handy

Tier 2: Muscles of Iron

Tier 3: Eye for Detail or Improvise

Tier 4: Enhanced Might

Tier 4: Tough It Out

Tier 5: Expert Skill

Tier 6: Greater Enhanced Potential or Hard-Won Resilience

GM Intrusions: Repairs sometimes fail. Wiring can be tricky to decipher and still carry an electrical charge. Some people are rude to those who work for a living.

6.4.99 Works Miracles

You can heal others with a touch, alter time to help others, and are generally beloved by everyone.

Tier 1: Healing Touch

Tier 2: Alleviate

Tier 3: Font of Healing or Miraculous Health

Tier 4: Inspire Action

Tier 5: Undo

Tier 6: Greater Healing Touch or Restore Life

GM Intrusions: Attempts to heal might cause harm instead. A community or individual needs a healer so desperately that they hold one against their will.

6.4.100 Works the Back Alleys

You make your way unseen, stealing from the wealthy to achieve your ends.

Tier 1: Stealth Skills

Tier 2: Underworld Contacts

Tier 3: Pull a Fast One or Guild Training

Tier 4: Master Thief

Tier 5: Dirty Fighter

Tier 6: Alley Rat or All-Out Con

GM Intrusions: Thieves are thrown in jail. Powerful enemies are made.

6.4.101 Works the System

You can exploit flaws in artificial systems, including but not limited to computer code.

- Tier 1: Hack the Impossible
- Tier 1: Computer Programming
- Tier 2: Connected
- Tier 3: Confidence Artist or Skill With Attacks
- Tier 4: Confuse Enemy
- Tier 5: Work the Friendship
- Tier 6: Call in Favor or Greater Enhanced Potential
- GM Intrusions: Contacts sometimes have ulterior motives. Devices sometimes have failsafes or even traps.

6.4.102 Would Rather Be Reading

Books are your friends. What's more important than knowledge? Nothing.

- Tier 1: Knowledge Is Power
- Tier 2: Greater Enhanced Intellect
- Tier 3: Applying Your Knowledge or Flex Skill
- Tier 4: Knowledge Is Power
- Tier 4: Knowing the Unknown
- Tier 5: Greater Enhanced Intellect
- Tier 6: Knowledge Is Power
- Tier 6: Tower of Intellect or Read the Signs
- GM Intrusions: Books burn, get wet, or get lost. Computers break or lose power. Glasses break.

6.4.103 Uses Wild Magic

spellcaster who learns a variety of spells instead of focusing on just one kind of magic.

- Tier 1: Magical Repertoire
- Tier 1: Cypher Casting
- Tier 2: Expanded Repertoire
- Tier 3: Cypher Surge or Faster Wild Magic
- Tier 4: Expanded Repertoire
- Tier 5: Magical Training
- Tier 6: Maximize Cypher or Wild Insight
- GM Intrusions: A spell performs erratically or rebounds upon the caster. Something interferes with preparing spells. Spellcasting attracts the attention of a powerful creature or potential rival. The cypher spell being cast is replaced with that of a random cypher.

6.4.104 Walks the Wild Woods

An adherent of nature magic who draws on the power and strength of trees.

- Tier 1: Wilderness Life
- Tier 1: Patient Recovery
- Tier 2: Wooden Body
- Tier 3: Tree Companion or Wilderness Awareness
- Tier 4: Tree Travel
- Tier 5: Great Tree
- Tier 6: Dreadwood or Restorative Bloom
- GM Intrusions: A wooden character catches fire. A wild swing from a tree branch hits or trips an ally. Some trees have evil hearts and hate all walking things.

6.4.105 Wields an Enchanted Weapon

One who channels magic through or from a weapon to create a unique fighting style.

- Tier 1: Enchanted Weapon
- Tier 1: Innate Power
- Tier 1: Charge Weapon
- Tier 2: Power Crash
- Tier 3: Rapid Attack or Throw Enchanted Weapon
- Tier 4: Defending Weapon
- Tier 5: Enchanted Movement
- Tier 6: Deadly Strike or Spin Attack
- GM Intrusions: A weapon breaks or is dropped. The weapon loses its connection to you until you use an action to reestablish the attunement. The weapon's energy discharges in an unexpected way.

6.5 Creating New Foci

This section provides everything you need to create your own foci.

Every focus has an overarching style, whether that's exploration, energy manipulation, or simply dealing a lot of damage in combat. These broad classifications are called focus categories.

Each focus category has an overarching theme, followed by selection guidelines that describe how to choose abilities for each tier from the Abilities chapter, from tier 1 to tier 6.

The newly created focus should be named in the form of a verb, like Controls Beasts or Abides in Stone. For instance, a fire-using focus created by following the guidelines in the energy manipulation focus category might be called Bears a Halo of Fire (one of the sample foci in this chapter). Alternatively, a new fire-using focus should get an all-new name like Stokes the Flames of the Apocalypse or Lights Fires With a Thought.

6.5.1 Focus Categories

- Ally use
- Basic
- Energy manipulation
- Environment manipulation
- Exploration
- Influence
- Irregular
- Movement expertise
- Striker combat
- Support
- Tank combat

6.5.2 Choosing Abilities By Relative Power

The ability selection guidelines invite you to choose an ability from one of three ranges: low tier, mid tier, and high tier. These ranges correspond with the power “grades” given for every ability. These abilities are further sorted into ability categories based on the kinds of things they do—abilities that improve physical attacks are in the attack skill category, abilities that assist allies are in the support category, and so on. Look for the grades and categories in the Ability Categories and Relative Power section of the Abilities chapter.

Low-tier abilities are best suited for focus options at tiers 1 and 2. Mid-tier abilities are best suited for focus options at tiers 3 and 4. High-tier abilities are best suited for focus options at tiers 5 and 6.

That said, sometimes you’ll find it appropriate to assign a low-tier ability at tier 3 or 4, or maybe a mid-tier ability at tier 1 or 2. Do so sparingly, but don’t rule it out. It might be the only way to get all the abilities you want for the focus you’re building. Higher-tier abilities usually cost more Pool points to use. So if a mid-tier ability is made available at tier 1 or 2, or a high-tier ability is made available at tier 3 or 4, the higher cost will be a balancing factor.

6.5.3 Balancing Activities

The guidelines within each category go a long way toward ensuring that the focus you build will be balanced. Sometimes it might be appropriate to grant a low-power ability along with a regular ability at a given tier, depending on the needs of the focus. A “low-power ability” is deliberately open for GM interpretation, but generally speaking, should be no more potent than a low-tier ability (that is, an ability that is normally available at tier 1 or 2).

For instance, someone who uses cold might be able to create small snow sculptures in addition to emitting a cold ray. Someone who uses electricity might be able to charge a depleted artifact or have an asset for dealing with electrical systems. And so on.

Often, the focus guidelines note this as a possibility. However, you have great leeway in deciding if a focus needs an additional ability, even if the guidelines for that tier don’t indicate one. If you do add an ability, or there is a higher-power ability at a tier that normally shouldn’t have it, it might mean that the choice given at the next tier, or the previous tier, isn’t quite as good. Balancing a focus is a bit of an art. Resist the urge to overpower the focus, but don’t underpower it, either.

6.5.4 Ability Guidelines are not Prescriptive

Each focus category provides a guideline for what kind of ability you should select at every tier. But don’t regard the guidelines as something that you can’t vary. They’re not prescriptive; they’re just a place to start. You might want to vary the kind of ability at a particular tier that isn’t indicated in the guidelines. As long as the chosen ability falls within the expected power curve for that tier, it’s fine. The guideline isn’t meant to be a straitjacket.

For example, if you’re building a cold-using focus for a game set in a fantasy genre, you may decide that an ability that calls up a demon is a better choice at a particular tier than an ability that does damage in an area, which is what the tier 5 guideline for energy manipulation calls for. Making the change is probably especially valid if you call your new focus something like Channels the Ninth Circle.

6.5.5 Ability Swap

If you’re creating a focus and you think it should provide a suite of abilities at first tier that would mechanically overload it, you have the option to add one as a “swap” ability. Doing so is as easy as allowing a character to swap out one of their type abilities for an indicated low-tier focus ability. The ability is gained instead of one of the abilities normally granted by the character’s type.

6.5.6 Concept and Category

Choosing to create a focus that uses a particular concept—say, creating illusions—doesn’t lock you into creating a focus within a particular category—in this case, environment manipulation. A focus can be constructed in a variety of ways using a particular energy, tool, or concept, each ultimately leading to a focus that provides different results. It all depends on your ends. In this case, creating illusions might be used to sway others, which argues for a focus built using the influence category guidelines.

In the same way, if a focus grants a character the ability to call some kind of force or energy, that doesn’t mean the focus should automatically be built using the energy manipulation category guidelines (though of course it could, if attacking and protecting yourself with that energy is the point). But a focus could be built that grants abilities to call energy or force that is primarily focused on durability, suggesting a tank combat focus (someone who can take a lot of punishment in a fight); or blasting away with a main concern for maximizing damage, thus suggesting a striker combat focus; or creating a follower composed of that energy or force, suggesting an ally use focus (that is, someone who uses helping creatures, NPCs, or even duplicate versions of themselves to give them a leg up).

Here’s another example: the focus Controls Gravity could conceivably be an environment manipulation focus or an energy manipulation focus. It depends on whether the focus is more concerned with crushing and holding things in place (environment manipulation) or on blasting things and protecting yourself with gravity (energy manipulation).

The same malleability of concept holds true in other realms. For instance, if someone is able to call up and mold raw earth, they might use it to transform themselves into a being of stone (tank combat), to batter foes (striker combat), or to create walls, barricades, and shields to protect their allies (support).

If you’re looking for an ability and can’t seem to find the right one in the vast catalog in the Abilities chapter, consider reskinning one to make it seem new (and to accomplish what you need). Reskinning means that you use the underlying mechanics of an ability as written but change the flavor in some fashion. For instance, maybe you’re creating a new earth-moving focus but can’t find enough earth-related abilities to meet your need. It’s easy enough to change up other abilities so they use earth instead of fire, cold, or magnetism. For instance, Wings of Fire might become Wings of Earth, Ice Armor could become Earth Armor, and so on. These alterations change nothing except the type of damage and any knock-on effects (for instance, Wings of Earth might generate clouds of dust in their wake).

6.5.7 Abilities That Reference Other Abilities

Some abilities in the Abilities chapter reference other abilities. If you select an ability for your focus or type that refers to or modifies a lower-tier ability, also include that lower-tier ability

in your type or focus as a selection a PC can make at a lower tier.

6.5.8 Creating Brand-New Abilities

You can go further than reskinning and create one or more brand-new abilities. When doing this, try to find something as close as possible to the effect you want, then use it as a template. In any case, deciding how much an ability should cost when it comes to a character's Pool is one of the most important aspects of getting an ability right.

You may notice that higher-tier abilities are more expensive. This is partly because they do more, but it's also because higher-tier characters have more Edge than lower-tier characters, which means they pay fewer points from their relevant Pools. A third-tier character with 3 Edge in a relevant Pool pays no cost for abilities that cost 3 or fewer points. That's great for lower-tier abilities, but you'll usually want a character to think a little bit about how often to use their most powerful abilities. That means they should cost at least 1 point more than the Edge the character is likely to have at that tier. (Often, a character will have an Edge in their relevant Pool equal to their tier.)

As a good rule of thumb, a typical ability should cost points equal to its tier.

6.5.9 Choose GM Intrusions

Think about the kinds of things that might surprise, alarm, or go catastrophically wrong for someone with the new focus being created, and assign it as a GM intrusion for that focus. Of course, this often is done on the fly during the game. But giving the topic some thought while the focus is being constructed and the ideas are fresh in your head is likely to yield some particularly devilish options.

6.5.10 Focus Categories

Ally Use

Foci that prioritize providing NPC followers to the character are ally use foci. The followers give aid to the PC in a variety of ways, but at base they usually provide an asset to the character's actions.

Multiple potential themes exist within the ally use category, from abilities that allow a character to summon or craft allies to those that allow them to attract allies through fame, magic, or essential authority or charisma.

Connection: Choose four relevant connections from the Focus Connections list.

Additional Equipment: Any object necessary for the character to keep an ally. For instance, someone with a focus that uses super-science to create robot allies would require tools to build and repair those allies. Some foci in this category don't require anything to gain or retain their benefits.

Minor Effect Suggestions: The NPC ally's tasks are eased on its next turn.

Major Effect Suggestions: The NPC ally gains an immediate extra action.

The following are examples and not meant to provide a complete list of all possible foci in this category.

- Builds Robots
- Consorts With the Dead

- Controls Beasts
- Exists in Two Places at Once
- Leads
- Masters the Swarm
- Shepherds Spirits

Ability Selection Guidelines

Tier 1: Choose a low-tier ability that grants a level 2 NPC follower to the character, or gives a similar benefit provided by an NPC. Alternatively, lay the groundwork for gaining such NPC allies at higher tiers by choosing an ability that gives the character influence over others.

Sometimes an additional low-power ability is appropriate, depending on the focus. Often, this is an ability that grants skill training in a related area of knowledge or a related skill. For instance, training in a skill related to the kind of NPC follower the character gains would be appropriate.

Tier 2: Choose a low-tier ability that grants influence over similar kinds of NPCs as the follower gained at the previous tier. If no follower was gained at the previous tier, this ability should provide that benefit now.

Sometimes a secondary ability might be appropriate in addition to the ability provided above, perhaps a low-power ability that grants 2 or 3 points to a Pool.

Tier 3: Choose two mid-tier abilities. Give both of them as options for the focus; a PC will choose one or the other.

One option should be a mid-tier ability that improves the NPC follower previously provided (usually from level 2 to level 3) or grants an additional follower.

The other option should be something that benefits the character—perhaps an offensive or defensive ability, or something that broadens their influence over their followers (or potential followers).

Tier 4: Choose a mid-tier ability that gives the character an offensive or defensive capability if they haven't previously gained one, preferably within the theme of the focus. For instance, if the character gains followers because of their charisma, this ability might let them command foes for brief periods. If the character gains followers by building or calling them, this ability might let them affect entities of the same type that are not already their followers.

Alternatively, this ability might further improve a previously gained follower from level 3 to level 4, or grant an additional follower.

Tier 5: Choose an ability that improves the character by providing a defense, an improved stat Pool, or another kind of protection.

Alternatively, this ability could open a new front in influencing and calling NPC allies related to the focus's theme. For instance, someone who keeps beast allies might gain an ability to call a horde of lesser beasts. Someone who builds robots might gain an ability to build several lesser robot helpers. And so on.

Finally, this ability might improve a previously gained follower to level 5.

Tier 6: Choose two high-tier abilities. Give both of them as options for the focus; a PC will choose one or the other.

One of the abilities should improve a previously gained follower to level 5, if that wasn't already provided at tier 5. If that's the case, this ability might be provided in addition to two other related abilities.

Another high-tier option could provide a handful of level 3 followers to the character.

The last high-tier ability could open a new front in influencing and calling NPC allies related to the focus's theme. For instance, someone who gains followers through high charisma and training might gain an ability to learn otherwise impossible-to-glean information.

Basic

Foci that rely mostly on providing skill training, assets to tasks, and bumps to stat Pools and Edge in order to improve a character fall within the basic category. An overarching theme is also included, as with most of the other categories, that makes sense of the various basic abilities provided.

In addition, because the benefits provided by such foci are mostly straightforward (usually with a few exceptions), most basic foci would also be appropriate for non-fantastic campaigns where magic, super-science, or psychic abilities normally don't come into play. That said, just because the abilities granted by basic foci are straightforward doesn't mean they are not potent when combined with the abilities granted by type, descriptor, cyphers, and other character aspects.

Connection: Choose four relevant connections from the Focus Connections list.

Additional Equipment: Any object necessary to fulfill the overarching theme of the focus. For instance, a focus called Would Rather Be Reading should grant a handful of books to the character. A focus called Works for a Living should provide a set of tools.

Minor Effect Suggestions: Next action is eased.

Major Effect Suggestions: Make a free, no-action recovery roll that doesn't count against daily recovery rolls.

The following are examples and not meant to provide a complete list of all possible foci in this category.

- Doesn't Do Much
- Interprets the Law
- Learns Quickly
- Works for a Living
- Would Rather Be Reading

Ability Selection Guidelines

Tier 1: Choose an ability that grants training or an asset to skills associated with the focus's theme, or that grants 5 or 6 points to a particular Pool.

Alternatively, choose an ability that grants only 2 or 3 points to a particular Pool and an ability that provides training or an asset to just one task.

Tier 2: Choose whichever kind of ability wasn't chosen at tier 1.

Tier 3: Choose two mid-tier abilities. Give both of them as options for the focus; a PC will choose one or the other.

One option should be a non-fantastic ability that improves the character's abilities within the focus's theme. For instance, if the theme involves paying attention in some fashion, an information-gathering ability might be appropriate.

The other option should be something that either improves the character's Edge in an appropriate stat or provides the character with some kind of defense.

Tier 4: Choose another ability that grants additional training or an asset to skills associated with the focus's theme, or that grants 5 or 6 points to a particular Pool best suited to the focus. Or choose two abilities that provide only 2 or 3 points plus another tier 4 ability that improves a single task or skill.

Alternatively, provide a branch-out ability suggested at tier 5.

Finally, if the focus has yet to grant some kind of defense, a defensive ability could be provided here.

Tier 5: Choose an ability that allows the character to branch out slightly—perhaps one like Expert Skill that allows them to automatically succeed on a task they're trained in.

Alternatively, if a nonstandard benefit was provided at tier 4, provide the benefits suggested at tier 4 here.

Tier 6: Choose two high-tier abilities. Give both of them as options for the focus; a PC will choose one or the other.

One option should be an ability that provides another 5 or 6 points to a particular Pool best suited to the focus, or that the character can divide up as they wish. Alternatively, training in offense or defense would also be appropriate.

The other tier 6 option should give the character a brand-new ability within their theme, but not one that strays into the realm of the fantastic. For instance, an ability that allows a character to take two actions instead of one would be reasonable. Granting additional training, assets, or Edge would also be fine.

Energy Manipulation

Energy manipulation foci offer abilities that can call fire, electricity, force, magnetism, or nonstandard forms of energy such as cold, stone, or something stranger like "void" or "shadow." These abilities usually give a character a way to achieve something of a balance between attacking enemies and granting themselves or allies additional protection. The focus usually also offers abilities that provide other ways to use specific energy for things like transportation, creating large concentrations of energy that can affect multiple targets, or creating a temporary object or barrier of energy.

Connection: Choose four relevant connections from the Focus Connections list.

Additional Equipment: One or more pieces of equipment immune to the energy manipulated, which might be a set of clothes. Alternatively, something related to the energy being generated. Some foci in this category don't require additional equipment.

Energy Abilities: If a character type grants special abilities that normally use some other kind of energy, they now produce the kind used by this focus. For example, if a character uses this focus to manipulate electricity, their force blasts become blasts of electricity. These alterations change nothing except the type of damage and any knock-on effects (for instance, electricity might temporarily short out electronic systems).

Minor Effect Suggestions: The target or something near the target is hindered because of residual energy.

Major Effect Suggestions: An important item on the target's person is destroyed.

The following are examples and not meant to provide a complete list of all possible foci in this category.

- Absorbs Energy
- Bears a Halo of Fire

- Dances With Dark Matter
- Rides the Lightning
- Thunders
- Wears a Sheen of Ice

Ability Selection Guidelines

Tier 1: Choose a low-tier ability that either inflicts damage or provides protection using the appropriate energy type in some fashion.

Sometimes an additional low-power ability is appropriate, depending on the energy type. For instance, a focus that manipulates cold might grant an ability to create snow sculptures. A focus that manipulates electricity might grant an ability to charge a depleted artifact or have an asset for dealing with electrical systems. A focus that absorbs energy might grant an ability to release it as a basic attack. And so on.

Tier 2: Choose whichever kind of ability wasn't chosen at tier 1.

Tier 3: Choose two mid-tier abilities. Give both of them as options for the focus; a PC will choose one or the other.

One option should be an ability that inflicts damage using the appropriate energy type (and possibly a related effect).

The other should grant enhanced movement by use of the appropriate energy type, give additional protection provided by the preferred energy, or use the energy in a completely new way, such as by draining the energy from a machine (if using electricity), entombing a victim in a layer of ice (if using cold), creating perfect silence (if using sound), creating a dazzling blast of illumination (if using light), and so on.

Tier 4: Choose whichever kind of ability wasn't chosen at tier 3.

Tier 5: Choose a high-tier ability that inflicts damage (and possibly a related effect) that can affect more than one target using the appropriate energy type, or an ability that uses the energy in some fashion not previously used, as described in tiers 3 and 6.

Tier 6: Choose two high-tier abilities. Give both of them as options for the focus; a PC will choose one or the other.

One of the high-tier abilities should use the preferred energy to inflict a lot of damage to a single target or to several.

The other option should use the appropriate energy type to accomplish a task not previously provided by lower-tier abilities, such as fashioning a fiery follower (if using fire), teleporting a great distance as a blast of lightning (if using electricity), creating solid objects out of the energy, and so on.

Environment Manipulation

Foci that allow a character to move objects, affect gravity, create objects (or illusions of objects), and so on are environment manipulation foci. Given that, in many cases, energy is used as part of this process, this category and energy manipulation overlap to some extent. Environment manipulation foci prioritize abilities that indirectly affect enemies and allies via objects, forces, and alterations of the surroundings; energy manipulation foci prioritize directly damaging targets with the chosen energy or force.

For example, rather than blasting a foe with a gravity pulse that does damage, a character using an environment manipulation focus based on gravity is more likely to have abilities that hold a target in place, use gravity to throw heavy objects as an

attack, or lower gravity in a particular area or even on a particular object.

Connection: Choose four relevant connections from the Focus Connections list.

Additional Equipment: Any object necessary to manipulate the surrounding environment. For instance, someone with a focus that grants the ability to craft objects would require basic tools. Some foci in this category don't require anything to gain or retain their benefits.

Environment Manipulation Abilities: Foci themes that involve imagery or visible energies can affect the look of your type abilities. Such alterations, if any, do nothing but change the appearance of effects. If gravity is manipulated, perhaps a telltale bluish glow permeates all ability uses, including type abilities. If illusion is generated, perhaps flamboyant visual and auditory qualities accompany type abilities, such as the appearance of a tentacled beast holding a target in place when Stasis is used. And so on.

Minor Effect Suggestions: The target gets turned around, and its next attack is hindered.

Major Effect Suggestions: The character is refreshed and recovers 4 points to one Pool.

The following are examples and not meant to provide a complete list of all possible foci in this category.

- Awakens Dreams
- Blazes With Radiance
- Calculates the Incalculable
- Controls Gravity
- Crafts Illusions
- Crafts Unique Objects
- Employs Magnetism
- Focuses Mind Over Matter

Ability Selection Guidelines

Tier 1: Choose a low-tier ability that grants a basic use of an ability that alters the environment (or predicts it) using the focus's theme. For instance, a gravity-affecting focus might provide an ability that makes a target lighter or heavier. An illusion-crafting focus might grant an ability that allows the creation of an image. An object-making focus might grant a basic proficiency in creating a particular kind of object. A predictive focus might calculate outcomes and provide the character with the benefits of that foreknowledge. And so on.

Sometimes an additional low-power ability is appropriate, depending on the focus. Often, this is an ability that grants skill training in a related area of knowledge.

Tier 2: Choose a low-tier ability that provides a new defensive or offensive capability related to the focus's theme.

Alternatively, this ability might provide an additional or brand-new capability to manipulate the environment related to the focus's theme.

Tier 3: Choose two mid-tier abilities. Give both of them as options for the focus; a PC will choose one or the other.

One option should be a mid-tier ability related to the focus's theme that provides an additional environment manipulation capacity or further improves the basic environment manipulation ability previously granted. This ability isn't directly offensive or defensive, but provides either an all-new ability related to the basic ability, or one that increases the strength, range, or some other extension of the previously unlocked basic ability.

The other mid-tier option should provide an offensive or defensive ability related to the specific form of movement the focus provides, if possible.

Tier 4: Choose a mid-tier ability that is either an offensive or a defensive use of the ability, whichever one wasn't chosen as an option in the previous tier.

Tier 5: Choose a high-tier penultimate use of the environment-manipulation ability. For instance, if the focus-granted manipulation is illusory, this ability might haunt a target with terrifying images. If the focus is gravity based, it might unlock flight. If magnetic, it might allow the user to reshape metal. If the focus grants telekinetic powers, this ability could allow a character to hurl massive objects at foes. And so on.

Tier 6: Choose two high-tier abilities. Give both of them as options for the focus; a PC will choose one or the other.

One of the abilities should provide either an offensive or a defensive ability, opposite the ability provided at tier 4 (though high tier rather than mid tier).

The other option should be something that further explores the use of the basic environment manipulation capability. If the tier 5 choice was the penultimate ability, this might be an even better ultimate ability related to the kind of manipulation offered, or a different way of using that ability to unlock an as-yet-unexplored facet of the ability.

Exploration

Foci that allow a character to gather information, survive in unfamiliar environments, and find their way to new locations or track down particular creatures and foes are exploration foci. Surviving in unfamiliar environments requires a reasonable selection of defensive options; however, abilities that allow a character to find and learn are prioritized.

Exploration foci rely on a variety of methods, though training and expertise are the mainstays. Some methods require specific tools (such as a vehicle) to grant the benefits provided, while others might rely on the supernatural or super-science to learn new things and explore strange places from afar.

Connection: Choose four relevant connections from the Focus Connections list.

Additional Equipment: Any object necessary to explore. For instance, starting maps and/or a compass would be basic equipment, while someone who uses psychic abilities might require a mirror or crystal sphere to gaze into. Equipment might also include access to a vehicle required for exploration, as previously noted.

Minor Effect Suggestions: You have an asset on any action that involves using your senses, such as perceiving or attacking, until the end of the next round.

Major Effect Suggestions: Your Intellect Edge increases by 1 until the end of the next round.

The following are examples and not meant to provide a complete list of all possible foci in this category.

- Explores Dark Places
- Infiltrates
- Operates Undercover
- Pilots Starcraft
- Sees Beyond
- Separates Mind From Body

Ability Selection Guidelines

Tier 1: Choose a low-tier ability that grants the character basic exploratory, survival, or information-gathering capabilities within the focus's theme.

Sometimes an additional low-power ability is appropriate, depending on the focus. Often, this is an ability that grants skill training in a related area of knowledge or a related skill (though this may already be covered in the main ability). Alternatively, it might offer a simple bonus of 2 or 3 points to the Might Pool.

Tier 2: Choose another low-tier ability that grants an additional capability related to exploration, survival, or information gathering.

For instance, a focus dedicated to surviving savage conditions might offer an ability (or two) that makes it easier to avoid natural hazards, poisons, difficult terrain, and so on. A focus dedicated to exploration of a particular area might grant abilities to gain access to that area, or a capability that others normally lack (like the ability to see in the dark).

Tier 3: Choose two mid-tier abilities. Give both of them as options for the focus; a PC will choose one or the other.

One option should further improve the basic exploration ability granted, or give a new exploratory, survival, or information-gathering ability.

The other option should be something that benefits the character, either an offensive or defensive ability (especially if this focus hasn't already granted that) or something that further broadens the character's ability to explore in the focus's chosen realm.

Tier 4: Choose a mid-tier offensive or defensive ability (whichever wasn't offered at tier 3) that benefits the character. Alternatively, if offensive and defensive abilities are already well represented, choose a different mid-tier ability that broadens the character's ability to explore, survive, or gather information.

Tier 5: Choose a high-tier ability that alleviates some of the penalties for exploring, surviving, or gathering information in a normally inhospitable place.

Tier 6: Choose two high-tier abilities. Give both of them as options for the focus; a PC will choose one or the other.

One option should further improve the basic exploration-themed ability previously granted, or give a brand-new exploratory, survival, or information-gathering ability.

The other option should be something that benefits the character, either an offensive or defensive ability, or yet another ability that further broadens their capacity to explore in the focus's chosen realm.

Influence

Foci that prioritize authority and influence—whether that's to make people or machines do as commanded, to help others, or to rise to some other prestigious and significant position—fall within the influence category.

These foci grant influence through training and persuasion, by direct mental manipulation, by using fame to get people's attention and influence their actions, or simply by knowing and learning things that affect later decisions. In this sense, the concept of influence is broad.

Connection: Choose four relevant connections from the Focus Connections list.

Additional Equipment: Any object necessary to achieve the influence suggested should be granted as additional equipment. Some influence foci don't require anything to gain or

retain their benefits.

Minor Effect Suggestions: The range or duration of the influencing ability is doubled.

Major Effect Suggestions: An ally or indicated target can take an additional action.

The following are examples and not meant to provide a complete list of all possible foci in this category.

- Commands Mental Powers
- Conducts Weird Science
- Fuses Mind and Machine
- Is Idolized by Millions
- Solves Mysteries
- Talks to Machines
- Works the System

Ability Selection Guidelines

Tier 1: Choose a low-tier ability that allows the character to learn something significant enough that they can choose a smart course of action (or use that knowledge to persuade or intimidate). How the character learns the information varies by the specifics of the focus. One character might do experiments to learn answers, another might open a telepathic link with others to trade information secretly and quickly, and still another might simply be trained in interaction tasks.

Sometimes an additional low-power ability is appropriate, depending on the focus. Often, this is an ability that grants skill training in a related area of knowledge.

Tier 2: Choose a low-tier ability that improves the character's ability to apply influence. This might open an additional front on the focus's basic theme or simply further enhance the basic ability already provided. For instance, this tier 2 ability could ease influence-related tasks by a few steps, allow a telepath to read the minds of others who have secrets they'd otherwise not reveal, or grant influence over physical objects (either to improve them or to learn more about them). And so on.

Tier 3: Choose two mid-tier abilities. Give both of them as options for the focus; a PC will choose one or the other.

One option should provide an offensive or defensive capability related to the focus's specific kind of influence, if possible. For instance, an inventor might create a serum that gives them increased abilities (which could be used for offense or defense), a telepath might have some method of blasting foes with mental energy, and someone with only the basic skills of debate and influence through fame might have to rely on weapon training or their entourage.

The other mid-tier option should provide an additional ability to influence in the theme of the focus, or further improve the basic influence ability previously granted. This option isn't directly offensive or defensive, but provides either an all-new ability related to the basic ability, or increases the strength, range, or some other extension of the previously unlocked basic ability. For instance, a telepath might have a psychic suggestion ability.

Tier 4: Choose a mid-tier ability that is either an offensive or a defensive use of the influence ability, whichever one wasn't chosen as an option in the previous tier.

Alternatively, this ability could grant an additional capability related to the kind of influence the focus provides.

Tier 5: Choose a high-tier penultimate use of the specific influence ability granted at lower tiers.

Alternatively, choose an ability not previously gained at a lower tier, one that opens a new front on the particular influence capability. For instance, if the focus-granted influence is telepathic, the tier 5 ability might allow a character to see into the future to gain assets for dealing with enemies (and allies).

Tier 6: Choose two high-tier abilities. Give both of them as options for the focus; a PC will choose one or the other.

One of the options should provide either an offensive or a defensive ability, opposite the ability provided at tier 4 (though high tier rather than mid tier).

The other option should be something that further explores the use of the basic influence ability provided by the focus. If the tier 5 choice was the penultimate ability, this might be an even better ultimate ability related to the kind of influence used, or a different way of using that ability to unlock an as-yet-unexplored facet of the ability.

Irregular

Most foci have a basic theme, a "character story" that logically leads to a series of related abilities. However, certain foci themes are so wide that they don't fit into any other category except an irregular one of their own.

Irregular foci provide a basket of disparate abilities. Usually that's because the overarching theme is one that demands variability and access to several different kinds of abilities. Often, these foci are found in genres that suggest additional rule tweaks to leverage their use even further, such as power shifts in the superhero genre and spellcasting in the fantasy genre. However, other irregular foci are possible.

Connection: Choose four relevant connections from the Focus Connections list.

Additional Equipment: Any object necessary to the focus's theme. For instance, a superhero-themed focus might grant a superhero costume.

Minor Effect Suggestions: The target is also dazed for one round, during which time all of its tasks are hindered.

Major Effect Suggestions: The target is stunned and loses its next turn.

The following are examples and not meant to provide a complete list of all possible foci in this category.

- Channels Divine Blessings
- Descends From Nobility
- Emerged From the Obelisk
- Flies Faster Than a Bullet
- Masters Spells
- Speaks for the Land

Ability Selection Guidelines

Tier 1: Choose a low-tier ability that grants one of the benefits the focus theme promises, one that a first-tier character should have.

Sometimes an additional low-power ability is appropriate, depending on the focus. Often, this is an ability that grants skill training in a related area of knowledge or a related skill. Alternatively, it might offer a simple bonus of 2 or 3 points to a Pool.

Tier 2: Choose a low-tier ability that grants one of the benefits the focus theme promises, one that's presumably not immediately related to the one provided at tier 1. That said, if a defense wasn't provided at tier 1, tier 2 is a good place to add it.

Tier 3: Choose two mid-tier abilities. Give both of them as options for the focus; a PC will choose one or the other.

One option should provide one of the benefits the focus theme promises, one that may not be immediately related to those provided at earlier tiers.

The other option should include a method of attack if none has previously been granted. Alternatively, if the lower-tier abilities don't quite get the character where they need to be, this option might further increase a capability unlocked at a lower tier.

Tier 4: Choose a mid-tier ability that grants one of the benefits the focus theme promises, one that may not be immediately related to those provided at earlier tiers.

Tier 5: Choose a high-tier ability that grants one of the benefits the focus theme promises, one that may not be immediately related to those provided at earlier tiers.

Tier 6: Choose two high-tier abilities. Give both of them as options for the focus; a PC will choose one or the other.

One option should grant one of the benefits the focus theme promises, one that may not be immediately related to those provided at earlier tiers. However, this ability might also provide an ultimate version of a lower-tier ability if a mid-tier or low-tier option wasn't quite sufficient.

The other option should provide an alternate method to round out the character in a way that doesn't replicate the first tier 6 option. For instance, if the first option provided some kind of attack, this one might be an interaction, information-gathering, or healing ability, depending on the focus's overarching theme.

Movement Exercise

Foci that prioritize novel forms of movement—in order to excel in combat, escape situations most others can't, move with stealth for purposes of theft or escape, or move into locations normally inaccessible—fall within the movement expertise category. These foci usually have methods of granting either offense or defense through movement, though they may provide some means of doing both.

The classic movement expertise focus is one that relies on speed to make more attacks and avoid being hit, though general agility might also provide the same benefit. Other foci in this category might fall within the theme by granting a character the ability to become immaterial, to change their form into something like water or air, or to instantly move via teleportation.

Connection: Choose four relevant connections from the Focus Connections list.

Additional Equipment: Any object necessary to achieve great speeds, change state, or otherwise gain the benefit of the focus should be granted as additional equipment. Some foci in this category don't require anything to gain or retain their benefits.

Minor Effect Suggestions: The target is dazed, and their next action is hindered.

Major Effect Suggestions: The target is stunned and loses their next action.

The following are examples and not meant to provide a complete list of all possible foci in this category.

- Exists Partially Out of Phase
- Moves Like a Cat
- Moves Like the Wind
- Runs Away
- Shreds the Walls of the World
- Travels Through Time
- Works the Back Alleys

Ability Selection Guidelines

Tier 1: Choose a low-tier ability that grants the basic benefit of the specific movement style, whether that's enhanced speed, agility, immateriality, and so on.

Sometimes an additional low-power ability is appropriate, depending on the focus. If the basic benefit of the movement demands some kind of additional understanding or training, this ability could be that. Alternatively, if the movement provided seems like it should also unlock a basic offensive or defensive benefit (relying on the use of the initial basic ability), append it as well.

Tier 2: Choose a low-tier ability that provides a new offensive or defensive capability related to the focus's theme.

Alternatively, this ability might provide some additional capability related to the form of movement that grants useful information to the character that would normally be inaccessible to someone without the focus.

Tier 3: Choose two mid-tier abilities. Give both of them as options for the focus; a PC will choose one or the other.

One option should provide an additional movement capacity or further improve the basic movement capacity, related to the focus's theme. This isn't directly offensive or defensive, but provides the character with a new level of ability or an all-new ability related to their basic movement ability.

The other option should provide either an offensive or a defensive capability related to the specific form of movement the focus provides.

Tier 4: Choose a mid-tier ability that further enhances the advantages provided by focus's movement-enhancing paradigm. This could provide a new or better form of defense (directly, or indirectly if moving to a location or time where danger doesn't threaten), or a new or better form of offense.

Tier 5: Choose a high-tier penultimate use of the movement-related ability. For instance, if the focus-provided movement is temporal, this ability might allow actual (if brief) jaunts of time travel. If the focus enhances speed, this ability might allow the character to move up to a very long distance with one action. And so on.

Alternatively, unlock an as-yet-unexplored related ability that could derive from the basic movement power provided by the focus.

Tier 6: Choose two high-tier abilities. Give both of them as options for the focus; a PC will choose one or the other.

One of the options should provide either an offensive or a defensive ability, opposite the ability provided at tier 4 (though high tier rather than mid tier).

The other option should be something that further explores the use of the basic movement ability. If the tier 5 choice was the penultimate ability, this might be an even better ultimate ability related to the movement.

Striker Combat

Striker combat foci prioritize dealing damage in battle over other concerns. Foci in this category offer defensive abilities as well, but they emphasize abilities that provide ways to spike damage to heights that other foci normally don't reach.

To achieve this end, a striker combat focus might offer mastery of a particular style of martial combat, which could be training with a particular weapon or martial art, or the use of a unique tool (or even a kind of energy). A style might be something as singular as being the best at fighting a particular kind of enemy, or something much broader, such as adopting a particularly vicious or unsporting style. A striker combatant might use fire, force, or magnetism as their preferred method of spiking damage.

Connection: Choose four relevant connections from the Focus Connections list.

Additional Equipment: The weapon, tool, or other special item or substance (if any) required to engage in the particular style of combat. For instance, a dose of level 5 poison for Fights Dirty or Murders, a trophy from a previously defeated foe for Battles Robots, or stylish clothes for Fights With Panache.

Minor Effect Suggestions: The target is so dazzled by your expertise that it is dazed for one round, hindering all of its tasks.

Major Effect Suggestions: Make an immediate additional attack using an attack provided by the focus as part of your turn.

The following are examples and not meant to provide a complete list of all possible foci in this category.

- Battles Robots
- Fights Dirty
- Fights With Panache
- Hunts
- Is Licensed to Carry
- Looks for Trouble
- Masters Weaponry
- Murders
- Needs No Weapon
- Performs Feats of Strength
- Rages
- Slays Monsters
- Throws With Deadly Accuracy
- Wields Two Weapons at Once

Ability Selection Guidelines

Tier 1: Choose a low-tier ability that inflicts additional damage when a character attacks using the focus's particular fighting style, energy, or attitude, or when used against a chosen enemy.

Sometimes an additional low-power ability is appropriate, depending on the focus. For instance, a focus that grants proficiency in a special weapon might offer training in crafting tasks associated with that weapon. A focus that grants increased damage against a particular kind of foe might offer training in skills to recognize, locate, or just have general knowledge about

that foe. A fighting style that involves fighting in a vicious or dirty manner might provide training in intimidation. And so on.

If the focus is about fighting a particular enemy, additional secondary powers (more than might otherwise be offered) may be appropriate. Those either further enhance effectiveness against the chosen enemy, or offer broader but related abilities that give the character who takes the focus some functionality even when not fighting that enemy.

Tier 2: Choose a low-tier ability that provides some form of defense using the weapon, weapon style, or chosen energy. If the weapon style is being especially good at fighting a certain kind of foe, the ability should be a defense against that kind of foe. Alternatively, the focus might offer another method for increasing damage within the chosen paradigm.

Sometimes an additional low-power ability is appropriate at tier 2. If so, choose whichever low-power ability wasn't gained at tier 1.

Tier 3: Choose two mid-tier abilities. Give both of them as options for the focus; a PC will choose one or the other.

One option should inflict additional damage when using the focus's fighting style, energy, or attitude, or when used against a chosen enemy. That could be as simple as an ability that offers an additional attack of that kind.

The other option should provide a method to temporarily neutralize a foe by disarming them, dazing or stunning them, slowing or holding them, or otherwise discombobulating them by using the focus's fighting style, energy, or attitude, or when used against a chosen enemy.

Tier 4: Choose a mid-tier ability that further enhances the advantages provided by the focus's paradigm. Often, this includes training in a particular kind of attack. Alternatively, the ability might increase the advantages provided by achieving a certain combat status, such as gaining surprise.

Tier 5: Choose a high-tier ability that inflicts damage. Alternatively, if focused on fighting a particular kind of foe, this ability might give the character a chance to completely neutralize, destroy, blind, or kill a singular target of up to level 3 (or higher, if the focus is on a singular foe).

Tier 6: Choose two high-tier abilities. Give both of them as options for the focus; a PC will choose one or the other.

One of the options should use the focus paradigm to inflict an exceptional amount of damage.

The other option could be a different way of inflicting damage, either using the focus paradigm or just dealing lots of damage in general (and relying on previous focus tier abilities to improve targeting). This could be against multiple targets if the first option was for a single target, to outright kill or neutralize a target (starting with level 4, but with guidance for using Effort to increase the level of the target), or to select yet another foe, make another attack, or get away in order to fight another day.

Support

Foci that allow a character to help others succeed, defend others, heal others who are hurt, and so on are support foci. Of course, most foci abilities are often used in aid of others, but support foci (such as Siphons Power) prioritize aiding, healing, and improving the character who takes the focus.

Support foci rely on a variety of methods to provide their help, including martial training used in defense, supernatural or sci-fi means of providing healing, or simply easing the cares of others through entertainment.

Connection: Choose four relevant connections from the Focus Connections list.

Additional Equipment: Any object necessary to provide support. For instance, someone with a focus that uses entertainment to help others would require an instrument or similar object in aid of their craft. Some foci in this category don't require anything to gain or retain their benefits.

Minor Effect Suggestions: You can draw an attack without having to use an action at any point before the end of the next round.

Major Effect Suggestions: You can take an extra action in aid of an ally.

The following are examples and not meant to provide a complete list of all possible foci in this category.

- Defends the Weak
- Entertains
- Helps Their Friends
- Metes Out Justice
- Shepherds the Community
- Siphons Power
- Works Miracles

Ability Selection Guidelines

Tier 1: Choose a low-tier ability that provides some form of defense, aid or entertainment, benefit to recovery or healing, or protection. That defense or protection could be to the PC and not to an ally, as one cannot protect another without first being able to protect themselves (and sometimes protecting themselves is the entire point).

Sometimes an additional low-power ability is appropriate, depending on the focus. Often, this is an ability that grants skill training in a related area of knowledge or a related skill, but it might be something that works with the initial ability that, by itself, wouldn't do much.

Tier 2: Choose a low-tier ability that follows up on the support style opened in the previous tier. If the previous tier's ability provided a means of protection only for the focus taker, this tier 2 ability should specifically provide aid to another. If the previous tier specifically provided aid to another, this tier 2 ability could defend the focus taker or provide an offensive capability grounded, if possible, in the focus's theme.

Tier 3: Choose two mid-tier abilities. Give both of them as options for the focus; a PC will choose one or the other.

One option should work within the focus's theme to aid, heal, protect, or otherwise help another.

The other option should be something that benefits the character, either an offensive or defensive ability, or something that broadens their expertise in some fashion. Alternatively, it could be another, different method of helping someone else.

Tier 4: Choose a mid-tier ability that gives an ally a direct boon or provides the character with a way to help another. It could also be an ability that harms or nullifies a foe, as removing foes certainly helps allies.

Tier 5: Choose a high-tier ability that provides an offensive or defensive option for the character, if none have been provided yet. If this need has been previously addressed or is deemed unnecessary, choose a high-tier ability that provides some form of defense, aid or entertainment, benefit to recovery

or healing, or protection to another. For example, a tier 5 ability might grant an ally an additional free action or allow them to repeat a failed action.

Tier 6: Choose two high-tier abilities. Give both of them as options for the focus; a PC will choose one or the other.

One of the options should provide an ultimate method of helping another in the theme of the focus.

The other option could provide an alternative ultimate method of helping another; many foci in this category do. However, an option that provides high-tier offense or defense is also completely reasonable.

Tank Combat

Foci that prioritize being able to take a lot of punishment and soak up excess damage from foes fall within the tank combat category. These foci provide offensive abilities too, as well as additional abilities related to the particular method by which improved protection is achieved, but defensive abilities are most pronounced.

Some tank combat foci involve a physical transformation that grants additional protection, and others rely on specialized training, use tools like shields or heavy armor, or provide the ability to heal incredibly fast. The kinds of physical transformation that a tank focus provides, if any, vary widely. A focus might turn a character's skin to stone, reinforce their body with metal, turn them into a monstrous being, make them so big it becomes harder to hurt them, and so on.

Connection: Choose four relevant connections from the Focus Connections list.

Additional Equipment: Any object necessary to maintain a physical transformation (such as a tool for repair if partly robotic, a shield or other defensive tool used if skilled, or possibly some kind of amulet or serum). Some tank combat foci don't require anything to gain or retain their benefits.

Minor Effect Suggestions: +2 to Armor for a few rounds.

Major Effect Suggestions: Regain 2 points to Might Pool.

The following are examples and not meant to provide a complete list of all possible foci in this category.

- Abides in Stone
- Brandishes an Exotic Shield
- Defends the Gate
- Fuses Flesh and Steel
- Grows to Towering Heights
- Howls at the Moon
- Lives in the Wilderness
- Masters Defense
- Never Says Die
- Stands Like a Bastion

Ability Selection Guidelines

Tier 1: Choose a low-tier ability that provides defense within the focus's theme. If the theme is simply intense training or the use of a defensive tool, the ability might be as simple as a bonus to Armor. If protection comes from physical transformation, this ability provides the base form effects, benefits, and in some cases drawbacks for making the transformation. A low-tier enhanced healing ability would also be appropriate at first tier.

Sometimes an additional low-power ability is appropriate, depending on the focus. If the character transforms, this ability may provide a knock-on effect, though in the case of some transformations, it might be a description of how someone with an abnormal physiognomy can fully heal. Other times, the secondary power may simply be training in a related skill, or it may unlock the ability to use a particular armor or shield without penalty.

Tier 2: If the theme of the focus isn't physical transformation, choose a low-tier ability that provides an additional method of defending, healing damage, or avoiding attacks.

If the theme of the focus is physical transformation, choose a low-tier ability that unlocks a new capability related to the form the character takes. That might mean gaining better control of the transformation, unlocking a robotic interface, or otherwise more fully unlocking that form. This ability is not necessarily defensive, though it could be.

Tier 3: Choose two mid-tier abilities. Give both of them as options for the focus; a PC will choose one or the other.

One option should provide an additional form of protection in keeping with the focus's theme, such as more defensive capabilities unlocked from a transformation (which might also come with additional offensive capabilities) or a simple physical enhancement if defense is gained by skills or enhanced healing.

The other option should provide an offensive capability, especially if creating a non-transformation focus that doesn't already have offensive benefits. That capability could be an enhanced attack or provide some other benefit useful in combat, such as quickly evading or (on the other end of the continuum) becoming immovable.

Tier 4: Choose a mid-tier ability that further enhances the advantages provided by the focus's damage-soaking paradigm. Often, this includes training in a particular kind of defense. Alternatively, it might increase the advantages provided by previously unlocked defensive abilities, whether that means gaining greater control over a transformation, gaining additional chances to avoid damage or retry tasks related to enhanced determination, and so on. If the focus is lacking in offensive options, this is a good place to include one.

Tier 5: Choose a high-tier ability that provides protection, possibly in the form of shrugging off a debilitating condition (including death). If the focus offers a physical transformation, this ability might further unlock an additional related ability, whether offensive, defensive, or something related to exploration or interaction (such as flight if the form is winged, intimidation if the form is fearsome, and so on).

Tier 6: Choose two high-tier abilities. Give both of them as options for the focus; a PC will choose one or the other.

One option should use the focus paradigm to increase the defense, protection, or ability to shrug off damage.

The other option could be a different way of being defensive. In some cases, the best defense is a good offense, so this option could provide a high-tier offensive ability in keeping with the focus's theme, whether that's a straight-up damage boost on attacks or better control of an unstable physical trans-

formation.

6.6 Customizing Foci

Sometimes not everything about a focus is right for a character's concept, or perhaps the GM needs additional guidelines for creating a new focus. Either way, the solution lies in looking at foci abilities at their most basic default levels.

At any tier, a player can select one of the following abilities in place of the ability granted by the tier. Many of these replacement abilities, particularly at the higher tiers, might involve body modification, integration with high-tech devices, learning powerful magic spells, uncovering forbidden secrets, or something similar appropriate to the genre.

Tier 1

- Combat Prowess
- Enhanced Potential

Tier 2

Lower-tier ability: choose any tier 1 replacement ability, above.

- Skill With Defense
- Practiced With All Weapons
- Skill With Attacks

Tier 3

Lower-tier ability: choose any tier 1 or 2 replacement ability, above.

- Incredible Health
- Fusion Armor

Tier 4

Lower-tier ability: choose any tier 1, 2, or 3 replacement ability, above.

- Poison Resistance
- Built-in Weaponry

Tier 5

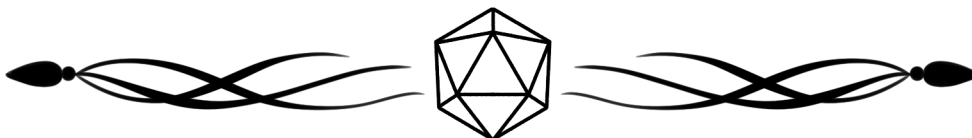
Lower-tier ability: choose any tier 1, 2, 3, or 4 replacement ability, above.

- Adaptation
- Defensive Field

Tier 6

Lower-tier ability: choose any tier 1, 2, 3, 4, or 5 replacement ability, above.

- Reactive Field



Chapter 7

Abilities

This chapter presents a vast catalog of more than a thousand abilities a character can gain from their type, flavor (if any), and focus. They are sorted alphabetically by the ability's name.

A character's type, flavor, and focus assign an appropriate tier to each ability. However, if you're creating a brand-new focus or type, we provide a couple of additional tools.

The first is a power grade for each ability, which tells you about how potent it is in relation to other abilities. Abilities appropriate for tiers 1 and 2 characters are called "low-tier" abilities. Abilities appropriate for tiers 3 and 4 are called "mid-tier" abilities. Abilities appropriate for tiers 5 and 6 are called "high-tier" abilities.

These abilities are further sorted into ability categories based on the kinds of things they do—abilities that improve physical attacks are in the attack skill category, abilities that assist allies are in the support category, and so on.

(Unless otherwise noted, you cannot choose the same ability twice, even if you get it from both your type and a flavor.)

7.1 Ability Categories and Relative Power

Abilities can be divided into several categories based on the kinds of things they do—improve your physical attacks, assist allies, provide defense, give you a special attack form, and so on. Under each of the following category descriptions is a list of abilities that fit that category, sorted into low-, medium-, and high-tier abilities.

The categories are mainly used by GMs when designing new foci for a campaign, allowing them to search a short list of abilities instead of trying to find something appropriate among the thousand or so abilities in this chapter. For example, the GM might have a custom focus in their campaign called "Is Born of the Swamp" and want a defensive ability for tier 5, so they can look at the high-tier abilities in the protection category and quickly narrow down what options are available.

(It may be possible that a character gains the same ability from more than one source (such as from their type and their descriptor). Unless the two abilities are obviously additive (such as two abilities that each add 3 points to your Might Pool, which together would give the character +6 Might points), the duplicated ability might be improved in some way, such as having a longer duration or greater effect, or automatically providing an asset. Some abilities give suggestions on how to do this; otherwise, the player and the GM should work out whether and how the ability is improved.)

The ability categories are not intended to be rigid or comprehensive. Some abilities fall into more than one category, and it could be argued that some abilities could be included in more categories than are listed here.

These categories have some overlap with the categories in the Focus chapter. For example, there is a support category here and a support category in the Focus chapter. They aren't intended to be exact parallels and they don't mean exactly the same thing. That said, if you're creating a support-centric focus, many of the abilities in the support ability category would be appropriate choices.

7.1.1 Attack Skill

Gives you training or specialization in a specific physical attack (like swords or unarmed combat), a category of physical attacks (light bladed, heavy bashing, and so on), or another physical skill primarily used to inflict harm (such as breaking objects).

Low Tier:

- Heads-Up Display
- Practiced With Guns
- Practiced With Medium Weapons
- Practiced With Swords
- Quarry
- Unarmed Fighting Style

Mid Tier:

- Blood Fever
- Cognizant Offense
- Greater Skill With Defense
- Practiced With All Weapons
- Robot Fighter
- Serv-0 Aim
- Serv-0 Brawler
- Skill With Attacks
- Sniper's Aim
- Specialized Throwing

High Tier:

- As Foretold in Prophecy
- Duel to the Death
- Greater Skill With Attacks
- Hunter's Drive
- Master of Unarmed Fighting Style
- Mastery With Attacks
- Specialized Basher

7.1.2 Companion

Gives you a follower, modifies a follower, or gives you an additional benefit when interacting with or near your follower. This category includes humanoid followers, beast companions, and temporary companions like summoned swarms, conjured spirits, and so on.

Low Tier:

- Basic Follower
- Beast Companion
- Bound Magic Creature
- Control Swarm
- Critter Companion
- Duplicate
- Entourage
- Influence Swarm
- Necromancy
- Resilient Duplicate
- Robot Assistant
- Serv-0
- Spirit Accomplice

Mid Tier:

- Beast Eyes
- Call Swarm
- Expert Follower
- Fellow Explorer
- Fiery Hand of Doom
- Gain Unusual Companion
- Greater Necromancy
- Improved Object Bond
- Living Armor
- Machine Companion
- Mount
- Retinue
- Shipspeak
- Stronger Together
- Summon Giant Spider
- Superior Duplicate
- Time Doppelganger
- Time Loop

High Tier:

- As If One Creature
- Band of Desperados
- Band of Followers
- Beast Call
- Call Dead Spirit
- Call in Favor
- Call Otherworldly Spirit
- Call Through Time
- Conjuration
- Deadly Swarm
- Dragon's Maw
- Fire Servant
- Improved Apportation
- Improved Companion
- Improved Machine Companion
- Insect Eruption
- Legal Intern
- Masterful Armor
- Modification
- Multiplicity
- Object Bond Mastery
- Recruit Deputy
- Robot Fleet
- Summon Demon
- Time Doppelganger
- True Necromancy

7.1.3 Control

Controls or influences minds in ways outside of what could be done with conventional intimidation and persuasion, such as using psychic mind control, fear gas, and so on.

Low Tier:

- Calm Stranger
- Charm Machine
- Cloud Personal Memories
- Community Activist
- Fast Talk
- Goad
- Hack the Impossible
- Robot Control
- Soothe the Savage
- Terrifying Presence

Mid Tier:

- Calm
- Captivate or Inspire
- Captivate With Starshine
- Command
- Command Machine
- Command Spirit
- Crowd Control
- Daydream
- Grand Deception
- Interruption
- Mind Control
- Psychic Suggestion

High Tier:

- Advanced Command
- Assume Control
- Brainwashing
- Change the Paradigm
- Control Machine
- Control the Savage
- Defuse Situation
- Flee
- Psychic Passenger
- Show Them the Way
- Suggestion
- Word of Command

7.1.4 Craft

Creates useful physical things, such as mundane tools (hammers, crowbars), limited-use devices (manifest cyphers, artifacts), or independent beings (robots, elementals, zombies). Includes blueprints, plans, and effects that aid or speed crafting.

Low Tier:

- Create Deadly Poison
- Fortification Builder
- Junkmonger
- Machine Efficiency
- Modify Device
- Natural Crafter
- Quick Work
- Robot Builder
- Trapster
- Weapon Crafter

Mid Tier:

- Dream Becomes Reality
- Expert Crafter
- Ice Creation
- Poison Crafter
- Robot Upgrade
- Sculpt Light

High Tier:

- Create
- Dark Matter Structure
- Improved Sculpt Light
- Innovator
- Jury-Rig
- Modify Artifact Power
- Reshape

7.1.5 Cure

Cures damage, adds or improves recovery rolls, or negates, cures, suspends, or otherwise gives immunity to a harmful effect or condition, such as poison, disease, mental attacks, moving down on the damage track, or dying.

Low Tier:

- Alleviate
- Crystalline Body
- Destined for Greatness
- Diver
- Drain Creature
- Drain Machine
- Endurance
- Escape
- Extra Recovery
- Foil Danger
- Healing Touch
- Ignore the Pain
- Improved Recovery
- Living Off the Land
- Push on Through
- Quick Recovery
- Repair Flesh
- Restful Presence
- Speedy Recovery
- Surging Confidence
- Totally Chill
- Water Adaptation
- Will of Legend

Mid Tier:

- Aquatic Combatant
- Biomorphic Healing
- Damage Transference
- Drain Charge
- Fight On
- Font of Healing
- Healing Pulse
- Ignore Affliction
- Immovable
- Incredible Health

- Miraculous Health
- Noble's Courage
- One With the Wild
- Poison Resistance
- Preternatural Senses
- Regeneration
- Store Energy
- Thinking Ahead
- Tough As Nails
- Unmovable
- Unraveling Consumption
- Wilderness Encouragement
- Willing Sacrifice

High Tier:

- Deep Reserves
- Final Defiance
- Free to Move
- Gamer's Fortitude
- Gaming God
- Greater Healing Touch
- Incredible Recovery
- Infuse Spirit
- Inspiration
- Inspire the Innocent
- Mind Surge
- Negate Danger
- Not Dead Yet
- Rapid Recovery
- Regenerate
- Restore Life
- Resuscitate
- Share the Power
- Stay the Course
- Trick Driver
- Vigilant

7.1.6 Environment

Manipulates the environment or things in the environment, such as with telekinesis, weather control, gravity control, illusions, and so on.

Low Tier:

- Create Water
- Dreamcraft
- Fetch
- Grasping Foliage
- Hedge Magic
- Hidden Closet
- Illuminating Touch
- Illusory Duplicate
- Impetus
- Legerdemain
- Lock
- Minor Illusion
- Move Metal
- Slip Into Shadow
- Telekinesis
- Wilderness Explorer

Mid Tier:

- Daydream
- Define Down
- Field of Gravity
- Force Field Barrier
- Force to Reckon With
- Illusory Selves
- Living Wall
- Major Illusion
- Nullify Sound
- Projection
- Storm Seed
- Sunlight

High Tier:

- Adaptation
- Control Weather
- Diamagnetism
- Force Wall

- Generate Force Field
- Grandiose Illusion
- Granite Wall
- Inferno Trail
- Move Mountains
- Permanent Illusion
- Relocate
- Terrifying Image
- Wall of Lightning
- The Wild Is on Your Side

7.1.7 Information

Gives the ability to learn information about something, whether chosen by the GM like Scan, by asking a question and the GM giving the answer, or by learning a language.

Low Tier:

- Babel
- Communication
- Community Knowledge
- Decipher
- Dream Thief
- Eye for Detail
- Gather Intelligence
- Lab Analysis
- Mind Reading
- Monster Lore
- Network Tap
- Predictive Model
- Premonition
- Question the Spirits
- Retrieve Memories
- Salvage and Comfort
- Scan
- See History
- Speaker for the Dead
- Telepathic

Mid Tier:

- Creature Insight
- Device Insight
- Draw Conclusion
- Find the Hidden
- Got a Feeling

- Know Their Faults
- Machine Telepathy
- Mechanical Telepathy
- Reading the Room
- Sensor Array
- Serv-0 Scanner
- Soul Interrogation
- Spot Weakness
- Wilderness Awareness

High Tier:

- Deep Consideration
- Drawing on Life's
- Experiences
- Information Gathering
- Knowing the Unknown
- Mind of a Leader
- Read the Signs
- Telepathic Network

7.1.8 Meta

Modifies an existing ability or character trait's effects or parameters, such as increasing range or, damage, easing the difficulty, giving you additional noncombat actions each turn, rerolling a failed attempt, or treating a number on the die as something different than normal.

Low Tier:

- A Smile and a Word
- Arcane Flare
- Artifact Tinkerer
- Augment Cypher
- Careful Shot
- Charge
- Coaxing Power
- Combat Prowess
- Crushing Blow
- Crystalline Body
- Curious
- Distant Interface
- Double Strike
- Drain Creature
- Driving on the Edge

- Elusive
- Energize Object
- Enhanced Body
- Extra Use
- Find the Way
- Fists of Fury
- Fleet of Foot
- Frenzy
- Golem Body
- Gunner
- Hacker
- Hold Breath
- Improved Designation
- Investigator
- Lead From the Front
- Machine Efficiency
- Mind for Might
- Modify Device
- Monster Bane
- Natural Crafter
- No Need for Weapons
- Object Bond
- Overload Machine
- Precision
- Quick Death
- Quick Work
- Range Increase
- Reload
- Something in the Road
- Tinker
- Weapon Master
- Wreck

Mid Tier:

- Amazing Effort
- Betrayal
- Better Living Through Chemistry
- Capable Warrior
- Cast Illusion
- Cyphersmith
- Deadly Aim

- Deep Resources
- Disarming Strike
- Dodge and Resist
- Drain at a Distance
- Energized Shield
- Enhanced Intellect
- Enhanced Intellect Edge
- Enhanced Might
- Enhanced Might Edge
- Enhanced Physique
- Enhanced Potential
- Enhanced Speed
- Enhanced Speed Edge
- Experienced in Armor
- Expert Cypher Use
- Expert Skill
- Fast Kill
- Flameblade
- From the Shadows
- Fury
- Fusion
- Greater Beast Form
- Greater Designation
- Greater Enhanced Intellect
- Greater Enhanced Might
- Greater Enhanced Physique
- Greater Enhanced Potential
- Greater Enhanced Speed
- Greater Frenzy
- Guide Bolt
- Guild Training
- Heroic Monster Bane
- Hidden Reserves
- Huge
- Immovable
- Improved Absorb Kinetic Energy
- Improved Edge
- Improved Monster Bane
- Improved Sensor
- Incomparable Pilot
- Increased Effects
- Iron Fist
- Know Where to Look
- Lunge
- Machine Bond
- Machine Vulnerabilities
- Minor Wish
- Never Fumble
- One With the Wild
- Outlast the Foe
- Outwit
- Overcharge Energy
- Perfect Stranger
- Precise Cut
- Punish the Guilty
- Push Off and Throw
- Quick Wits
- Rapid Processing
- Resilient Ice Armor
- Roaming Third Eye
- Robot Improvement
- Seize the Moment
- Shepherd's Fury
- Slippery Customer
- Space Fighting
- Speed Burst
- Stone Breaker
- Store Energy
- Strategize
- Think Your Way Out
- Tower of Will
- Trust to Luck
- Uncanny Luck
- Wall With Teeth
- Weaponization
- Willing Sacrifice
- Wrest From Chance

High Tier:

- Adroit Cypher Use
- Again and Again
- Agile Wit
- All-Out Con
- Artifact Scavenger
- Blurring Speed
- Burst of Escape
- Charging Horde
- Coordinated Effort
- Damage Dealer
- Damn the Guilty
- Deep Reserves
- Disarming Attack
- Discipline of Watchfulness
- Divide Your Mind
- Dual Distraction
- Duel to the Death
- Effective Skill
- Enhanced Beast Form
- Enhanced Phased Attack
- Escape Plan
- Extreme Mastery
- Force and Accuracy
- Gambler
- Go to Ground
- Hard to Kill
- Horde Tactics
- Impart Understanding
- Improved Command Spirit
- Improved Gravity Cleave
- Improved Machine Companion
- Improved Success
- Inventor
- Lethal Damage
- Machine Enhancement
- Maneuvering Adept
- Master Cypher Use
- Master Machine
- Masterful Armor Modification
- Moderate Wish
- Modify Artifact Power
- Multiple Quarry
- Multiplicity
- Overcharge Device
- Perfect Control
- Perfect Speed Burst
- Physically Gifted
- Recycled Cyphers
- Reinforcing Field
- Resonant Frequency
- Robot Evolution
- Seize the Initiative
- Shield Burst
- Shred Existence
- Subtle Tricks
- Thief's Luck
- Trick Driver
- Twist of Fate
- Two Things at Once
- Ultra Enhancement
- Using What's Available
- Usurp Cypher
- Weightless Shot
- Weird Science Breakthrough
- Wild Vitality
- Winter Gauntlets

7.1.9 Movement

Increases your movement (such as increasing your basic movement speed from short to long) or adds a new type of movement (such as flight, wallcrawling, phasing, or teleporting).

Low Tier:

- Bolt Rider
- Contortionist
- Danger Instinct
- Far Step
- Get Away
- Hover
- Phase Sprint
- Void Wings
- Walk Through Walls

Mid Tier:

- Apportation
- Blink of an Eye
- Bypass Barrier
- Controlled Fall
- Ghost
- Mobile Fighter
- Obstacle Running
- Phase Door
- Runner
- Swim
- Temporal Dislocation
- Up to Speed
- Windrider
- Wings of Fire
- Wormhole

High Tier:

- Alley Rat
- Blurring Speed
- Chamber of Dreams
- Electrical Flight
- Embraced by Darkness
- Fast Travel
- Flash Across the Miles
- Flight

- Impossible Walk
- Incredible Running Speed
- Jaunt
- Juggernaut
- Living Light
- Masterful Armor
- Modification
- Mental Projection
- Return to the Obelisk
- Teleportation
- Time Travel
- Traverse the Worlds
- Very Long Sprinting
- Wind Chariot
- Windwracked Traveler

7.1.10 Protection

Gives training or specialization in one or more types of combat defenses (Might, Speed, or Intellect), provides or increases Armor, or otherwise helps prevent damage.

Low Tier:

- Absorb Kinetic Energy
- Block
- Closed Mind
- Courageous
- Crystalline Body
- Defense Against Robots
- Defensive Phasing
- Deflect Attacks
- Distortion
- Enhanced Body
- Enveloping Shield
- Fearsome Reputation
- Field of Destruction
- Flesh of Stone
- Flight Not Fight
- Force Field Shield
- Fortified Position
- Go Defensive
- Golem Body
- Hard to Distract
- Hard to Hit

- Hardiness
- Have Spacesuit, Will Travel
- Ice Armor
- Just a Bit Mad
- Magic Shield
- Mentally Tough
- Out of Harm's Way
- Phase Sprint
- Powered Armor
- Practiced in Armor
- Quick Block
- Repel Metal
- Resist the Elements
- Resist Underwater Hazards
- Resonance Field
- Safe Fall
- Serv-0 Defender
- Shield Master
- Shroud of Flame
- Skill With Defense
- Sound Conversion Barrier
- Stare Them Down
- Sturdy
- Trained Without Armor
- Unarmored Fighter
- Ward
- Warding Shield
- Weapon Defense
- Weather the Vicissitudes
- Wind Armor
- Mid Tier:**
 - Absorb Pure Energy
 - Anticipate Attack
 - Blood Fever
 - Cloak of Opportunity
 - Confounding Banter
 - Confuse Enemy
 - Counter Danger
 - Countermeasures
 - Dark Matter Shell
 - Dark Matter Shroud
 - Discerning Mind
 - Divert Attacks
 - Dodge and Respond
 - Dual Defense
 - Electric Armor
 - Elemental Protection
 - Energy Protection
 - Energy Resistance
 - Experienced in Armor
 - Experienced Defender
 - Force Field Barrier
 - Fusion Armor
 - Hard-Won Resilience
 - Horde Fighting
 - Huge
 - Illusory Evasion
 - Magnetic Field
 - Matter Cloud
 - Minor Wish
 - Moving Like Water
 - Nimble Swimmer
 - Outlaw Reputation
 - Poison Crafter
 - Rapid Processing
 - Resilience
 - Resilient Ice Armor
 - Robot Fighter
 - Shield Training
 - Subconscious Defense
 - Temporal Acceleration
 - Tough It Out
 - Tower of Intellect
 - Tower of Will
 - Tumbling Moves
 - Versatile Mind
 - Vigilance
 - Wraith Cloak

High Tier:

- Defense Master
- Defensive Augmentation
- Defensive Field
- Energize Creature
- Energize Crowd
- Evasion
- Field-Reinforced Armor
- Hard Target
- Hard to Kill
- Lost in the Chaos
- Masterful Armor
- Modification
- Mastery in Armor
- Mastery With Defense
- Microgravity Avoidance
- Moderate Wish
- Nothing but Defend
- Parry
- Precognition
- Reactive Field
- See the Future
- Still As a Statue
- Ultra Enhancement
- Untouchable
- Untouchable While Moving
- Wear It Well

7.1.11 Senses

Enhances your senses (seeing in the dark, seeing underwater or through mist, sensing danger, finding optimal places to stand in combat, and so on), but doesn't provide direct answers to questions like an information ability does.

Low Tier:

- Eyes Adjusted
- Familiarize
- Find an Opening
- Heads-Up Display
- Link Senses
- Mental Link
- Reveal

- See the Unseen
- See Through Matter
- Sense Ambush
- Share Senses
- Third Eye

Mid Tier:

- Animal Senses and Sensibilities
- Awareness
- Beast Eyes
- Break the Line
- Detect Life
- Distance Viewing
- Echolocation
- Experienced Finder
- Inhabit Crystal
- Remote Viewing
- Sensing Package
- Sensor
- Serv-0 Spy
- Trapfinder
- Use Senses of Others

High Tier:

- Amplify Sounds
- Battlefield Tactician
- Dark Explorer
- Infer Thoughts
- Master Machine
- See Through Time
- True Senses

7.1.12 Social

Gives you an indirect social benefit, such as providing a useful contact in a city or letting you take advantage of your social status.

Low Tier:

- Connected
- Debate
- Demeanor of Command
- Impart Ideal
- Misdirect Blame
- Negotiate
- Perks of Stardom
- Powerful Rhetoric
- Privileged Nobility
- Underworld Contacts
- Unexpected Betrayal

Mid Tier:

- Betrayal
- Flamboyant Boast
- Informer
- Oratory
- Perfect Stranger

High Tier:

- Group Friendship

7.1.13 Special Attack

Gives the ability to make a special melee or ranged attack (weapon, energy blast, psychic, and so on). The attack might do damage, have a special effect (disarm, hinder, move the target, and so on), or both. This also includes abilities like Spray that let you attack multiple targets as your action.

Low Tier:

- Advantage to Disadvantage
- Aggression
- Arcane Flare
- Bash
- Bloodlust
- Concussive Blast
- Control the Field
- Cutting Light
- Dazzling Sunburst
- Disincentivize

- Disrupting Touch
- Drain Machine
- Dream Thief
- Dual Light Wield
- Entangling Force
- Enthrall
- Erase Memories
- Eye Gouge
- Flash
- Force Bash
- Frost Touch
- Golem Grip
- Grasping Foliage
- Hemorrhage
- Hurl Flame
- Misdirect
- Onslaught
- Opportunist
- Overwatch
- Pierce
- Push
- Quick Throw
- Ray of Confusion
- Release Energy
- Resonance Field
- Ribbons of Dark Matter
- Scramble Machine
- Scratch Existence
- Seeds of Fury
- Shatter
- Shock
- Stasis
- Successive Attack
- Surprise Attack
- Swipe
- Thrust
- Thunder Beam
- Weighty

Mid Tier:

- Acrobatic Attack

- Ambusher
- Answering Attack
- Better Surprise Attack
- Bolts of Power
- Built-in Weaponry
- Burning Light
- Castigate
- Center of Attention
- Crystal Lens
- Dark Matter Strike
- Dazing Attack
- Debilitating Strike
- Destroy Metal
- Disable Mechanisms
- Disarming Strike
- Divine Radiance
- Dodge and Respond
- Drain Charge
- Dual Medium Wield
- Everything Is a Weapon
- Exile
- Feint
- Fire and Ice
- Fire Bloom
- Fling
- Force at Distance
- Force Blast
- Freezing Touch
- Golem Stomp
- Grab
- Gravity Cleave
- Ignition
- Improved Object Bond
- Knock Out
- Matter Cloud
- Mind Games
- Momentum
- Overawe
- Overcome All Obstacles

- Phase Detonation
- Phased Attack
- Power Strike
- Pry Open
- Psychic Burst
- Psychosis
- Push Off and Throw
- Quick Strike
- Rapid Attack
- Reaction
- Remote Control
- Run and Fight
- Shattering Shout
- Slice
- Snap Shot
- Snipe
- Spray
- Sprint and Grab
- Taking Advantage
- Tall Tale
- Throw
- Throw Force Shield
- Trick Shot

High Tier:

- Absorb Energy
- Arc Spray
- Assassin Strike
- Asserting Your Privilege
- Attack and Attack Again
- Biomorphic Detonation
- Blind Machine
- Blinding Attack
- Bouncing Shield
- Break the Ranks
- Break Their Mind
- Call the Storm
- Cold Burst
- Concussion
- Deactivate Mechanisms

- Deadly Strike
- Death Touch
- Defense Master
- Destroyer
- Dirty Fighter
- Disarming Attack
- Divine Intervention
- Divine Symbol
- Do You Know Who I Am?
- Drain Power
- Dust to Dust
- Earthquake
- Embrace the Night
- Explosive Release
- Finishing Blow
- Fire Tendrils
- Foul Aura
- Ice Storm
- Iron Punch
- Jump Attack
- Lethal Ploy
- Lethal Vibration
- Murderer
- Nightmare
- Phase Foe
- Protective Wall
- Psychokinetic Attack
- Punish All the Guilty
- Resonant Quake
- Return to Sender
- Shatter Mind
- Special Shot
- Spin Attack
- Spring Away
- Stun Attack
- Sun Siphon
- Taunt Foe
- Terrifying Gaze
- Twisting the Knife

- Undo
- Vindictive Performance
- Weapon and Body
- Weight of the World
- Weightless Shot
- Whirlwind of Throws
- Winter Gauntlets
- Word of Death

7.1.14 Support

Gives some sort of benefit to an ally rather than yourself, such as an extra action or an asset on their roll.

Low Tier:

- Advice From a Friend
- Anecdote
- Attack Flourish
- Defend the Innocent
- Enable Others
- Encouragement
- Encouraging Presence
- Force Field
- Friendly Help
- Good Advice
- Inspire Action
- Inspire Aggression
- Inspiring Ease
- Protector
- Rally to Me
- Reveal
- Sculpt Flesh
- Teamwork

Mid Tier:

- Accelerate
- Applying Your Knowledge
- Buddy System
- Combat Challenge
- Defend All the Innocent
- Dual Wards
- Elemental Protection
- In Harm's Way
- Lead by Inquiry

- Pay It Forward
- Play to the Crowd
- Spur Effort
- Take Command
- True Guardian

High Tier:

- Able Assistance
- Battle Management
- Block for Another
- Energize Creature
- Energize Crowd
- Impart Understanding
- Inspiration
- Inspire Coordinated Actions
- Inspiring Success
- Regenerate Other
- Share Defense
- Stimulate
- Teach Trick
- Transcend the Script
- True Defender
- Undo
- Will of a Leader
- Work the Friendship
- Careful Aim
- Celebrity Talent
- Computer Programming
- Contortionist
- Courageous
- Crafter
- Danger Sense
- Datajack
- Debate
- Deep Water Guide
- Designation
- Devoted Defender
- Disguise
- Divine Knowledge
- Driver
- Enlightened
- Exploratory Experience
- Extra Skill
- Feat of Strength
- Flex Lore
- Freakishly Large
- Game Lessons
- Gamer
- Good Advice
- Hand to Eye
- Handy
- Hard Choices
- Heads-Up Display
- Higher Mathematics
- How Others Think
- Impersonate
- Impressive Display
- Infiltrator
- Inner Defense
- Insight
- Inspire Aggression
- Interaction Skills
- Interface
- Investigate
- Investigative Skills

7.1.15 Task

Gives training, specialization, or an asset in one or more non-combat skills (climbing, healing, computers, initiative, and so on).

Low Tier:

- Advantages of Being Big
- Anticipation
- Assassin Skills
- Athlete
- Autodoctor
- Balance
- Bestiary Knowledge
- Blameless
- Breaker
- Car Surfer

- Knowing
 - Knowledge of the Law
 - Knowledge Skills
 - Late Inspiration
 - Learning the Path
 - Levity
 - Life Lessons
 - Machine Affinity
 - Machine Hunting
 - Machine Interface
 - Magic Training
 - Make Judgment
 - Master Identifier
 - Master Thief
 - Microgravity Adept
 - Monster Lore
 - Movement Skills
 - Muscles of Iron
 - Natural Charisma
 - Oneirochemistry
 - Open Mind
 - Opening Statement
 - Physical Skills
 - Pilot
 - Poetic License
 - Post-Apocalyptic Survivor
 - Powerful Rhetoric
 - Predictive Equation
 - Privileged Nobility
 - Quarry
 - Quick Study
 - Quick to Flee
 - Quicker Than Most
 - Resist Tricks
 - Ruin Lore
 - Sailor
 - Salvage and Comfort
 - Sense Attitudes
 - Serv-0 Repair
 - Sharp Senses
 - Sleuth
 - Slippery
 - Sneak
 - Stalker
 - Stand Watch
 - Stealth Skills
 - Straightforward
 - Superb Explorer
 - Superb Infiltrator
 - Taking Advantage
 - Task Training
 - Tech Skills
 - There's Your Problem
 - Tool Mastery
 - Tracker
 - Trained Excavator
 - Trained Interlocutor
 - Trained Swimmer
 - Travel Skills
 - Understanding
 - Vacuum Skilled
 - Wilderness Life
 - Wilderness Lore
 - Wound Tender
 - Zero Dark Eyes
- Mid Tier:**
- Action Processor
 - Agent Provocateur
 - Animal Senses and Sensibilities
 - Confidence Artist
 - Dark Matter Shell
 - Enhance Strength
 - Expert Driver
 - Expert Pilot
 - Find the Guilty
 - Flex Skill
 - Ghost
 - Hard to See

- Heightened Skills
- Improvise
- Increasing Determination
- Intelligent Interface
- Intense Interaction
- Knowledge Is Power
- Master Crafter
- Meticulous Planner
- Minor Wish
- Nightstrike
- Outlast the Foe
- Passing Mechanic
- Preternatural Senses
- Pull a Fast One
- Rapid Processing
- Rider
- Sea Legs
- Sensing Package
- Serv-0 Aim
- Serv-0 Brawler
- Sharp-Eyed
- Ship Footing
- Silent As Space
- Skill With Attacks
- Soothe Mind and Body
- Subtle Steps
- Targeting Eye
- Task Specialization
- Telling
- Temporal Acceleration
- Trained Basher
- Trained Gunner
- Trained Slayer
- Verbal Misdirection
- You Studied

High Tier:

- Amplify Sounds
- As Foretold in Prophecy

- Coordinated Effort
- Dark Explorer
- Explains the Ineffable
- Exploit Advantage
- Further Mathematics
- Learned a Few Things
- Like the Back of Your Hand
- Magnificent Moment
- Master Entertainer
- Multiple Skills
- No One Knows Better
- Precognition
- See the Future
- Subsonic Rumble
- Total Awareness
- Trick Driver
- Using the Environment

7.1.16 Transform

A significant change that temporarily enhances you, such as growing bigger, turning into a werewolf, and so on. Also includes apparent transformations like disguises and invisibility.

Low Tier:

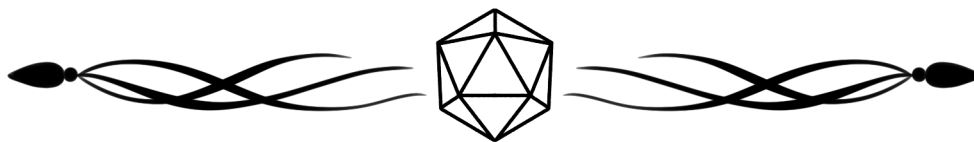
- Beast Form
- Bigger
- Controlled Change
- Enlarge
- Face Morph
- Golem Healing
- Illusory Disguise
- Phased Pocket
- Spin Identity
- Vanish

Mid Tier:

- Bigger Beast Form
- Blend In
- Evanesce
- Greater Controlled Change
- Hard to See
- Huge
- Invisible Phasing
- Moon Shape

High Tier:

- Colossal
- Command Metal
- Disappear
- Gargantuan
- Invisibility
- Mask
- Moderate Wish
- Outside Reality
- Perfect Control
- Wild Camouflage



7.2 Abilities—A

A Smile and a Word: When you use Effort on any action involving interactions—even those having to do with calming animals or communicating with someone or something whose language you do not speak—you gain a free level of Effort on the task. Action.

Able Assistance: When you help someone with a task and they apply a level of Effort, they get a free level of Effort on that task. Enabler.

Absorb Energy (7 Intellect points): You touch an object and absorb its energy. If you touch a manifest cypher, you render it useless. If you touch an artifact, roll for its depletion. If you touch another kind of powered machine or device, the GM determines whether its power is fully drained. In any case, you absorb energy from the object touched and regain 1d10 Intellect points. If this would give you more Intellect than your Pool's maximum, the extra points are lost, and you must make a Might defense roll. The difficulty of the roll is equal to the number of points over your maximum you absorbed. If you fail the roll, you take 5 points of damage and are unable to act for one round. You can use this ability as a defense action when you're the target of an incoming ability. Doing so cancels the incoming ability, and you absorb the energy as if it were a device. Action.

Absorb Kinetic Energy: You absorb a portion of the energy of a physical attack or impact. You negate 1 point of damage you would have suffered and store that point as energy. Once you have absorbed 1 point of energy, you continue to negate 1 point of damage from any incoming blow or impact, but the residual energy bleeds off with a flare of harmless light (you cannot store more than 1 point at a time). Enabler.

Absorb Pure Energy: When you use Absorb Kinetic Energy, you can also absorb and store energy from attacks made with pure energy (focused light, radiation, transdimensional, psychic, etc.) or from conduits that direct energy, if you can make direct contact. This ability does not change how many points of energy you can store. If you also have Improved Absorb Kinetic Energy, you can absorb 2 points of damage from other energy sources as well. Enabler.

Accelerate (4+ Intellect points): Your words imbue the spirit of a character within immediate range who is able to understand you, accelerating them so they gain an asset on initiative tasks and Speed defense rolls for ten minutes. In addition to the normal options for using Effort, you can choose to use Effort to affect more targets; each level of Effort affects one additional target. You must speak to additional targets to accelerate them, one target per round. Action per target to initiate.

Acrobatic Attack (1+ Speed points): You leap into the attack, twisting or flipping through the air. If you roll a natural 17 or 18, you can choose to have a minor effect rather than deal extra damage. If you apply Effort to the attack, you get a free level of Effort on the task. You can't use this ability if your Speed Effort costs are reduced from wearing armor. Enabler.

Action Processor (4 Intellect points): Drawing upon stored information and the ability to process incoming data at amazing speeds, you are trained in one physical task of your choice for ten minutes. For example, you can choose running, climbing, swimming, Speed defense, or attacks with a specific weapon. Action to initiate.

Adaptation: Thanks to a latent mutation, a device implanted in your spine, a ritual performed with dragon's blood, or some other gift, you now remain at a comfortable tempera-

ture; never need to worry about dangerous radiation, diseases, or gases; and can always breathe in any environment (even the vacuum of space). Enabler.

Adroit Cypher Use: You can bear four cyphers at a time. Enabler.

Advanced Command (7 Intellect points): A target within short range obeys any command you give as long as they can hear and understand you. Further, as long as you continue to do nothing but issue commands (taking no other action), you can give that same target a new command. This effect ends when you stop issuing commands or they are out of short range. Action to initiate.

Advantage to Disadvantage (3 Speed points): With a number of quick moves, you make an attack against an armed foe, inflicting damage and disarming them so that their weapon is now in your hands or 10 feet (3 m) away on the ground—your choice. This disarming attack is hindered. Action.

Advantages of Being Big: When you use Enlarge, you're so big that you can move massive objects more easily, climb buildings by using hand- and footholds unavailable to regular-sized people, and jump much farther. While you enjoy the effects of Enlarge, all climbing, lifting, and jumping tasks are eased. Enabler.

Advantages of Being Small: You've learned how to leverage your strength and accuracy in proportion to your size. Your damage is no longer halved when using Shrink, and climbing and jumping tasks are eased. Enabler.

Advice From a Friend (1 Intellect point): You know your friend's strengths and weaknesses, and how to motivate them to succeed. When you give an ally a suggestion involving their next action, the character is trained in that action for one round. Action.

Again and Again (8 Speed points): You can take an additional action in a round in which you have already acted. Enabler.

Ageless: Your body and mind do not age. Unless you are killed by violence (or some outside force such as poison or infection), you will never die. Enabler.

Agent Provocateur: Choose one of the following to be trained in: attacking with a weapon of your choice, demolitions, or sneaking and lockpicking (if you choose this last option, you are trained in both). Enabler.

Aggression (2 Might points): You focus on making attacks to such an extent that you leave yourself vulnerable to your opponents. While this ability is active, you gain an asset on your melee attacks, and your Speed defense rolls against melee and ranged attacks are hindered. This effect lasts for as long as you wish, but it ends if no combat is taking place within range of your senses. Enabler.

Agile Wit: When attempting a Speed task, you instead can roll (and spend points) as if it were an Intellect action. If you apply Effort to this task, you can spend points from your Intellect Pool instead of your Speed Pool (in which case you also use your Intellect Edge instead of your Speed Edge). Enabler.

All-Out Con (7 Intellect points): You put everything into it. You add three free levels of Effort to the next task you attempt. You can't use this ability again until after you've taken a ten-hour recovery action. Action.

Alleviate (3 Intellect points): You attempt to cancel or cure one malady (such as disease or poison) in one creature. Action.

Alley Rat (6 Intellect points): While in a city, you find or create a significant shortcut, secret entrance, or emergency escape route where it looked like none existed. Doing so requires

that you succeed on an Intellect action whose difficulty is set by the GM based on the situation. You and the GM should work out the details. Action.

Always Tinkering: If you have any tools and materials at all, and you are carrying fewer cyphers than your limit, you can create a manifest cypher if you have an hour of time to spend. The new cypher is random and always 2 levels lower than normal (minimum 1). It's also temperamental and fragile. These are called temperamental cyphers. If you give one to anyone else to use, it falls apart immediately, useless. Action to initiate; one hour to complete.

Amazing Copying: You can use Copy Power to copy more powerful abilities. In addition to the normal options for using Effort with Copy Power, if you apply two levels of Effort, the GM chooses a high-tier ability that most closely resembles that power (instead of a low-tier ability). Enabler.

Amazing Effort: When you apply at least one level of Effort to a noncombat task, you get a free level of Effort on that task. When you choose this ability, decide if it applies to Might Effort or Speed Effort. Enabler.

Amazing Leap (2 Might points): You leap through the air and land safely some distance away. You can jump up, down, or across to anywhere you choose within long range if you have a clear and unobstructed path to that location. If you have three or more power shifts in strength, your leaping range increases to very long. If you have five or more power shifts in strength, your leaping range increases to 1,000 feet (300 m). Action.

Ambusher: When you attack a creature that has not yet acted during the first round of combat, your attack is eased. Enabler.

Amplify Sounds (2 Might points): For one minute, you can amplify distant or small sounds so that you can hear them clearly, even if it's a conversation or the sound of a small animal moving through an underground burrow up to a very long distance away. You can attempt to perceive the sound even if interceding barriers block it or the sound is very slight, though this requires a few additional rounds of concentration. To discriminate the sound you wish in a noisy environment might also require a few additional rounds of concentration as you audibly explore the surrounding soundscape. Given enough time, you could pinpoint every conversation, every breathing creature, and every device creating noise within range. Action to initiate, up to several rounds to complete, depending on the difficulty of the task.

Anecdote (2 Intellect points): You can lift the spirits of a group of creatures and help them bond together by entertaining them with an uplifting or pointed anecdote. For the next hour, those who pay attention to your story are trained in a task you choose that's related to the anecdote, as long as it's not an attack or defense task. Action to initiate, one minute to complete.

Animal Scrying (4+ Intellect points): If you know the general location of an animal that is friendly toward you and within 1 mile (1.5 km) of your location, you can sense through its

senses for up to ten minutes. If you are not in animal form or not in a form similar to that animal, you must apply a level of Effort to use this ability. Action to establish.

Animal Shape (3+ Intellect points): You change into an animal as small as a rat or up to your own size (such as a large dog or small bear) for ten minutes. Each time you transform, you can take a different animal shape. Your equipment becomes part of the transformation, rendering it unusable unless it has a passive effect, such as armor. In this form your stats remain the same as your normal form, but you can move and attack according to your animal shape (attacks from most animals this size are medium weapons, which you can use without penalty). Tasks requiring hands (such as using door handles or pushing buttons) are hindered when in animal form. You cannot speak but can still use abilities that don't rely on human speech. You gain two minor abilities associated with the creature you become (see the Animal Form Minor Abilities table at the end of the Character Abilities section of this document). For example, if you transform into a bat, you become trained in perception and can fly up to a long distance each round. If you transform into an octopus, you are trained in stealth and can breathe underwater. If you apply a level of Effort when you use this ability, you can either become a talking animal or take a hybrid shape. The talking animal shape looks exactly like a normal animal, but you can still talk and use any abilities that rely on human speech. The hybrid shape is like your normal form but with animalistic features, even if that animal is something much smaller than you (such as a bat or rat). In this hybrid form you can speak, use all of your abilities, make attacks like an animal, and perform tasks using hands without being hindered. Anyone who sees you clearly in this hybrid form would never mistake you for a mere animal. Action to change or revert.

"Similar" is a broad term. Lions are similar to tigers and leopards, hawks are similar to ravens and swans, dogs are similar to wolves and foxes, and so on.

Even if your animal shape has multiple attack types (such as claws and bite), you can attack only once per round unless you have some other ability that lets you make additional attacks on your turn.

Animal Shape variant: If your character concept is that you always take the same animal form instead of being able to choose from multiple kinds of animals, double the duration of the Animal Shape ability (to twenty minutes per use). The GM may allow characters with this restriction to learn additional animal forms by spending 4 XP as a long-term benefit.

7.2.1 Animal Form Minor Abilities Table

Use the following as examples or suggestions of what a character gains when in the shape of an animal. If an animal shape lists two skills, the character chooses which one they want each time they take that shape.

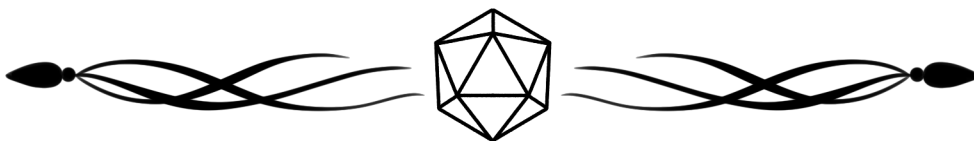


Table 7.1: Animal Form Minor Abilities

Task Animal	Skill Training	Other Abilities
Ape	Climbing	Hands
Badger	Climbing	Scent
Bat	Perception	Flying
Bear	Climbing	Scent
Bird	Perception	Flying
Boar	Might Defense	Scent
Cat	Climbing or Stealth	Small
Constrictor snake	Climbing	Constrict
Crocodile	Stealth or Swimming	Constrict
Deinonychus	Perception	Fast
Dolphin	Perception or Swimming	Fast
Fish	Stealth or Swimming	Aquatic
Frog	Jumping or Stealth	Aquatic
Horse	Perception	Fast
Leopard	Climbing or Stealth	Fast
Lizard	Climbing or Stealth	Small
OCtopus	Stealth	Aquatic
Shark	Swimming	Aquatic
Turtle	Might Defense	Armor
Venomous snake	Climbing	Venom
Wolf	Perception	Scent

- **Aquatic:** The animal either breathes water instead of air or is able to breathe water in addition to breathing air.
- **Armor:** The animal has a thick hide or shell, granting +1 to Armor.
- **Constrict:** The animal can grip its opponent fast after making a melee attack (usually with a bite or claw), easing attack rolls against that foe on later turns until it releases the foe.
- **Fast:** The animal can move a long distance on its turn instead of a short distance.
- **Flying:** The animal can fly, which (depending on the type of animal) may be up to a short or long distance on its turn.
- **Hands:** The animal has paws or hands that are nearly as agile as those of a human. Unlike with most animal shapes, the animal's tasks that require hands are not hindered (although the GM may decide that some tasks requiring human agility, such as playing a flute, are still hindered).
- **Scent:** The animal has a strong sense of smell, gaining an asset on tracking and dealing with darkness or blindness.
- **Small:** The animal is considerably smaller than a human, easing its Speed defense tasks but hindering tasks to move heavy things.
- **Venom:** The animal is poisonous (usually through a bite), inflicting 1 additional point of damage.

Animal Senses and Sensibilities: You are trained in listening and spotting things. In addition, most of the time, the GM should alert you if you're about to walk into an ambush or a trap that is lower than level 5. Enabler.

Answering Attack (3 Speed points): If you are struck in melee, you can make an immediate melee attack against that attacker once per round. The attack is hindered, and you can still take your normal action during the round. Enabler.

Anticipate Attack (4 Intellect points): You can sense when and how creatures attacking you will make their attacks. Speed defense rolls are eased for one minute. Action.

Anticipation (1 Intellect point): You look ahead to see how your actions might unfold. The first task you perform before the end of the next round gains an asset. Action.

Automatic Glow: Hard light objects you create with your type and focus abilities shed light, illuminating everything in immediate range. Whenever you want, your body (entirely or just part of it) sheds light, illuminating everything in short range. Enabler.

Applying Your Knowledge: When you help another character undertake any action that you're untrained in, you are treated as if you are trained in it. Action.

Apportation (4 Intellect points): You call a physical object to you. You can choose any piece of normal equipment on the standard equipment list, or (no more than once per day) you can allow the GM to determine the object randomly. If you call a random object, it has a 10 percent chance of being a manifest cypher or artifact, a 50 percent chance of being a piece of standard equipment, and a 40 percent chance of being a bit of worthless junk. You can't use this ability to take an item held by another creature. Action.

Aquatic Combatant: You ignore penalties for any action (including fighting) in underwater environments. Enabler.

Arc Spray (3 Speed points): If a weapon has the ability to fire rapid shots without reloading (usually called a rapid-fire weapon, such as a crank crossbow), you can fire your weapon at up to three targets (all next to one another) at once. Make a separate attack roll against each target. Each attack is hindered. Action.

Arcane Flare (1 Intellect point): You enhance the damage

of another attack spell with an extra charge of energy so that it deals 1 additional point of damage. Alternatively, you attack a target within long range by projecting a flare of raw magic that inflicts 4 points of damage. Enabler for enhancement; action for long-range attack.

Artifact Scavenger (6 Intellect points + 2 XP): You've developed a sixth sense for searching for the most valuable items in the wasteland. If you spend the time required to succeed on two scavenging tasks, you can exchange all the results you would otherwise obtain for a chance to gain an artifact of the GM's choosing if you succeed on a difficulty 6 Intellect task. You can use this ability at most once per day, and never within the same general area. Action to initiate, several hours to complete.

Artifact Tinkerer: If you spend at least one day tinkering with an artifact in your possession, it functions at one level higher than normal. This applies to all artifacts in your possession, but they retain this bonus only for you. Enabler.

As Foretold in Prophecy: You accomplish something that proves you are truly the chosen one. The next task you attempt is eased by three steps. You can't use this ability again until after you've taken a one-hour or a ten-hour recovery action. Action.

As If One Creature: When you and your beast (from your Beast Companion ability) are within immediate distance of each other, you can share damage inflicted on either of you. For instance, if one of you is struck by a weapon for 4 points of damage, divide the damage between the two of you as you see fit. Only the Armor and resistances of the target initially damaged come into play. So if you have 2 Armor and are struck by a force blast for 4 points of damage, your beast can take the 2 points of damage you would suffer, but their Armor does not come into play, nor does their immunity to force blasts, if any. Enabler.

Assassin Skills: You are trained in stealth and disguise tasks. Enabler.

Assassin Strike (5 Intellect points): If you successfully attack a creature that was previously unaware of your presence, you deal 9 additional points of damage. Enabler.

Asserting Your Privilege (3 Intellect points): Acting as only a privileged person can, you verbally harangue a foe who can hear and understand you so forcefully that they are unable to take any action, including attacks, for one round. Whether you succeed or fail, the next action the target takes is hindered.

Action.

Assume Control (6+ Intellect points): You control the actions of another creature you have interacted with or studied for at least a round. This effect lasts for ten minutes. The target must be level 2 or lower. Once you have assumed control, the target acts as if it wants to accomplish your desire to the best of its ability, freely using its own best judgment unless you use an action to give it a specific instruction on an issue-by-issue basis. In addition to the normal options for using Effort, you can choose to use Effort to increase the maximum level of the target. Thus, to attempt to command a level 5 target (three levels above the normal limit), you must apply three levels of Effort. When the effect ends, the target remembers everything that happened and reacts according to its nature and your relationship to it; assuming control might have soured that relationship if it was previously a positive one. Action to initiate.

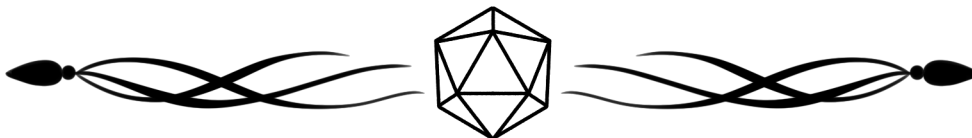
Athlete: You are trained in carrying, climbing, jumping, and smashing. Enabler.

Attack and Attack Again: Rather than granting additional damage or a minor or major effect, a natural 17 or higher on your attack roll allows you the option of immediately making another attack. Enabler.

Attack Flourish: With your attack, you add stylish moves, entertaining quips, or a certain something that entertains or impresses others. One creature you choose within short range who can see you gains an asset to its next task if taken within a round or two. Enabler. **Augment Cypher** (2+ Intellect points): When you activate a cypher, add +1 to its level. In addition to the normal options for using Effort, you can choose to use Effort to increase the level of the cypher by an additional +1 (per level of Effort applied). You can't increase the cypher's level above 10. Enabler.

Autodoctor: You are trained in healing, performing surgical procedures, and withstanding pain. You can perform surgeries on yourself, remaining conscious while you do so. Enabler.

Awareness (3 Intellect points): You become hyperaware of your surroundings in order to better locate your target. For ten minutes, you are aware of all living things within long range (including their general position), and by concentrating (another action), you can attempt to learn the general health and power level of any one of them. Action.



7.3 Abilities—B

Babel: After hearing a language spoken for a few minutes, you can speak it and make yourself understood. If you continue to use the language to interact with native speakers, your skills improve rapidly, to the point where you might be mistaken for a native speaker after just a few hours of speaking the new language. Enabler.

Balance: You are trained in balancing. Enabler.

Band of Desperados: Your reputation draws a band of six level 2 desperado NPC followers who are completely devoted to you. You and the GM must work out the details of these followers. If a follower dies, you gain a new one after at least two weeks and proper recruitment. Enabler.

Band of Followers: You gain four level 3 followers. They are not restricted on their modifications. Enabler.

Bash (1 Might point): This is a pummeling melee attack. Your attack inflicts 1 less point of damage than normal, but dazes your target for one round, during which time all tasks it performs are hindered. Action.

Basic Follower: You gain a level 2 follower. One of their modifications must be persuasion. You can take this ability multiple times, each time gaining another level 2 follower. Enabler. (When you use Basic Follower, the GM may require that you actually look for a suitable follower.)

Battle Management (4 Intellect points): As long as you use your action each round giving orders or advice, attack and defense actions taken by your allies within short range are eased. Action.

Battlefield Tactician (2+ Intellect points): You scrutinize your surroundings, learning whatever facts the GM feels are pertinent about attacking, defending, maneuvering, and dealing with environmental hazards within a short distance. For example, you might notice a pile of rubble you can stand on for an advantage in melee, a sheltered corner to help protect against enemy attacks, a less-slippery part of a frozen lake, or a place where the poison gas is thinner than elsewhere. If you (or someone you tell) move to that location, you (or they) gain an asset on tasks related to that optimal position (such as attack rolls from the high ground, Speed defense rolls from the sheltered corner, balance rolls on the frozen lake, or Might defense rolls against the poisonous cloud). Instead of gaining an advantageous location, you might learn of a disadvantageous location that you could use against your enemies, such as maneuvering them into an awkward corner that hinders their melee attacks or a weak spot on the frozen lake that will break if they stand on it. You can apply Effort to learn one additional good or bad location within range (one location per level of Effort), increase the range of this ability (another short distance per level of Effort), or both. Enabler.

Beast Call (5 Intellect points): You summon a horde of small animals or a single level 4 beast to help you temporarily. These creatures do your bidding for as long as you focus your attention, but you must use your action each turn to direct them. Creatures are native to the area and arrive under their own power, so if you're in an unreachable place, this ability won't work. Action.

Beast Companion: A level 2 creature of your size or smaller accompanies you and follows your instructions. You and the GM must work out the details of your creature, and you'll probably make rolls for it in combat or when it takes actions. The beast companion acts on your turn. As a level 2 creature, it has a target number of 6 and 6 health and it inflicts

2 points of damage. Its movement is based on its creature type (avian, swimmer, and so on). If your beast companion dies, you can hunt in the wild for 1d6 days to find a new one. Enabler. (A creature's level determines its target number, health, and damage, unless otherwise stated. So a level 2 beast companion has a target number of 6 and a health of 6, and it inflicts 2 points of damage. A level 4 beast companion has a target number of 12 and a health of 12, and it inflicts 4 points of damage. And so on.)

Beast Eyes (3 Intellect points): By linking to the creature from your Beast Companion ability, you can perceive through its senses if it is within 1 mile (1.5 km) of you. This effect lasts up to ten minutes. Action to establish.

Beast Form: On five consecutive nights each month, you change into a monstrous beast for up to one hour each night. In this new form, you gain +8 to your Might Pool, +1 to your Might Edge, +2 to your Speed Pool, and +1 to your Speed Edge. While in beast form, you can't spend Intellect points for any reason other than to try to change to your normal form before the one-hour duration is over (a difficulty 2 task). In addition, you attack any and every living creature within short range. After you revert to your normal form, you take a –1 penalty to all rolls for one hour. If you did not kill and eat at least one substantial creature while in beast form, the penalty increases to –2 and affects all your rolls for the next 24 hours. Action to change back.

Beneath Notice: Your decreased size makes it difficult to find you. While Shrink is active on you, all stealth tasks you attempt are eased. Enabler.

Bestiary Knowledge: You are trained in the lore of flesh-eating, nonhumanoid creatures—recognizing them, knowing their weaknesses, and knowing their habits and behaviors. Enabler.

Betrayal: Any time you convince a foe that you are not a threat and then suddenly attack it (without provocation), the attack deals 4 additional points of damage. Enabler.

Better Living Through Chemistry (4 Intellect points): You've developed drug cocktails specifically designed to work with your own biochemistry. Depending on which one you inject, it makes you smarter, faster, or tougher, but when it wears off, the crash is a doozy, so you use it only in desperate situations. You gain 2 to your Might Edge, Speed Edge, or Intellect Edge for one minute, after which you can't gain the benefit again for one hour. During this follow-up hour, every time you spend points from a Pool, increase the cost by 1. Action.

Better Surprise Attack: If attacking from a hidden vantage, with surprise, or before an opponent has acted, you get an asset on the attack (if you have Surprise Attack, this is in addition to the asset from that ability). On a successful hit with this surprise attack, you inflict 2 additional points of damage (for a total of 4 additional points of damage if you have Surprise Attack). Enabler.

Bigger: When you use Enlarge, you can choose to grow up to 12 feet (4 m) in height, and you add 3 more temporary points to your Might Pool. Enabler.

Bigger Animal Shape: When you use Animal Shape, your animal form grows to about twice its normal size. Being so large, your beast form gains the following additional bonuses: +1 to Armor, +5 to your Might Pool, and you are trained in using your animal form's natural attacks as heavy weapons (if you weren't already). However, your Speed defense tasks are hindered. While bigger, you also gain an asset to tasks that are easier for a larger creature to perform, like climbing, intimidat-

ing, wading rivers, and so on. Enabler.

Bigger Beast Form: When you use Beast Form, your beast form grows bigger than before, during which time you achieve a height of 12 feet (4 m). Being so large, your beast form gains the following additional bonuses: +1 to Armor, +5 to your Might Pool, and you are trained in using your fists as heavy weapons (if you weren't already). However, your Speed defense tasks are hindered. While bigger, you also gain an asset to tasks that are easier for a larger creature to perform, like climbing, intimidating, wading rivers, and so on. Enabler.

Biomorphic Detonation (7+ Might points): You radiate a pulse of biomorphic energy up to a short distance away, but you tune it to disrupt life in an area an immediate distance across. All within the detonation take 5 points of damage that ignores Armor (unless it is Armor provided by a force field effect). If you apply additional Effort to increase the damage, you deal 2 additional points of damage per level of Effort (instead of 3 points); targets in the area take 1 point of damage even if you fail the attack roll. Action.

Biomorphic Healing (4+ Might points): You consciously send out a pulse of your biomorphic field (a strange energy your body generates) and focus it on a living creature within short range. The target gains a free and immediate one-action recovery roll. You can't use this ability again on that creature until after its next ten-hour rest. Action.

Blameless: You are trained in one of the following: deception, stealth, or disguise. Enabler.

Blend In (4 Intellect points): When you blend in, creatures still see you, but they attach no importance to your presence for about a minute. While blending in, you are specialized in stealth and Speed defense tasks. This effect ends if you do something to reveal your presence or position—attacking, using an ability, moving a large object, and so on. If this occurs, you can regain the remaining period of effect by taking an action to focus on seeming innocuous and as if you belong. Action to initiate or reinitiate.

Blessing of the Gods: As a servant of the gods, you can call up blessings in their name. This blessing depends on the god's general demeanor and area of influence. Choose two of the abilities described below.

- **Authority/Law/Peace** (3 Intellect points). You prevent a foe that can hear and understand you from attacking anyone or anything for one round. Action.
- **Benevolence/Righteousness/Spirit** (2+ Intellect points). One level 1 demon, spirit, or similar creature within short range is destroyed or banished. In addition to the normal options for using Effort, you can choose to use Effort to increase the maximum level of the target. Thus, to destroy or banish a level 5 target (four levels above the normal limit), you must apply four levels of Effort. Action.
- **Death/Darkness** (2 Intellect points). A target you choose within short range withers, suffering 3 points of damage. Action.
- **Desire/Love/Health** (3 Intellect points). With a touch, you restore 1d6 points to one stat Pool of any creature, including yourself. This ability is a difficulty 2 Intellect task. Each time you attempt to heal the same creature, the task is hindered by an additional step. The difficulty returns to 2 after that creature rests for ten hours. Action.

- **Earth/Stone.** You are trained in climbing, stonecraft, and spelunking. Enabler.
- **Knowledge/Wisdom** (3 Intellect points). Choose up to three creatures (potentially including yourself). For one minute, a particular type of task (but not an attack roll or defense roll) is eased for those creatures, but only while they remain within immediate range of you. Action.
- **Nature/Animals/Plants.** You are trained in botany and handling natural animals. Enabler.
- **Protection/Silence** (3 Intellect points). You create a quiet bubble of protection around you to an immediate radius for one minute. The bubble moves with you. All defense rolls for you and all creatures you designate within the bubble are eased, and no noise, regardless of its origin, sounds louder than a normal speaking voice. Action to initiate.
- **Sky/Air** (2 Intellect points). A creature you touch is immune to airborne toxins or contaminants for ten minutes. Action.
- **Sun/Light/Fire** (2 Intellect points). You cause one creature or object within short range to catch fire, inflicting 1 point of ambient damage each round until the fire is extinguished (requiring an action). Action.
- **Trickery/Greed/Commerce.** You are trained in detecting the deceptions of other creatures. Enabler.
- **War** (1 Intellect point). A target you choose within short range (potentially yourself) deals 2 additional points of damage with its next successful weapon attack. Action.
- **Water/Sea** (2 Intellect points). A target you touch can breathe water for ten minutes. Action.

Blind Machine (6 Speed points): You deactivate the sensory apparatus of a machine, making it effectively blind until it can be repaired. You must either touch the target or strike it with a ranged attack (inflicting no damage). Action.

Blinding Attack (3 Speed points): If you have a source of light, you can use it to make a melee attack against a target. If successful, the attack deals no damage, but the target is blinded for one minute. Action.

Blink of an Eye (4 Speed points): You move up to 1,000 feet (300 m) in one round. Action.

Block (3 Speed points): You automatically block the next melee attack made against you within the next minute. Action to initiate.

Block for Another: If you use a light or medium weapon, you can block attacks made against an ally near you. Choose one creature within immediate range. You provide an asset to that creature's Speed defense tasks. You can't use Quick Block while using Block for Another. Enabler.

Blood Fever: When you have no points in one or two Pools, you gain an asset to attacks or defense rolls (your choice). Enabler.

Bloodlust (3 Might points): If you take down a foe, you can move a short distance, but only if you move toward another foe. You don't need to spend the points until you know that the first foe is down. Enabler.

Blurring Speed (7 Speed points): You move so quickly that until your next turn, you look like a blur. While you are blurred, if you apply Effort to a melee attack task or Speed defense task, you get a free level of Effort on that task; you can

move a short distance as part of another action or a long distance as your entire action. Enabler.

Body Morph (3+ Intellect points): You alter your facial and bodily features and coloration for one hour, hiding your identity or impersonating someone. If you apply a level of Effort, you can imitate a specific person accurately enough to fool someone who knows them well or has observed them closely (including fingerprints and voice prints, but not their retina print or DNA). You have an asset in all tasks involving disguise (this is in addition to the asset from Face Morph). You must apply a separate level of Effort to be able to impersonate a different species (such as a human morphing into a humanoid alien). Action.

Bolt Rider (4 Intellect points): You can move a long distance from one location to another almost instantaneously, carried by a bolt of lightning. You must be able to see the new location, and there must be no intervening barriers. Action.

Bolts of Power (5+ Intellect points): You blast a fan of lightning out to short range in an arc that is approximately 50 feet (15 m) wide at the end. This discharge inflicts 4 points of damage. If you apply Effort to increase the damage rather than to ease the task, you deal 2 additional points of damage per level of Effort (instead of 3 points); targets in the area take 1 point of damage even if you fail the attack roll. Action.

Bolster Illusion (2+ Intellect points): You give one of your visual illusions a limited physical reality that viewers can smell, taste, hear, and feel. This effect is bound to that illusion and acts appropriate to the illusion itself. For example, it can make the illusion of a brick wall feel like brick, the illusion of a person smell like perfume and able to open a door, and the illusion of a fireplace hot to the touch.

The physical reality provided to your illusion is a level 1 effect with 3 health. If the illusion is used to make attacks, it inflicts only 1 point of damage (whether this is regular damage like an illusory punch or kick, or ambient damage like a falling brick wall or a fireplace's flames). You can increase the level of the created effect by applying levels of Effort to this ability, each level of Effort increasing the effect's level by 1.

You can activate this ability as part of the action to create an illusion (using whatever ability it is that you use to create illusions, such as Minor Illusion), or use a separate action to apply it to one of your existing illusions. The effect ends if the illusion is destroyed, you let the illusion lapse, the effect's health is reduced to 0, or ten minutes pass. Enabler.

Boost Manifest Cypher (2 Intellect points): The manifest cypher you activate with your next action functions as if it were 2 levels higher. Action.

Boost Manifest Cypher Function (4 Intellect points): Add 3 to the functioning level of a manifest cypher that you activate with your next action, or change one aspect of its parameters (range, duration, area, etc.) by up to double or down to one tenth. Action.

Bouncing Shield: When you use Throw Force Shield, instead of dissipating after one attack (whether it hits or misses), it will attack up to two additional targets within short range. Effort or other modifiers applied to the first attack affect all other targets as well. Whether you hit all, some, or none of your targets, the shield dissipates and then reforms in your grasp. (If you choose Bouncing Shield and have previously taken the Throw Force Shield ability, you have the option to exchange that ability for Healing Pulse.) Enabler.

Bound Magic Creature: You have a level 3 magic ally bound to a physical object (perhaps a minor djinn bound to a lamp, a lesser demon bound to a coin, or a spirit bound to a mir-

ror). The magic ally doesn't yet have the full power that one of its kind could possess when mature. Normally, the ally remains quiescent in its bound object. When you use an action to manifest it, it appears next to you as a creature that can converse with you. The creature has its own personality determined by the GM and is a level higher than its base level for one area of knowledge (such as local history). The GM determines whether the magic ally has a long-term goal of its own.

Each time the magic ally becomes physically manifest, it remains so for up to one hour. During that period, it accompanies you and follows your instructions. The magic ally must remain an immediate distance from you; if it moves farther away, it is yanked back into its object at the end of your following turn and cannot return until after your next ten-hour recovery roll. It doesn't attack creatures, but it can use its action to serve as an asset for any one attack you make on your turn. Otherwise, it can take actions on its own (though you'll likely roll for it).

If the creature is reduced to 0 health, it dissipates. It reforms in its object in 1d6 + 2 days.

If you lose the bound object, you retain a sense of the direction in which it lies. Action to manifest the magic creature.

Brainwashing (6+ Intellect points): You use trickery, well-spoken lies, and mind-affecting chemicals (or other means, like magic or high technology) to make others temporarily do what you want them to do. You control the actions of another creature you touch. This effect lasts for one minute. The target must be level 3 or lower. You can allow it to act freely or override its control on a case-by-case basis as long as you can see it. In addition to the normal options for using Effort, you can choose to use Effort to increase the maximum level of the target or increase the duration by one minute. Thus, to control the mind of a level 6 target (three levels above the normal limit) or control a target for four minutes (three minutes above the normal duration), you must apply three levels of Effort. When the duration ends, the creature doesn't remember being controlled or anything it did while under your influence. Action to initiate.

Break the Line (4 Intellect points): You have an eye for group discipline and hierarchy, even among your foes. If a group of foes is gaining any kind of benefit from working together, you can attempt to disrupt that benefit by pointing out the weak spot in the enemy's line, formation, or swarm attack. This effect lasts for up to a minute or until all the affected foes spend a round assessing and resetting themselves to regain their normal advantage. Action to initiate.

Break the Ranks (6 Speed points): You move up to a short distance and attack up to four different foes as a single action as long as they are all along your path. Any modifiers that apply to one attack apply to all the attacks you make. If you have another special ability that allows you to move and take an action, when you use Break the Ranks, you gain an asset to attacking these foes. Action.

Break Their Mind (7+ Intellect points): Using your clever words and knowledge of others, and given a couple of rounds of conversation to gain a few specific pieces of context regarding your target, you can utter a sentence designed to cause your target immediate psychological distress. If the target can hear and understand you, it suffers 6 points of Intellect damage (ignores Armor) and forgets the last day of its life, which might mean it forgets you and how it came to be where it currently is. In addition to the normal options for using Effort, you can choose to use Effort to attempt to break the mind of one additional target who can hear and understand you. Action to initiate, action to complete.

Breaker: You are trained in tasks related to damaging objects with the goal of breaking, piercing, or demolishing them. It is a Might action to damage an object, and on a success, the object moves one step down the object damage track. If the Might roll exceeds the difficulty by two steps, the object instead moves two steps down the object damage track. If the Might roll exceeds the difficulty by four steps, the object moves three steps down the object damage track and is immediately destroyed. Brittle material reduces the effective level of the object, while hard material like wood or stone adds 1 to the effective level or 2 for very hard objects like those made of metal. Enabler.

Brute Strike (4 Might points): You deal 4 additional points of damage with all melee attacks until the end of the next round. Enabler.

Buddy System (3 Intellect points): Choose one character standing next to you. That character becomes your buddy for ten minutes. You are trained in all tasks involving finding, healing, interacting with, and protecting your buddy. Also, while you stand next to your buddy, both of you have an asset on Speed defense tasks. You can have only one buddy at a time. Action to initiate.

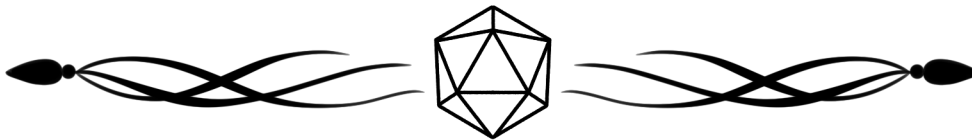
Built-in Weaponry: Biomechanical implants, a magical jewel fused to your forehead, or something just as wild now

provides you with inherent weaponry. This allows you to fire a blast of energy up to long range that inflicts 5 points of damage. There is no cost for you to use this ability. Action.

Burning Light (3 Intellect points): You send a beam of light at a creature within long range and then tighten the beam until it burns, inflicting 5 points of damage. Action.

Burst of Escape (5 Speed points): You can take two separate actions this round, as long as one of them is to hide or to move in a direction that is not toward a foe. Enabler.

Bypass Barrier (6+ Intellect points): You get past a door, force field, or other barrier up to 3 feet (1 m) thick that is blocking your way. Depending on the barrier, this might involve finding a weak spot you can push through, pressing the right button by luck, just breaking through, or even weirder explanations like touching a thin place between dimensions or an unexpected interaction with your equipment. The difficulty of the task is the level of the barrier. This ability allows you alone to pass through, not anyone else, and the way through closes at the end of your turn (which might mean you're trapped on the far side). You have an asset in any attempts to get through it again. In addition to the normal options for using Effort, you can choose to use Effort to increase the maximum thickness of the barrier, each level adding 3 feet (1 m). Action.



7.4 Abilities—C

Call Dead Spirit (6 Intellect points): At your touch, the remains of a creature dead no longer than seven days appears as a manifest (and apparently physical) spirit, whose level is the same as it had in life. The raised spirit persists for up to a day (or less, if it accomplishes something important to it before then), after which it fades away and cannot return again.

The raised spirit remembers everything it knew in life and possesses most of its previous abilities (though not necessarily its equipment). In addition, it gains the ability to become insubstantial as an action for up to a minute at a time. The raised spirit is not beholden to you, and it does not need to stay near you to remain manifest. Action to initiate.

Call in Favor (4 Intellect points): A guard, doctor, technician, or hired thug in the employ of or allied with a foe is secretly your ally or owes you a favor. When you call in the favor, the target does what they can to help you out of a specific fix (unties you, slips you a knife, leaves a cell door unlocked) in a way that minimizes their risk of revealing their divided loyalties to their employer or other allies. This ability is a difficulty 3 Intellect task. Each additional time you use this ability, the task is hindered by an additional step. The difficulty returns to 3 after you rest for ten hours. Action.

Call Otherworldly Spirit (6 Intellect points): You summon a spirit creature that manifests for up to a day (or less, if it accomplishes something important to it before then), after which it fades away and cannot be summoned again. The spirit is a creature of level 6 or lower, and it can be substantial or insubstantial as it wishes (using an action to change). The spirit is not beholden to you, and it does not need to stay near you to remain manifest. Action to initiate.

Call the Storm (7+ Intellect points): If you are outside or in a location that has a ceiling at least 300 feet (90 m) above the floor, you summon a boiling layer of lightning-lit, rumbling clouds up to 1,500 feet (460 m) in diameter for ten minutes. During daylight hours, natural illumination beneath the storm is reduced to dim light. While the storm rages, you can use an action to send a lightning bolt from the cloud to attack a target you can see directly, inflicting 4 points of damage (you can spend Effort normally on each individual lightning bolt attack). Three actions to initiate; action to call down a lightning strike.

Call Swarm (4 Intellect points): If you're in a location where it's possible for the creatures from your Influence Swarm ability to come, you call a swarm of them for one hour. During this hour, they do as you telepathically command as long as they are within long range. They can swarm about and hinder any or all opponents' tasks. While the creatures are in long range, you can speak to them telepathically and perceive through their senses. Action to initiate.

Call Through Time (6+ Intellect points): You call a creature or person of up to level 3 from the recent past, and it appears next to you. You can choose a creature that you've previously encountered (even if it is now dead), or (no more than once per day) you can allow the GM to determine the creature randomly. If you call a random creature, it has a 10 percent chance of being a creature of up to level 5. The creature has no memory of anything before being called by you, though it can speak and has the general knowledge a creature of its type should possess. The time-shifted creature does your bidding for as long as you concentrate on it, but you must use your action each turn to direct it; otherwise it returns to the past.

In addition to the normal options for using Effort, you can

choose to use Effort to call a more powerful creature; each level of Effort used in this way increases the creature's level by 1. For example, applying one level of Effort calls a specific creature of up to level 4 or a random creature with a 10 percent chance of being up to level 6. Action.

Calm (3 Intellect points): Through jokes, song, or other art, you prevent a living foe from attacking anyone or anything for one round. Action.

Calm Stranger (2+ Intellect points): You can cause one intelligent creature to remain calm as you speak. The creature doesn't need to speak your language, but it must be able to see you. It remains calm as long as you focus all your attention on it and it is not attacked or otherwise threatened. In addition to the normal options for using Effort, you can choose to use Effort to calm additional creatures allied with your initial target, one additional creature per level of Effort applied. Action.

Capable Warrior: Your attacks deal 1 additional point of damage. Enabler.

Captivate or Inspire: You can use this ability in one of two ways. Either your words keep the attention of all NPCs that hear them for as long as you speak, or your words inspire all NPCs that hear them to function as if they were one level higher for the next hour. In either case, you choose which NPCs are affected. If anyone in the crowd is attacked while you're trying to speak to them, you lose the crowd's attention. Action to initiate.

Captivate With Starshine: For as long as you speak, you keep the attention of all level 2 or lower NPCs who can hear you. If you also have the Enthrall ability, you can similarly captivate all level 3 NPCs. Action to initiate.

Car Surfer: You can stand or move about on a moving vehicle (such as on the hood, on the roof, in the open door well, etc.) with a reasonable expectation of not falling off. Unless the vehicle veers sharply, stops suddenly, or otherwise engages in extreme maneuvers, standing or moving about on a moving vehicle is a routine task for you. If the vehicle engages in extreme maneuvers like those described, any tasks to remain on the vehicle's surface are eased. Enabler.

Careful Aim: You are trained in attacks with all weapons that you throw. Enabler.

Careful Shot: You can spend points from either your Speed Pool or your Intellect Pool to apply levels of Effort to increase your gun damage. Each level of Effort adds 3 points of damage to a successful attack, and if you spend a turn lining up your shot, each level of Effort instead adds 5 points of damage to a successful attack. Enabler.

Cast Illusion: You can increase the range at which you create and maintain your immediate-range illusions (such as from Minor Illusion) to anywhere within short range that you can perceive. Enabler.

Castigate (4 Intellect points): You intimidate any opponent within long range who understands speech (even if it is not your language) so much that they lose their next action and all the rest of their actions are hindered for one minute. Each additional time you attempt this ability against the same target, you must apply one more level of Effort than you applied on the previous attempt. Action.

Celebrity Talent: You are trained in two of the following areas: writing, journalism, a particular style of art, a particular sport, chess, science communication, acting, news presentation, or some related noncombat skill that led to your celebrity. Enabler.

Center of Attention (5 Intellect points): A literal (or metaphorical, depending on the genre) beam of pure radiance

descends from on high and spotlights you. All creatures you choose within immediate range fall to their knees and lose their next action. Affected targets cannot defend themselves and are treated as helpless. Action.

Chamber of Dreams (8 Intellect points): You and your allies can step into a chamber of dreams, decorated as you wish, that contains a number of doors. The doors correspond with other locations that you have visited or know reasonably well. Stepping through one of the doors delivers you to the desired location. This is a difficulty 2 Intellect-based task (which could be modified upward by the GM if the location is warded). Action to step into chamber of dreams; action to move through a door in the chamber.

Change the Paradigm (6+ Intellect points): You sway the worldview of a creature you spend at least one round speaking to, as long as it can understand you. The creature changes its mind on a significant belief, which could include something as straightforward as helping you instead of trying to kill you, or it could be something more esoteric. This effect lasts for at least ten minutes, but it can last longer if the creature wasn't previously your foe. During this time, the creature takes actions in accordance with the wisdom you have imparted to it. The target must be level 2 or lower. In addition to the normal options for using Effort, you can choose to use Effort to increase the maximum level of the target by one for each level of Effort applied. Action to initiate.

Charge (1+ Intellect points): You can charge an artifact or other device (except a cypher) so that it can be used once. The cost is 1 Intellect point plus 1 point per level of the device. Action.

Charge Weapon (2+ Intellect points): As part of making an attack with your enchanted weapon, you charge it with magical power, inflicting 2 additional points of energy damage. If you make more than one attack on your turn, you choose whether to spend the cost for this ability before you make each attack. Enabler.

Charging Horde (7 Might points): You and two or more of your followers next to you can act like a single creature to make a charge attack. When you do, all of you move up to a short distance, during which time you can attack anything that comes within immediate range along your path with an asset to the attack. Targets that take damage take an additional 3 points and are knocked prone. Action.

Charm Machine (2 Intellect points): You convince an unintelligent machine to "like" you. A machine that likes you is 50 percent less likely to function if said function would cause you harm. Thus, if a foe attempts to detonate a bomb near you controlled by a detonator that likes you, there is a 50 percent chance that it won't explode. Action to initiate.

Cloak of Opportunity (5 Intellect points): You set small objects from the environment (rocks, broken items, clumps of dirt, and so on) swirling about you for up to ten minutes, which grants you +2 Armor. Action to initiate.

Closed Mind: You are trained in Intellect defense tasks and have +2 Armor against damage that selectively targets your Intellect Pool (which normally ignores Armor). Enabler.

Cloud Personal Memories (3 Intellect points): If you interact with or study a target for at least a round, you gain a sense of how its mind works, which you can use against it in the most blunt fashion possible. You can attempt to confuse it and make it forget what's just happened. On a success, you erase up to the last five minutes of its memory. Action to prepare; action to initiate.

Coaxing Power (2 Intellect points): You boost the power or function of a machine so that it operates at one level higher than normal for one hour. Action to initiate.

Cognizant Offense: During combat, your brain shifts into a sort of battle mode where all potential attacks you could make are plotted on vector graphs in your mind's eye, which always provides the best option. Your attacks are eased. Enabler.

Cold Burst (5+ Intellect points): You emit a burst of cold in all directions, up to short range. All within the burst (except you) take 5 points of damage. If you apply Effort to increase the damage rather than to ease the task, you deal 2 additional points of damage per level of Effort (instead of 3 points); targets in the area take 1 point of damage even if you fail the attack roll. Action.

Colossal: When you use Enlarge, you can choose to grow up to a base height of 60 feet (18 m). When you do, you add 5 more temporary points to your Might Pool (plus any from Gargantuan and Bigger), and you deal an additional 2 points of damage with melee attacks (plus any from your Huge ability). For each level of Effort you apply to increase your height further, your total height increases by 10 feet (3 m), and you add 1 more point to your Might Pool. Thus, the first time you use Enlarge after a ten-hour recovery roll, if you apply two levels of Effort, your base height is 80 feet (24 m), and you add a total of 17 temporary points to your Might Pool. Enabler.

Combat Challenge: All attempted tasks that draw an attack to yourself (and away from someone else) are eased by two steps. Enabler.

Combat Prowess: You add +1 damage to one type of weapon attack of your choice: melee weapon attacks or ranged weapon attacks. Enabler.

Command (3 Intellect points): Through sheer force of will, you can issue a simple imperative command to a single living creature, who then attempts to carry out your command as its next action. The creature must be within short range and able to understand you. The command can't inflict direct harm on the creature or its allies, so "Commit suicide" won't work, but "Flee" might. In addition, the command can require the creature to take only one action, so "Unlock the door" might work, but "Unlock the door and run through it" won't. A commanded creature can still defend itself normally and return an attack if one is made on it. If you possess another ability that allows you to command a creature, you can target two creatures at once as your base effect if you use either ability. Action.

Command Beast (3+ Intellect points): You can command a nonhostile, nonhuman beast (such as one that you've made calm with Soothe the Savage) of up to level 3 within short range. If you are successful, for the next minute the beast follows your verbal commands to the best of its understanding and ability. The GM has final say over what counts as a nonhuman beast, but unless some kind of deception is at work, you should know whether you can affect a creature before you attempt to use this ability on it. Aliens, extradimensional entities, very intelligent creatures, and robots never count.

In addition to the normal options for using Effort, you can choose to use Effort to increase the maximum level of the target. Thus, to command a level 5 beast (two levels above the normal limit), you must apply two levels of Effort. Action to initiate.

Command Machine (4 Intellect points): If you've charmed an unintelligent machine or have spoken telepathically with an intelligent machine, you can attempt to command it to take one action within its capabilities on its next turn. (If you

use this ability to command an intelligent machine, it likely becomes hostile to you afterward.) Action.

Command Metal (5 Intellect points): You reshape a metallic item as you desire. The item must be within sight and within short range, and its mass can be no greater than your own. You can affect multiple items at once as long as their combined mass falls within these limits. You can fuse multiple items together. You can use this power to destroy a metal object (as the Destroy Metal ability), or you can craft it into another desired shape (crudely, unless you have the proper crafting skills). You can then move the new object anywhere within range. For example, you could take a few metal shields, fuse them together, and use the resulting shape to block a doorway. You can use this ability to make an attack—causing a foe's armor to constrict, rendering a metal item into shards that you fling across the battlefield, and so on—against one target within short range. Regardless of the form of the attack, it is an Intellect action that deals 7 points of damage. Action.

Command Spirit (3 Intellect points): You can command a spirit or animated dead creature of up to level 5 within short range. If you are successful, the target cannot attack you for one minute, during which time it follows your verbal commands if it can hear and understand you. Action to initiate.

Communication (2 Intellect points): You can convey a basic concept to a creature that normally can't speak or understand speech. The creature can also give you a very basic answer to a simple question. Action.

Community Activist: When speaking to others in a community you have a strong connection to, you are trained in persuasion and intimidation tasks about topics that directly relate to the community. Enabler.

Community Knowledge (2 Intellect points): If you've invested yourself in a community and have spent at least a few months living there, you can learn things about it through a variety of methods. Sometimes contacts slip the information to you. Other times, you're able to draw conclusions simply by what you can see and hear. When you use this ability, you can ask the GM one question about the community and get a very short answer. Action.

Computer Programming: You are trained in using (and exploiting) computer software, you know one or more computer languages well enough to write basic programs, and you are fluent in internet protocol. Enabler.

Concussion (7 Intellect points): You cause a pulse of concussive force to explode out from a point you choose within long range. The pulse extends up to short range in all directions, dealing 5 points of damage to everything in the area. Even if you fail the attack roll, targets in the area take 1 point of damage. Action.

Concussive Blast (2 Intellect points): You release a beam of pure force that smashes into a creature within short range, inflicting 5 points of damage and moving it back an immediate distance. Action.

Confidence Artist: When you're hacking into a computer system, running a con, picking a pocket, fooling or tricking a dupe, sneaking something by a guard, and so on, you gain an asset on the task. Enabler.

Confounding Banter (4 Intellect points): You spew a stream of nonsense to distract a foe within immediate range. On a successful Intellect roll, your defense roll against the creature's next attack before the end of the next round is eased. Action.

Confuse Enemy (4 Intellect points): Through a clever bit

of misdirection involving a flourish of your coat, ducking at just the right moment, or a similar stratagem, you can attempt to redirect a physical melee attack that would otherwise hit you. When you do, the misdirected attack hits another creature you choose within immediate range of both you and the attacking foe. This ability is a difficulty 2 Intellect task. Enabler.

Conjuration (7 Intellect points): You produce, as if from thin air, a level 5 creature of a kind you have previously encountered. The creature remains for one minute and then returns home. While present, the creature acts as you direct, but this requires no action on your part. Action.

Connected: You know people who get things done—not just respected people in positions of authority, but also a variety of online hackers and regular street criminals. These people are not necessarily your friends and might not be trustworthy, but they owe you a favor. You and the GM should work out the details of your contacts. Enabler.

Contortionist (2 Speed points): You can wriggle free from bindings or squeeze through a tight spot. You are trained in escaping. When you use an action to escape or move through a tight area, you can immediately use another action. You may use this action only to move. Enabler.

Control the Field (1 Might point): This melee attack inflicts 1 less point of damage than normal, and regardless of whether you hit the target, you maneuver it into a position you desire within immediate range. Action.

Control Machine (6 Intellect points): You can attempt to control the functions of any machine, intelligent or otherwise, within short range for ten minutes. Action.

Control the Savage (6 Intellect points): You can control a calm nonhuman beast within 30 feet (9 m). You control it for as long as you focus all your attention on it, using your turn each round. The GM has final say over what counts as a nonhuman beast, but unless some kind of deception is at work, you should know whether you can affect a creature before you attempt to use this ability on it. Aliens, extradimensional entities, very intelligent creatures, and robots never count. Action.

Control Swarm (2 Intellect points): Your swarm creatures from your Influence Swarm ability within short range do as you telepathically command for ten minutes. Even common insects (level 0) in large enough numbers can swarm about a single creature and hinder its tasks. Action to initiate.

Control Weather (10 Intellect points): You change the weather in your general region. If performed indoors, this creates minor effects, such as mist, mild temperature changes, and so on. If performed outside, you can create rain, fog, snow, wind, or any other kind of normal (not overly severe) weather. The change lasts for a natural length of time so that a storm might last for an hour, fog for two or three hours, and snow for a few hours (or for ten minutes if it's out of season). For the first ten minutes after activating this ability, you can create more dramatic and specific effects, such as lightning strikes, giant hailstones, twisters, hurricane-force winds, and so on. These effects must occur within 1,000 feet (300 m) of your location. You must spend your turn concentrating to create an effect or maintain it in a new round. These effects inflict 6 points of damage each round. If you have this ability from another source, the cost for the ability is 7 Intellect points instead of 10. If you already have the Storm Seed ability, you can immediately replace it with a new ability of the same tier. Action to initiate.

Controlled Change: You can try to use your Beast Form ability to change into your beast form on any night you wish (a difficulty 3 Intellect task). Any transformations you make using

this power are in addition to the five nights per month that you change involuntarily. Action to change.

Controlled Fall: When you fall while you are able to use actions and within reach of a vertical surface, you can attempt to slow your fall. Make a Speed roll with a difficulty of 1 for every 20 feet (6 m) you fall. On a success, you take half damage from the fall. If you reduce the difficulty to 0, you take no damage. Enabler.

Coordinated Effort (3 Intellect points): When you and the duplicate from your Duplicate ability would attack the same creature, you can choose to make one attack roll with an asset. If you hit, you inflict damage with both attacks and treat the attacks as if they were one attack for the purpose of subtracting Armor from the damage. Action.

Copy Power (2+ Intellect points): You can copy someone else's superpower for an hour, performing it as if it were natural for you. Within the past hour you must have touched the creature whose power you want to copy (an attack roll) and must have seen that ability used by them. Choose the power you want to copy, and the GM chooses an appropriate low-tier ability that most closely resembles that power. For example, if you're battling a supervillain who can create blasts of force, if you copy that ability, you gain a low-tier ability that creates a blast of force. In addition to the point cost of Copy Power, you must pay the Might, Speed, or Intellect cost (if any) of the equivalent ability that the GM chose. For example, if you want to copy a supervillain's force blast, the GM will probably decide that's equivalent to Onslaught (167), so you'd pay 2 Intellect points to activate Copy Power and 1 Intellect point to use Onslaught.

You can copy only one power at a time; copying another one ends any other power you're copying with this ability.

Copy Power doesn't copy effects of a power that permanently adds points to your Pools, such as Enhanced Body (134).

In addition to the normal options for using Effort, you can choose to use Effort to copy an ability you saw longer than one hour ago; each level of Effort used in this way extends the time period by one hour. Action.

Counter Danger (4 Intellect points): You negate a source of potential danger related to one creature or object within immediate distance for one minute (instead of one round, as with Foil Danger). This could be a weapon or device held by someone, a creature's natural ability, or a trap triggered by a pressure plate. You can also try to counter an action (like moving or making a conventional mundane attack with a weapon, a claw, etc.). Action. (Using Counter Danger is usually a matter of the character applying quick thinking in the face of immediate danger. The ability doesn't rely on supernatural means, but rather a practical act.)

Countermeasures (4 Intellect points): You immediately end one ongoing effect (such as an effect created by a character ability) within immediate range. Alternatively, you can use this as a defense action to cancel any incoming ability targeted at you, or you can cancel any device or the effect of any device for 1d6 rounds. You must touch the effect or device to cancel it. Action.

Courageous: You are trained in Intellect defense tasks and initiative tasks. Enabler.

Crafter: You are trained in the crafting of two kinds of items. Enabler.

Create (7 Intellect points): You create something from nothing. You can create any item you choose that would ordinarily have a difficulty of 5 or lower (using the crafting rules). Once created, the item lasts for a number of hours equal to 6

minus the difficulty to create it. Thus, if you create a set of sturdy manacles (difficulty 5), it would last for one hour. Action.

Create Deadly Poison (3+ Intellect points): You create one dose of a level 2 poison that either inflicts 5 points of damage or hinders the poisoned creature's actions for ten minutes (your choice each time you create the poison). You can apply this poison to a weapon, food, or drink as part of the action of creating it. In addition to the normal options for using Effort, you can choose to use Effort to increase the level of the poison; each level of Effort used in this way increases the poison level by 1. If unused, the poison loses its potency after one hour. Action.

Create Water (2 Intellect points): You cause water to bubble up from a spot on the ground you can see. The water flows from that spot for one minute, creating about 1 gallon (4 liters) by the time it stops. Action to initiate.

Creature Insight (3 Intellect points): When examining any nonhuman creature, you can ask the GM one question to gain an idea of its level, its capabilities, what it eats, what motivates it, what its weaknesses are (if any), how it can be repaired, or any other similar query. This is for difficult or strange creatures beyond those readily identified by using skills. Action.

Critter Companion: A level 1 creature accompanies you and follows your instructions. This creature is no larger than a large cat (about 20 pounds, or 9 kg) and is normally some sort of domesticated species. You and the GM must work out the details of your creature, and you'll probably make rolls for it in combat or when it takes actions. The critter companion acts on your turn. As a level 1 creature, it has a target number of 3 and 3 health, and it inflicts 1 point of damage. Its movement is based on its creature type (avian, swimmer, and so on). If your critter companion dies, you can search an urban or wild environment for 1d6 days to find a new one. Enabler.

Crowd Control (6+ Intellect points): You control the actions of up to five creatures in short range. This effect lasts for one minute. All targets must be level 2 or lower. Your control is limited to simple verbal commands like "Stop," "Run away," "Follow that guard," "Look over there," or "Get out of my way." All affected creatures respond to the command unless you specifically command them otherwise. In addition to the normal options for using Effort, you can choose to use Effort to increase the maximum level of the targets or affect an additional five people. Thus, to control a group that has a level 4 target (two levels above the normal limit) or a group of fifteen people, you must apply two levels of Effort. When the Crowd Control ability ends, the creatures remember your commands but don't remember being controlled—your commands seemed reasonable at the time. Action to initiate.

Crushing Blow (2 Might points): When you use a bashing or bladed weapon in both hands and apply Effort on the attack, you get a free level of Effort on the damage. (If fighting unarmed, this attack is made with both fists or both feet together.) Action.

Crystal Lens: You can focus the inherent energy surging through you from your Crystalline Body ability. This allows you to fire a blast of energy that inflicts 5 points of damage on a target within very long range. Action.

Crystalline Body: You are composed of animate, translucent crystal the color of amber. Work with your GM to decide your exact form, though it is likely about the shape and size of a humanoid. Your crystal body grants you +2 to Armor and +4 to your Might Pool. However, you're not quick and your Speed

defense tasks are hindered. Certain conditions, like mundane diseases and poisons, do not affect you. Your crystalline body repairs itself more slowly than a body of living flesh would. You have only the one-round, one-hour, and ten-hour recovery rolls available each day; you do not have a ten-minute recovery roll available. Any ability you have that requires a ten-minute recovery roll instead requires a one-hour recovery roll. Enabler.

Curious: You're always curious about your surroundings, even on a subconscious level. Whenever you use Effort to attempt navigation, perception, or initiative tasks in an area that you've only rarely or never visited before, you can apply an additional free level of Effort. Enabler.

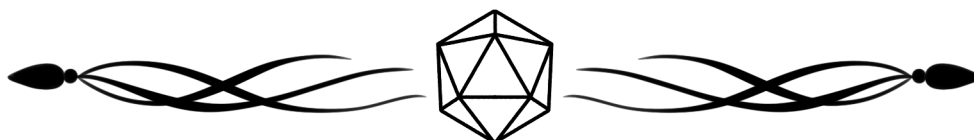
Cutting Light (2 Intellect points): You emit a thin beam of energized light from your hand. This inflicts 5 points of damage to a single foe in immediate range. The beam is even more effective against immobile, nonliving targets, slicing up to 1 foot

(30 cm) of any material that is level 6 or lower. The material can be up to 1 foot thick. Action.

Cypher Casting: You can cast any of your subtle cyphers on another creature instead of yourself. You must touch the creature to affect it. Enabler.

Cypher Surge: When you use a subtle cypher spell, as part of that action you can expend one other subtle cypher. Instead of the second cypher's normal effect, you add one free level of Effort to the first cypher spell. Enabler.

Cyphersmith: All manifest cyphers you use function at one level higher than normal. If given a week and the right tools, chemicals, and parts, you can tinker with one of your manifest cyphers, transforming it into another cypher of the same type that you had in the past. The GM and player should collaborate to ensure that the transformation is logical—for example, you probably can't transform a pill into a helmet. Enabler.



7.5 Abilities—D

Damage Dealer: You inflict an additional 3 points of damage with your chosen weapon. Enabler.

Damage Transference: When you or your duplicate (from the Duplicate ability) would take damage, you can transfer 1 point of damage from one to the other provided that you and your duplicate are within 1 mile (1.5 km) of each other. Enabler.

Damn the Guilty (3 Intellect points): You speak words of revelation and judgment to everyone within close range. Those whom you have designated as guilty with your Designation ability take an additional 3 points of damage from any attack they receive from anyone who heard your judgment. This judgment lasts for up to one minute or until they move at least a long distance away from you. Action.

Danger Instinct (3 Speed points): If you are attacked by surprise, whether by a creature, a device, or simply an environmental hazard (a tree falling on you), you can move an immediate distance before the attack occurs. If moving prevents the attack, you are safe. If the attack can still potentially affect you—if the attacking creature can move to keep pace, if the attack fills an area too big to escape, etc. —the ability offers no benefit. Enabler.

Danger Sense (1 Speed point): Your initiative task is eased. You pay the cost each time the ability is used. Enabler.

Dark Explorer: You ignore penalties for any action (including fighting) in extremely dim light or in cramped spaces. If you also have the Eyes Adjusted ability, you can act without penalty even in total darkness. You are trained in sneaking tasks while in dim or no light. Enabler.

Dark Matter Shell (5 Intellect points): For the next minute, you cover yourself with a shell of dark matter. Your appearance becomes a dark silhouette, and you gain an asset to sneaking tasks and gain +1 to your Armor. The dark matter shell works seamlessly with your desires, and if you apply a level of Effort to any physical task while the shell persists, you can apply an additional free level of Effort to that same task. Action to initiate.

Dark Matter Shroud (4 Intellect points): Ribbons of dark matter condense and swirl about you for up to one minute. This shroud eases your Speed defense tasks, inflicts 2 points of damage to anyone who tries to touch you or strike you with a melee attack, and gives you +1 Armor. Action to initiate.

Dark Matter Strike (4 Intellect points): When you attack a foe within long range, dark matter condenses around your target and entangles its limbs, holding it in place and easing your attack by two steps. The ability works for whatever kind of attack you use (melee, ranged, energy, and so on). Enabler.

Dark Matter Structure (5 Intellect points): You can form dark matter into a large structure consisting of up to ten 10-foot (3 m) cubes. The structure can be somewhat complex, though everything has the same matte black color from which no light shines. Otherwise, the structure can possess different densities, textures, and capacities. This means it can include windows, doors with locks, furnishings, and even decor, as long as it is all black as pitch. For example, you could shape the dark matter into a large, defensible structure; a sturdy 100-foot (30 m) bridge; or anything similar. The structure is a level 6 creation and lasts for 24 hours. You can't keep more than one such structure solid at any one time. Action.

Datajack (1 Intellect point): With computer access, you jack in instantly and learn a bit more about something you can

see. You get an asset on a task involving that person or object. Action.

Daydream (4 Intellect points): You pull someone into a daydream, substituting a dream of your own creation for the target's reality for up to one minute. You can affect a target within long range that you can see, or a target within 10 miles (16 km) that you have hair or skin clippings from. To all outward appearances, an affected target stands (or lies) unmoving. But inside, the substituted reality (or dream within a dream, if the target was sleeping) is what the target experiences. If the target is under duress, it can attempt another Intellect defense roll each round to break free, though the target may not realize its state. Either the dream unfolds according to a script you prepared when you used this ability, or if you use your own actions (forcing you into a similar state as the target), you can direct the unfolding dream from round to round. Using this ability on a sleeping target eases the initial attack. Action to initiate; if you direct the dream, action to direct per round.

Dazing Attack (3 Might points): You hit your foe in just the right spot, dazing them so that tasks they attempt on their next turn are hindered. This attack inflicts normal damage. Action.

Dazzling Sunburst (2 Intellect points): You send a barrage of dazzling colors at a creature within short range and, if successful, inflict 2 points of damage on the target. In addition, the creature's attacks are hindered on its next turn, unless the target relies primarily on senses other than sight. Action.

Deactivate Mechanisms (5+ Speed points): You make a melee attack that inflicts no damage against a machine. Instead, if the attack hits, make a second Speed-based roll. If successful, a machine of level 3 or lower is deactivated for one minute. For each additional level of Effort applied, you can affect one higher level of machine or you can extend the duration for an additional minute. If you have the Scramble Machine or Disable Mechanisms ability (or an ability that works similarly), when you apply a level of Effort to any of them, you gain an additional free level of Effort. Action.

Deadly Aim (3 Speed points): For the next minute, all ranged attacks you make inflict 2 additional points of damage. Action to initiate.

Deadly Strike (5 Might points): If you strike a foe of level 3 or lower with a weapon you're practiced with, you kill the target instantly. Action.

Deadly Swarm (6 Intellect points): If you're in a location where it's possible for your swarm of creatures from your Influence Swarm ability to come, you call a swarm of them for ten minutes. During this time, they do as you telepathically command as long as they are within long range. They can swarm about and hinder any or all opponents' tasks, or they can focus the swarm and attack all opponents within immediate range of each other (all within long range of you). The attacking swarm inflicts 4 points of damage. While the creatures are in long range, you can speak to them telepathically and perceive through their senses. Action to initiate. (Swarms don't usually have game stats, but if needed, a typical swarm is level 2. Only attacks that affect a large area affect the swarm.)

Death Touch (6 Intellect points): You gather disrupting energy in your fingertip and touch a creature. If the target is an NPC or a creature of level 3 or lower, it dies. If the target is a PC of any tier, they move down one step on the damage track. Action.

Debate (3 Intellect points): In any gathering of two or more people trying to establish the truth or come to a decision, you

can sway the verdict with masterful rhetoric. If you are given one minute or more to argue your point, either the decision goes your way or, if someone else effectively argues a competing point, any associated persuasion or deception task is eased by two steps. Action to initiate; one minute to complete.

Debilitating Strike (4 Speed points): You make an attack to deliver a painful or debilitating strike. The attack is hindered. If it hits, the creature takes 2 additional points of damage at the end of the next round, and its attacks are hindered until the end of the next round. Action.

Decipher (1 Intellect point): If you spend one minute examining a piece of writing or code in a language you do not understand, you can make an Intellect roll of difficulty 3 (or higher, based on the complexity of the language or code) to get the gist of the message. Action to initiate.

Deep Consideration (6 Intellect points): When you develop a plan that involves you and your friends working together to accomplish a goal, you can ask the GM one very general question about what is likely to happen if you carry out the plan, and you will get a simple, brief answer. In addition, all of you gain an asset to one roll related to enacting the plan you developed together, as long as you put the plan into action within a few days of the plan's creation. Action.

Deep Reserves: When others are exhausted, you can push through. Once each day, you can transfer up to 5 points among your Pools in any combination, at a rate of 1 point per round. For example, you could transfer 3 points of Might to Speed and 2 points of Intellect to Speed, which would take a total of five rounds. Action.

Deep Resources: You gain an additional 6 points to your Speed Pool. Enabler.

Deep Water Guide: While underwater, any creature you choose that can see you has an asset on swimming tasks. Enabler.

Defend All the Innocent: You protect everyone within immediate range whom you have designated as innocent with your Designation ability. Speed defense rolls made by such creatures gain an asset. Enabler.

Defend the Innocent (2 Speed points): For the next ten minutes, if someone you have designated as innocent with the Designation ability stands next to you, that creature shares any defensive advantages that you might have, other than mundane armor. These advantages include the Speed defense from your shield, the Armor offered from a force field, and so on. In addition, Speed defense rolls made by the innocent creature gain an asset. You can protect only one innocent creature at a time. Action to initiate.

Defending Weapon: When using your enchanted weapon, you are trained in Speed defense tasks. Enabler.

Defense Against Robots: You have studied your enemy and are trained in anticipating the actions that a robot or machine is likely to take in a fight. Defense tasks you attempt against these foes are eased. Enabler.

Defense Master: Every time you succeed at a Speed defense task, you can make an immediate attack against your foe. (If you have Dodge and Respond, you can exchange that ability for Dodge and Resist.) Your attack must be the same type (melee weapon, ranged weapon, or unarmed) as the attack you defend against. If you don't have an appropriate type of weapon ready, you can't use this ability. Enabler.

Defensive Augmentation: By upgrading your nervous and immune systems, you are trained in Might defense and Speed defense tasks. Enabler.

Defensive Blinking (4 Intellect points): You enter a heightened reactive state so that when you are struck hard enough to take damage, you teleport an immediate distance in a random direction (not up or down) to help evade the brunt of the attack. Your Speed defense rolls are eased for one minute. Action.

Defensive Field: Thanks to subdermal implants, a permanent spell, alien modifications, or something similar, you now have a force field that radiates 1 inch (2.5 cm) from your body and provides you with +2 Armor. Enabler.

Defensive Phasing (2 Intellect points): You can change your phase so that some attacks pass through you harmlessly. For the next ten minutes, you gain an asset to your Speed defense tasks, but during this time you lose any benefit from armor you wear. Action to initiate.

Define Down (4 Intellect points): The natural gravity within an area a short distance across that you are within immediate range of changes directions so that it flows in the direction you determine (up, up and to the south, west, and so on) for a few seconds, then snaps back. Affected targets could be tossed up to 20 feet (6 m) and take a few points of damage. Action.

Deflect Attacks (1 Intellect point): Using your mind, you protect yourself from incoming attacks. For the next ten minutes, you are trained in Speed defense tasks. Action to initiate.

Defuse Situation: During the course of an investigation, your questions sometimes elicit an angry or even violent response. Through dissembling, verbal distraction, or similar evasion, you prevent a living foe from attacking anyone or anything for one round. Action.

Demeanor of Command (2 Intellect points): You project confidence, knowledge, and charisma to all who see you for the next hour. Your demeanor is such that those who see you automatically understand that you are someone important, accomplished, and with authority. When you speak, strangers who are not already attacking give you at least a round to have your say. If speaking to a group that can understand you, you can attempt to have them produce their leader or ask that they take you to their leader. You gain a free level of Effort that can be applied to one persuasion task you attempt during this period. Action to initiate.

Designation: You assign an innocent or guilty label to one creature within immediate range, based on your assessment of a given situation or a predominant feeling. In other words, someone who is labeled innocent can be innocent in a certain circumstance, or they can be generally innocent of terrible crimes (such as murder, major theft, and so on). Likewise, you can declare that a creature is guilty of a particular crime or of terrible deeds in general. The accuracy of your assessment isn't important as long as you believe it to be the truth; the GM may require you to give a rationale. Henceforth, your tasks to socially interact with someone you designate as innocent gain an asset, and your attacks against those you designate as guilty gain an asset. You can change your assessment, but it requires another designation action. The benefits of the designation last until you change it or until you are shown proof that it is wrong. Action. (The benefits provided by Designation apply to the character using the ability, their allies, and anyone who hears or is told of their judgment and believes their assessment.)

Destined for Greatness: You enjoy uncanny luck as if something was watching over you and keeping you from harm. When you would otherwise descend a step on the damage track, make an Intellect defense roll versus the difficulty set by the level of the foe or effect. If you succeed, you do not descend that step. If the step was because you fell to 0 points in a Pool,

you are still at 0 points; you just don't suffer the negative effects of being impaired or debilitated. If you would otherwise descend the final step on the damage track to death, a successful defense roll keeps you at 1 point in one Pool, and you remain debilitated. Enabler.

Destroy Metal (3 Intellect points): You instantly tear, rip, or burst a metal object that is within sight, within short range, and no bigger than half your size. Attempt an Intellect task to destroy the object; the task is eased by three steps compared to breaking it with brute strength. Action.

Destroyer (6 Might points): If you succeed on a Might task to damage an object, instead of descending one step on the object damage track, the object descends all three steps and is destroyed. Action.

Detect Life (3+ Might points): You consciously send out a pulse of your your life energy. You detect all living creatures within short range, even if they are behind cover, though not if they're behind a force field. When you detect a creature, you detect its general location (to within an immediate range). If you apply two additional levels of Effort, you can increase the range of detection to long. Action.

Device Insight (3 Intellect points): When examining any unknown, alien, or high-technology device, you can ask the GM one question to gain an idea of its capabilities, how it functions, how it can be activated or deactivated, what its weaknesses are (if any), how it can be repaired, or any other similar query. This is for difficult or strange things beyond those readily identified by using the appropriate knowledge or technical skill. Action.

Devoted Defender (2 Might or Intellect points): Choose one character you can see. That character becomes your ward. You are trained in all tasks involving finding, healing, interacting with, and protecting that character. You can have only one ward at a time. Action to initiate.

Diamagnetism: You magnetize any nonmetallic object within short range so that it can be affected by your other magnetic powers. Thus, with Move Metal, you can move any object. With Repel Metal, you are trained in all Speed defense tasks, regardless of whether the incoming attack uses metal. And so on. Enabler.

Dimensional Squeeze (2+ Intellect points): You cram yourself into a transitional dimension, allowing you to instantaneously appear anywhere you choose within short range if you have a clear and unobstructed path to that location. You can pass through an intervening barrier if it has an open space that you could easily fit your head through—about 1 square foot (30 cm by 30 cm square). In addition to the normal options for using Effort, you can choose to use Effort to pass through a smaller opening in a barrier; each level of Effort used in this way reduces the minimum opening size by one-fourth. You land safely when you use this ability. Action.

- Transitional dimension: A dimension where distances are shorter compared to those in other dimensions, so travel through it is faster than normal movement.

Dirty Fighter (2 Speed points): You distract, blind, annoy, hamper, or otherwise interfere with a foe, hindering their attacks and defenses for one minute. Action.

Disable Mechanisms (3 Speed points): With a keen eye and quick moves, you disrupt some functions of a robot or machine and inflict upon it one of the following maladies:

- All its tasks are hindered for one minute.
- Its speed is halved.

- It can take no action for one round.
- It deals 2 fewer points of damage (minimum 1 point) for one minute.

You must touch the robot or machine to disrupt it (if you are making an attack, it inflicts no damage). Action.

Disappear (4 Intellect points): You bend light that falls on you so you seem to disappear. You are invisible to other creatures for ten minutes. While invisible, you are specialized in stealth and Speed defense tasks. This effect ends if you do something to reveal your presence or position—attacking, using an ability, moving a large object, and so on. If this occurs, you can regain the remaining invisibility effect by taking an action to focus on hiding your position. Action to initiate or reinitiate.

Disarming Attack (5 Speed points): You attempt a Speed task to disarm a foe as part of your melee attack. If you succeed, your attack inflicts 3 additional points of damage and the target's weapon is knocked from their grip, landing up to 20 feet (6 m) away. If you fail, you still attempt your normal attack, but you don't inflict the extra damage or disarm the opponent if you hit. Action.

Disarming Strike (3 Speed points): Your attack inflicts 1 point less damage and disarms your foe so that their weapon is now 10 feet (3 m) away on the ground. (If your chosen weapon is a whip, you can instead deposit the disarmed weapon into your hands; if your chosen weapon is a bow or other ranged weapon that fires physical rounds, you can instead "nail" the disarmed weapon to a nearby object or structure. Choosing to do either of these hinders your attack.) Action.

Discerning Mind: You have +3 Armor against damaging attacks and damaging effects that target your mind and Intellect. Defense rolls you make against attacks that attempt to confuse, persuade, frighten, or otherwise influence you are eased. Enabler.

Discipline of Watchfulness (7 Intellect points): You keep your allies on their toes with occasional questions, jokes, and even mock drills for those who care to join in. After spending 24 hours with you, your allies can apply a free level of Effort to any initiative tasks they attempt. This benefit is ongoing while you remain in the allies' company. It ends if you leave, but it resumes if you return to the allies' company within 24 hours. If you leave the allies' company for more than 24 hours, you must spend another 24 hours together to reactivate the benefit. You must spend the Intellect point cost each 24 hours you wish to keep the benefit active. Enabler.

Disguise: You are trained in disguise. You can alter your posture, voice, mannerisms, and hair to look like someone else for as long as you keep up the disguise. However, it is extremely difficult to adopt the appearance of a specific individual without a disguise kit at your disposal. Enabler.

Disguise Other (4+ Intellect points): You apply your shapechanging ability to another creature of your size or smaller, giving them a form that you are able to assume. This lasts for about ten minutes. In addition to the normal options for using Effort, you can choose to use Effort to increase the duration; one level of Effort increases it to an hour, two increases it to a day. A creature can revert to its normal form as an action, but it cannot then change back into the altered form. Action. You probably can't use Disguise Other to disguise a kind of creature that is very different from you, such as a human disguising a robot, animal, or crystalline alien.

Disincentivize (1 Intellect point): You hinder all actions attempted by any number of targets within short range who can

understand you. You choose which targets are affected. Affected targets' actions are hindered for one round. Enabler.

Disrupting Touch (1+ Might points): You can turn your Phase Sprint into a melee attack by purposefully grazing another creature as you run. When you do, the touch releases a violent blast of energy that inflicts 2 points of damage to the target (ignores Armor). Whether you hit or miss, your movement (and turn) ends immediately, which puts you within immediate distance of your target. If you apply Effort to increase damage rather than to ease the task, you deal 2 additional points of damage per level of Effort (instead of 3 points); the target takes 1 point of damage even if you fail the attack roll. Enabler.

Distance Viewing (5 Intellect points): You know that space and distance are illusions. You concentrate to create an invisible, immobile sensor at a location you have previously visited or viewed (at the GM's discretion, you may have to succeed at an Intellect task if the location is warded). The sensor lasts for one hour. Once it is created, you can concentrate to see, hear, and smell through the sensor. It doesn't grant you sensory capabilities beyond the norm. Action to create; action to check.

Distant Interface (2 Intellect points): You can activate, deactivate, or control a machine at long range as if you were next to it, even if normally you would have to touch or manually operate it. If you have never interacted with the particular machine before, the task is hindered by two steps. To use this ability, you must understand the function of the machine, it must be your size or smaller, and it can't be connected to another intelligence (or be intelligent itself). Action.

Distortion (2 Intellect points): You modify how a willing creature within short range reflects light for one minute. The target rapidly shifts between its normal appearance and a blot of darkness. The target has an asset on Speed defense rolls until the effect wears off. Action to initiate. **Diver:** You can safely dive into water from heights of up to 100 feet (30 m), and you can withstand pressure when in water as deep as 100 feet. Enabler.

Divert Attacks (4 Speed points): For one minute, you automatically deflect or dodge any ranged projectile attacks. However, on your next turn after you're attacked with ranged projectiles, all your other actions are hindered. Action to initiate.

Divide Your Mind (7 Intellect points): You split your consciousness into two parts. For one minute, you can take two actions on each of your turns, but only one of them can be to use a special ability. Action.

Divine Intervention (2 Intellect points, or 2 Intellect points + 4 XP): You ask the divine to intervene on your behalf, usually against a creature within long range, changing the course of its life in a small way by introducing a major special effect upon it. The major special effect is akin to what occurs when you roll a natural 20 on an attack. If you want to try for a larger effect, and if the GM allows it, you can attempt a divine intervention with a more far-reaching effect, which is more like the kind of GM intrusion initiated by the GM on their players. In this case, Divine Intervention also costs 4 XP, the effect may not work out exactly like you hope, and you may not make another plea for divine intervention for a week. Action.

Divine Knowledge: You are trained in all tasks related to knowledge of godly beings. Enabler.

Divine Radiance (2 Intellect points): Your prayer calls divine radiance from the heavens to punish an unworthy target within long range, inflicting 4 points of damage. If the target is a demon, spirit, or something similar, it also stands in unwilling awe of the divine energy coursing through it and is unable to act

on its next turn. Once exposed to this blessing, the target can't be awed by this attack again for several hours. Action.

Divine Symbol (5+ Intellect points): You invoke divine power by scribing a glowing symbol in the air with your fingers. Writhing pillars of divine radiance spear up to five targets within long range. A successful attack on a target inflicts 5 points of damage. If you apply Effort to increase the damage, you deal 2 additional points of damage per level of Effort (instead of 3 points); targets take 1 point of damage even if you fail the attack roll. Action.

Do You Know Who I Am? (3 Intellect points): Acting only as someone who is famous and used to privilege can, you verbally harangue a living foe who can hear and understand you so forcefully that it is unable to take any action, including making attacks, for one round. Whether you succeed or fail, the next action the target takes after your attempt is hindered. Action.

Dodge and Resist (3 Speed points): You can reroll any of your Might, Speed, or Intellect defense rolls and take the better of the two results. Enabler.

Dodge and Respond (3 Might points): If a melee attack misses you, you can immediately make a melee attack in return, but no more than once per turn. Enabler.

Double Strike (3 Might points): When you wield two weapons, you can choose to make one attack roll against a foe. If you hit, you inflict damage with both weapons plus 2 additional points of damage, and because you made a single attack, the target's Armor is subtracted only once. Action.

Dragon's Maw (6 Intellect points): You fashion and control a "hovering" phantasmal construct of magic within long range that resembles a dragon's head. The construct lasts for up to an hour, until it is destroyed, or until you cast another spell. It is a level 4 construct that inflicts 6 points of damage with its bite when directed. While the construct persists, you can use it to manipulate large objects, carry heavy items in its mouth, or attack foes. If you use it to attack foes, you must use your action to directly control the phantom maw for each attack. Action to initiate.

Drain at a Distance: Your Drain Machine and Drain Creature abilities work on a target within short range. Enabler.

Drain Charge: You can drain the power from an artifact or device, allowing you to regain 1 Intellect point per level drained. You regain points at the rate of 1 point per round and must give your full concentration to the process each round. The GM determines whether the device is fully drained (likely true of most handheld or smaller devices) or retains some power (likely true of large machines). Action to initiate; action each round to drain.

Drain Creature (3+ Intellect points): You can drain energy from a living creature you touch, inflicting 3 points of damage and restoring 3 points to your Might or Speed Pool. Action.

Drain Machine (3+ Intellect points): You can drain the power from an artifact or powered device you touch. If the target is a robot, you inflict 3 points of damage and restore 3 points to your Might or Speed Pool. If the target is an object, you restore points to your Might or Speed Pool equal to the level of the target. If the target is a manifest cypher, it is fully drained and useless. Artifacts and similar devices must immediately check for depletion (items with a depletion of "—" are either immune to this ability or have a depletion of 1 in 1d10 when attacked with this ability). Action.

Drain Power (5 Speed points): You affect the main power source of a robot or machine, inflicting upon it all four conditions in Disable Mechanisms at once. You must touch the robot

to do this (if you are making an attack, it inflicts no damage). Action.

Draw Conclusion (3 Intellect points): After careful observation and investigation (questioning one or more NPCs on a topic, searching an area or a file, and so on) lasting a few minutes, you can learn a pertinent fact. This ability is a difficulty 3 Intellect task. Each additional time you use this ability, the task is hindered by an additional step. The difficulty returns to 3 after you rest for ten hours. Action.

Drawing on Life's Experiences (6 Intellect points): You've seen a lot and done a lot, and that experience comes in handy. Ask the GM one question, and you'll receive a general answer. The GM assigns a level to the question, so the more obscure the answer, the more difficult the task. Generally, knowledge that you could find by looking somewhere other than your current location is level 1, and obscure knowledge of the past is level 7. Action.

Dreadwood (6 Intellect points): You manipulate wind, mist, and shadows to embody the primordial fear of mysterious woods. For the next minute, you gain an asset on intimidation tasks. Creatures within short range may become frightened; make a separate Intellect attack roll for each creature (if you are larger than normal from using Great Tree or another source, these rolls are eased). Success means that they are frozen in fear, not moving or taking actions for one minute or until they are attacked. Some creatures without minds might be immune to this fear. Action.

Dream Becomes Reality (4 Intellect points): You create a dream object of any shape you can imagine that is your size or smaller, which takes on apparent substance and heft. The object is crude and can have no moving parts, so you can make a sword, a shield, a short ladder, and so on. The dream object has the approximate mass of the real object, if you choose. Your dream objects are as strong as iron, but if you do not remain within long range of them, they function for only one minute before fading away. Action.

Dream Thief (2 Intellect points): You steal a previous dream from a living creature within short range. The creature loses 2 points of Intellect (ignores Armor), and you learn something the GM chooses to reveal about the creature—its nature, a portion of its plans, a memory, and so on. Action.

Dreamcraft (1 Intellect point): You pull an image from a dream into the waking world and place it somewhere within long range. The dream lasts for up to one minute, and it can be tiny or fill an area an immediate distance in diameter. Though it appears solid, the dream is intangible. The dream (a scene, a creature, or an object) is static unless you use your action each round to animate it. As part of that animation, you could move the dream up to a short distance each round, as long as it remains within long range. If you animate the dream, it can make sound but does not produce odor. Direct physical interaction or sustained interaction with the dream shatters it into dispersing mist. For example, attacking the dream shatters it, as does the strain of keeping up appearances when an NPC moves through a dream scene or engages a dream creature in conversation for more than a couple of rounds. Action to initiate; action to ani-

mate.

Driver: You are trained in all tasks related to driving a car, truck, or motorcycle, including mechanical repair tasks. Enabler.

Driving on the Edge: You can make an attack with a light or medium ranged weapon and attempt a driving task as a single action. Enabler.

Dual Defense: When you wield two weapons, you are trained in Speed defense tasks. Enabler.

Dual Distraction (1+ Speed points): When you wield two weapons, your opponent's next attack is hindered, and if you apply Effort on your next attack against that same foe, you get a free level of Effort on the task. Enabler.

Dual Light Wield: You can use two light weapons at the same time, making two separate attacks on your turn as a single action. You remain limited by the amount of Effort you can apply on one action, but because you make separate attacks, your opponent's Armor applies to both. Anything that modifies your attack or damage applies to both attacks, unless it's specifically tied to one of the weapons. Enabler.

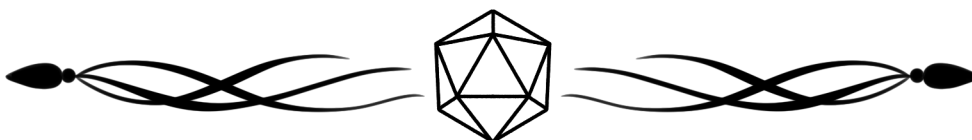
Dual Medium Wield: You can use two light weapons or medium weapons at the same time (or one light weapon and one medium weapon), making two separate attacks on your turn as a single action. This ability otherwise works like the Dual Light Wield ability. Enabler.

Dual Wards: You can have two wards from Devoted Defender at a time. Choosing a second ward can be its own action, or you can choose two wards with one action (and only pay the cost once for doing so). The wards must remain within an immediate distance of each other. Benefits provided by Devoted Defender apply to both your wards. If your wards separate, you choose which retains the benefit. If they come back together, both regain the benefit immediately. Enabler.

Duel to the Death (5 Speed points): Choose a target (a single individual creature that you can see). You are trained in all tasks involving fighting that creature. When you successfully attack that target, you inflict +5 damage, or +7 damage if the creature is engaging someone else instead of you. You can duel only one creature at a time. A duel lasts up to one minute, or until you break it off. Action to initiate.

Duplicate (2 Might points): You cause a duplicate of yourself to appear at any point you can see within short range. The duplicate has no clothing or possessions when it appears. The duplicate is a level 2 NPC with 6 health. The duplicate obeys your commands and does as you direct it. The duplicate remains until you dismiss it using an action or until it is killed. When the duplicate disappears, it leaves behind anything it was wearing or carrying. If the duplicate disappears because it was killed, you take 4 points of damage that ignore Armor, and you lose your next action. Action to initiate.

Dust to Dust (7 Intellect points): You disintegrate one object that is smaller than you and whose level is less than or equal to your tier. You must touch the object to affect it. If the GM feels it appropriate to the circumstances, you can disintegrate a portion of an object (the total volume of which is smaller than you) rather than the entire thing. Action.



7.6 Abilities—E

Earthquake (7 Might points): You direct your destructive resonance into the ground and trigger an earthquake centered on a spot you can see within very long range. The ground within short range of that spot heaves and shakes for five minutes, causing damage to structures and terrain in the area. Buildings and terrain features shed debris and rubble. Each round, creatures in the area take either 3 points of damage due to the general shaking, or 6 points of damage if in or adjacent to a structure or terrain feature shedding debris. Action to initiate.

Echolocation: You are especially sensitive to sound and vibration, so much so that you can sense your environment within a short distance regardless of your ability to see. Enabler.

Effective Skill: Choose one noncombat skill when you gain this ability. You get a minor effect with that skill when you roll a natural 14 or higher (the d20 shows “14” or more). You get a major effect with that skill when you roll a natural 19 or higher (the d20 shows “19” or higher). You can select this ability more than once. Each time you select it, you must choose a different noncombat skill. Enabler.

Elastic Grip (3 Might points): Your attack with your stretchy limbs or body is eased. If you hit, you can grab the target, preventing it from moving on its next turn. While you hold the target, its attacks or attempts to break free are hindered. If the target attempts to break free instead of attacking, you must succeed at a Might-based task to maintain your grip. If the target fails to break free, you can continue to hold it each round as your subsequent actions, automatically inflicting 4 points of damage each round by squeezing. Enabler.

Electric Armor (4 Intellect points): When you wish it, electricity crackles across your body for ten minutes, granting you +1 Armor. While electrified, you have an additional +2 Armor versus electrical damage specifically, and you inflict 2 points of damage on any creature that touches you or attacks you with a melee weapon that conducts electricity. Enabler.

Electrical Flight (5 Intellect points): You exude an aura of crackling electricity that lets you fly a long distance each round for ten minutes. You can’t carry other creatures with you. Action to activate.

Elemental Protection (4+ Intellect points): You and every target you designate within immediate range gains +5 Armor against one type of direct elemental damage (such as fire, lightning, shadow, or thorn) for one hour, or until you cast this spell again. Each level of Effort applied increases the elemental protection by +2. Action to initiate.

Elusive (2 Speed points): When you succeed on a Speed defense action, you immediately gain an action. You can use this action only to move. Enabler.

Embrace the Night (7+ Intellect points): You fashion a truly horrifying facade of a creature from swirling ribbons of dark matter and launch it at your foes within long range. Each round, you can attack a target within long range using the creation as your weapon. When you attack, the creature inserts hair-fine tendrils of shadow into the target’s eyes and brain. The target takes 3 points of Intellect damage (ignores Armor) and is stunned for one round so that it loses its next turn. Alternatively, you can cause the creature to take other actions, as long as you are able to see it and mentally control it as your action. The creature disperses after about a minute. Action to initiate.

Embraced by Darkness (6 Intellect points): For the next hour, you take on some characteristics of a shadow thanks to a fundamental adaptation of your flesh or a device you’ve kept

secret. Your appearance is a dark silhouette. When you apply a level of Effort to sneaking tasks, you get a free level of Effort on the task. During this time, you can move through the air at a rate of a short distance per round, and you can move through solid barriers (even those that are sealed to prevent the passage of light or shadow), but not energy barriers, at a rate of 1 foot (30 cm) per round. You can perceive while passing through a barrier or object, which allows you to peek through walls. As a shadow, you can’t affect or be affected by normal matter. Likewise, you can’t attack, touch, or otherwise affect anything. However, attacks and effects that rely on light can affect you, and sudden bursts of light can potentially make you lose your next turn. Action to initiate.

Enable Others: You can use the helping rules to provide a benefit to another character attempting a physical task. Unlike the normal helping rules, this doesn’t require you to use your action helping the other character with the task. This requires no action on your part. Enabler.

Enchanted Movement (4+ Intellect points): You use your enchanted weapon to move yourself to any location within a long distance that you can see, as long as there are no obstacles or barriers in your way. The exact way this happens depends on your weapon; you might throw your magical hammer and be pulled along after it, shoot an arrow from your bow that pulls you forward like a grapple line, and so on. In addition to the normal options for using Effort, you can choose to use Effort to increase the distance traveled; each level of Effort used in this way increases the range by another 100 feet (30 m). If you have another ability (such as from your type) that allows you to cross a long distance, the range of that ability and this one increases to very long. Action. **Enchanted Weapon** (1 Intellect point): You attune yourself to a physical weapon, such as a sword, hammer, or bow. You know exactly where it is if it is within a short distance of you, and you know its general direction and distance if farther away. All of your other focus abilities require you to be holding or wielding this weapon. You can be attuned to only one weapon at a time; attuning yourself to a second weapon loses the attunement to the first one. Action to initiate, ten minutes to complete. Enabler.

If you attune yourself to a different weapon, come up with a story reason for why you are able to do that and why you chose this new weapon.

Encouragement (1 Intellect point): While you maintain this ability through ongoing inspiring oration, your allies within short range ease one of the following task types (your choice): defense tasks, attack tasks, or tasks related to any skill that you are trained or specialized in. Action.

Encouraging Presence (2 Intellect points): For one minute, allies within short range gain an asset on defense rolls. Action.

Endurance: Any duration dealing with physical actions is either doubled or halved, whichever is better for you. For example, if the typical person can hold their breath for thirty seconds, you can hold it for one minute. If the typical person can march for four hours without stopping, you can do so for eight hours. In terms of harmful effects, if a poison paralyzes its victims for one minute, you are paralyzed for thirty seconds. The minimum duration is always one round. Enabler.

Energize Creature (6+ Might points): You extend your Absorb Kinetic Energy ability to one creature within immediate range so that they also can absorb energy from physical attacks and impacts for one hour. That creature, however, cannot release excess energy as a blast. For each level of Effort you ap-

ply, you can increase the number of targets you affect by one. If you have Absorb Pure Energy or Improved Absorb Kinetic Energy, those abilities are also duplicated in your target when you use Energize Creature. Action to initiate.

Energize Crowd (9 Might points): You extend your Absorb Kinetic Energy ability to up to thirty creatures within short range so that they also can absorb energy from physical attacks and impacts for one hour. If you have Absorb Pure Energy or Improved Absorb Kinetic Energy, these creatures can use those abilities as well. The creatures, however, cannot release excess energy as a blast. Action to initiate.

Energize Object: By focusing your Absorb Kinetic Energy ability on an object (like a weapon), you infuse it with your power. The object holds the energy until it is touched by anyone but you, so putting it into your melee weapon or the ammo of a ranged weapon allows the weapon to trigger the energy in combat. The energy inflicts 3 points of damage on the creature touched in addition to any damage the weapon itself might do. You cannot have more than one energized object on your person at a time. Action to initiate.

Energized Shield: Your force shield from your Force Field Shield ability now pulses with dangerous energy whenever you manifest it. Each time you use your shield as a melee or ranged weapon, it inflicts an additional 3 points of damage. Enabler.

Energy Protection (3+ Intellect points): Choose a discrete type of energy that you have experience with (such as heat, sonic, electricity, and so on). You gain +10 to Armor against damage from that type of energy for ten minutes. Alternatively, you gain +1 to Armor against damage from that energy for 24 hours. You must be familiar with the type of energy; for example, if you have no experience with a certain kind of extradimensional energy, you can't protect against it. In addition to the normal options for using Effort, you can choose to use Effort to protect more targets; each level of Effort used in this way affects up to two additional targets. You must touch additional targets to protect them. Action to initiate.

Energy Resistance: Choose a discrete type of energy that you have experience with (such as heat, sonic, electricity, and so on). You gain +5 to Armor against damage from that type of energy. You must be familiar with the type of energy; for example, if you have no experience with a certain kind of extradimensional energy, you can't protect against it. You can select this ability more than once. Each time you select it, you must choose a different kind of energy. Enabler.

Enhance Strength (3 Intellect points): For the next ten minutes, you gain an asset on tasks that depend on brute force, such as moving a heavy object, smashing down a door, or hitting someone with a melee weapon. Action to initiate.

Enhanced Beast Form: When you use Beast Form, your beast form gains the following additional bonuses: +3 to your Might Pool, +2 to your Speed Pool, and +2 to Armor. Enabler.

Enhanced Body: Your machine parts grant you +1 to Armor, +3 to your Might Pool, and +3 to your Speed Pool. Traditional healing skills, medicines, and techniques work only half as well for you. Each time you start at full health, the first 5 points of damage you take can never be healed in these ways or recovered normally. Instead, you must use repairing skills and abilities to restore those points. For example, if you start with a full Might Pool of 10 and take 8 points of damage, you can use recovery rolls to restore 3 points, but the remaining 5 points must be restored with repair tasks. Enabler.

Enhanced Intellect: You gain 3 points to your Intellect Pool. Enabler.

Enhanced Intellect Edge: You gain +1 to your Intellect Edge. Enabler.

Enhanced Might: You gain 3 points to your Might Pool. Enabler.

Enhanced Might Edge: You gain +1 to your Might Edge. Enabler.

Enhanced Phased Attack (5 Intellect points): This ability works like the Phased Attack ability except that your attack also disrupts the foe's vitals, dealing an additional 5 points of damage. Enabler.

Enhanced Physique: You gain 3 points to divide among your Might and Speed Pools however you wish. Enabler.

Enhanced Potential: You gain 3 points to divide among your stat Pools however you wish. Enabler.

Enhanced Speed: You gain 3 points to your Speed Pool. Enabler.

Enhanced Speed Edge: You gain +1 to your Speed Edge. Enabler.

Enlarge (1+ Might point): You trigger an enzymatic reaction that draws additional mass from another dimension, and you (and your clothing or suit) grow larger. You achieve a height of 9 feet (3 m) and stay that way for about a minute. During that time, you add 4 points to your Might Pool, add +1 to Armor, and add +2 to your Might Edge. While you are larger than normal, your Speed defense rolls are hindered, and you are practiced in using your fists as heavy weapons. When the effects of Enlarge end, your Armor and Might Edge return to normal, and you subtract a number of points from your Might Pool equal to the number you gained (if this brings the Pool to 0, subtract the overflow first from your Speed Pool and then, if necessary, from your Intellect Pool). Each additional time you use Enlarge before your next ten-hour recovery roll, you must apply an additional level of Effort. Thus, the second time you use Enlarge, you must apply one level of Effort; the third time you use Enlarge, two levels of Effort; and so on. Action to initiate.

Enlightened: You are trained in any perception task that involves sight. Enabler.

Entangling Force (1+ Intellect point): A target within short range is subject to a snare constructed of semi-tangible lines of force for one minute. The force snare is a level 2 construct. A target caught in the force snare cannot move from its position, but it can attack and defend normally. The target can also use its action attempting to break free. You can increase the level of the force snare by 1 per level of Effort applied. Action to initiate.

Entrhall (1 Intellect point): While talking, you grab and keep another creature's attention, even if the creature can't understand you. For as long as you do nothing but speak (you can't even move), the other creature takes no actions other than to defend itself, even over multiple rounds. If the creature is attacked, the effect ends. Action.

Entourage: You gain an entourage of five level 1 twenty-somethings that accompanies you wherever you go unless you purposefully disband it for a particular outing. You can ask them to deliver things for you, run messages, pick up your dry cleaning—pretty much whatever you want, within reason. They can also run interference if you're trying to avoid someone, help hide you from media attention, help you muscle through a crowd, and so on. On the other hand, if a situation becomes physically violent, they retreat to safety. Enabler.

Enveloping Shield: Your Force Field Shield ability produces an envelope of force that enfolds you while you are holding the shield, granting you +1 to Armor. Enabler.

Erase Memories (3 Intellect points): You reach into the mind of a creature within immediate range and make an Intellect roll. On a success, you erase up to the last five minutes of its memory. Action.

Escape (2 Speed points): You slip your restraints, squeeze through the bars, break the grip of a creature holding you, pull free from sucking quicksand, or otherwise get loose from whatever is holding you in place. Action.

Escape Plan: When you kill a foe, you can attempt a stealth task to immediately hide from anyone around, assuming that a suitable hiding place is nearby. Enabler.

Evanescence (3 Speed points): You step into shadows or behind cover, and everyone who was observing you completely loses track of you. Although you're not invisible, you can't be seen until you reveal yourself again by moving out of the shadows or from behind cover (or by making an attack). Action.

Evasion: You're hard to affect when you don't want to be affected. You are trained in all defense tasks. Enabler.

Everything Is a Weapon: You can take any small object—a coin, a pen, a bottle, a stone, and so on—and throw it with such force and precision that it inflicts damage as a light weapon. Enabler.

Exile (5 Intellect points): You send a target that you touch hurtling into another random dimension or universe, where it remains for ten minutes. You have no idea what happens to the target while it's gone, but at the end of ten minutes, it returns to the precise spot it left. Action. Expanded Repertoire: The number of subtle cyphers you can bear at the same time increases by one. Enabler.

Experienced Defender: When wearing armor, you gain +1 to Armor. Enabler.

Experienced Finder (6+ Intellect points): When you are looking for something specific, such as a particular rare component, a chemical needed to complete a vaccine for a disease, a spare part required to repair a damaged device, the tracks of a specific beast, or the sword that a thief stole from you, this ability is of great use. For the next 24 hours, if you come within short range of the thing and circumstances are such that it is possible for you to perceive the thing (for example, it's not in a locked chamber for which you do not have the key), you find it. This ability assumes that you are constantly on the lookout, always looking everywhere possible, peering behind obstacles, and so on—if you're running for your life, sleeping, or otherwise occupied, this ability does not help you. You use this ability in lieu of making a roll to find the thing, but only if the difficulty for finding the object is level 6 or below. You can apply Effort to increase the maximum level of the thing you're trying to find (each level of Effort used this way increases the maximum level by 1). Action to initiate.

Experienced in Armor: The cost reduction from your Practiced in Armor ability improves. You now reduce the Speed cost by 2. Enabler.

Expert Crafter: Instead of rolling, you can choose to automatically succeed on a crafting task you're trained in. The task must be difficulty 4 or lower. If you are able to reduce the assessed difficulty of a crafting task to 4 or lower, this ability also applies to each subtask, assuming something doesn't interrupt you during the ensuing time to build. Enabler.

Expert Cypher Use: You can bear three cyphers at a time. Enabler.

Expert Driver: You are specialized in all tasks related to driving a car, truck, or motorcycle, including mechanical repair tasks. Enabler.

Expert Follower: You gain a level 3 follower. They are not restricted on their modifications. You can take this ability multiple times, each time gaining another level 3 follower. Alternatively, you could choose to advance a level 2 follower you already have to level 3 and then gain a new level 2 follower. Enabler.

Expert Pilot: You are specialized in all tasks related to piloting a starcraft. Enabler.

Expert Skill: Instead of rolling a d20, you can choose to automatically succeed on a task you're trained in. The task must be difficulty 4 or lower, and it can't be an attack roll or a defense roll. Enabler. (A character can't apply Effort or other abilities to any task they accomplish using Expert Skill.)

Explains the Ineffable: Through anecdotes, historical retellings, and citing knowledge that few but you have previously understood, you enlighten your friends. After spending 24 hours with you, once per day, each of your friends can ease a particular task by two steps. This benefit is ongoing while you remain in your friends' company. It ends if you leave, but it resumes if you return to your friends' company within 24 hours. If you leave your friends' company for longer than that, you must spend another 24 hours together to reactivate the benefit. Enabler.

Exploit Advantage: Even if you can do something well, you've learned that you can always do it even better. Whenever you have an asset for a roll, you ease the task by one additional step. Enabler.

Exploratory Experience: You are trained in two additional skills in which you are not already trained. Choose from the following: navigation, perception, sensing danger, initiative, peacefully opening communications with strangers, and tracking. Enabler.

Explosive Release (6 Intellect points): You can amplify the energy stored in your Siphon Pool (from your Store Energy ability) and release it in a massive blast that affects either one target within short range or everything within immediate range. If you choose a single target, it takes 2 points of damage for every point in your Siphon Pool. If you choose an area, everything in the area (except you) takes 1 point of damage per point in your Siphon Pool (or half that if your attack fails against them). This drains your Siphon Pool to 0 points. Action.

Extra Recovery: You gain an additional one-action recovery each day. Enabler.

Extra Skill: You are trained in one skill of your choice (other than attacks or defense) in which you are not already trained. You can select this ability multiple times. Each time you select it, you must choose a different skill. Enabler.

Extra Use (3 Intellect points): You attempt to gain an extra use from an artifact without triggering a depletion roll. The difficulty of the task is equal to the level of the artifact. If you crafted the artifact, you gain an asset to the task. On a failure, the depletion roll occurs normally. You could also try to use a manifest cypher without burning it out, but the task is hindered. A failed attempt to gain an additional use from a manifest cypher destroys it before it can produce the desired effect. Action.

Extreme Mastery (6 Might or 6 Speed points): When using your chosen weapon, you can reroll any attack roll you wish and take the better of the two results. Enabler.

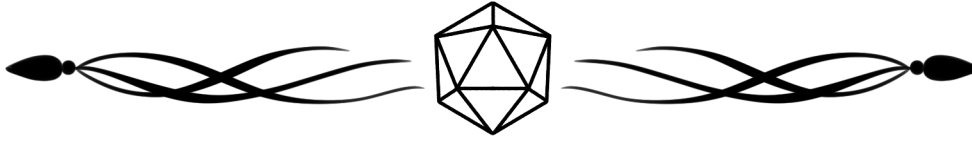
Eye for Detail (2 Intellect points): When you spend five minutes or so thoroughly exploring an area no larger than a short distance in diameter, you can ask the GM one question about the area. The GM must answer you truthfully. You can-

not use this more than one time per area per 24 hours. Action to initiate, five minutes to complete.

Eye Gouge (2 Speed points): You make an attack against a creature with an eye. The attack is hindered, but if you hit, the creature has trouble seeing for the next hour. During this time,

the creature's tasks that rely on sight (which is most tasks) are hindered. Action.

Eyes Adjusted: You can see in extremely dim light as though it were bright light. You can see in total darkness as if it were extremely dim light. Enabler.



7.7 Abilities—F

Face Morph (2+ Intellect points): You alter your features and coloration for one hour, hiding your identity or impersonating someone. This affects only your face, not the rest of your body. You can't perfectly duplicate someone else's face, but you can be accurate enough to fool someone who knows that person casually. You have an asset in all tasks involving disguise. You must apply a level of Effort to be able to impersonate a different species (such as a human morphing into a humanoid alien). Action.

Familiarize: You can familiarize yourself with a new area if you spend at least one hour studying a region up to a long distance across that you are able to directly access and move about in. Once you've familiarized yourself with an area, all your tasks related to perception, navigation, salvaging and scavenging, defense, and moving about the area gain an asset. Each time you familiarize yourself with a new area, you lose focus on a previous area unless you spend 1 XP to retain the familiarity permanently. Action to initiate, one hour to complete.

Far Step (2 Intellect points): You leap through the air and land some distance away. You can jump up, down, or across to anywhere you choose within long range if you have a clear and unobstructed path to that location. You land safely. Action.

Fast Kill (2 Speed points): You know how to kill quickly. When you hit with a melee or ranged attack, you deal 4 additional points of damage. You can't make this attack in two consecutive rounds. Action.

Fast Talk (1 Intellect point): When speaking with an intelligent creature who can understand you and isn't hostile, you convince that creature to take one reasonable action in the next round. A reasonable action must be agreed upon by the GM; it should not put the creature or its allies in obvious danger or be wildly out of character. Action.

Fast Travel (7 Intellect points): You warp time and space so that you and up to ten other creatures within immediate distance travel overland at ten times the normal rate for up to eight hours. At this speed, most dangerous encounters or regions of rough terrain are ignored, though the GM may declare exceptions. Outright barriers still present a problem. Action to initiate.

Faster Wild Magic: If you spend ten minutes preparing your magic, you can fill any of your open cypher slots with subtle cyphers chosen randomly by the GM (this time can be part of a ten-minute, one-hour, or ten-hour recovery action if you are awake for the entire time). You can't use this ability again until after you've taken a ten-hour recovery action. You can still use Magical Repertoire to fill your cypher slots. Action to initiate, ten minutes to complete.

Fearsome Reputation (3 Intellect points): You and those you travel with have earned a fearsome reputation in some parts. If your foes have heard of you, affected targets within earshot become afraid, and all attacks they make against you are hindered until one or more of them successfully inflicts damage on you or one of your allies, at which time their fear abates. Action.

Feat of Strength (1 Might point): Any task that depends on brute force is eased. Examples include smashing down a barred door, tearing open a locked container, lifting or moving a heavy object, or striking someone with a melee weapon. Enabler.

Feint (2 Speed points): If you use one action creating a misdirection or diversion, in the next round you can take advantage of your opponent's lowered defenses. Make a melee attack roll

against that opponent. You gain an asset on this attack. If your attack is successful, it inflicts 4 additional points of damage. Action.

Fellow Explorer: You gain a level 2 follower. One of their modifications must be for tasks related to perception. Enabler.

Fetch (3 Intellect points): You cause an object to disappear and reappear in your hands or somewhere else nearby. Choose one object that can fit inside a 5-foot (2 m) cube and that you can see within long range. The object vanishes and appears in your hands or in an open space anywhere you choose within immediate range. Action.

Field of Destruction (4 Might points): When you cause an object to descend one or more steps on the object damage track, you gain 1 additional point of Armor for one minute. Enabler.

Field of Gravity (4 Intellect points): When you wish it, a field of manipulated gravity around you pulls incoming ranged projectile attacks to the ground. You are immune to such attacks until your turn in the next round. You must be aware of an attack to foil it. This ability does not work on energy attacks. Enabler.

Field-Reinforced Armor: You gain +1 to Armor while wearing the power armor from your Powered Armor ability. Enabler.

Fiery Hand of Doom (3 Intellect points): While your Shroud of Flame is active, you can reach into your halo and produce a hand made of animate flame that is twice the size of a human's hand. The hand acts as you direct, floating in the air. Directing the hand is an action. Without a command, the hand does nothing. It can move a long distance in a round, but it never moves farther away from you than long range. The hand can grab, move, and carry things, but anything it touches takes 1 point of damage per round from the heat. The hand can also attack. It's a level 3 creature and deals 1 extra point of damage from fire when it attacks. Once created, the hand lasts for ten minutes. Action to create; action to direct.

Fight On: You do not suffer the normal penalties for being impaired on the damage track. If debilitated, instead of suffering the normal penalty of being unable to take most actions, you can continue to act; however, all tasks are hindered. Enabler.

Final Defiance: When you would normally be dead, you instead remain conscious and active for one more round plus one additional round each time you succeed on a difficulty 5 Might task. During these rounds, you are debilitated. If you do not receive healing or otherwise gain points in a Pool during your final round(s) of activity, you are subject to the effects of Not Dead Yet. Enabler.

Find an Opening (1 Intellect point): You use trickery to find an opening in your foe's defenses. If you succeed on a Speed roll against one creature within immediate range, your next attack against that creature before the end of the next round is eased. Action.

Find the Guilty: If you have used Designation on a target, you are trained in tracking them, spotting them when they are hidden or disguised, or otherwise finding them. Enabler.

Find the Hidden (4+ Intellect points): You see the trajectories of objects as they move through space and time. You can sense the distance and direction of any specific inanimate object that you once touched. This takes anywhere from one action to hours of concentration, depending on what the GM feels is appropriate due to time, distance, or other mitigating circumstances. However, you don't know in advance how long it will take. If you use at least two levels of Effort, once you have established the distance and direction, you remain in contact

with the object for one hour per level of Effort used. Thus, if it moves, you are aware of its new position. Action to initiate; action each round to concentrate.

Find the Way: When you apply Effort to a navigation task because you don't know the way, are lost, are attempting to blaze a new route, need to choose between two or more otherwise similar paths to take, or something very similar, you can apply a free level of Effort. Enabler.

Finishing Blow (5 Might points): If your foe is prone, stunned, or somehow helpless or incapacitated when you strike, you inflict 7 additional points of damage on a successful hit. Enabler.

Fire and Ice (4 Intellect points): You cause a target within short range to become either very hot or very cold (your choice). The target suffers 3 points of ambient damage (ignores Armor) each round for up to three rounds, although a new roll is required each round to continue to affect the target. Action to initiate.

Fire Bloom (4+ Intellect points): Fire blooms within long range, filling an area 10 feet (3 m) in radius and inflicting 3 points of damage on all affected targets. Effort applied to one attack counts for all attacks against targets in the area of the bloom. Even on an unsuccessful attack, a target in the area still takes 1 point of damage. Flammable objects in the area may catch fire. Action.

Fire Servant (6 Intellect points): While your Shroud of Flame is active, you reach into your halo and produce an automaton of fire that is your general shape and size. It acts as you direct each round. Directing the servant is an action, and you can command it only when you are within long range of it. Without a command, the servant continues to follow your previous command. You can also give it a simple programmed action, such as "Wait here, and attack anyone who comes within short range until they're dead." The servant lasts for ten minutes, is a level 5 creature, and deals 1 extra point of damage from fire when it attacks. Action to create; action to direct.

Fire Tendrils (5 Intellect points): When you wish it, your halo (from your Shroud of Flame ability) sprouts three tendrils of flame that last for up to ten minutes. As an action, you can use the tendrils to attack, making a separate attack roll for each. Each tendril inflicts 4 points of damage. Otherwise, the attacks function as standard attacks. If you don't use the tendrils to attack, they remain but do nothing. Enabler.

Fists of Fury: You inflict 2 additional points of damage with unarmed attacks. Enabler.

Flamboyant Boast (1 Intellect point): You boastfully describe an act that you will accomplish, and then as part of the same action, you attempt it. If an average person would find the action difficult (or impossible) and you succeed on it, creatures who witnessed it who are not your allies are potentially dazed on their next turn, and all tasks they attempt are hindered. The GM will help you determine whether your boast is something that would impress onlookers so significantly. If you attempt the task you boast about but fail to accomplish it, all your attempts to affect or attack onlookers who saw you are hindered for about ten minutes. Enabler.

Flameblade (4 Intellect points): When you wish it, you extend your Shroud of Flame to cover a weapon you wield in flame for one hour. The flame ends if you stop holding or carrying the weapon. While the flame lasts, the weapon inflicts 2 additional points of damage. Enabler.

Flash (4 Intellect points): You create an explosion of energy at a point within close range, affecting an area up to im-

mediate range from that point. You must be able to see the location where you intend to center the explosion. The blast inflicts 2 points of damage to all creatures or objects within the area. If you apply Effort to increase the damage, you deal 2 additional points of damage per level of Effort (instead of 3 points); targets in the area take 1 point of damage even if you fail the attack roll. Action.

Flash Across the Miles (6+ Intellect points): You can move to an open location on the planet that you're familiar with almost instantaneously, transformed into a bolt of lightning. If you apply a level of Effort, you can attempt to penetrate covered locations that you're aware of as long as a route exists from the open air to the area you want to reach that electricity can easily follow. Action.

Flee (6 Intellect points): All non-allies within short distance who can hear your dreadful, intimidating words flee from you at top speed for one minute. Action.

Fleet of Foot (1+ Speed points): You can move a short distance as part of another action. You can move a long distance as your entire action for a turn. If you apply a level of Effort to this ability, you can move a long distance and make an attack as your entire action for a turn, but the attack is hindered. Enabler.

Flesh of Stone: You have +1 to Armor if you do not wear physical armor. Enabler.

Flex Lore: After each ten-hour recovery roll when you have access to a high-technology digital reference library (such as one that might be found in a starship or in a learning center), choose one field of knowledge related to a specific planet or some other location. The field might be habitations, customs, governments, characteristics of the main species, important figures, and so on. You're trained in that field until you use this ability again. You could use this ability with an area of knowledge you're already trained in to become specialized. Enabler.

Flex Skill: At the beginning of each day, choose one task (other than attacks or defense) on which you will concentrate. For the rest of that day, you're trained in that task. You can't use this ability with a skill in which you're already trained to become specialized. Enabler.

Flex Weapon Skill: At the beginning of each day, choose one type of attack: light bashing, light bladed, light ranged, medium bashing, medium bladed, medium ranged, heavy bashing, heavy bladed, or heavy ranged. For the rest of that day, you are trained in attacks using that type of weapon. You can't use this ability with an attack skill in which you're already trained to become specialized. Enabler.

Flight (4+ Intellect points): You can float and fly through the air for one hour. For each level of Effort applied, you can affect one additional creature of your size or smaller. You must touch the creature to bestow the power of flight. You direct the other creature's movement, and while flying, it must remain within sight of you or fall. In terms of overland movement, a flying creature moves about 20 miles (32 km) per hour and is not affected by terrain. Action to initiate.

Flight Exertion (3 Might or 3 Speed points): You can fly up to a short distance as your movement this round. If all you do is move on your turn, you can fly up to a long distance. Enabler.

Flight Not Fight: If you use your action only to move, all Speed defense tasks are eased. Enabler.

Fling (4 Intellect points): You violently launch a creature or object about your size or smaller within short range and send it flying a short distance in any direction. This is an Intellect attack that inflicts 4 points of damage to the object being flung when it lands or strikes a barrier. If you aim the primary target

at another creature or object (and succeed on a second attack), the secondary target also takes 4 points of damage. Action.

Flying Companion: You gain a level 3 companion creature that can fly at the same speed as you; depending on other aspects of your character, this might be a trained bird, a machine drone, or a helpful strange creature such as a familiar. This creature accompanies you and acts as you direct. As a level 3 companion, it has a target number of 9 and 9 health, and it inflicts 3 points of damage. If it's killed or destroyed, it takes you one month to find or create a suitable replacement. Enabler.

Foil Danger (2 Intellect points): You negate one source of potential danger related to one creature or object that you are aware of within immediate distance for one round. This could be a weapon or device held by someone, a trap triggered by a pressure plate, or a creature's natural ability (something special, innate, and dangerous, like a dragon's fiery breath or a giant cobra's venom). You can also try to foil a foe's mundane action (such as an attack with a weapon or claw), so that the action isn't made this round. Make your roll against the level of the attack, danger, or creature. Action.

Font of Healing: With your approval, other creatures can touch you and regain 1d6 points to either their Might Pool or their Speed Pool. This healing costs them 2 Intellect points. A single creature can benefit from this ability only once each day. Enabler.

Force and Accuracy: You inflict 3 additional points of damage with attacks using weapons that you throw. Enabler.

Force at Distance (4+ Intellect points): You temporarily bend the fundamental law of gravity around a creature or object (up to twice your mass) within short range. The target is caught in your telekinetic grip, and you can move it up to a short distance in any direction each round that you retain your hold. A creature in your grip can take actions, but it can't move under its own power. Each round after the initial attack, you can attempt to keep your grip on the target by spending 2 additional Intellect points and succeeding at a difficulty 2 Intellect task. If your concentration lapses, the target drops back to the ground. In addition to the normal options for using Effort, you can choose to use Effort to increase the amount of mass you can affect. Each level allows you to affect a creature or object twice as massive as before. For example, applying one level of Effort would affect a creature four times as massive as you, two levels would affect a creature eight times as massive, three levels would affect a creature sixteen times as massive, and so on. Action to initiate.

Force Bash (1 Might point): This is a pummeling melee attack you make with your Force Field Shield. Your attack inflicts 1 less point of damage than normal but dazes your target for one round, during which time all tasks it performs are hindered. Enabler.

Force Blast: You figure out how to project blasts of pure force from the gauntlets of the power armor from your Powered Armor ability. This allows you to fire a blast of force that inflicts 5 points of damage with a range of 200 feet (60 m). Action.

Force Field (3 Intellect points): You create an invisible energy barrier around a creature or object you choose within short range. The force field moves with the creature or object and lasts for ten minutes. If the target is a creature, they gain +1 to Armor; if the target is an object, attacks against it are hindered.

Force Field Barrier (3+ Intellect points): You create an opaque, stationary barrier of solid energy (a force field) within immediate range. The barrier is 10 feet by 10 feet (3 m by 3 m) and of negligible thickness. It is a level 2 barrier and lasts for

ten minutes. It can be placed anywhere it fits, whether against a solid object (including the ground) or floating in the air. Each level of Effort you apply strengthens the barrier by one level. For example, applying two levels of Effort creates a level 4 barrier. Action.

Force Field Shield: You manifest a small plane of pure force, which takes on a shield-like shape with the barest flicker of a thought. You can dismiss it just as easily. To use the force shield, you must hold it in one of your hands. You are practiced in using your exotic shield in one hand as a light melee weapon; however, if you attack with both your shield and a weapon held in the other hand, both attacks are hindered. When you are unconscious or sleeping, the force field dissipates. Enabler. (A shield, including one produced by a force field, provides an asset to a character's Speed defense task while it is held in one hand.)

Force to Reckon With: You can break through force fields and energy barriers as if they were physical walls. Enabler.

Force Wall (5 Intellect points): You can trigger the energy in your Force Field Shield to expand outward in all directions to create an immobile plane of solid force up to 20 feet by 20 feet (6 m by 6 m) for up to one hour or until you take your shield back. (The force shield becomes the force wall.) The plane of the force wall conforms to the space available. While the force wall remains in place, you cannot use any of your other abilities that require Force Field Shield. Action to initiate.

Fortification Builder: Whenever you attempt a crafting task—or help in the crafting task—to build a wall or other fortification, you ease the crafting difficulty by two steps, to a minimum of difficulty 1. Enabler.

Fortified Position (2 Might points): For the next minute, you gain +1 Armor and an asset to your Might defense tasks, as long as you haven't moved more than an immediate distance since your last turn. Action to initiate.

Foul Aura (5+ Intellect points): Your words, gestures, and touch invest an object no larger than yourself with an aura of doom, fear, and doubt for one day. Creatures that can hear and understand you feel an urge to move at least a short distance away from the object. If a creature does not move away, all tasks, attacks, and defenses it attempts while within the aura are hindered. The duration of the aura is extended by one day per level of Effort applied. The aura is temporarily blocked while the object is covered or contained. Action to initiate.

Freakishly Large: Your increased size intimidates most people. While you enjoy the effects of Enlarge, all intimidation tasks you attempt are eased. Enabler.

Free to Move: You ignore all movement penalties and adjustments due to terrain or other obstacles. You can fit through any space large enough to fit your head. Tasks involving breaking free of bonds, a creature's grip, or any similar impediment gain three free levels of Effort. Enabler.

Freezing Touch (4 Intellect points): Your hands become so cold that your touch freezes solid a living target of your size or smaller, rendering it immobile for one round. If you have another cold ability activated by touch (such as Frost Touch), you can use it as part of the Freezing Touch attack. Action.

Frenzy (1 Intellect point): When you wish, while in combat, you can enter a state of frenzy. While in this state, you can't use Intellect points, but you gain +1 to your Might Edge and your Speed Edge. This effect lasts as long as you wish, but it ends if no combat is taking place within range of your senses. Enabler.

Friendly Help: If your friend tries a task and fails, they can

try again without spending Effort if you help. You provide this advantage to your friend even if you are not trained in the task that they are retrying. Enabler.

From the Shadows: If you successfully attack a creature that was previously unaware of your presence, you deal 3 additional points of damage. Enabler.

Frost Touch (1 Intellect point): Your hands become so cold that the next time you touch a creature, you inflict 3 points of damage. Alternatively, you can use this ability on a weapon, and for ten minutes, it inflicts 1 additional point of damage from the cold. Action for touch; enabler for weapon.

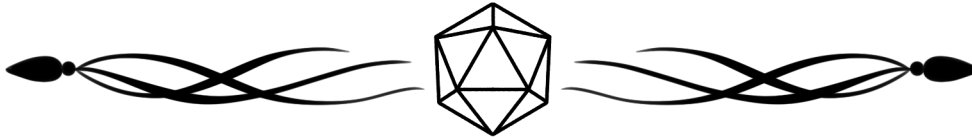
Further Mathematics: You are specialized in higher mathematics. If you are already specialized, choose some other

sphere of knowledge to become trained in. Enabler.

Fury (3 Might points): For the next minute, all melee attacks you make inflict 2 additional points of damage. Action to initiate.

Fusion: You can fuse your manifest cyphers and artifacts with your body. These fused devices function as if they were one level higher. Enabler.

Fusion Armor: A procedure gives you biometal implants in major portions of your body, you grow metal-hard skin, the blessings of an angel protect you, or something similar happens. These changes give you +1 to Armor even when you're not wearing physical armor. Enabler.



7.8 Abilities—G

Gain Unusual Companion: You gain a special specimen as a constant companion. It is level 4, probably the size of a small dog, and follows your telepathic commands. You and the GM must work out the details of your creature, and you'll probably make rolls for it in combat or when it takes actions. The companion acts on your turn. If your companion dies, you can hunt in the wild for 1d6 days to find a new one. Enabler.

Gambler: Each day, choose two different numbers from 2 to 16. One number is your lucky number, and the other is your unlucky number. Whenever you make a roll that day and get a number matching your lucky number, your next task is eased. Whenever you make a roll that day and get a number matching your unlucky number, your next task is hindered. Enabler.

Game Lessons: You've played so many games that you've picked up some real knowledge. Choose any two noncombat skills. You are trained in those skills. Enabler.

Gamer: Pick any one style of game such as real-time strategy games, games of chance in the style of poker, roleplaying games, and so on. You can apply an asset to a task related to playing that style of game once between each recovery roll. Enabler.

Gamer's Fortitude: Sitting and playing a game for twelve hours straight is not something most people can do, but you've figured it out. Once after each ten-hour recovery roll, you can transfer up to 5 points between your Pools in any combination, at a rate of 1 point per round. For example, you could transfer 3 points of Might to Speed and 2 points of Intellect to Speed, which would take a total of five rounds. Action.

Gaming God: Any time you use Effort on an Intellect action, add one of the following enhancements to the action (your choice):

- Free level of Effort
- Automatic minor effect

Enabler.

Gargantuan: When you use Enlarge, you can choose to grow up to 30 feet (9 m) in height, and you add 3 more temporary points to your Might Pool (if you also have the Bigger ability, the temporary points from Gargantuan are in addition to the points from Bigger). Enabler.

Gather Intelligence (2 Intellect points): When in a group of people (a caravan, a palace, a village, a city, etc.) you can ask around about any topic you choose and come away with useful information. You can ask a specific question, or you can simply obtain general facts. You also get a good idea of the general layout of the location involved, note the presence of all major sites, and perhaps even notice obscure details. For example, not only do you find out if anyone in the palace has seen the missing boy, but you also get a working knowledge of the layout of the palace itself, note all the entrances and which are used more often than others, and take notice that everyone seems to avoid the well in the eastern courtyard for some reason. Action to initiate, about an hour to complete.

Generate Force Field (9+ Intellect points): You create six planes of solid force (level 8), each 30 feet (9 m) to a side, which persist for one hour. The planes must be contiguous, and they retain the position that you choose when initiating this ability. For instance, you could arrange the planes linearly, creating a wall 180 feet (55 m) long, or you could create a closed cube. The planes conform to the space available. Each additional level

of Effort you apply increases the level of the barrier by one (to a maximum of level 10) or increases the number of hours it remains by one. Action to initiate.

Get Away (2 Speed points): After your action on your turn, you move up to a short distance or get behind or beneath cover within immediate range. Enabler.

Ghost (4 Intellect points): For the next ten minutes, you gain an asset to sneaking tasks. During this time, you can move through solid barriers (but not energy barriers) at a rate of 1 foot (30 cm) per round, and you can perceive while phased within a barrier or object, which allows you to peek through walls. Action to initiate.

Go Defensive (1 Intellect point): When you wish, while in combat, you can enter a state of heightened awareness of threat. While in this state, you can't use points from your Intellect Pool, but you gain +1 to your Speed Edge and gain two assets to Speed defense tasks. This effect lasts as long as you wish or until you attack a foe or no combat is taking place within range of your senses. Once the effect of this ability ends, you can't enter it again for one minute. Enabler.

Go to Ground (4 Speed points): You move up to a long distance and attempt to hide. When you do, you gain an asset on the stealth task to blend in, disappear, or otherwise escape the senses of everyone previously aware of your presence. Action.

Goad (1 Intellect point): You can attempt to goad a target into a belligerent—and probably foolish—reaction that requires the target to try to close the distance between you and attempt to physically strike you on its next turn. They attempt this action even if this would cause them to break formation or to give up cover or a tactically superior position. Whether the target strikes you or fails to do so, they come to their senses immediately afterward, after which further tasks attempting to goad the target again are hindered. Action to initiate.

Golem Body: You gain +1 to Armor, +1 to your Might Edge, and 5 additional points to your Might Pool. You do not need to eat, drink, or breathe (though you do need rest and sleep). You move more stiffly than a creature of flesh, which means you can never be trained or specialized in Speed defense rolls. Furthermore, you are practiced in using your stone fists as a medium weapon. Enabler.

Golem Grip (3 Might points): Your attack with the stone fists from your Golem Body ability is eased. If you hit, you can grab the target, preventing it from moving on its next turn. While you hold the target, its attacks or attempts to break free are hindered. If the target attempts to break free instead of attacking, you must make a Might-based roll to maintain your grip. If the target fails to break free, you can continue to hold it each round as your subsequent actions, automatically inflicting 4 points of damage each round by squeezing. Enabler.

Golem Healing: Your stone form from the Golem Body ability is more difficult to repair than flesh, which means you are unable to use the first, single-action recovery roll of the day that other PCs have access to. Thus, your first recovery roll on any given day requires ten minutes of rest, the second requires an hour of rest, and the third requires ten hours. Enabler.

Golem Stomp (4 Might points): You stomp on the ground with all of your strength, creating a shock wave that attacks all creatures in immediate range. Affected creatures take 3 points of damage and are either pushed out of immediate range or fall down (your choice). Action.

Good Advice: Anyone can help an ally, easing whatever task they're attempting. However, you have the benefit of clarity and wisdom. When you help another character, they gain an

additional asset. Enabler.

Got a Feeling (4 Intellect points): You have an uncanny intuition when it comes to finding things. While exploring, you can extend your senses up to 1 mile (1.5 km) in any direction and ask the GM a very simple, general question—usually a yes-or-no question—about that area, such as “Is there an orc encampment nearby?” or “Is there dark matter to be found in that rusted hulk?” If the answer you seek is not in the area, you receive no information. Action.

Grab: While you are using the Enlarge ability, you can attack by attempting to wrap your massive hands around a target the size of a normal human or smaller. While you maintain your hold as your action, you keep the target from moving or taking physical actions (other than attempts to escape). The target’s escape attempt is hindered by two steps due to your size. If you wish, you can automatically inflict 3 points of damage each round on the target while you hold it, but you can also keep it protected (by taking all attacks otherwise meant for the target). Action.

Grand Deception (3 Intellect points): You convince an intelligent creature that can understand you and isn’t hostile of something that is wildly and obviously untrue. Action.

Grandiose Illusion (8 Intellect points): You create a fantastically complex scene of images that fit within a 1-mile (1.5 km) cube that you are also within. You must be able to see the images when you create them. The images can move in the cube and act in accordance with your desires. They can also act logically (such as reacting appropriately to fire or attacks) when you aren’t directly observing them. The illusion includes sound and smell. For example, armies can clash in battle, with air support from machines or flying creatures, on and above terrain of your creation. The illusion lasts for one hour (or longer, if you concentrate on it after that time). Action.

Granite Wall (7+ Intellect points): You create a level 6 granite wall within short range. The wall is 1 foot (30 cm) thick and up to 20 feet by 20 feet (6 m by 6 m) in size. It appears resting on a solid foundation and lasts for about ten hours. If you apply three levels of Effort, the wall is permanent until destroyed naturally. Action to initiate.

Grasping Foliage (3+ Intellect points): Roots, branches, grass, or other natural foliage in the area snags and holds a foe you designate within short range for up to one minute. A foe caught in the grasping foliage can’t move from its position, and all physical tasks, attacks, and defenses are hindered, including attempts to free itself. In addition to the normal options for using Effort, you can choose to use Effort to deal damage with the initial attack. Each level applied inflicts 2 additional points of damage when Grasping Foliage first snags and holds your foe.

You can also use this ability to clear an area of entangling growth in the immediate radius, such as an area of tall grass, thick brush, impenetrable vines, and so on. Action.

Gravity Cleave (3 Intellect points): You can harm a target within short range by rapidly increasing gravity’s pull on one portion of the target and decreasing it on another, inflicting 6 points of damage. Action.

Great Tree: When you use Wooden Body, you may grow to up to 12 feet (4 m) in height. In this larger form, you add 7 points to your Might Pool and +2 to your Might Edge. If you chose to grow, when Wooden Body ends you subtract 7 points from your Might Pool (if this brings the Pool to 0, subtract the overflow first from your Speed Pool and then, if necessary, from your Intellect Pool). When you use Wooden Body, whether or not you choose to grow, instead of looking like a wooden ver-

sion of your normal self, you can take on the full appearance of a humanoid tree creature or an actual tree (including growing additional branches, extra foliage, and so on). This does not affect any of your abilities—in tree shape, you can use type abilities, other focus abilities, and so on. In tree shape, pretending to be a tree and hiding among normal trees are eased by two steps. Enabler.

Greater Beast Form: When using Beast Form, your beast form gains the following additional bonuses: +1 to your Might Edge, +2 to your Speed Pool, and +1 to your Speed Edge. Enabler.

Greater Controlled Change: It’s easier to change into and out of the shape granted by your Beast Form ability. Transforming either way is now a difficulty 2 Intellect task. Enabler.

Greater Designation: You can assign an innocent or guilty label to all creatures within immediate range when you use Designation. The one label applies to all affected creatures. This lasts until you use Greater Designation again. Action.

Greater Enhanced Intellect: You gain 6 points to your Intellect Pool. Enabler.

Greater Enhanced Might: You gain 6 points to your Might Pool. Enabler.

Greater Enhanced Physique: You gain 6 points to divide among your Might and Speed Pools however you wish. Enabler.

Greater Enhanced Potential: You gain 6 points to divide among your stat Pools however you wish. Enabler.

Greater Enhanced Speed: You gain 6 points to your Speed Pool. Enabler.

Greater Frenzy (4 Intellect points): When you wish, while in combat, you can enter a state of frenzy. While in this state, you can’t use Intellect points, but you gain +2 to your Might Edge and your Speed Edge. This effect lasts as long as you wish, but it ends if no combat is taking place within range of your senses. If you have the Frenzy ability, you can use it or this ability, but you can’t use both at the same time. Enabler.

Greater Healing Touch (4 Intellect points): You touch a creature and restore its Might Pool, Speed Pool, and Intellect Pool to their maximum values, as if it were fully rested. A single creature can benefit from this ability only once each day. Action.

Greater Necromancy (5+ Intellect points): This ability works like the Necromancy ability except that it creates a level 3 creature. Action to animate.

Greater Skill With Attacks: Choose one type of attack, even one in which you are already trained: light bashing, light bladed, light ranged, medium bashing, medium bladed, medium ranged, heavy bashing, heavy bladed, or heavy ranged. You are trained in attacks using that type of weapon. If you’re already trained in that type of attack, you instead are specialized in that type of attack. Enabler.

Greater Skill With Defense: Choose one type of defense task, even one in which you are already trained: Might, Speed, or Intellect. You are trained in defense tasks of that type, or specialized if you are already trained. You can select this ability up to three times. Each time you select it, you must choose a different type of defense task. Enabler.

Group Friendship (4 Intellect points): You convince a sentient creature to regard you (and up to ten creatures that you designate within immediate distance of you) positively, as they would a potential friend. Action.

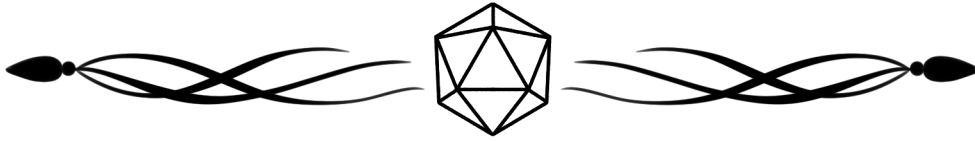
Guide Bolt (4+ Intellect points): When you make an attack with a metallic bolt or metal-tipped arrow on a target within short range, you can improve the attack’s aim and velocity,

which grants an asset to the attack and inflicts an additional 2 points of damage. If you apply a level of Effort, you grant the same benefits to a ranged attack made by an ally within immediate range. In any case, you can use this ability only once per round. Enabler.

Guild Training: Your type abilities that have durations last

twice as long. Your type abilities that have short ranges reach to long range instead. Your type abilities that inflict damage deal 1 additional point of damage. Enabler.

Gunner: You inflict 1 additional point of damage with guns. Enabler.



7.9 Abilities—H

Hack the Impossible (3 Intellect points): You can persuade robots, machines, and computers to do your bidding. You can discover an encrypted password, break through security on a website, briefly turn off a machine such as a surveillance camera, or disable a robot with a moment's worth of fiddling. Action.

Hacker (2 Intellect points): You gain quick access to a desired bit of information in a computer or similar device, or you access one of its primary functions. Action.

Hand to Eye (2 Speed points): This ability provides an asset to any tasks involving manual dexterity, such as pickpocketing, lockpicking, games involving agility, and so on. Each use lasts up to a minute; a new use (to switch tasks) replaces the previous use. Action to initiate.

Handy: You work for a living and are trained in tasks related to carpentry, plumbing, and electrical repair. Your knowledge in these realms also gives you an asset to craft entirely new items within your spheres of knowledge and the limits of possibility within the setting. Enabler.

Hard Choices: Sometimes, you believe that you've got to lie to those who trust you for their own good. You are specialized in deception tasks. Enabler.

Hard Target: If you move a short distance or farther on your turn, all Speed defense rolls are eased. Enabler.

Hard to Distract: You are trained in Intellect defense tasks. Enabler.

Hard to Hit: You are trained in Speed defense tasks. Enabler.

Hard to Kill: You can choose to reroll any defense task you make but never more than once per round. Enabler.

Hard to See: When you move, you are a blur. It is impossible to make out your identity as you run past, and in a round where you do nothing but move, stealth tasks and Speed defense tasks are eased. Enabler.

Hard-Won Resilience: In your explorations of dark places, you've been exposed to all sorts of terrible things and are developing a general resistance. You gain +1 to Armor and are trained in Might defense tasks. Enabler.

Harder Light: When you create an object out of hard light, the object is one level higher than normal. Enabler. Hardiness: You are trained in Might defense tasks. Enabler.

Have Spacesuit, Will Travel Somehow or another, you became the legal owner of a fully functional and advanced spacesuit. The spacesuit provides +1 Armor and, more important, allows you to survive in the vacuum of space using suit reserves for up to twelve hours at a time with enough reaction mass to get around in zero gravity on jets of ionized gas for that same period. After each use, the suit must be recharged, either with already-charged cartridges of air and reaction mass or by allowing the suit to sit idle in an area with breathable atmosphere for at least two hours, during which time it will recharge both air and reaction mass using integrated solid state mechanisms. The suit's power supply is a radioisotope thermoelectric generator, which means it'll function for a few decades before needing to be changed out. Enabler.

Heads-Up Display (2+ Intellect points): Your Powered Armor ability comes with systems that help you make sense of, analyze, and use your weapons in your environment. When you trigger this ability, you gain an asset on one attack roll as the suit perfectly outlines foes and steadies your aim, regardless of whether you're making a melee or ranged attack.

Alternatively, you can use the heads-up display to magnify your vision, increasing your vision range to 5 miles (8 km) for two rounds. If you apply one level of Effort, you can also see through mundane materials (such as wood, concrete, plastic, and stone) to a short distance in false color images. If you apply two levels of Effort, you can see through special materials (such as solid lead or other substances) to an immediate distance in false color images; however, the GM might require you to succeed at an Intellect-based task first, depending on the material blocking your armor's sensors. Enabler.

Healing Pulse (3 Intellect points): You and all targets you choose within immediate range gain the immediate benefits of using one of their recovery rolls (as long as it is not their ten-hour recovery roll) without having to spend an action, ten minutes, or one hour. Targets regain points to their Pools immediately but mark off that recovery use. PCs who have already used up their one-action, ten-minute, and one-hour recovery rolls for the day gain no benefit from this ability. NPCs targeted by this ability regain a number of health points equal to their level. Action.

Healing Touch (1 Intellect point): With a touch, you restore 1d6 points to one stat Pool of any creature. This ability is a difficulty 2 Intellect task. Each time you attempt to heal the same creature, the task is hindered by an additional step. The difficulty returns to 2 after that creature rests for ten hours. Action.

Hedge Magic (1 Intellect point): You can perform small tricks: temporarily change the color or basic appearance of a small object, cause small objects to float through the air, clean a small area, mend a broken object, prepare (but not create) food, and so on. You can't use Hedge Magic to harm another creature or object. Action.

Heightened Skills: You are trained in two tasks of your choosing (other than attacks or defense). If you choose a task you're already trained in, you instead become specialized in that task. You can't choose a task you're already specialized in. Enabler.

Hemorrhage (2+ Might points): You make a powerful and precise strike that inflicts additional damage later. On your next turn, the target of this attack takes an additional 3 points of damage (ignores Armor). The target can prevent this additional damage by making a recovery roll, using any ability that heals it, or using its action to attend to the injury. In addition to the normal options for using Effort, you can choose to use Effort to increase this duration by one round. Action.

Heroic Monster Bane: When you inflict damage to creatures more than twice as large or massive as you, you inflict 3 additional points of damage. Enabler.

Hidden Closet: The magic ally from your Bound Magic Creature ability can store items for you within its bound object, including extra sets of clothing, tools, food, and so on. The interior of the object is, in effect, a 10-foot (3 m) square pocket dimension that normally only the magic ally can access. Enabler.

Hidden Reserves: When you use an action to make a recovery roll, you also gain +1 to both your Might Edge and your Speed Edge for ten minutes thereafter. Enabler.

Higher Mathematics: You are trained in standard and higher mathematics. Enabler.

Hold Breath: You can hold your breath for up to five minutes. Enabler.

Horde Fighting: When two or more foes attack you at once in melee, you can use them against each other. You gain an asset

to Speed defense rolls or attack rolls (your choice each round) against them. Enabler.

Horde Tactics (7 Might points): For up to one hour a day, you and at least three other allies can act like a single creature. Use your stats, but add +8 to your Might Pool, +1 to your Might Edge, +2 to your Speed Pool, +1 to your Speed Edge, and +1 to your Armor. Enabler.

Hover (2 Intellect points): You float slowly into the air. If you concentrate, you can control your movement to remain motionless in the air or float up to a short distance as your action; otherwise, you drift with the wind or with any momentum you have gained. This effect lasts for up to ten minutes. Action to initiate.

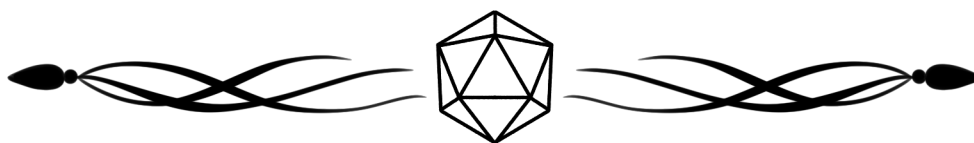
How Others Think: You have a sense of how people think. You're trained in one of the following tasks: persuasion, decep-

tion, or detecting falsehoods. Enabler.

Huge: When you use Enlarge, you can choose to grow up to 16 feet (5 m) in height. When you do, you add +1 to Armor (a total of +2 to Armor) and deal 2 additional points of damage with melee attacks. Enabler.

Hunter's Drive (5 Intellect points): Through force of will, when you wish it, you grant yourself greater prowess in the hunt for ten minutes. During this time, you gain an asset to all tasks involving your quarry, including attacks. Your quarry is the creature you selected with your Quarry ability. Enabler.

Hurl Flame (2 Intellect points): While your Shroud of Flame is active, you can reach into your halo and hurl a handful of fire at a target. This is a ranged attack with short range that deals 4 points of fire damage. Action.



7.10 Abilities—I

Ice Armor (1 Intellect point): When you wish it, your body is covered in a sheen of ice for ten minutes that gives you +1 to Armor. While the sheen is active, you feel no discomfort from normal cold temperatures and have an additional +2 to Armor versus cold damage specifically. Enabler.

Ice Creation (4+ Intellect points): You create a solid object of ice that is your size or smaller. The object is crude and can have no moving parts, so you can make a sword, a shield, a short ladder, and so on. Your ice objects are as strong as iron, but if you're not in constant contact with them, they function for only 1d6 + 6 rounds before breaking or melting. For example, you can make and wield an ice sword, but if you give it to another PC, the sword won't last as long for that character. In addition to the normal options for using Effort, you can choose to use Effort to create objects larger than you. For each level of Effort used in this way, you can create an object up to twice again as large as you. Action.

Ice Storm: You attempt an additional Intellect task as part of your Cold Burst attack, and if successful, you blind foes for up to one minute with a layer of freezing ice. All tasks of blinded creatures are hindered by two steps. Enabler.

Ignition (4 Intellect points): You designate a creature or flammable object you can see within short range to catch fire. This is an Intellect attack. The target takes 6 points of ambient damage per round until the flames are extinguished, which a creature can do by dousing itself in water, rolling on the ground, or smothering the flames. Usually, putting out the flames takes an action. Action to initiate.

Ignore Affliction (5 Might points): If you are affected by an unwanted condition or affliction (such as disease, paralysis, mind control, broken limb, and so on, but not damage), you can ignore it and act as if it does not affect you for one hour. If the condition would normally last less than an hour, it is entirely negated. Action.

Ignore the Pain: You ignore the impaired condition and treat the debilitated condition as impaired. Enabler.

Illuminating Touch (1 Intellect point): You touch an object, and that object sheds light to illuminate everything in short range. The light remains until you use an action to touch the object again, or until you've illuminated more objects than you have tiers, in which case the oldest objects you illuminated go dark first. Action.

Illusory Disguise (2+ Intellect points): You appear to be someone or something else, roughly of your size and shape, for up to one hour. Once created, the disguise requires no concentration. For each additional Intellect point you spend, you can disguise one other creature. All disguised creatures must stay within sight of you or lose their disguise. Action to create.

Illusory Duplicate (2 Intellect points): You create a single image of yourself within immediate range. The image looks like you as you are now (including how you are dressed). The image can move (for example, you could make it walk or attack), but it can't move more than an immediate distance from where you created it. The illusion includes sound and smell. It lasts for ten minutes and changes as you direct (no concentration is needed). If you move beyond short range of the illusion, it vanishes. Action to create.

Illusory Evasion (5 Intellect points): When you would be hit by an attack, you teleport an immediate distance away, leaving behind an illusory copy of yourself to be struck by that attack instead of you. This destroys the illusion but leaves you

unharmful by the attack. If the attack affects an area and the teleportation can't get you out of that area, the attack still affects you normally. Enabler.

Illusory Selves (4 Intellect points): You create four holographic duplicates of yourself within short range. The duplicates last for one minute. You mentally direct their actions, and the duplicates aren't mirror images—each one can do different things. If struck violently, they either disappear permanently or freeze motionless (your choice). Action to create.

Immovable: You gain +3 to your Might Pool. You can attempt a Might task to avoid being knocked down, pushed back, or moved against your will even if the effect attempting to move you doesn't allow it. If you apply Effort to this task, you can apply two free levels of Effort. Enabler.

Impart Ideal (3 Intellect points): After interacting for at least one minute with a creature who can hear and understand you, you can attempt to temporarily impart an ideal to it that you could not otherwise convince it to adopt. An ideal is different than a specific suggestion or command; an ideal is an overarching value such as "All life is sacred," "My political party is the best," "Children should be seen, not heard," and so on. An ideal influences a creature's behavior but doesn't control it. The imparted ideal lasts as long as befits the situation, but usually at least a few hours. The ideal is jeopardized if someone friendly to the creature spends a minute or more bringing it back to its senses. Action.

Impart Understanding: Your Learning the Path ability works more effectively, allowing you to ease a task by two steps or to provide two assets to a friend's task, instead of easing normally. Enabler.

Impersonate (2 Intellect points): For one hour, you alter your voice, posture, and mannerisms, whip together a disguise, and gain an asset on an attempt to impersonate someone else, whether it is a specific individual (Bob the cop) or a general role (a police officer). Action to initiate.

Impetus (2 Intellect points): A loose object within short range that you could carry in one hand is drawn to your free hand. If the object is stuck or held by another creature, you must succeed on a Might roll to rip it free, or the object remains where it is. Action.

Impossible Walk (5+ Speed points): You can walk (or crawl or run) on steep inclines and horizontal surfaces (such as walls and cliffs) for the next minute as if they were flat ground. When using this ability, "down" for you is either the surface you are walking on or the normal orientation of gravity (your choice). If you apply one level of Effort, you can also walk on the ceiling or on a liquid or semi-liquid surface such as water, mud, quicksand, or even lava (although touching a dangerous surface like lava still harms you). If you apply two levels of Effort, you can also walk on air as if it were solid ground. Enabler.

Impressive Display (2 Might points): You perform a feat of strength, speed, or combat, impressing those nearby. For the next minute you gain an asset on all interaction tasks with people who saw you use this ability. Action.

Improved Absorb Kinetic Energy: When you use Absorb Kinetic Energy, instead of being able to absorb 1 point of damage from a physical attack or impact, you can absorb 2 points. You can also store up to 2 points of energy from any source. However, you can still release energy only 1 point at a time. Enabler.

Improved Apportation (6 Intellect points): You call a creature of up to level 3, which appears next to you. You can choose a creature that you've previously encountered, or (no

more than once per day) you can allow the GM to determine the creature randomly. If you call a random creature, it has a 10 percent chance of being a creature of up to level 5. The creature has no memory of anything before being called by you, though it can speak and has the general knowledge a creature of its type should possess. The creature is receptive to communication and helping you (unless shown that it should do otherwise). Action.

Improved Command Spirit: When you use your Command Spirit ability, you can command a spirit or animate undead creature of up to level 7. Enabler.

Improved Companion: Your companion (such as a controlled beast) or follower increases to level 4. As a level 4 creature, it has a target number of 12 and 12 health, and it inflicts 4 points of damage (though in most cases, instead of attacking, it provides an asset to your attacks). You can gain this ability once per tier. Each additional time you select it, it increases your companion or follower's level by 1. Enabler.

Improved Copying: You can use Copy Power to copy more powerful abilities. In addition to the normal options for using Effort with Copy Power, if you apply one level of Effort, the GM chooses a mid-tier ability that most closely resembles that power (instead of a low-tier ability). Enabler. When you use Improved Copying, a copied ability must be low, medium, or high tier according to how it is listed in the ability categories. It doesn't matter if a type or focus makes it available at a lower or higher tier.

Improved Designation: When you use Designation, you can designate one additional creature to be innocent or guilty, which means up to two creatures at a time may be innocent, or two guilty, or one innocent and one guilty. Enabler.

Improved Edge: Choose one of your Edge stats that is 0. It increases to 1. Enabler.

Improved Gravity Cleave (9 Intellect points): You can harm a group of targets within long range by rapidly increasing gravity's pull on one portion of each target and decreasing it on another, inflicting 6 points of damage. The targets must be within immediate range of each other. Action.

Improved Machine Companion: The machine from your Machine Companion ability improves, becoming a level 5 creature with the ability either to fly a long distance each round (and carry you) for up to ten minutes at a time, or to carry an extra cypher for you that doesn't count against your cypher limit. Enabler.

Improved Monster Bane: When you inflict damage to creatures more than twice as large or massive as you, you inflict 3 additional points of damage. Enabler.

Improved Object Bond (5 Intellect points): When you manifest the ally from your Bound Magic Creature ability, it is now a level 4 creature. Also, the creature gains a pulse attack that renders all artifacts, machines, manifest cyphers, and lesser magic devices within short range inoperable for one minute. After the creature uses this ability, it must retreat to its object to rest for three hours. Enabler.

Improved Recovery: Your ten-minute recovery roll takes only one action instead, so that your first two recovery rolls are one action, the third is one hour, and the fourth is ten hours. Enabler.

Improved Sculpt Light (7+ Intellect points): You create an object of solid light in any shape you can imagine whose base size can fit within a 10-foot (3 m) cube. The object appears in an area adjacent to you or floating freely in space up to a long distance away, and the object lasts for a few days. The object is crude and can have no moving parts, so you can make

a wall segment, a block, a box, stairs, and so on. The sculpted object has the approximate mass of the real object and is level 6. If you apply Effort to increase the size of the object, each level applied increases the size by an additional 10-foot (3 m) cube. Action.

Improved Sensor (2 Intellect points): When you use Sensor, you can place the sensor anywhere you choose within long range. Enabler.

Improved Success: When you roll a 17 or higher on an attack roll that deals damage, you deal 1 additional point of damage. For instance, if you roll a natural 18, which normally deals 2 extra points of damage, you instead deal 3 extra points. If you roll a natural 20 and choose to deal damage instead of achieve a special major effect, you deal 5 extra points of damage. Enabler.

Improvise (3 Intellect points): When you perform a task in which you are not trained, you can improvise to gain an asset on the task. The asset might be a tool you cobble together, a sudden insight into overcoming a problem, or a rush of dumb luck. Enabler. (Improvise can be used on a task a character has an inability in, but instead of gaining an asset, the character just loses the inability penalty.)

In Harm's Way (3 Intellect points): When you put your friends before yourself as your action, you ease all defense tasks for all characters you choose that are adjacent to you. This lasts until the end of your next turn. If one of your friends would be damaged, you can choose to take up to half the number of points of damage they would otherwise take, but only if you're not already impaired or debilitated. Enabler.

Incomparable Pilot: While on a starcraft you own or have a direct connection with, your Might Edge, Speed Edge, and Intellect Edge increase by 1. When you make a recovery roll on a starcraft you're familiar with, you recover 5 additional points. Enabler.

Increased Effects: You treat rolls of natural 19 as rolls of natural 20 for either Might actions or Speed actions (your choice when you gain this ability). This allows you to gain a major effect on a natural 19 or 20. Enabler.

Increasing Determination: If you fail at a noncombat physical task (pushing open a door or climbing a cliff, for example) and then retry the task, the task is eased. If you fail again, you gain no special benefits. Enabler.

Incredible Feat of Science (12 Intellect points): You do something amazing in the lab. This takes parts and materials equivalent to three expensive items. Possible incredible feats include:

- Reanimate and command a dead body for one hour.
- Create an engine that runs on perpetual motion.
- Create a teleportation gate that remains open for one minute.
- Transmute one substance into another substance.
- Cure one person with an incurable disease or condition.
- Create a weapon designed to hurt something that can't otherwise be hurt.
- Create a defense designed to protect against something that can't otherwise be stopped.

Action to initiate; a full day of work to complete.

Incredible Health: Thanks to a dip in a magical pool, an injection of artificial antibodies and immune defense nanobots

into your bloodstream, exposure to strange radiation, or something else, you are now immune to diseases, viruses, and mutations of any kind. Enabler.

Incredible Recovery (6 Might points): You move up one step on the damage track or shake off any unwanted ongoing condition. Action.

Incredible Running Speed: You move much farther than normal in a round. This means as a part of another action, you can move up to a long distance. As an action, you can move up to 200 feet (60 m), or up to 500 feet (150 m) as a Speed-based task with a difficulty of 4. Enabler.

Infer Thoughts (4 Intellect points): If you interact with or study a target for at least a round, you can attempt to read its surface thoughts, even if the subject doesn't want you to. You must be able to see the target. Once you have gained a sense of what it's thinking—through its body language, its speech, and what it does and doesn't say—you can continue to infer the target's surface thoughts for up to one minute as long as you can still see and hear the target. Action to prepare; action to initiate.

Inferno Trail (6 Intellect points): For the next minute, you leave a trail of flame in your wake. The trail matches your path and lasts for up to a minute, creating a wall of flame about 6 feet (2 m) high that inflicts 5 points of damage to any creature that passes through it, potentially catching them on fire for an additional 1 point of damage each round (if they are flammable) until they spend a round putting out the fire. Action.

Infiltrator: You are trained in interactions involving lies or trickery. Enabler.

Influence Swarm (1 Intellect point): You master one type of small creature (such as insects, rats, bats, or even birds) and they respond to you in number. Your creatures within short range will not harm you or those you designate as allies for one hour. Action to initiate.

Information Gathering (5 Intellect points): You speak telepathically with any or all machines within 1 mile (1.5 km). You can ask one basic question about themselves or anything happening near them and receive a simple answer. For example, while in an area with many machines, you could ask about the location of a specific creature or individual, and if they are within a mile of you, one or more machines will probably provide the answer. Action.

Informer: You gain an informer within an allied community. They act as your secret (or known) informer. If something of note happens in your informer's location, they will use whatever means they have available to tell you about it. Enabler.

Infuse Spirit: When you kill a creature or destroy a spirit with an attack, if you choose, its spirit (if unprotected) immediately infuses you, and you regain 1d6 points to one of your Pools (your choice). The spirit is stored within you, which means it cannot be questioned, raised, or restored to life by any means unless you allow it. Enabler.

Inhabit Crystal (4 Intellect points): You transfer your body and whatever you are carrying into a crystal at least the size of your index finger. While in the crystal, you are aware of what is going on around it, seeing and hearing through the crystal. You can even speak through the crystal and carry on conversations. You cannot take actions other than to exit the crystal. You remain within as long as you wish, but you are not in stasis and should exit to eat, drink, sleep, and so on as normal (breathing is not an issue). If the crystal is destroyed or takes major damage while you are within it, you immediately exit, cannot act for three rounds, and move two steps down the damage track. Action to enter and exit. (A character should specify where they

place the crystal for the Inhabit Crystal ability before using it, even if it's just on the ground at their feet.)

Innate Power: Choose either your Might Pool or your Speed Pool. When spending points to activate your focus abilities, you can spend points from this Pool instead of your Intellect Pool (in which case you use your Might Edge or Speed Edge instead of your Intellect Edge, as appropriate). Enabler
Inner Defense: Life's trials have toughened you and made you hard to read. You are trained in any task to resist another creature's attempt to discern your true feelings, beliefs, or plans. You are likewise trained in resisting torture, telepathic intrusion, and mind control. Enabler.

Innovator: You can modify any artifact to give it different or better abilities as if that artifact were one level lower than normal, and the modification takes half the normal time. Enabler.

Insect Eruption (6 Intellect points): You call a swarm of insects in a place where it is possible for insects to appear. They remain for one minute, and during this time, they do as you command while they are within long range. They can swarm about and hinder any or all creatures' tasks, or you can focus the swarm and attack all targets within immediate range of each other (all within long range of you). The attacking swarm inflicts 2 points of damage per round. You can also command the swarm to move heavy objects through collective effort, eat through wooden walls, and perform other actions suitable for a supernatural swarm. Action to initiate.

Insight: You are trained in tasks to discern others' motives and to ascertain their general nature. You have a knack for sensing whether or not someone is truly innocent. Enabler.

Inspiration (6 Intellect points): You speak words of encouragement and inspiration. All allies within short range who can hear you immediately gain a recovery roll, gain an immediate free action, and have an asset for that free action. The recovery roll does not count as one of their normal recovery rolls. Action.

Inspire Action (4 Intellect points): If one ally can see and easily understand you, you can instruct that ally to take an action. If the ally chooses to take that exact action, they can do so as an additional action immediately. Doing so doesn't interfere with the ally taking a normal action on their turn. Action.

Inspire Aggression (2 Intellect points): Your words twist the mind of a character within short range who is able to understand you, unlocking their more primitive instincts. As a result, they gain an asset on their Might-based attack rolls for one minute. Action to initiate.

Inspire Coordinated Actions (9 Intellect points): If your allies can see and easily understand you, you can instruct each of them to take one specific action (the same action for all of them). If any of them choose to take that exact action, they can do so as an additional action immediately. This doesn't interfere with them taking their normal actions on their turns. Action.

Inspire the Innocent (3 Intellect points): You speak words of encouragement and inspiration to everyone within immediate range whom you have designated as innocent with your Designation ability. They immediately gain a free recovery roll. One person you choose can gain an immediate free action instead of a free recovery roll. If you also have the Inspiration ability, the target who gains a free action also gains an asset on it. Action.

Inspiring Ease: Through stories, songs, art, or other forms of entertainment, you inspire your friends. After spending 24 hours with you, once per day each of your friends can ease a

task. This benefit is ongoing while you remain in the friend's company. It ends if you leave, but it resumes if you return to the friend's company within 24 hours. If you leave the friend's company for more than 24 hours, you must spend another 24 hours together to reactivate the benefit. Enabler.

Inspiring Success (6 Intellect points): When you succeed on a roll to perform a task related to the stat that you choose upon selecting this ability, and you applied at least one level of Effort, you may choose another character within short range. That character has an asset on the next task they attempt using that stat on their next turn. Enabler.

Intelligent Interface (3 Intellect points): You can speak telepathically with any intelligent machine within long range. Further, you are trained in all interactions with intelligent machines. Such machines and robots that normally would never communicate with a human might talk to you. Enabler.

Intense Interaction (3 Intellect points): You gain an asset on intimidating, persuading, and influencing people for ten minutes. Action.

Interaction Skills: You are trained in two skills in which you are not already trained. Choose two of the following: deceiving, persuading, public speaking, seeing through deception, or intimidation. You can select this ability multiple times. Each time you select it, you must choose two different skills. Enabler.

Interface: By directly plugging into a device, you can identify and learn to operate it as though the task were one level lower. Enabler.

Interruption (4 Intellect points): Your vociferous, booming command prevents a creature within short range from taking any action for one round. It can defend itself if attacked, but when it does so, its defense is hindered by two steps. Each additional time you attempt this ability against the same target, you must apply one more level of Effort than you applied on the previous attempt. Action.

Inventor: You can create new artifacts in half the time, as if they were two levels lower, by spending half the normal XP. Enabler.

Investigate: You are trained in perception, cryptography, deceiving, and breaking into computers. Enabler.

Investigative Skills: You are trained in two skills in which you are not already trained. Choose two of the following: perception, identifying, lockpicking, assessing danger, or tinkering with devices. You can select this ability multiple times. Each time you select it, you must choose two different skills. Enabler.

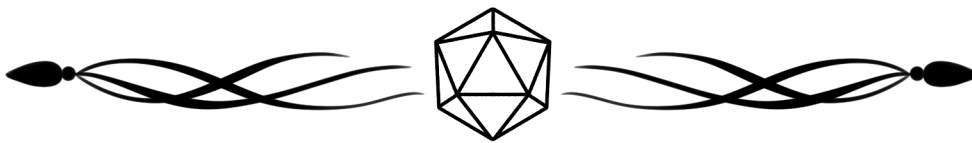
Investigator: To really shine as an investigator, you must engage your mind and body in your deductions. You can spend points from your Might Pool, Speed Pool, or Intellect Pool to apply levels of Effort to any Intellect-based task. Enabler.

Invisibility (4 Intellect points): You become invisible for ten minutes. While invisible, you are specialized in stealth and Speed defense tasks. This effect ends if you do something to reveal your presence or position—attacking, using an ability, moving a large object, and so on. If this occurs, you can regain the remaining invisibility effect by taking an action to hide your position. If you have another ability that also confers invisibility, using either one allows you to remain invisible for twice as long as the duration specified. Action to initiate or reinstate.

Invisible Phasing (4 Might points): You become invisible while using Phase Sprint and during the following round. While invisible, stealth is eased by two steps and Speed defense is eased by two steps (this replaces the asset to Speed defense tasks provided by Phase Sprint). The first attack you make using any Shreds the Walls of the World attack abilities is also eased by two steps; however, if you attack a creature, Invisible Phasing ends immediately instead of lasting for one additional round. If you have the Invisibility ability, you can remain invisible during the entire round, which means that if you use Scratch Existence or Shred Existence, attacking each target along your path is eased by two steps. Enabler.

Iron Fist: Your unarmed attacks deal 4 points of damage. Enabler.

Iron Punch (5+ Intellect points): You magnetically pick up a metallic heavy object within short range and hurl it at someone within short range, an Intellect action that deals 6 points of damage to the target and to the hurled object. For each additional level of Effort applied, you can pick up a slightly larger object, allowing you to affect one additional target within short range as long as it is next to the prior target. Action.



7.11 Abilities—J

Jaunt (5+ Intellect points): You instantaneously teleport yourself to any location within long distance that you can see. In addition to the normal options for using Effort, you can choose to use Effort to increase the distance you can travel; each level of Effort used in this way increases the range by another 100 feet (30 m). Action.

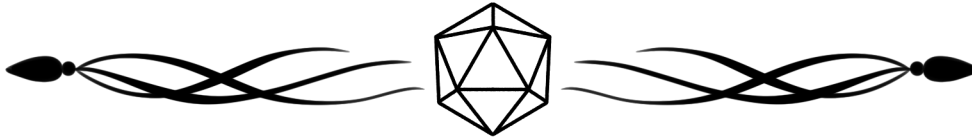
Juggernaut (5 Might points): Until the end of the next round, you can move through solid objects such as doors and walls. Only 2 feet (60 cm) of wood, 1 foot (30 cm) of stone, or 6 inches (15 cm) of metal can stop your movement. Enabler.

Jump Attack (5+ Might points): You attempt a difficulty 4 Might roll to jump high into the air as part of your melee attack action. If you succeed at the jump and your attack hits, you inflict 3 additional points of damage and knock the foe prone. If you fail at the jump, you still make your normal attack roll, but you don't inflict the extra damage or knock down the opponent if you hit. In addition to the normal options for using Effort, you can choose to use Effort to enhance your jump; each level of Effort used in this way adds +2 feet to the height and +1 damage to the attack. Action.

Junkmonger (2 Intellect points): You are trained in crafting two kinds of items using scavenged junk. If you have scavenged (or otherwise obtained) at least two pieces of junk in different categories (electronic, plastic, dangerous, metallic, glass, or textile), you have the materials you need to craft a new item in one of your areas of training (unless the GM deems otherwise). Enabler.

Jury-Rig (5 Intellect points): You quickly create an object using what would seem to be entirely inappropriate materials. You can make a bomb out of a tin can and household cleaners, a lockpick out of aluminum foil, or a sword out of broken furniture. The level of the item determines the difficulty of the task, but the appropriateness of the materials eases or hinders it as well. Generally, the object can be no larger than something you can hold in one hand, and it functions once (or, in the case of a weapon or similar item, is essentially useful for one encounter). If you spend at least ten minutes on the task, you can create an item of level 5 or lower. You can't change the nature of the materials involved. For example, you can't take iron rods and make a pile of gold coins or a wicker basket. Action.

Just a Bit Mad: You are trained in Intellect defense tasks. Enabler.



7.12 Abilities—K

Knock Out (5+ Might points): You make a melee attack that inflicts no damage. Instead, if the attack hits, make a second Might-based roll. If successful, a foe of level 3 or lower is knocked unconscious for one minute. For each level of Effort used, you can affect one higher level of foe, or you can extend the duration for an additional minute. Action.

Know Their Faults: If a creature that you can see has a special weakness, such as a vulnerability to loud noises, a negative modification to perception, and so on, you know what it is. Ask and the GM will tell you; usually, this is not associated with a roll, but in certain cases the GM may decide that there is a chance for you not to know. In these cases, you are specialized in knowing creature weaknesses. Enabler.

Know Where to Look: Whenever the GM obtains a result for you on the Useful Stuff table, you get two results instead of one. If the GM is using some other method to generate rewards for finding valuables, you should gain double the result you would otherwise obtain. Enabler.

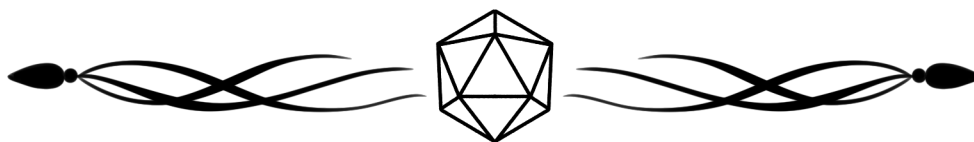
Knowing: You are trained in one area of knowledge of your choice. Enabler.

Knowing the Unknown (6 Intellect points): By accessing the resources appropriate to your character, you can ask the GM one question and get a general answer. The GM assigns a level to the question, so the more obscure the answer, the more difficult the task. Generally, knowledge that you could find by looking somewhere other than your current location is level 1, and obscure knowledge of the past is level 7. Gaining knowledge of the future is impossible. Action.

Knowledge of the Law: You're trained in the law of the land. If you don't know the answer to a question of law, you know where and how to research it (a university's law library is a good place to start, but you've also got online sources). Enabler.

Knowledge Is Power: Choose two noncombat skills in which you are not trained. You are trained in those skills. Enabler.

Knowledge Skills: You are trained in two skills in which you are not already trained. Choose two areas of knowledge such as history, geography, archeology, and so on. You can select this ability multiple times. Each time you select it, you must choose two different skills. Enabler.



7.13 Abilities—L

Lab Analysis (3 Intellect points): You analyze the scene of a crime, the site of a mysterious incident, or a series of unexplained phenomena, and maybe learn a surprising amount of information about the perpetrators, the participants, or the force(s) responsible. To do so, you must collect samples from the scene. Samples are paint or wood scrapings, dirt, photographs of the area, hair, an entire corpse, and so on. With samples in hand, you can discover up to three pertinent pieces of information about the scene, possibly clearing up a lesser mystery and pointing the way to solving a greater one. The GM will decide what you learn and what level of difficulty is needed to learn it. (For comparison, discovering that a victim was killed not by a fall, as seems immediately obvious, but rather by electrocution, is a difficulty 3 task for you.) The task is eased if you take the time to transport the samples to a permanent lab (if you have access to one), as opposed to conducting the analysis with your field science kit. Action to initiate, 2d20 minutes to complete.

Late Inspiration (3 Intellect points): You retry a task you failed within the past one minute, using the same difficulty and modifiers, except this time you have an asset on the task. If this retry fails, you can't use this ability to retry it again. Enabler.

Lead by Inquiry: You keep your allies on their toes with occasional questions, jokes, and even mock drills for those who care to join in. After spending 24 hours with you, your allies are treated as if trained in tasks related to perception. This benefit is ongoing while you remain in your allies' company. It ends if you leave, but it resumes if you return to the allies' company within 24 hours. If you leave the allies' company for more than 24 hours, you must spend another 24 hours together to reactivate the benefit. Enabler.

Lead From the Front: You gain 3 new points to divide among your stat Pools however you wish. Enabler.

Learned a Few Things: You are trained in two areas of knowledge of your choice, or specialized in one area of knowledge of your choice. Enabler.

Learning the Path (2 Intellect points): You observe or study a creature, object, or location for at least one round. The next time you interact with it (possibly in the following round), a related task (such as persuading the creature, attacking it, or defending from its attack) is eased. Action.

Legal Intern: You gain a level 4 follower who is mostly interested in helping with your law-related tasks, but who might also help you in other areas. Enabler.

Legerdemain (1 Speed point): You can perform small but seemingly impossible tricks. For example, you can make a small object in your hands disappear and move into a desired spot within reach (like your pocket). You can make someone believe that they have something in their possession that they do not have (or vice versa). You can switch similar objects right in front of someone's eyes. Action.

Lend Animal Shape (6+ Intellect points): You change into an animal, and one willing creature within immediate range also transforms into an animal of that type (bear, tiger, wolf, and so on) for ten minutes, as if they were using your Animal Shape ability. For each level of Effort applied, you can affect one additional creature. All creatures transforming with you must be your size or smaller. A creature can revert to its normal form as an action, but it cannot then change back into the animal form. One creature (whether you or someone else) changing form does not affect any other creature affected with this abil-

ity. Action.

- A creature that takes animal form with Lend Animal Shape counts as an animal for the use of Animal Scrying.
- A character might be able to take the shape of a creature that is similar to a common animal, such as a unicorn instead of a horse or a basilisk instead of a lizard, but doing so should require applying at least one level of Effort to the change, and the character wouldn't gain any of the creature's magical abilities.

Lethal Damage: Choose one of your existing attacks that inflicts points of damage (depending on your type and focus, this might be a specific weapon, a special ability such as a blast of fire, or your unarmed attacks). When you hit with that attack, you inflict an additional 5 points of damage. Enabler.

Lethal Ploy (5+ Intellect points): Long experience has revealed to you that subterfuge is your friend in desperate situations. You push, attack, or distract the target in some seemingly inconsequential way that leads to the target's death. The target must be level 2 or lower. In addition to the normal options for using Effort, you can choose to use Effort to increase the maximum level of the target by 1. Thus, to kill a level 5 target (three levels above the normal limit), you must apply three levels of Effort. Action.

Lethal Vibration (7 Might points): You set up a lethal vibration in your own body and pass it to a creature you touch with a successful attack. If the target is level 2 or lower, it dies, exploding in a peal of thunder. If the target is level 3 or higher, it sustains 6 points of damage and is stunned on its next action. If the target is a PC of any tier, they move down one step on the damage track. In addition to the normal options for using Effort, you can choose to use Effort to affect a more powerful target (one level of Effort means a target of up to level 3 explodes and a target of level 4 or higher takes damage and is stunned, and so on). Action.

Levity: Through wit, charm, humor, and grace, you are trained in all social interactions other than those involving coercion or intimidation. During rests, you put friends and comrades at ease so much that they gain +1 to their recovery rolls. Enabler.

Life Lessons: Choose any two noncombat skills. You are trained in those skills. Enabler.

Like the Back of Your Hand: All tasks directly related to a starcraft that you own or have a direct connection with are eased. Tasks include repair, refueling, finding a breach in the hull, finding a stowaway, and so on. The same goes for any attack or defense rolls you make within the starcraft against enemy boarders, as well as any attack or defense rolls you make with the ship against enemy ships. Enabler.

Link Senses (2 Intellect points): You touch a willing creature and link its senses to yours for one minute. At any time during that duration, you can concentrate to see, hear, and smell what that creature is experiencing, instead of using your own senses. If you or the creature move out of long range, the connection is broken. Action to initiate.

Living Armor (4 Intellect points): If you're in a location where it's possible for your creatures from Influence Swarm to come, you call a swarm around you for one hour. They crawl over your body or fly around you in a cloud. During this time, your Speed defense tasks are eased, and you gain +1 to Armor. Action to initiate.

Living Light (6+ Intellect points): Your body dissolves into a cloud of photons that instantly travel to a location you choose and then reform. You can choose any open space big enough to contain you that you can see within very long range, or any place you have lit by Illuminating Touch that is still shining. You disappear and almost instantly reappear in the space you chose. It takes until the end of the round for your body to become fully solid, so until the start of the next round, you take a maximum of 1 point of damage from any given attack or source of damage. Each level of Effort you apply allows you to bring along one additional person besides yourself, as long as they are within immediate range when you depart. Action.

Living Off the Land: Given an hour or so, you can always find edible food and potable water in the wilderness. You can even find enough for a small group of people, if need be. Further, since you're so hardy and have gained resistance over time, you are trained in resisting the effects of natural poisons (such as those from plants or living creatures). You're also immune to natural diseases. Enabler.

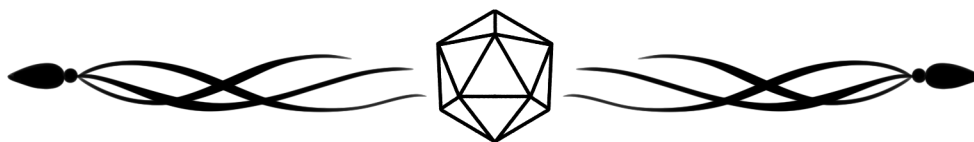
Living Wall (3 Might points): You specify a confined area—such as an open doorway, a hallway, or a space between

two trees—where you stand. For the next ten minutes, if anyone attempts to enter or pass through that area and you don't wish it, you make an automatic attack against them. If you hit, not only do you inflict damage, but they must also stop their movement. Enabler.

Lock (2+ Intellect points): A door, gate, chest, drawer, locket, or other object that can be closed within long range snaps shut and is magically locked (level 3 effect) for one hour. If an object or creature is physically holding the target object open, you must also succeed on an Intellect-based attack. For each level of Effort you apply, the quality of the magical lock increases by one level. Action to initiate.

Lost in the Chaos: When faced with several foes at once, you have developed tactics for using their numbers against them. When two or more foes attack you at once in melee, you play one off the other. Speed defense rolls or attack rolls (your choice) against them are eased. Enabler.

Lunge (2 Might points): This ability requires you to extend yourself for a powerful stab or smash. The awkward lunge hinders the attack roll. If your attack is successful, it inflicts 4 additional points of damage. Action.



7.14 Abilities—M

Machine Affinity: You are trained in tasks involving electrical machines. Enabler.

Machine Bond: From very long range, you can activate and control a device (including a robot or vehicle) that you have bonded with. For example, you can detonate a manifest cypher even when it is held by someone else, or cause an automated turret to fire where you direct. Bonding is a process that requires 24 hours of meditation in the presence of the machine. Action.

Machine Companion: You create a level 3 animate, intelligent machine that accompanies you and acts as you direct. As a level 3 machine companion, it has a target number of 9 and 9 health, and it inflicts 3 points of damage. If it's destroyed, it takes you one month to create a new one. Enabler.

Machine Efficiency (3 Intellect points): You can make a blaster shoot farther, coax more speed from a skycycle, improve the clarity of a camera, jury-rig a light to be brighter, speed up a network connection, and so on. You increase an object's level by 2 for one minute, or you treat the object as an asset that eases an associated task by two steps for one minute (your choice). Action to initiate.

Machine Enhancement: Any time you use Effort on an Intellect action, add one of the following enhancements to the action (your choice):

- Free level of Effort
- Automatic minor effect

Enabler.

Machine Hunting: You are trained in tasks associated with tracking, spotting, or otherwise finding robots and animate machines. You are also trained in all stealth tasks. Enabler.

Machine Interface (2 Intellect points): For one minute you gain an asset on tasks to discern the level, function, and activation of technological devices that you touch. Enabler.

Machine Telepathy (3 Intellect points): You can read the surface thoughts of a machine within short range, even if the machine doesn't want you to. You must be able to see the machine. Once you have established contact, you can read the target's thoughts for up to one minute. If you or the target move out of range, the connection is broken. If you have the Mind Reading ability, when you apply Effort to Machine Telepathy, you gain a free level of Effort. Action to initiate.

Machine Vulnerabilities: You inflict 3 additional points of damage against robots and animate machines of all kinds. Enabler.

Magic Shield (1 Intellect point): You gain +1 to Armor for an hour. Action to initiate.

Magic Training: You are trained in the basics of magic (including the operation of magic artifacts and cyphers) and can attempt to understand and identify its properties. Enabler.

Magical Repertoire: The number of subtle cyphers you can bear at the same time increases by two. If you spend one hour preparing your magic, you can fill any of your open cypher slots with subtle cyphers chosen randomly by the GM (this hour can be part of a one-hour or ten-hour recovery action if you are awake for the entire time). As part of this preparation process, you may discard any number of subtle cyphers you carry to make room for more subtle cyphers. Enabler.

- If a character has Magical Repertoire, the GM should give the PC frequent opportunities to gain new subtle

cyphers, whether from preparation or by gaining them automatically as explained in the Cyphers chapter

Magical Training: You are trained in all of your spells. As a result, you ease any task involved in the use of your spells. Enabler.

Magnetic Field (4 Intellect points): When you wish it, a field of magnetism around you pulls incoming, ranged, metallic projectile attacks (such as arrows, bullets, a thrown metal knife, and so on) to the ground. You are immune to such attacks for one round. You must be aware of an attack to foil it. Enabler.

Magnificent Moment: If you make an attack or attempt a task with the immediate action you gain by using Seize the Moment, the attack or task is eased. Enabler.

Major Illusion (3 Intellect points): You create a complex scene of images within immediate range. The entire scene must fit within a 100-foot (30 m) cube. The images can move, but they can't leave the area defined by the cube. The illusion includes sound and smell. It lasts for ten minutes and changes as you direct (no concentration is needed). If you move beyond immediate range of the cube, the illusion vanishes. Action to create.

Make Judgment: You are trained in discerning the truth of a situation, seeing through lies, or otherwise overcoming deception. Enabler.

Maneuvering Adept: If you apply at least one level of Effort to a task involving climbing, jumping, balancing, or some other kind of maneuvering, you get a free level of Effort. Enabler.

Mask (5 Intellect points): You transform your body to become someone else. You can change any physical characteristic you wish, including coloration, height, weight, gender, and distinguishing markings. You can also change the appearance of whatever you are wearing or carrying. Your stats, as well as the stats of your items, do not change. You remain in this form for up to a day or until you use an action to resume your normal appearance. Action to initiate.

Master Crafter: You are trained in the crafting of two kinds of items, or you are specialized in two kinds of items that you are already trained in. Enabler.

Master Cypher Use: You can bear five cyphers at a time. Enabler.

Master Entertainer: Your Inspiring Ease ability works more effectively, easing your friends' tasks by two steps rather than one step. Enabler.

Master Identifier: You are trained in identifying the function of any kind of device. Enabler.

Master Machine (8 Intellect points): You can control the functions of a machine you have bonded with using Machine Bond, intelligent or otherwise. In addition, if you use an action to concentrate on a machine, you are aware of what is going on around it (you see and hear as if you were standing next to it, no matter how far away you are). You must touch the machine to create the bond, but afterward, there is no range limitation. This bond lasts for one week. You can bond with only one machine at a time. Action to initiate.

Master of Unarmed Fighting Style: You are specialized in unarmed attacks. If you are already specialized in unarmed attacks, you instead deal 2 additional points of damage with unarmed attacks. Enabler.

Master Thief: You are trained in climbing, escaping from bonds, slipping through narrow places, and other contortionist moves. Enabler.

Masterful Armor Modification: Choose one of the following modifications to make to the Powered Armor from your Powered Armor ability. If you choose to make a different modification later, you can do so, but you must spend 2 XP each time and substitute the updated modification for the previous modification. Cypher Pod. The power armor provides an insulated pod in which you can carry one additional manifest cypher beyond what your cypher limit normally allows. Enabler. Drone (3 Intellect points). A level 4 drone no larger than 1 foot (30 cm) on a side launches from your armor for one hour, flying up to a long distance each round. The drone accompanies you and follows your instructions. It has manipulators, allowing it to attempt to accomplish physical tasks. You'll probably make rolls for your drone when it takes actions. A drone in combat usually doesn't make separate attacks but helps with yours. On your action, if the drone is next to you, it serves as an asset for one attack you make on your turn. If the drone is destroyed, you must spend another 2 XP to rebuild it or choose another Masterful Armor Modification. Action to initiate.

Improved Field Reinforcement. You gain +1 to Armor while wearing your power armor. Enabler. Jet-Assisted Flight (3+ Might points). You modify your power armor to allow you to blast off the ground and fly for one minute at a time. For each level of Effort applied, you can increase the duration by an additional minute. Action.

Mastery in Armor: The cost reduction from your Practiced in Armor ability improves. You now reduce the Speed Effort cost for wearing armor to 0. Enabler.

Mastery With Attacks: Choose one type of attack in which you are trained: light bashing, light bladed, light ranged, medium bashing, medium bladed, medium ranged, heavy bashing, heavy bladed, or heavy ranged. You are specialized in attacks using that type of weapon. Enabler. (If you aren't trained in an attack, select Skill With Attacks to become trained in that attack.)

Mastery With Defense: Choose one type of defense task in which you are trained: Might, Speed, or Intellect. You are specialized in defense tasks of that type. You can select this ability up to three times. Each time you select it, you must choose a different type of defense task. Enabler.

Matter Cloud (5 Intellect points): Pebbles, dirt, sand, and debris rise into the air around you to form a swirling cloud. The cloud extends out to immediate range, moves with you, and lasts for one minute. When it ends, all the materials fall to the ground around you. The cloud makes it harder for other creatures to attack you, giving you an asset on Speed defense rolls. In addition, while the cloud is around you, you can use an action to whip the material so that it abrades everything within immediate range, dealing 1 point of damage to each creature and object in the area. Action to initiate.

Maximize Cypher: Choose one subtle cypher you bear. Its level becomes the maximum level possible for that cypher. For example, a meditation aid has a level range of 1d6 + 2, so maximizing that cypher changes its level to 8. You can have only one maximized subtle cypher at a time. You can't use this ability again until after you've taken a ten-hour recovery action. Enabler.

Mechanical Telepathy (3 Intellect points): By touching a thinking machine, you gain access to its surface "thoughts." Action.

Medium Teleportation (5+ Intellect points): You instantly teleport yourself to any location within a long distance that you can see. In addition to the normal options for using Effort, you

can choose to use Effort to increase your range, teleport to a location you can't see, or bring other people with you. Each additional long distance costs one level of Effort. Teleporting to a destination you can't see costs one level of Effort. Each additional one or two targets brought with you costs one level of Effort (you must touch any additional targets). These levels of Effort are counted separately, so teleporting an additional long distance away to a location you can't see with two passengers costs a total of three levels of Effort. Action.

If you already have Short Teleportation when you select Medium Teleportation or Teleportation, you may replace Short Teleportation with another tier 4 type ability.

Memory Becomes Action (4+ Intellect points): You can duplicate a one-action character ability, performing it as if it were natural for you. You must have seen the ability used within the past week, it must be third tier or lower, and it must be an ability with a point cost. In addition to the point cost of Memory Becomes Action, you must pay the Might, Speed, or Intellect cost of the ability you are copying. For example, if you want to copy a friend's Lunge attack (which normally costs 2 Might points), you'd pay 4 Intellect points to activate Memory Becomes Action and 2 Might points to use Lunge. In addition to the normal options for using Effort, you can choose to use Effort to copy an ability you saw longer than one week ago; each level of Effort used in this way extends the time period by one week. Enabler.

Mental Link (1+ Intellect point): You open a pathway to another creature's mind via a light touch, which allows you to transmit thoughts and images to each other. The mental link remains regardless of distance and lasts for one hour. In addition to the normal options for using Effort, you can choose to use Effort to extend the duration by one hour for each level of Effort applied. Action to initiate.

Mental Projection (6+ Intellect points): Your mind fully leaves your body and manifests anywhere you choose within immediate range. Your projected mind can remain apart from your body for up to 24 hours. This effect ends early if your Intellect Pool is reduced to 0 or if your projection touches your resting body. Your disembodied mind is a psychic construct that looks like you, though its frayed edges trail off into nothingness. You control this body as if it were your normal body and can act and move as you normally would with a few exceptions. You can move through solid objects as if you were phased, and you ignore any terrain feature that would impede your movement.

Your attacks inflict 3 fewer points of damage (to a minimum of 1) and you take 3 fewer points of damage (to a minimum of 1) from physical attacks, unless they can affect transdimensional or phased beings, in which case you take full damage. Regardless of the source, you take all damage as Intellect damage first.

Your mind can travel up to 1 mile (1.5 km) from your body. Each level of additional Effort applied extends the range that you can travel by 1 mile (1.5 km).

Your physical body is helpless until this effect ends. You cannot use your physical senses to perceive anything. For example, your body could sustain a significant injury, and you wouldn't know it. Your body cannot take Intellect damage, so if your body takes enough damage to reduce both your Might Pool and your Speed Pool to 0, your mind snaps back to your body, and you are stunned until the end of the next round as you try to reorient yourself to your predicament. Action to initiate.

(Mentally projecting characters may attract psychic entities and predators that PCs normally don't have to deal with, run into

weather psychic phenomena that risks severing their connection, and possibly even become lost on a different metaphysical plane.)

Mentally Tough: Staring into the naked weave of hyperspace, warped space, or a similar effect related to faster-than-light travel is hard on the mind, but you've developed resistance. You're trained in Intellect defense tasks. Enabler.

Meticulous Planner: If you spend a long time planning an action, you gain an asset on performing it. The time to study and plan for the action is ten times as long as it takes to perform the action. For example, if you want to jump across a hole in the floor (one action), you can study the area for ten rounds (about a minute), and when you attempt to jump over the hole, you have an asset on the jump. This benefit applies to only one roll—if you want to perform the task again with the benefit of an asset, you need to study and plan again. Enabler.

Microgravity Adept: You ignore all the ill effects of low gravity and no gravity on movement; you are trained in low-gravity maneuvers and zero-gravity maneuvers. (You might still be subject to negative biological effects of long-term exposure, if any.) Enabler.

Microgravity Avoidance: By taking advantage of microgravity conditions, you gain an asset to Speed defense tasks while in zero-gravity or low-gravity conditions. Enabler.

Mind Control (6+ Intellect points): You control the actions of another creature you touch. This effect lasts for one minute. The target must be level 2 or lower. Once you have established control, you maintain mental contact with the target and sense what it senses. You can allow it to act freely or override its control on a case-by-case basis. In addition to the normal options for using Effort, you can choose to use Effort to increase the maximum level of the target or increase the duration by one minute. Thus, to control the mind of a level 5 target (three levels above the normal limit) or control a target for four minutes (three minutes above the normal duration), you must apply three levels of Effort. When the duration ends, the creature doesn't remember being controlled or anything it did while under your command. Action to initiate.

Mind for Might: When performing a task that would normally require spending points from your Intellect Pool, you can spend points from your Might Pool instead, and vice versa. Enabler.

Mind Games (3 Intellect points): You use lies and trickery, mockery, and perhaps even hateful, obscene language against a foe that can understand you. If successful, the foe is stunned for one round and cannot act, and it is dazed in the following round, during which time its tasks are hindered. Action.

Mind of a Leader (6 Intellect points): When you develop a course of action to deal with a future situation, you can ask the GM one very general question about what is likely to happen if you carry out the plan, and you will get a simple, brief answer. Action.

Mind Reading (2 Intellect points): You can read the surface thoughts of a creature within short range, even if the target doesn't want you to. You must be able to see your target. Once you have established contact, you can read the target's thoughts for up to one minute. If you also have the Mind Reading special ability from another source, you can use this ability at long range, and you don't need to be able to see the target (but you do have to know that the target is within range). Action to initiate.

Mind Surge: In addition to your normal recovery rolls each day, you can—at any time between ten-hour rests—recover 1d6 + 6 points to your Intellect Pool. Action.

Minor Illusion (1 Intellect point): You create a single image of a creature or object within immediate range. The image must fit within a 10-foot (3 m) cube. The image can move (for example, you could make the illusion of a person walk or attack), but it can't leave the area defined by the cube. The illusion includes sound but not smell. It lasts for ten minutes, but if you want to change the original illusion significantly—such as making a creature appear to be wounded—you must concentrate on it again (though doing so doesn't cost additional Intellect points). If you move beyond immediate range of the cube, the illusion vanishes. Action to create; action to modify.

Minor Wish: At your request, the magic ally from your Bound Magic Creature ability can use its action to cast a minor spell on you. Afterward, it must retreat to its bound object to rest for one hour. The effects it can produce include the following. Action to initiate.

- *Golden Anger.* A golden light touches your eyes. For the next several minutes, if you attack a target, you inflict 2 additional points of damage.
- *Golden Ward.* You gain +1 to Armor for one hour from a translucent sheen of golden light.
- *Light of Truth.* Whenever you attempt to discern falsehood during the next hour, the task is eased by two steps.
- *Touch of Grace.* With the magic ally's touch, you add 3 points to any stat Pool. If you are not damaged, you add the points to your chosen Pool's maximum. They remain until you spend them, you lose them to damage, or an hour passes.

Miraculous Health: When you would descend a step on the damage track, you can attempt a Might task to resist, with a difficulty equal to the level of the foe or effect that harmed you. If successful, you don't descend the step and you regain 1 point in any Pool that is bereft of points. You can't use this ability again until after your next ten-hour rest. Enabler.

Misdirect (3 Speed points): When an opponent misses you, you can redirect their attack to another target (a creature or object) of your choosing that's within immediate range of you. Make an unmodified attack roll against the new target (do not use any of your or the opponent's modifiers to the attack roll, but you can apply Effort for accuracy). If the attack hits, the target takes damage from your opponent's attack. Enabler.

Misdirect Blame (2+ Intellect points): Using your clever words and knowledge of others, you can attempt to alter the narrative so that a target of up to level 3 within short range becomes uncertain of its conviction in one simple area, such as their conviction that you just stole a fruit from their stand or their belief that they've never met you before. This effect usually lasts only for the period of time you spend speaking, and perhaps up to a minute longer, before the target realizes its error. In addition to the normal options for using Effort, you can choose to use Effort to increase the target level that can be affected. Afterward, all your tasks to persuade or otherwise socially interact with the target are hindered. Action.

Mist Cloud (1+ Intellect points): You create an area of mist an immediate distance across. The cloud lingers for about a minute unless conditions (such as wind or freezing temperatures) dictate otherwise. In addition to the normal options for using Effort, you can choose to use Effort to increase the area (one level of Effort to fill a short area, two to fill a long area, or three to fill a very long area). Action.

Mobile Fighter (3 Speed points): As part of your attack, you can leap on or over obstacles, swing from ropes, run along narrow surfaces, or otherwise move around the battlefield at your normal speed as if such tasks were routine (difficulty 0). You can't use this ability if your Speed Effort costs are reduced from wearing armor. Enabler.

Moderate Wish: At your request, the magic ally from your Bound Magic Creature ability can spend its action casting a moderate spell on you. Afterward, it must retreat to its bound object to rest for at least one hour. The effects it can produce include the following. Action to initiate.

- *Golden Armor.* You gain +3 to Armor for one hour from a translucent sheen of golden light.
- *Golden Fury.* A golden light blazes in your eyes. For the next three minutes, if you attack a target, you inflict 5 additional points of damage.
- *Improved Touch of Grace.* With the magic ally's touch, you add 6 points to any stat Pool. If you are not damaged, you add the points to your chosen Pool's maximum. They remain until you spend them, you lose them to damage, or an hour passes.
- *Invisible.* With a touch, the magic ally bends light that falls on you, so you seem to disappear. You are invisible to other creatures for ten minutes. While invisible, you are specialized in stealth and Speed defense tasks. This effect ends if you do something to reveal your presence or position—attacking, using an ability, moving a large object, and so on. If this occurs, you can regain the remaining invisibility effect by taking an action to focus on hiding your position.

Action to initiate.

Modify Artifact Power (6 Intellect points): You permanently add +1 to the level of an artifact of up to level 5. The difficulty of this task is equal to the modified higher level of the artifact. If the task is failed, the artifact makes a depletion roll and is not advanced in level. Once modified, the artifact can't be similarly boosted again. Action.

Modify Cyphers: You can take any two manifest cyphers and quickly jury-rig a new manifest cypher of the same level as the lowest-level cypher. You determine the function of the new cypher, but it must be that of a cypher you have used before (but not necessarily one you've ever built). The new cypher is a temperamental cypher, like those created with Always Tinkering. The original two cyphers are consumed in this process. This ability does not function if one or more of the original cyphers are temperamental cyphers. Action.

Modify Device (4 Intellect points): You jury-rig a piece of mechanical or electrical equipment to make it function above its rated specs for a very limited time. To do so, you must use spare parts equal to an expensive item, have a field science kit (or a permanent lab, if you have access to one), and succeed at a difficulty 3 Intellect-based task. When complete, using the device eases all tasks performed in conjunction with the device, until the device inevitably breaks. For example, you could overclock a computer so research tasks using it are easier, modify an espresso maker so that each cup of coffee made with it is better, modify a car's engine so that it goes faster (or modify its steering so it handles better), and so on. Each use of the modified device requires a depletion roll of 1–5 on a d20. Action to initiate, one hour to complete.

Momentum: If you use an action to move, your next attack made using a melee weapon before the end of the next round inflicts 2 additional points of damage. Enabler.

Monster Bane: You inflict 1 additional point of damage with weapons. When you inflict damage to creatures more than twice as large or massive as you, you inflict 3 additional points of damage. Enabler.

Monster Lore: You are trained in the names, habits, suspected lairs, and related topics regarding the monsters of your world. You can make yourself understood in their languages (if they have one). Enabler.

Moon Shape (4+ Intellect points): You change into a monstrous natural beast, such as a wolf, bear, or other terrestrial creature, for up to one hour. If you try to change during daylight hours when you are not deep underground (or otherwise away from the daylight), you must apply a level of Effort. In your new form, you add 8 points to your Might Pool, gain +2 to your Might Edge, add 2 points to your Speed Pool, and gain +2 to your Speed Edge. Reverting to your normal form is a difficulty 2 task. While in beast form, you are prone to fits of rage (triggered by GM intrusion), during which you attack every living creature within short range, and the only way to end the rage is to revert to your normal form. Either way, after you revert to your normal form, you take a –1 penalty to all rolls for one hour. If you did not kill and eat at least one substantial creature while in beast form, the penalty increases to –2 and affects all your rolls for the next day. Action to change; action to revert.

Mount: A level 3 creature serves you as a mount and follows your instructions. While you're mounted on it, the creature can move and you can attack on your turn, which provides an asset to your attack. You and the GM must work out the details of the creature, and you'll probably make rolls for it when it takes noncombat actions. The mount acts on your turn. If your mount dies, you can hunt in the wild for 3d6 days to find a new one. Enabler.

Move Metal (1 Intellect point): You can exert force on metal objects within short range for one round. Once activated, your power has an effective Might Pool of 10, a Might Edge of 1, and an Effort of 2 (approximately equal to the strength of a fit, capable, adult human), and you can use it to move metal objects, push against metal objects, and so on. For example, in your round, you could lift and pull a light metal object anywhere within range to yourself or move a heavy object (like a piece of furniture) about 10 feet (3 m). This power lacks the fine control to wield a weapon or move objects with much speed, so in most situations, it's not a means of attack. You can't use this ability on your own body. The power lasts for one hour or until its Might Pool is depleted, whichever comes first. Action.

Move Mountains (9 Intellect points): You exert a tremendous amount of physical force within 250 feet (75 m) of you. You can push up to 10 tons (9 t) of material up to 50 feet (15 m). This force can collapse buildings, redirect small rivers, or perform other dramatic effects. Action.

Movement Skills: You are trained in climbing and jumping. Enabler.

Moving Like Water (3 Speed points): You spin and move so that your defense and attacks are aided by your fluid motion. For one minute, all your attacks and Speed defense tasks gain an asset. Enabler.

Multiple Copying: When you use Copy Power, you can copy two of the creature's abilities at the same time. In addition to the normal options for using Effort with Copy Power, you can apply levels of Effort to copy additional abilities, each

level of Effort copying an additional ability beyond the initial two (three for one level of Effort, four for two levels, and so on). Enabler.

Multiple Quarry (6 Intellect points): This ability functions like the Quarry ability except that you can select up to three creatures as quarry. You must be able to see all three creatures when you initiate this ability. If you have Hunter's Drive, it applies to all three creatures. Action to initiate.

Multiple Skills: You are trained in three skills of your choice in which you are not already trained. You can select this ability multiple times. Each time you select it, you must choose three different skills. Enabler.

Multiplicity (6 Might points): This ability functions as Duplicate, except you can create two duplicates. Action to initiate.

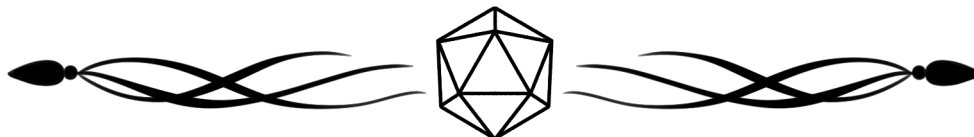
Multi-Vanish (4+ Intellect points): You turn up to five human-sized creatures or objects invisible for a short amount of time. The targets you choose must be within an immediate area and within short range of you (if you are in the area, you can make yourself invisible and don't count toward the limit of five invisible targets). Anything invisible has an asset on stealth

and Speed defense tasks. Affected creatures can see each other in a limited way, and you can see them clearly.

The invisibility ends at the end of your next turn. If one of the affected creatures does something to reveal their presence or position—attacking, using an ability, moving a large object, and so on—the invisibility ends early for that creature. In addition to the normal options for using Effort, you can choose to use Effort to increase the duration; each level of Effort used in this way increases the duration by one round (but creatures can still end it early for themselves). Action.

Murderer (8+ Speed points): With a swift and sudden attack, you strike a foe in a vital spot. If the target is level 4 or lower, it is killed outright. For each additional level of Effort you apply, you can increase the level of the target by 1. Action.

Muscles of Iron (2 Might points): For the next ten minutes, all Might-based actions other than attack rolls that you attempt are eased. If you already have this ability from another source, the effect of this ability lasts for one hour instead of ten minutes. Enabler.



7.15 Abilities—N

Natural Charisma: You are trained in all social interactions, whether they involve charm, learning a person's secrets, or intimidating others. Enabler.

Natural Crafter: All commonplace objects or structures you craft are effectively one level higher than an average example of that object or structure. For instance, if you craft a defensive wall that would normally be level 4, its effective level is 5. Enabler.

Necromancy (3+ Intellect points): You animate the body of a dead creature of approximately your size or smaller, creating a level 1 creature. It has none of the intelligence, memories, or special abilities that it had in life. The creature follows your verbal commands for one hour, after which it becomes an inert corpse. Unless the creature is killed by damage, you can reanimate it again when its time expires, but any damage it had when it became inert applies to its newly reanimated state. If you have access to multiple bodies, you can create an additional undead creature for each additional Intellect point you spend when you activate the ability. Action to animate.

Negate Danger (7 Intellect points): You permanently negate a source of potential danger related to one creature or object within immediate distance. This could be a weapon or device held by someone, a creature's natural ability, or a trap triggered by a pressure plate. Action.

Negotiate (3 Intellect points): In any gathering where two or more people are trying to establish the truth or come to a decision, you can sway the verdict with masterful rhetoric. If you are given a few rounds or more to argue your point, either the decision goes your way or, if someone else effectively argues a competing point, any associated persuasion or deception task is eased by two steps. Action to initiate, one or more rounds to complete.

Network Tap (4 Intellect points): You can ask the GM one question and get a very short answer if you succeed on an Intellect roll against a difficulty assigned by the GM. The more obscure the answer, the more difficult the task. On a failed roll, feedback or perhaps some defense from the network you're accessing inflicts 4 points of Intellect damage on you (ignores Armor). Action. (Generally, knowledge that you could find by looking somewhere other than your current location is level 1, while obscure knowledge of the past is level 7. Gaining knowledge of the future is impossible.)

Never Fumble: If you roll a natural 1 when attacking with your chosen weapon, you can ignore or countermand the GM intrusion for that roll. You can never be disarmed of your chosen weapon, nor will you ever drop it accidentally. Enabler.

Nightmare (5 Intellect points): You pull a horrifying creature from your worst nightmare into the waking world and sic it on your foes. The nightmare (level 5) persists each round while you use your action concentrating on it (or until you disperse it or it is destroyed). It has one of the following abilities, which you choose when you call it.

- **Confusion.** Instead of making a normal attack, the nightmare's attack confuses the target for one round. On its next action, the target attacks an ally.
- **Horrify.** Instead of making a normal attack, the nightmare's attack horrifies the target, which drops to its knees (or similar appendages). The target takes 3 points of damage that ignore Armor and is dazed for one round, during which time all its tasks are hindered.
- **Pustule Eruption.** Instead of making a normal attack, the nightmare's attack causes rancid, painful pustules to rise all over the target's skin for one minute. If the target takes a forceful action (such as attacking another creature or moving farther than an immediate distance), the pustules burst, dealing 5 points of damage that ignore Armor.

Action to initiate, action each round to concentrate.

Nightstrike: When you attack a foe in dim light or darkness, you get a free level of Effort on the attack. Enabler.

Nimble Swimmer: You are trained in all defense actions while underwater. Enabler.

No Need for Weapons: When you make an unarmed attack (such as a punch or kick), it counts as a medium weapon instead of a light weapon. Enabler.

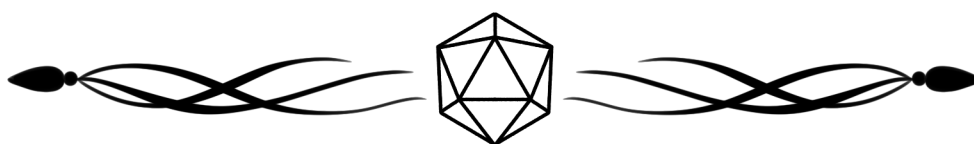
No One Knows Better: You are trained in two of the following skills: persuasion, deception, intimidation, research, knowledge in one area, or seeing through deception. If you choose a skill in which you're already trained, you become specialized in that skill instead. Enabler.

Noble's Courage (3+ Intellect points): Your noble lineage teaches that courage is necessary to do things that are difficult, tedious, or dangerous. When your mind would be negatively affected by an effect of up to level 4, whether something as overt as a psychic command or illness or something as subtle as fear or even boredom, your courage neutralizes the effect for up to a minute or, if you're actively being attacked, until the next attack. For each level of Effort applied, you can increase the level of the effect you can neutralize by 1. Enabler.

Not Dead Yet: When you would normally be dead, you instead fall unconscious for one round and then awaken. You immediately gain 1d6 + 6 points to restore your stat Pools, and you are treated as if debilitated until you rest for ten hours. If you die again before you make your ten-hour recovery roll, you are truly dead. If you also have this ability from another source, your healing from this ability increases to 1d6 + 12. Enabler.

Nothing but Defend: If you do nothing on your turn but defend, you are specialized in all defense tasks for one round. Action.

Nullify Sound (3 Might points): You pulse perfectly misaligned sounds within short range to create a zone of absolute quiet up to an immediate distance across for one minute. All sound is canceled in the zone. Action to initiate.



7.16 Abilities—O

Object Bond (3 Intellect points): When you manifest the magic ally from your Bound Magic Creature ability, it can move up to 300 feet (90 m) from you before being returned to its bound object. Also, it can remain manifest for an extended period, lasting until the end of your next ten-hour recovery roll. Finally, if you give permission, the magic ally can emerge from and enter the bound object on its own initiative. Enabler.

Object Bond Mastery (7 Intellect points): When you manifest the magic ally from your Bound Magic Creature ability, it is now a level 7 creature. It can remain manifest for only three minutes, after which it must return to its object and rest for three days before you can manifest it again.

The magic ally can make its own magic touch attacks (when it does, you roll for it). If it uses its pulse attack from Improved Object Bond, instead of deactivating items, it can take control of one item within short range for one minute, if applicable.

Finally, the magic ally can transform into smoke and flame as its action, giving it +10 to Armor but rendering it incapable of attacking foes. In this form, it can fly a long distance each round, and the first time each day it returns to flesh (as an action), it regains 25 points of health. Enabler.

Obstacle Running (3 Speed points): For the next minute, you can ignore obstacles that slow your movement, allowing you to travel at normal speed through areas with rubble, fences, tables, and similar objects that you would have to climb over or move around. This movement might include sliding on a railing, briefly running along a wall, or even stepping on a creature to boost yourself over something. If an obstacle would normally require a Might or Speed task to overcome, such as swinging on a rope, balancing on a rope, or jumping over a hole, you are trained in that task. Enabler.

One With the Wild (6 Intellect points): For the next hour, natural animals and plants within long range will not knowingly harm you or those you designate. In addition, your Might Edge, Speed Edge, and Intellect Edge increase by 1, and if you make any recovery rolls during this period, you recover twice as many points. Action to initiate.

Oneirochemy: You are trained in tasks related to sleep and mixing natural elixirs to help creatures fall asleep. Enabler.

Onslaught (1 Intellect point): You attack a foe using energies that assail either their physical form or their mind. In either case, you must be able to see your target. If the attack is physical, you emit a short-range ray of force that inflicts 4 points of damage. If the attack is mental, you focus your mental energy to blast the thought processes of another creature within short range. This mindslice inflicts 2 points of Intellect damage (ignores Armor). Some creatures without minds (such as robots) might be immune to your mindslice. Action.

Open Mind (3 Intellect points): You open your mind to increase your awareness. You gain an asset to any task involving perception. While you have this asset and you are conscious and able to take actions, other characters gain no benefit from surprising you. The effect lasts for one hour. Action.

Opening Statement: You're trained in tasks related to persuasion, deception, and detecting the falsehoods of others. Enabler.

Opportunist: You have an asset on any attack roll you make against a creature that has already been attacked at some point during the round and is within immediate range. Enabler.

Oratory (4 Intellect points): When speaking with a group of intelligent creatures that can understand you and aren't hos-

tile, you convince them to take one reasonable action in the next round. A reasonable action should not put the creatures or their allies in obvious danger or be wildly out of character. Action.

Out of Harm's Way: No matter how careful, an investigator sometimes ends up in a scrap. Knowing how to survive is more than half the battle. You are trained in Speed defense tasks. Enabler.

Outlast the Foe: If you have been in combat for five full rounds, you have an asset for all tasks in the remainder of the combat, and you deal 1 additional point of damage per attack. Enabler.

Outlaw Reputation (3 Intellect points): People know of your notorious exploits, which have been told and retold so many times that they bear little resemblance to reality. But people fear your name when they recognize you (or you declare yourself). They become so afraid that all attacks made against you by affected targets within earshot are hindered until one or more of them successfully inflicts damage on you or one of your allies, at which time their fear abates. Enabler.

Outside Reality (6+ Intellect points): You exist outside of everything until the start of your next turn. To you, a few seconds pass while you are alone in a cool void. To everyone else, you seem to vanish for a few seconds and reappear in the same place. While in this unreal state, you can use abilities or objects on yourself, but you can't perceive, interact with, or affect the rest of the world, and vice versa. Time-based effects already on you (like a poison that inflicts damage every round) are paused while you exist outside reality, but when this ability ends they resume as if no time had passed. In addition to the normal options for using Effort, you can choose to use Effort to increase the duration; each level of Effort used in this way adds one round to how long you spend outside reality. Enabler.

Outwit: When you make a Speed defense roll, you can use your Intellect in place of your Speed. Enabler.

Overawe (5 Intellect points): A blast of divine radiance from the heavens spotlights a target you select within long range, pushing the target to its knees (or similar appendages, if any) and rendering it helpless in the light for up to ten minutes, or until it breaks free. The overawed target cannot defend itself, make attacks, or attempt anything other than to shake free of the divine awe each round. If the target is a demon, spirit, or something similar, it also takes 1 point of damage that ignores Armor each round it remains affected. Action to initiate.

Overcharge Device: You infuse 1 point of energy gained from using Absorb Energy or related ability into a device, such as an artifact, raising its effective level on its next use by three (to a maximum of 10). Action.

Overcharge Energy: When you use Release Energy, it inflicts an additional 2 points of damage. Enabler.

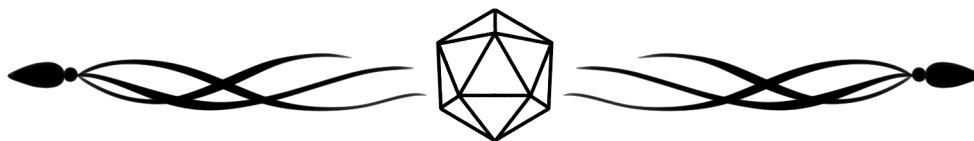
Overcome All Obstacles (3+ Intellect points): Those who stand against you do so at their peril and eventually shrink away in your presence. When you focus on a particular foe within long range, the target suffers 2 points of Intellect damage (ignores Armor) each round for one minute or until the target can throw off the effect. This ability can only be active on one target at a time. You can apply Effort to increase damage during the first round, and for any one round in which you apply Effort and use another action. Action to initiate.

Overload Machine (3+ Intellect points): Through the robot assistant from your Serv-0 ability, you infuse a powered device of level 3 or lower with more energy than it can handle. If affected, the device is destroyed or disabled for at least one minute, depending on its size and complexity. The GM may

rule that the disabling effect lasts until the device is repaired. In addition to the normal options for using Effort, you can choose to use Effort to increase the maximum level of the target. Thus, to overload a level 5 device (two levels above the normal limit), you must apply two levels of Effort. Action.

Overwatch (1 Intellect point): You use a ranged weapon to target a limited area (such as a doorway, a hallway, or the east-

ern side of the clearing) and make an attack against the next viable target to enter that area. This works like a wait action, but you also negate any benefit the target would have from cover, position, surprise, range, illumination, or visibility. Further, you inflict 1 additional point of damage with the attack. You can remain on overwatch as long as you wish, within reason. Action.



7.17 Abilities—P

Parry (5 Speed points): You can deflect incoming attacks quickly. When you activate this ability, for the next ten rounds you ease all Speed defense rolls. Enabler.

Passing Mechanic: You are trained in tasks related to the repair and maintenance of a starcraft. Enabler.

Patient Recovery: You gain an extra ten-minute recovery roll each day. Enabler. **Pay It Forward** (3 Intellect points): You can pass on what you've learned. When you give another character a suggestion involving their next action that is not an attack, their action is eased for one minute. Action.

Perfect Control: You no longer need to make a roll to use Beast Form or change into your normal form. You can change back and forth as your action. When you return to your normal form, you no longer take a penalty to your rolls. Enabler.

Perfect Speed Burst (6 Speed points): You can take two separate actions this round. Enabler.

Perfect Stranger (3 Intellect points): You alter your posture and way of speaking and make a small but real alteration to an outfit (such as putting on or taking off a hat, reversing a cloak, and so on). For the next hour (or as long as you keep up the alteration), even creatures that know you well don't recognize you. All tasks related to hiding your true identity during this period gain one free level of Effort. Action to initiate.

Perks of Stardom: You are adept at claiming the rewards that fame can generate. When you are recognized, you can be seated at any restaurant, be let into any government building, be invited to any show or sports event (even if they're sold out), get a seat at a private function of any sort, or get into any club, no matter how exclusive. When dealing with someone who can't or won't immediately give in to your desire, you gain an asset on all tasks related to persuasion if that person recognizes you or is convinced that you're a celebrity even if they don't recognize you. Enabler.

Permanent Illusion (9 Intellect points): An illusion (or portion of an illusion) that you create using Minor Illusion or related ability that fits within a 10-foot (3 m) cube becomes permanent. You can permanently end the illusion as an action, but others must expend exceptional ingenuity to prevent the illusion from regenerating even if it has apparently been dispersed. Enabler.

Phase Detonation (2+ Might points): When you use Phase Sprint or Walk Through Walls, you can choose to significantly damage normal matter around you with a blast of transdimensional energy when you first go into or come out of phase (your choice). This detonation inflicts 4 points of damage that ignores Armor to all creatures and objects within immediate range. If you apply Effort to increase the damage rather than ease the task, you deal 2 additional points of damage per level of Effort (instead of 3 points); targets in the area take 1 point of damage even if you fail the attack roll. Enabler.

Phase Door (4 Intellect points): You can phase into a solid object's surface and then phase out of any other solid object within long range of the first, even if the two objects are not connected. There must be no intervening barriers between the two objects, and you must be aware of or able to see the destination object. Action.

Phase Foe (6+ Intellect points): You gather disrupting energy in your fingertip and touch a creature. If the target is an NPC or a creature of level 3 or lower, it becomes phased as if it had used the Ghost ability. However, unless it can figure out how to control its movement while being phased, which most

creatures have no experience with, it begins to sink through solid matter. If it can't control itself or end the effect, it might be gone for good because when it becomes solid again after ten minutes, it's probably deep in the earth. For each additional level of Effort you apply, you can attempt to affect a target of one level higher. Action.

Phase Sprint (1+ Speed points): You can run up to a long distance as long as you take no other actions. During your action and until the beginning of your next turn, you are partially phased, and some attacks pass through you harmlessly. While phased, you gain an asset to your Speed defense tasks, but you lose any benefit from armor you wear.

Note that some of your other special abilities may enable specific actions that you can take while using Phase Sprint. For instance, when using Disrupting Touch, you can make one touch attack while moving (though this ends your movement). Action. (You don't have to run in one long, straight line when using Phase Sprint, but can instead zig and zag, curve, or even return to where you started.) (Other abilities can be used with Phase Sprint to unlock additional effects, including Disrupting Touch, Scratch Existence, Invisible Phasing, and Phase Detonation. These abilities are additive enablers, requiring the user to spend points for both abilities, and sometimes from two different Pools.)

Phased Attack (3 Intellect points): The attack you make on this turn ignores your foe's armor. The ability works for whatever kind of attack you use (melee, ranged, energy, and so on). Enabler.

Phased Pocket (2+ Intellect points): You connect yourself for one hour to a small space that is out of phase and moves with you. You can access this space as if it were a convenient pocket or bag, but nobody else can perceive or access the space unless they have the ability to interact with transdimensional areas. The space can hold up to 1 cubic foot. The space is a part of you, so you can't use it to carry more cyphers than your limit, a detonation cypher activated inside the space harms you, and so on. When the connection ends, anything in the space falls out. For each 2 additional Intellect points you spend, the pocket lasts an additional hour. Enabler.

Physical Skills: You are trained in two skills in which you are not already trained. Choose two of the following: balancing, climbing, jumping, running, or swimming. You can select this ability multiple times. Each time you select it, you must choose two different skills. Enabler.

Physically Gifted: Any time you spend points from your Might Pool or Speed Pool on an action for any reason, if you roll a 1 on the associated die, you reroll, always taking the second result (even if it's another 1). Enabler.

Pierce (1 Speed point): This is a well-aimed, penetrating ranged attack. You make an attack and inflict 1 additional point of damage if your weapon has a sharp point. Action.

Pilot: You are trained in all tasks related to piloting a starcraft. Generally speaking, piloting tasks are Speed-based tasks, though using sensors and communication instruments are Intellect-based tasks. Enabler.

Play to the Crowd (3 Intellect points): You give a speech that is both rousing and terrifying. Those within short range who can hear and understand you have their next action either eased (an asset) or hindered—you choose, and it can be different for each individual. Action; a few rounds to complete.

Poetic License: You are trained in all social interactions, including persuasion, deception, and intimidation. You also know two additional languages. Enabler.

Poison Crafter: You are trained in crafting, sensing, identifying, and resisting poisons. Your poison crafting has given you some immunity to poisons; you have +5 Armor that applies specifically to poison damage. Enabler.

Poison Resistance: Thanks to an injection of biological agents, a quaff of a magical elixir, a ring from a dying alien, or something just as extreme, you are now immune to poisons, toxins, or any kind of particulate threat. You are not immune to viruses, bacteria, or radiation. Enabler.

Post-Apocalyptic Survivor: You are trained in stealth and Might defense tasks. Enabler.

Power Strike (3+ Might points): If you successfully attack a target, you knock it prone in addition to inflicting damage. The target must be your size or smaller. You can knock down a target larger than you if you apply a level of Effort to do so (rather than to ease the attack). Enabler.

Power Crash (3 Intellect points): You strike your enchanted weapon against the ground (or a similar large surface), creating an explosion of energy that affects an area up to immediate range from that point. (If your enchanted weapon is a ranged weapon, you can instead target a point within close range to be the center of the explosion.) The blast inflicts 2 points of damage to all creatures or objects within the area (except for you). Because this is an area attack, adding Effort to increase your damage works differently than it does for single-target attacks. If you apply a level of Effort to increase the damage, add 2 points of damage for each target, and even if you fail your attack roll, all targets in the area still take 1 point of damage. Action.

Power Memory: When you use Copy Power, you only need to have seen the ability used within the past day (instead of the past hour), and using Effort extends how long ago your copying can reach to one day per level of Effort (instead of one hour per level). Enabler.

Powered Armor: You have a suit of powered armor. It is effectively medium armor (+2 to Armor); however, you suffer no Speed penalties for wearing it. Also, your suit grants other benefits: it provides breathable air for up to eight hours and a comfortable environment even in bitter heat, cold, vacuum, or underwater to a depth of 4 miles (6 km); and it allows you to see in the dark up to a short distance. Getting into the suit requires an action (and, of course, access to your suit). Enabler.

Powerful Rhetoric (1 Intellect point): After engaging a creature in conversation for at least a minute, you can attempt to influence how that creature is perceived, promoting it as a friend, dismissing it as a fool, or denouncing it as an enemy. Your words are so well chosen that even you and it are affected, because your conviction and its doubt are paramount. The accuracy of your assessment isn't important as long as you keep up the rhetoric. From then on (or until you change your rhetoric or the creature offers a convincing defense to those who've heard your label), the friend's social interactions gain an asset, the fool's social interactions are hindered, or the enemy's defenses are hindered. Action to initiate, one minute to complete.

Practiced in Armor: You can wear armor for long periods of time without tiring and can compensate for slowed reactions from wearing armor. You reduce the Speed cost for wearing armor by 1. You start the game with a type of armor of your choice. Enabler.

Practiced With All Weapons: You become practiced with light, medium, and heavy weapons and suffer no penalty when using any kind of weapon. Enabler.

Practiced With Guns: You are practiced with guns and

suffer no penalty when using one. Enabler.

Practiced With Medium Weapons: You can use light and medium weapons without penalty. If you wield a heavy weapon, attacks with it are hindered. Enabler.

Practiced With Swords: You are practiced with swords and can use them without penalty. Enabler.

Precise Cut: You inflict 1 additional point of damage with light weapons. Enabler.

Precision: You deal 2 additional points of damage with attacks using weapons that you throw. Enabler.

Precognition (6 Intellect points): You dimly sense the future for the next ten minutes. This has the following effects until the duration expires:

- Your defense tasks gain an asset.
- You can predict the actions of those around you. You gain an asset to seeing through deceptions and attempts to betray you as well as avoiding traps and ambushes.
- You know what people are probably thinking and what they will say before they say it, which gives you an edge. You gain an asset to all interaction skills.

Enabler.

Predictive Equation (2 Intellect points): You observe or study a creature, object, or location for at least one round. The next time you interact with it (possibly in the following round), a related task (such as persuading the creature, attacking it, or defending from its attack) is eased. Action.

Predictive Model (2+ Intellect points): If you've used Predictive Equation on a creature, object, or location within the last few days, you can learn one random fact about the subject that is pertinent to a topic you designate. If you also have the magic flavor ability Premonition, one use of either ability grants you two random but related facts about the subject. In addition, you can use Predictive Model on the same subject multiple times (even if you've learned a creature's level), but each time you do, you must apply one additional level of Effort than on your previous use. Action.

Premonition (2 Intellect points): You learn one random fact about a creature or location that is pertinent to a topic you designate. Alternatively, you can choose to learn a creature's level; however, if you do so, you cannot learn anything else about it later with this ability. Action.

Preternatural Senses: While you are conscious and able to use an action, you cannot be surprised. In addition, you are trained in initiative actions. Enabler.

Privileged Nobility: You are adept at claiming the rewards that a noble background can generate. When recognized, you can be seated at any eating establishment no matter how full, get a room in an inn even if that means others are turned out, be let into any court or other structure where laws are decided or nobility rules, be invited to any gala, and get a seat at a private function of any sort. In addition, you are trained in persuasion. Enabler.

Projection (4 Intellect points): You project an image of yourself to any location you have seen or previously visited. Distance does not matter as long as the location is on the same world as you. The projection copies your appearance, movements, and any sounds you make for the next ten minutes. Anyone present at the location can see and hear you as if you were there. However, you do not perceive through your projection. Action to initiate.

Protective Wall (6+ Might points): When engaging in combat that directly relates to defending a community you are associated with, you can attack up to five different foes as a single action as long as they are all within immediate range. If you hit an attacker, they are pushed back an immediate distance. All of the attacks have to be the same sort of attack (melee or ranged). Make a separate attack roll for each foe. You remain limited by the amount of Effort you can apply on one action. Anything that modifies your attack or damage applies to all of these attacks. In addition to the normal options for using Effort, you can choose to use Effort to increase the number of foes you can attack with this ability, one additional foe per level of Effort. Enabler.

Protector: You designate a single character to be your charge. You can change this freely every round, but you can have only one charge at a time. As long as that charge is within immediate range, they gain an asset for Speed defense tasks because you have their back. Enabler.

Pry Open (4 Intellect points): You tear apart the defenses of a creature within long range. Any energy-based defenses it has (such as a force field or a Ward ability) are negated for 1d6 + 1 rounds. If the creature has no energy defenses, its Armor is reduced by 2 for one minute. If it has no energy-based defenses or Armor, attacks against it are eased for one minute. Action.

Psychic Burst (3+ Intellect points): You blast waves of mental force into the minds of up to three targets within short range (make an Intellect roll against each target). This burst inflicts 3 points of Intellect damage (ignores Armor). For each 2 additional Intellect points you spend, you can make an Intellect attack roll against an additional target. Action.

Psychic Passenger (6 Intellect points): You place your mind into the body of a willing creature you choose within short range and remain in that body for up to one hour. Your own body falls down and becomes insensate until this ability ends.

You see, hear, smell, touch, and taste using the senses of the creature whose body you inhabit. When you speak, the words come from your defenseless body, and the creature you inhabit hears those words in their mind.

The creature you inhabit can use your Intellect Edge in place of their own. In addition, you and the creature have an asset on any task that involves perception.

When you take an action, you use the creature's body to perform that action if they allow it.

Action to initiate.

(A character should using Psychic Passenger should consider secreting their actual body someplace away from prying eyes and wild beasts, or they may return to an unfortunate situation.)

Psychic Suggestion (4 Intellect points): You attempt to make the target take the action you indicate on its next turn. If the action you wish the target to take would cause direct harm to itself or its allies, your mental attack is hindered. Action.

Psychokinetic Attack (5 Intellect points): You can use this attack in one of two ways. The first is to pick up a heavy ob-

ject and hurl it at someone within short range. This attack is an Intellect action, and if successful, it deals 6 points of damage to the target and to the hurled object (which could be another foe, although that would require two rolls—one roll to grab the first foe and another roll to hit the second foe with the first). The second way is to unleash a shattering burst of power that works only against an inanimate object no larger than half your size. Make an Intellect roll to instantly destroy the object; the task is eased by three steps compared to breaking it with brute strength. Action.

Psychosis (4 Intellect points): Your words inflict a destructive psychosis in the mind of a target within long range that can understand you, dealing 6 points of Intellect damage (ignores Armor) per round. The psychosis can be dispersed if a target uses an action doing nothing but calming and centering itself. Action to initiate.

Pull a Fast One (3 Intellect points): When you're running a con, picking a pocket, fooling or tricking a dupe, sneaking something by a guard, and so on, you gain an asset on the task. Enabler.

Punish All the Guilty (3 Speed points): You can attack up to five foes within immediate range that you have designated as guilty with your Designation ability, all as part of the same action in one round. Make separate attack rolls for each foe, but all attacks count as a single action in a single round. You remain limited by the amount of Effort you can apply on one action. Anything that modifies your attack or damage applies to all attacks. If you also have the Spin Attack ability, you inflict 1 additional point of damage when you use Punish All the Guilty. Action.

Punish the Guilty (2 Might points): For the next ten minutes, if you attack someone you have designated as guilty with your Designation ability, you inflict 2 additional points of damage. Action to initiate.

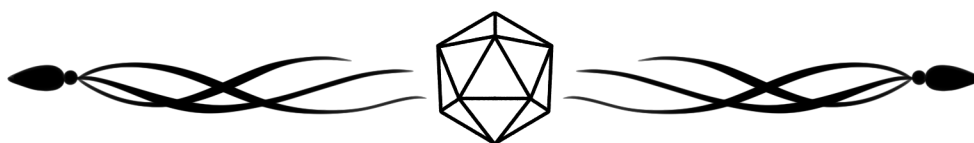
Push (2 Intellect points): You telekinetically push a creature or object an immediate distance in any direction you wish. You must be able to see the target, which must be your size or smaller, must not be affixed to anything, and must be within short range. The push is quick, and the force is too crude to be manipulated. For example, you can't use this ability to pull a lever or close a door. Action.

Push Off and Throw (3 Speed points): You can make precise, point-to-point jumps in microgravity, which means you can move up to a long distance and make a melee attack or attempt to grab a foe of your size or smaller. If you successfully grab your foe, you move your foe up to a short distance from its original position.

Alternatively, while you come to a standstill (or move off in an immediate distance per round in any direction you choose) you can launch your foe in a chosen direction through space at a rate of a short distance per round.

Action.

Push on Through (2 Might points): You ignore the effects of terrain while moving for one hour. Enabler.



7.18 Abilities—Q

Quarry (2 Intellect points): Choose a quarry (a single individual creature that you can see). You are trained in all tasks involving following, understanding, interacting with, or fighting that creature. You can have only one quarry at a time. Action to initiate.

Question the Spirits (2 Intellect points): You can call a spirit to you and petition it to answer a few questions (usually no more than three before the spirit fades).

First, you must summon a spirit. If it is a spirit of the dead, you must have personally known the creature, have an object that was owned by the creature, or touch the physical remains of the creature. For other spirits, you must know the spirit's full name or have a great deal of an element (such as fire or earth) that the spirit is associated with.

If the spirit responds, it can manifest as an insubstantial shade that answers for itself, it can inhabit an object or any remains you provide, or it can manifest as an invisible presence that you speak for.

The spirit may not wish to answer your questions, in which case you must persuade it to help. You can attempt to psychically wrestle the spirit into submission (an Intellect task), or you can try diplomacy, deception, or blackmail ("Answer me, or I'll tell your children that you were a philanderer" or "I'll destroy this relic that belonged to you").

The GM determines what the spirit might know, based on the knowledge it possessed in life.

Action to initiate.

Quick Block: If you use a light or medium weapon, you are trained in Speed defense tasks. Enabler.

Quick Death (2 Speed points): You know how to kill quickly. When you hit with a melee or ranged attack, you deal 4 additional points of damage. You can't make this attack in two consecutive rounds. Action.

Quick Recovery: Your second recovery roll (usually requiring ten minutes) is only a single action. Enabler.

Quick Strike (4 Speed points): You make a melee attack with such speed that it is hard for your foe to defend against, and it knocks them off balance. Your attack is eased by two steps, and the foe, if struck, takes normal damage but is dazed so that their tasks are hindered for the next round. Action.

Quick Study: You learn from repetitive actions. You gain a +1 bonus to rolls for similar tasks after the first time (such as operating the same device or making attacks against the same foe). Once you move on to a new task, the familiarity with the old task fades—unless you start doing it again. Enabler.

Quick Switch: You can activate Shrink as part of another action (the ability is now an enabler for you instead of an action). While the one-minute duration of Shrink is active, on your turn you can change size once before taking an action and once after taking an action. For example, on your turn you could change to small size, make an attack, and then return to your normal size, or you could change to your normal size, use your action to move a short distance, and then return to small size. Enabler.

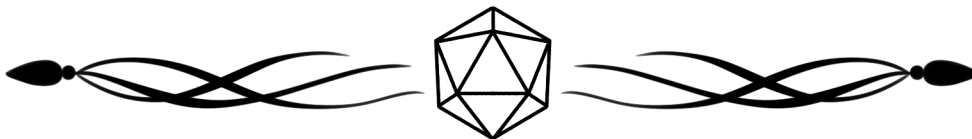
Quick Throw (2 Speed points): After using a thrown light weapon, you draw another light weapon and make another thrown attack against the same target or a different one. Action.

Quick to Flee: You are trained in stealth and movement tasks. Enabler.

Quick Wits: When performing a task that would normally require spending points from your Intellect Pool, you can spend points from your Speed Pool instead. Enabler.

Quick Work (3+ Intellect points): One use of any artifact (or one minute of its continuous function) is increased by one level if you use it within the next minute. If you spend 4 additional Intellect points, the use is increased by two levels if you use it within the next minute. Action.

Quicker Than Most: Experience has honed your reaction times, because those who act first gain the advantage in most situations. You're trained in tasks related to initiative, seeing underlying patterns, and solving puzzles. Enabler.



7.19 Abilities—R

Rally to Me (2 Intellect points): You cry out, blow a battle horn, or otherwise signal to everyone within very long range that you require aid. All allied creatures who respond by moving to within an immediate distance of you within the next few rounds gain one asset on any one attack or defense task within the next hour that you suggest, such as “Hold the gate,” “Charge that group of orcs,” or something similar. Action to initiate.

Range Increase: Ranges for you increase by one step. Immediate becomes short, short becomes long, long becomes very long, and very long becomes 1,000 feet (300 m). Enabler.

Rapid Attack (3 Speed points): Once per round, you can make an additional attack with your chosen weapon. Enabler.

Rapid Processing (6 Intellect points): You or a target you touch experiences a higher level of mental and physical reaction time for about a minute. During that period, all Speed tasks (including Speed defense rolls) are eased. In addition, the target can take one extra action at any time before the ability’s duration expires. Action.

Rapid Recovery: You can make most recovery rolls faster than normal. You can make your one-action recovery roll as part of another action or when it isn’t your turn, your ten-minute recovery roll takes you only one action, and your one-hour recovery roll takes you only ten minutes (your ten-hour rest is unchanged). If you make a recovery roll when it isn’t your turn, until the end of your next turn all of your tasks are hindered. Enabler.

Ray of Confusion (2 Intellect points): You project a grey beam of confusion at a creature within short range, inflicting 1 point of damage that ignores Armor. In addition, until the end of the next round, all tasks, attacks, and defenses the target attempts are hindered. Action.

Reaction: If a creature you attacked on your last turn with a melee attack uses its action to move out of immediate range, you gain an action to attack the creature as a parting blow, even if you have already taken a turn in the round. Enabler.

Reactive Field: Thanks to a remarkable enhancement of science, magic, psionics, or something even stranger, you now have a force field that radiates 1 inch (2.5 cm) from your body and provides you with +2 to Armor. In addition, if struck by a melee attack, the field creates a backlash that inflicts 4 points of electricity damage to the attacker. Enabler.

Read the Signs (4 Intellect points): You examine an area and learn precise, useful details about the past (if any exist). You can ask the GM up to four questions about the immediate area; each requires its own roll. Action.

Reading the Room (3 Intellect points): You gain knowledge about an area by speaking with dead spirits or reading residual energies from the past. You can ask the GM a single, matter-of-fact question about the location and get an answer if you succeed on the Intellect roll. “What killed the cattle in this barn?” is a good example of a simple question. “Why were these cattle killed?” is not an appropriate question because it has more to do with the mindset of the killer than the barn. Simple questions usually have a difficulty of 2, but extremely technical questions or those that involve facts meant to be kept secret can have a much higher difficulty. Action.

Recruit Deputy: You gain a level 4 follower. They are not restricted on their modifications. Alternatively, you can choose to advance a level 3 follower you already have to level 4 and then gain a new level 3 follower. Enabler.

Recycled Cyphers: All manifest cyphers you use function

at one level higher than normal. In addition, if given a week and at least ten items of junk from the Junk table, you can tinker with one of your manifest cyphers, transforming it into another cypher of the same type that you had in the past. The GM and player should collaborate to ensure that the transformation is logical—for example, you probably can’t transform a pill into a helmet. Enabler.

Regenerate: Your ability to heal (whether from a potent spell, unique mutation, or cybernetic graft) continues to function even if you die from violence, as long as your body is mostly intact. One minute after your death, this ability activates and brings you back to life; however, you come back with a permanent 2-point deduction from your Intellect Pool. Enabler. (A character might discover that Regenerate is both a blessing and a curse, because relying on it too much leads to a kind of malaise that vitality alone can’t fix.)

Regenerate Other (9 Might points): You can confer your Regenerate ability on another creature that you touch and attempt to return it to life, as long as its body is mostly intact. (If you don’t have the Regenerate ability, you gain it, but can use it only on yourself.) The difficulty of the task is equal to 3 plus the number of days the target has been dead. (If the body has been perfectly preserved in stasis or through some other non-damaging preservation mechanism, no time limit applies.) Enabler.

Regeneration (6 Intellect points): You restore points to a target’s Might or Speed Pool in one of two ways: either the chosen Pool regains up to 6 points, or it is restored to a total value of 12. You make this decision when you initiate this ability. Points are regenerated at a rate of 1 point each round. You must remain within immediate range of the target the whole time, either touching them or conversing with them. In no case can this raise a Pool higher than its maximum. Action.

Reinforcing Field (6+ Intellect points): You can reinforce any object or structure by infusing it with a force field for one hour. The force field increases the level of the object or structure by 2 for tasks related to durability and withstanding damage and destruction. Action to initiate.

Release Energy: You release 1 point of energy you’ve absorbed with your Absorb Kinetic Energy ability, magnifying and focusing it into a blast of energy that strikes a single foe within long range for 4 points of damage. (If you don’t have any kinetic energy absorbed, you can still use this ability, but it requires that you transform a fraction of yourself into the blast, which costs 1 point of Might.) Action.

Reload (1 Speed point): When using a weapon that normally requires an action to reload, such as a heavy crossbow, you can reload and fire (or fire and reload) in the same action. Enabler.

Relocate (7 Intellect points): Choose one creature or object within immediate range. You instantly transport it to a new position within long range that you can see. The new position can be any direction from you, but it cannot be inside a solid object. Action.

Remote Control (5 Intellect points): You can use a starcraft’s communication and sensor arrays to launch an attack that briefly renders an enemy starcraft within 20 miles (32 km) inoperative for up to a minute. Action. (Remote Control is a masterful attempt to jam or hack an enemy spacecraft, a task normally requiring multiple rolls, and you only succeed if you roll a total of three successes before rolling a total of two failures. However, all such tasks are hindered by at least two steps due to hardened spacecraft electronic security.)

Remote Viewing (6 Intellect points): Distance is an illusion, as all space is one space. With great concentration, you can see another place. This ability can be used in one of two ways:

- Distance and direction. Pick a spot a specific distance away and in a specific direction. You can see from that vantage point as if you had used the Sensor ability there, but only for one minute.
- Think of a place you have seen before, either conventionally or using the other application of this power. You can see from that vantage point as if you had used the Sensor ability there, but only for one or two rounds.

Either application takes anywhere from one action to hours of concentration, depending on what the GM feels is appropriate due to time, distance, or other mitigating circumstances. However, you don't know in advance how long it will take.

Action to initiate; action each round to concentrate.

Repair Flesh (3 Intellect points): When you touch an impaired or debilitated character, you can move them up one step on the damage track (for example, a debilitated PC becomes impaired, and an impaired one becomes hale). Alternatively, if you use this ability on a PC during a rest, you grant them a +2 bonus to their recovery roll. Action.

Repel Metal: By manipulating magnetism, you are trained in Speed defense tasks against any incoming attack that uses metal. Enabler.

Reshape (5 Intellect points): You reshape matter within short range in an area no larger than a 5-foot (1.5 m) cube. If you use only one action on this ability, the changes you make are crude at best. If you spend at least ten minutes and succeed at a hindered appropriate crafting task, you can make complex changes to the material. You can't change the nature of the material, only its shape. Thus, you can make a hole in a wall or floor, or you can seal one up. You can fashion a rudimentary sword from a large piece of iron. You can break or repair a chain. With multiple uses of this ability, you could bring about large changes, making a bridge, a wall, or a similar structure. Action.

Resilience: You have 1 point of Armor against any kind of physical damage, even physical damage that normally ignores Armor. Enabler.

Resilient Duplicate: Increase the health of any duplicate you create (such as with Duplicate) by 5. Enabler.

Resilient Ice Armor: The sheen of ice you generate using your Ice Armor ability gives you an additional +1 to Armor. Enabler.

Resist the Elements: You resist heat, cold, and similar extremes. You have a special +2 to Armor against ambient damage or other damage that would normally ignore Armor. Enabler.

Resist Tricks: You're trained in solving puzzles and recognizing tricks from years of game playing. Enabler.

Resist Underwater Hazards: Whether you're resisting crushing waters while exploring the depths or a sting from a poisonous fish, all defense tasks while submerged in water are eased. Enabler.

Resonance Field (1 Intellect point): Faint lines in a color you choose form a tracery over your entire body and emit faint light. The effect lasts for one minute. Whenever a creature within immediate range makes an attack against you, the pattern energizes to block the attack. You can make an Intellect defense roll in place of the defense roll you would normally make.

If you do so and you get a minor effect, the creature attacking you takes 1 point of damage. If you get a major effect, the creature attacking you takes 4 points of damage. Action to initiate.

Resonant Frequency: You can infuse an item of up to level 7 that you can hold in one hand with a special vibration generated from your core. The object then functions as if two levels higher for one minute. At the end of that minute, the resonant frequency ramps up exponentially until the object finally shatters from the energy buildup. Anything within immediate range of the detonation suffers 5 points of damage. Action to initiate.

Resonant Quake (7 Intellect points): You can infuse the ground beneath you with a special vibration generated from your core. This creates a small quake whose epicenter you can select within a very long distance. Everyone within short range of the epicenter is subject to 8 points of damage (from shaking and being struck by toppling objects, crumbling walls, and so on). However, you are dazed for a round afterward yourself, during which time all your tasks are hindered. If you have the Move Mountains ability, both abilities cost 3 fewer Intellect points to use. Action.

Restful Presence: Creatures who make a recovery roll within short range of you add +1 to their roll. Enabler.

Restore Life (9+ Intellect points): You can attempt to restore life to a dead creature of up to level 3, as long as the corpse is no more than a day old and is mostly intact. You can also attempt to restore life to a corpse that is much older but is especially well preserved. The difficulty of the Intellect task is equal to the level of the creature you're attempting to restore to life. For each additional level of Effort applied, you can attempt to restore the life of a creature whose level is 1 higher. When first restored to life, a creature is dazed for at least a day, and all tasks they attempt are hindered. Action; one minute to initiate.

Restorative Bloom (5 Might points): When Wooden Body or Great Tree is in effect, you produce a flower, acorn, fruit, or similar plant-based edible item. A creature that eats this food is nourished for a full day and restores their Might Pool, Speed Pool, and Intellect Pool to their maximum values, as if they were fully rested. Eating a second food produced by this ability in a day has no effect. If the food is not eaten within ten minutes, it spoils. Action to produce, action to eat.

Resuscitate (6 Intellect points): You can resuscitate a character who is up to two steps down on the damage track as your action. The target ascends one step on the damage track. If a character has dropped all three steps on the damage track (dead) but is otherwise in one piece and less than a minute has passed since they descended to the third step, you can resuscitate them if you succeed at a level 6 healing task. If you use this ability on an NPC who has no health but has been dead for less than a minute and is otherwise in one piece, the NPC is resuscitated with 1 health. Action.

Retinue: Four level 2 followers join you (and your first follower, if you have one). One of their modifications must be for tasks related to serving as your personal assistants. In addition to other tasks they might individually take on your behalf, they can also work together to run interference if you're trying to avoid someone, help hide you from the attention of others, help you muscle through a crowd, and so on. If a situation becomes physically violent, they provide an asset to your Speed defense tasks and, if you command it, try to hold a foe's attention while you escape. Enabler.

Retrieve Memories (3 Intellect points): You touch the remains of a recently killed creature and make an Intellect-based roll to restore its mind to life long enough to learn information

from it. The GM sets the difficulty based on the amount of time that has passed since the creature died. A creature that has been dead for only a few minutes is a difficulty 2 task, one that has been dead for an hour is a difficulty 4 task, and one that has been dead for a few days is a difficulty 9 task. If you succeed, you awaken the corpse, causing its head to animate and perceive things as if it were alive. This enables communication for about one minute, which is how long it takes for the creature to realize that it's dead. The creature is limited to what it knew in life, though it cannot recall minor memories, only big events of importance to it. When the effect ends, or if you fail the roll, the creature's brain dissolves to mush and cannot be awakened again. Action.

Return to Sender (3 Speed points): If you succeed at a Speed defense task against a melee attack, you can make an immediate melee attack against your foe. You can use this ability only once per round. Enabler.

Return to the Obelisk (7+ Intellect points): You transfer your body and personal possessions into a crystal of any size that you can touch, and you exit from another crystal of any size, including any crystal obelisks that you are aware of. You must know of the crystal you are going to use as an exit before you enter the first crystal. You can take one additional creature with you for each level of Effort applied. Action.

Reveal (2+ Intellect points): You adjust a creature's eyesight so that it can see normally in areas of dim light and darkness. You can affect one willing creature within immediate range for one hour. In addition to the normal options for using Effort, you can choose to use Effort to affect more targets; each level of Effort applied affects two additional targets. You must touch additional targets to affect them. Action to initiate.

Ribbons of Dark Matter (2 Intellect points): For the next minute, dark matter condenses within an area within long range that is no bigger than an immediate distance in diameter, manifesting as swirling ribbons. All tasks attempted by creatures in the area are hindered, and leaving the area requires a creature's entire action to move. You can dismiss the dark matter early as an action. Action to initiate.

Rider: You are trained in riding any kind of creature that serves as a mount, such as a noble warhorse. Enabler.

Roaming Third Eye (3 Intellect points): When you use your Third Eye ability, you can place the sensor anywhere within long range. In addition, until that ability ends, you can use an action to move the sensor anywhere within short range of its starting position. Enabler.

Robot Assistant: A level 2 robot of your size or smaller (built by you) accompanies you and follows your instructions. You and the GM must work out the details of your robot. You'll probably make rolls for it when it takes actions. A robot assistant in combat usually doesn't make separate attacks but helps with yours. On your action, if the artificial assistant is next to you, it serves as an asset for one attack you make on your turn. If the robot is destroyed, you can repair the original with a few days' worth of tinkering, or build a new one with a week's worth of half-time labor. Enabler.

Robot Builder: You are trained in tasks related to building and repairing robots. For the purposes of repair, you can use this skill to heal robots that use similar technology. Enabler.

Robot Control (2+ Intellect points): You use your knowledge of robot command and control (and possibly devices that transmit on the proper frequency) to affect any mechanized system or robot of level 2 or lower within short range. You can

render several targets inactive for as long as you focus all your attention on them. If you focus on just one target, you can attempt to take active control of it for one minute, commanding it to do simple tasks on your behalf while you concentrate. In addition to the normal options for using Effort, you can choose to use Effort to increase the maximum level of the mechanized system or robot. Thus, to affect a level 4 target (two levels above the normal limit), you must apply two levels of Effort. Action to initiate.

Robot Evolution: Your first artificial assistant from the Robot Assistant ability increases to level 5, and each of your level 2 robots from Robot Fleet increases to level 3. Instead of choosing this option, you may instead choose one upgrade from the Robot Upgrade ability. Enabler.

Robot Fighter: When fighting a robot or intelligent machine, you are trained in attacks and defense. Enabler.

Robot Fleet: You build up to four level 2 robot assistants, each no larger than yourself. (They are in addition to the assistant you built at first tier with Robot Assistant, which may have seen a few upgrades since then.) You and the GM must work out the details of these additional robots. If a robot is destroyed, you can build a new one (or repair the old one from its parts) after a week of half-time labor. Instead of this ability, you can select one of the following abilities: Expert Follower, Robot Control, or Robot Upgrade. Enabler.

Robot Improvement: Your artificial assistant from the Robot Assistant ability increases to level 4. Enabler.

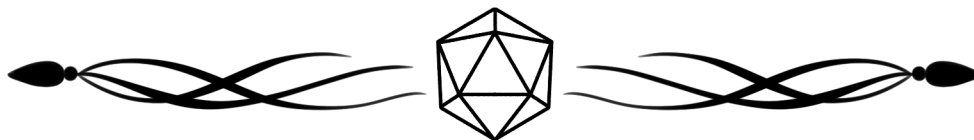
Robot Upgrade: You modify your artificial assistant from the Robot Assistant ability with one new capability. Standard options include the following. Work with your GM if you prefer a different capability.

- *Cypher Pod*. The robot can carry one extra manifest cypher for you. Enabler.
- *Flight*. The robot can fly a long distance each round. It can carry you, but only for up to an hour between each of your ten-hour recovery rolls. Enabler.
- *Force Shield*. The robot can erect an opaque level 5 force field around itself and anyone within 10 feet (3 m) of it for one minute (or until it is destroyed). It cannot do so again until after your next recovery roll. Action.
- *Mounted Laser Configuration*. The robot can reconfigure itself and become an immobile laser weapon on a gimbal mount. In this configuration, the robot is a heavy weapon that deals 7 points of damage. If the robot acts as an autonomous turret, treat it as one level lower than its normal level. However, if the laser is fired by you or someone else who has your permission, the laser attacks are eased. Action to reconfigure; action to return to normal robot configuration.

Ruin Lore: You are trained in scavenging, which means you're more likely to find useful things, and junk that can potentially be turned into useful things in the ruins of what came before. Enabler.

Run and Fight (4 Might points): You can move a short distance and make a melee attack that inflicts 2 additional points of damage. Action.

Runner: Your standard movement increases from short to long. Enabler.



7.20 Abilities—S

Safe Fall: You reduce the damage from a fall by 5 points. Enabler.

Sailor: You are trained in tasks related to sailing and trained in the geography of islands and coastlines. Enabler.

Salvage and Comfort (2 Intellect points): You're familiar with open space. If you spend an hour using your spacecraft's sensors and make a difficulty 3 Intellect roll, you can find salvage in the form of abandoned spacecraft, drifting motes of matter that were once inhabited, or a place to hide from pursuit in what most people would otherwise assume to be empty space (such as in a nebula, an asteroid field, or the shadow of a moon). Salvage you turn up includes enough food and water for you and several others, as well as the possibility of weapons, clothing, technological artifacts, survivors, or other usable items. In other contexts, this ability counts as training in tasks related to perception. Action to initiate, one hour to complete.

Scan (2 Intellect points): You scan an area equal in size to a 10-foot (3 m) cube, including all objects or creatures within that area. The area must be within short range. Scanning a creature or object always reveals its level. You also learn whatever facts the GM feels are pertinent about the matter and energy in that area. For example, you might learn that the wooden box contains a device of metal and plastic. You might learn that the glass cylinder is full of poisonous gas, and that its metal stand has an electrical field running through it that connects to a metal mesh in the floor. You might learn that the creature standing before you is a mammal with a small brain. However, this ability doesn't tell you what the information means. Thus, in the first example, you don't know what the metal and plastic device does. In the second, you don't know if stepping on the floor causes the cylinder to release the gas. In the third, you might suspect that the creature is not very intelligent, but scans, like looks, can be deceiving. Many materials and energy fields prevent or resist scanning. Action.

Scramble Machine (2 Intellect points): You render one machine within short range unable to function for one round. Alternatively, you can hinder any action by the machine (or by someone attempting to use the machine) for one minute. Action.

Scratch Existence (1+ Might points): You can choose to phase in a way that "scratches" normal matter in a long streak as you run using Phase Sprint. This tears a bit at you, too, reflected by the Might cost. When you use Phase Sprint, you inflict 2 points of damage (ignores Armor) to one target you select as you pass within immediate range, without triggering Disrupting Touch. In addition to the normal options for using Effort, you can choose to use Effort to increase the number of targets along your path that you can attack as part of the same action. Make a separate attack roll for each foe. You remain limited by the amount of Effort you can apply on one action. Anything that modifies your attack or damage applies to all of these attacks.

Alternatively, if you apply Effort to increase the damage rather than ease the task, you deal 2 additional points of damage per level of Effort (instead of 3 points); the target takes 1 point of damage even if you fail the attack roll.

Enabler.

Sculpt Flesh (2 Intellect points): You cause a willing creature's fingers to lengthen into claws and their teeth to grow into fangs. The effect lasts for ten minutes. The damage dealt by the target's unarmed strikes increases to 4 points. Action.

Sculpt Light (4 Intellect points): You create an object of solid light in any shape you can imagine that is your size or smaller, and it persists for about an hour. The object appears in an area adjacent to you. It is crude and can have no moving parts, so you can make a sword, a shield, a short ladder, and so on. The object has the approximate mass of the real object and is level 4. Action.

Sea Legs: You have gotten used to rough seas and unexpected surges. You are trained in balance. Any movement task that would be hindered by a pitching deck, moving through rigging, and so on is a routine task for you. Enabler.

See History (4 Intellect points): You touch an object, read the subtle echoes of its existence through time, ask the GM a question about the object's past, and get a general answer. The answers are often in the form of brief images or sensations rather than specific answers in a language you know. The GM assigns a level to the question, so the more obscure the answer, the more difficult the task. » Generally, knowledge that you could find by looking somewhere other than your current location is level 1, and obscure knowledge of the past is level 7. After you use this ability, you have an asset on identifying the object. Action. ("Obscure" is a relative term—a sage might not know how a vampire acquired a specific artifact, but someone using See History on that artifact would have an easy time sensing that event.)

See the Future (6 Intellect points): Based on all the variables you perceive, you can predict the next few minutes. This has the following effects: For the next ten minutes, your defense rolls gain an asset. You have a sort of danger sense. For the next ten minutes, you gain an asset in seeing through deceptions and attempts to betray you, as well as avoiding traps and ambushes.

You know what people are probably thinking and what they will say before they say it. For the next ten minutes, you gain an asset to tasks involving interaction and deception.

Enabler.

See the Unseen: You can automatically perceive creatures and objects that are normally invisible, out of phase, or only partially in this universe. When looking for things more conventionally hidden, the task is eased. Enabler.

See Through Matter (3+ Intellect points): You can see through matter as if it were transparent. You can see through up to 6 inches (15 cm) of material for one round. Doing so is a task whose difficulty is equal to the material or object's level. In addition to the normal options for using Effort, you can choose to use Effort to see through another 6 inches of material for each additional level of Effort you apply toward that goal. Action.

See Through Time (7 Intellect points): Time is an illusion, as all time is one time. With great concentration, you can see into another time. You specify a time period regarding the place where you now stand. Interestingly, the easiest time to view is about one hundred years in the past or future. Viewing farther back or ahead is a nearly impossible task.

This takes anywhere from one action to hours of concentration, depending on what the GM feels is appropriate due to time, distance, or other mitigating circumstances. However, you don't know in advance how long it will take.

Action to initiate; action each round to concentrate.

Seeds of Fury (1 Intellect point): You throw a handful of seeds in the air that ignite and speed toward a target within long range, scratching the air with twisting smoke trails. The attack deals 3 points of damage and catches the target on fire, which inflicts 1 additional point of damage per round for up to a minute or until the target uses an action to douse the flames. Action.

Seize the Initiative (5 Intellect points): Within one minute of successfully using your Draw Conclusion ability, you can take one additional, immediate action, which you can take out of turn. After using this ability, you can't use it again until after your next ten-hour recovery roll. Enabler.

Seize the Moment (4+ Speed points): If you succeed on a Speed defense roll to resist an attack, you gain an action. You can use the action immediately even if you have already taken a turn in the round. You don't take an action during the next round, unless you apply a level of Effort when you use Seize the Moment. Enabler.

Sense Ambush: You are never surprised by an attack. Enabler.

Sense Attitudes: You are trained in sensing lies and whether a person is likely to (or already does) believe your lies. Enabler.

Sensing Package: You can see in dim light and darkness as if it were bright light, and you can see up to a short distance through fog, smoke, and other obscuring phenomena. In addition, if you apply a level of Effort to perception or searching tasks, you get a free level of Effort on that task. Enabler.

Sensor (4 Intellect points): You create an immobile, invisible sensor within immediate range that lasts for 24 hours. At any time during that duration, you can concentrate to see, hear, and smell through the sensor, no matter how far you move from it. The sensor doesn't grant you sensory capabilities beyond the norm. If you also have this ability from another source, it lasts twice as long. Action to create; action to check.

Sensor Array (3 Intellect points): You are trained in using starcraft sensory instruments. These instruments allow users to answer general questions about a location, such as "How many people are in the mining colony?" or "Where did the other spacecraft crash?" Action.

Serv-0: You build a tiny robot assistant. It is level 1 and cannot take independent actions or leave your immediate area. In truth, it's more an extension of you than a separate being. It gains a modification in using machines and other technological devices. Enabler.

Serv-0 Aim: Your Serv-0 aids you in ranged combat. It gains a modification in ranged attacks. Enabler.

Serv-0 Brawler: Your Serv-0 aids you in melee combat. It gains a modification in melee attacks. Enabler.

Serv-0 Defender: Your Serv-0 aids you in combat by blocking attacks. It gains a modification in Speed defense. Enabler.

Serv-0 Repair: Your Serv-0 aids you in repairing other devices. It gains a modification in repair. Enabler.

Serv-0 Scanner (2 Intellect points): Your Serv-0 gains the Scan ability. Enabler.

Serv-0 Spy (3 Intellect points): You can send your Serv-0 up to a long distance away for up to ten minutes and see and hear through it as though its senses were your own. You direct its movement. Action to initiate.

Share Defense: If your training in a defense task is greater than that of an ally within short range, your advice and insight allow them to substitute your training for that defense task. Enabler.

Share the Power: When you use Drain Creature or Drain Machine to drain energy, you can transfer it to another creature, restoring points to their Might or Speed Pools (or health for an NPC) instead of yourself. You can spend points from your Siphon Pool (from the Store Energy ability) in the same way. You must touch the creature you want to heal, unless you

have the Drain at a Distance ability, in which case they can be up to a short distance away. Enabler.

Share Senses: While your duplicate created by the Duplicate ability is in existence and within 1 mile (1.5 km), you know everything it experiences and can communicate with it telepathically. Enabler.

Sharp Senses: You are trained in all tasks involving perception. Enabler.

Sharp-Eyed: Because you must always keep an eye out when you're traveling, you are trained in all tasks related to perception and navigation. Enabler.

Shatter (2+ Intellect points): You interrupt the fundamental force holding normal matter together for a moment, causing the detonation of an object you choose within long range. The object must be a small, mundane item composed of homogeneous matter (such as a clay cup, an iron ingot, a stone, and so on). The object explodes in an immediate radius, dealing 1 point of damage to all creatures and objects in the area. If you apply Effort to increase the damage, you deal 2 additional points of damage per level of Effort (instead of 3 points); targets in the area take 1 point of damage even if you fail the attack roll. Action.

Shatter Mind (7+ Intellect points): Your words reverberate destructively in the brain of an intelligent level 1 target within short range that can hear and understand you. They destroy tissue, memories, and personality, triggering a vegetative state. In addition to the normal options for using Effort, you can choose to use Effort to increase the maximum level of the target. Thus, to shatter the mind of a level 5 target (four levels above the normal limit), you must apply four levels of Effort. Action. (The vegetative state created by Shatter Mind can be healed by advanced magic or science, or by a condition remover cypher that cures psychosis.)

Shattering Shout (5+ Might points): Your focused shout sets up a destructive resonance in a creature or object within long range. Nothing happens on the round you strike your target other than an ominous humming or buzzing sound emitted by the target. But on your next turn, the resonance shatters discrete inanimate objects, inflicts major damage to structures, or inflicts 4 points of damage on a creature (ignores Armor).

If you shatter a discrete object, it shatters explosively, inflicting 1 point of damage on all creatures and objects within immediate range of it. If you apply Effort to increase the damage rather than ease the task, you deal 2 additional points of damage per level of Effort (instead of 3 points); targets in the area take 1 point of damage even if you fail the attack roll.

Action to initiate.

Shepherd's Fury: You inflict 3 additional points of damage when engaging in combat that directly relates to advancing the needs of a community you are associated with. (You and the GM can decide whether a particular situation warrants the additional damage.) Enabler.

Shield Burst: When you make a melee or ranged attack and hit with your Force Field Shield, it releases an explosion of energy, inflicting an additional 2 points of damage on the target and everything within immediate range of the target. If you applied Effort to inflict additional damage as part of the attack, each level of Effort inflicts only 2 additional points to all targets instead of 3 points. If you use Shield Burst with a melee attack, you and creatures behind you are not affected by this explosion. If you use Shield Burst with a ranged attack, the shield dissipates after the attack and then reforms in your grasp. Enabler.

Shield Master: When you use a shield, in addition to the asset it gives you (easing Speed defense tasks), you can act as if you are trained in Speed defense tasks. However, in any round in which you use this benefit, your attacks are hindered. Enabler.

Shield Training: If you use a shield, Speed defense tasks are eased by two steps instead of one. Enabler.

Ship Footing (3 Speed points): For ten minutes, all tasks you attempt while on a spaceship are eased. Action to initiate.

Shipspeak: You can make basic maneuvers from a planetary distance with a starship that you have bonded with using Machine Bond. You can send it to a designated place, call it to you, have it land, allow or deny entrance, and so on, even if you are not on board. Bonding is a process that requires a day of meditation while jacked into the ship. Action.

Shock (1 Intellect point): Your hands crackle with electricity, and the next time you touch a creature, you inflict 3 points of damage. Alternatively, if you wield a weapon, for ten minutes it crackles with electricity and inflicts 1 additional point of damage per attack. Action for touch; enabler for weapon.

Short Teleportation (4+ Intellect points): You instantly teleport to any location within a short distance that you can see. In addition to the normal options for using Effort, you can choose to use Effort to increase your range, teleport to a location you can't see, or bring other people with you. Each additional short distance costs one level of Effort. Teleporting to a destination you can't see costs one level of Effort. Each additional target brought with you costs one level of Effort (you must touch any additional targets). These levels of Effort are counted separately, so teleporting an additional short distance away to a location you can't see with one passenger costs a total of three levels of Effort. Action.

If you already have Short Teleportation when you select Medium Teleportation or Teleportation, you may replace Short Teleportation with another tier 4 type ability.

Show Them the Way (6+ Intellect points): Your presence overwhelms a creature that you touch and ask to aid you. Essentially, if the creature fails to defend against your presence, you control its actions for up to ten minutes. The target must be level 3 or lower. Once you have established control, you maintain control through verbal instruction. You can allow the target to act freely or override control on a case-by-case basis. In addition to the normal options for using Effort, you can choose to use Effort to increase the maximum level of the target. Thus, to affect a level 5 target (two levels above the normal limit), you must apply two levels of Effort. When the effect ends, the creature vaguely remembers doing your will, but it's as blurry as a dream. Action to initiate.

Shred Existence: When you use Disrupting Touch, Scratch Existence, or Phase Detonation, you inflict an additional 5 points of damage that ignores Armor. Enabler.

Shroud of Flame (1 Intellect point): At your command, your entire body becomes shrouded in flames that last up to ten minutes. The fire doesn't burn you, but it automatically inflicts 2 points of damage to anyone who tries to touch you or strike you with a melee attack. Flames from another source can still hurt you. While the shroud is active, you gain +2 Armor against damage from fire from another source. Enabler.

Shrink (1+ Might points): You (and your clothing or suit) become much smaller than your normal size. You become 6 inches (15 cm) tall and stay that way for about a minute. During this time, you add 4 points to your Speed Pool and add +2 to your Speed Edge. While you are smaller than normal, your

Speed defense rolls are eased, your movement speed is one-tenth normal, and your attacks inflict half the normal amount of damage (divide the total damage in half after all bonuses, Effort, and other damage modifiers). You can return to your normal size as part of another action.

When the effects of Shrink end, your Speed Edge, movement speed, and damage return to normal, and you subtract a number of points from your Speed Pool equal to the number you gained (if this brings the Pool to 0, subtract the overflow first from your Might Pool and then, if necessary, from your Intellect Pool). Each additional time you use Shrink before your next ten-hour recovery roll, you must apply an additional level of Effort (one level of Effort for the second use, two levels of Effort for the third use, and so on).

Action to initiate.

The increased Effort cost for repeat uses of Shrink between ten-hour recovery rolls only applies to new activations of Shrink, not to multiple size changes within one use of Shrink enabled by Quick Switch.

Shrink Others: You can use Shrink on other willing creatures within an immediate distance. In addition to the normal options for using Effort, you can choose to use Effort to affect more targets; each level of Effort affects one additional target. Unless these creatures have an ability to change their size, they remain small until the one-minute duration of Shrink ends for them. Enabler.

Silent As Space: By taking advantage of microgravity conditions, you gain an asset to stealth and initiative tasks while in zero-gravity or low-gravity conditions. Enabler.

Skill With Attacks: Choose one type of attack in which you are not already trained: light bashing, light bladed, light ranged, medium bashing, medium bladed, medium ranged, heavy bashing, heavy bladed, or heavy ranged. You are trained in attacks using that type of weapon. You can select this ability multiple times. Each time you select it, you must choose a different type of attack. Enabler.

Skill With Defense: Choose one type of defense task in which you are not already trained: Might, Speed, or Intellect. You are trained in defense tasks of that type. Enabler.

Sleuth: Finding the clues is the first step in solving a mystery. You are trained in perception. Enabler.

Slice (2 Speed points): This is a quick attack with a bladed or pointed weapon that is hard to defend against. You are trained in this task. If the attack is successful, it deals 1 less point of damage than normal. Action.

Slip Into Shadow (2+ Intellect points): You attempt to slip away from a selected target and hide from view in a nearby shadow, behind a tree or a furnishing, or in the next room, even if in full view of the target. For each level of Effort applied, you can attempt to affect one additional target, as long as all your targets are next to each other. Action to initiate.

Slippery: You are trained in escaping any kind of bond or grasp. Enabler.

Slippery Customer: When you apply Effort to tasks involving escaping from bonds, fitting in tight spaces, and other contortionist tasks, you get a free level of Effort on the task. Thanks to your experience, you are also trained in Speed defense tasks while wearing light armor or no armor. Enabler.

Small Flight (3+ Intellect points): For the next hour, when using Shrink, you can fly through the air. You might accomplish this flight by growing wings from your body, extending wings from your suit, calling a tiny creature to carry you, or "surfing" air currents. When flying, you can move up to a short distance

as part of another action or a long distance if all you do on your turn is move. Action to initiate.

Smaller: When you use Shrink, you can choose to shrink down to about half an inch (1 cm) high, and you add 3 more temporary points to your Speed Pool. Enabler.

Snap Shot: You can make two gun attacks as a single action, but the second attack is hindered by two steps. Enabler.

Sneak: You are trained in stealth and initiative tasks. Enabler.

Snipe (2 Speed points): If you spend one action aiming, in the next round you can make a precise ranged attack. You have an asset on this attack. If your attack is successful, it inflicts 4 additional points of damage. Action.

Sniper's Aim: By dint of almost constant practice playing games that simulate making ranged attacks, your hand-eye coordination is off the chart. You have an asset on all ranged attacks. Enabler.

Something in the Road: When you use a vehicle as a weapon, you inflict 5 additional points of damage. Enabler.

Soothe Mind and Body: The body and the mind are connected. All healing tasks you attempt are eased by two steps. Enabler.

Soothe the Savage (2 Intellect points): You calm a nonhuman beast within 30 feet (9 m). You must speak to it (although it doesn't need to understand your words), and it must see you. It remains calm for one minute or for as long as you focus all your attention on it. The GM has final say over what counts as a nonhuman beast, but unless some kind of deception is at work, you should know whether you can affect a creature before you attempt to use this ability on it. Aliens, extradimensional entities, very intelligent creatures, and robots never count. Action.

Soul Interrogation (5 Intellect points): You determine the weaknesses, vulnerabilities, qualities, and mannerisms of a single creature within long range. The GM should reveal the creature's level, basic abilities, and obvious weaknesses (if any). All actions you attempt that affect that creature—attack, defense, interaction, and so on—are eased for a few months afterward. Action.

Sound Conversion Barrier: Attacks that hit you—especially energy attacks like focused light, heat, radiation, and transdimensional energy—are partially converted to surges of harmless noise similar to the sound of a wave crashing to shore. This ability grants you +1 Armor against all attacks and an additional +2 Armor against energy attacks. Enabler.

Space Fighting: By taking advantage of microgravity conditions, you can use inertia and mass to your advantage. If you spend a round setting up a melee attack (or an attack from a thrown or launched object) while in zero-gravity or low-gravity conditions, the attack inflicts 6 additional points of damage. Enabler.

Speaker for the Dead (2+ Intellect points): You can ask a question of a dead being whose corpse you are touching. Because the answer comes through the filter of the being's understanding and personality, it can't answer questions that it wouldn't have understood in life, and it can't provide answers that it wouldn't have known in life. In fact, the being is not compelled to answer at all, so you might need to interact with it in a way that would have convinced it to answer while it was alive. For each additional Intellect point you spend when you activate the ability, you can ask the being an additional question. Action.

Special Shot: When you hit a target with a gun attack, you can choose to reduce the damage by 1 point but hit the target

in a precise spot. Some of the possible effects include (but are not limited to) the following:

- You can shoot an object out of someone's hand.
- You can shoot the leg, wing, or other limb it uses to move, reducing its maximum movement speed to immediate for a few days or until it receives expert medical care.
- You can shoot a strap holding a backpack, armor, or a similarly strapped-on item so that it falls off.

Enabler.

Specialized Basher: You are specialized in using the stone fists from your Golem Body ability as a medium weapon. Enabler.

Specialized Throwing: You are specialized in attacks with all weapons that you throw. Enabler.

Speed Burst (4 Speed points): You can take two separate actions in this round. In the following round, all actions are hindered. You cannot use this ability two rounds in a row. Enabler.

Speedy Recovery (3 Intellect points): Your words enhance the normal regenerative ability of a character within short range who is able to understand you. When they make a recovery roll, they must spend only half the normal amount of time required to do so (minimum one action). Action.

Spin Attack (5+ Speed points): You stand still and make attacks against up to five foes, all as part of the same action in one round. All of the attacks have to be the same sort of attack (melee or ranged). Make a separate attack roll for each foe. You remain limited by the amount of Effort you can apply on one action. Anything that modifies your attack or damage applies to all of these attacks. In addition to the normal options for using Effort, you can choose to use Effort to increase the number of foes you can attack with this ability (one additional foe per level of Effort used in this way). Action.

Spin Identity (2+ Intellect points): You convince all intelligent creatures who can see, hear, and understand you that you are someone or something other than who you actually are. You don't impersonate a specific individual known to the victim. Instead, you convince the victim that you are someone they do not know belonging to a certain category of people. "We're from the government." "I'm just a simple farmer from the next town over." "Your commander sent me." A disguise isn't necessary, but a good disguise will almost certainly be an asset to the roll involved. If you attempt to convince more than one creature, the Intellect cost increases by 1 point per additional victim. Fooled creatures remain so for up to an hour, unless your actions or other circumstances reveal your true identity earlier. Action.

Spirit Accomplice: A level 3 spirit accompanies you and follows your instructions. The spirit must remain within immediate range—if it moves farther away, it fades at the end of your following turn and cannot return for a day. You and the GM must work out the details of your spirit accomplice, and you'll probably make rolls for it when it takes actions. The spirit accomplice acts on your turn, can move a short distance each round, and exists partially out of phase (allowing it to move through walls, though it makes a poor porter). The spirit takes up residence in an object you designate, and it manifests as either an invisible presence or a ghostly shade. Your spirit accomplice is specialized in one knowledge skill the GM determines.

The spirit is normally insubstantial, but if you use an action and spend 3 Intellect points, it accretes enough substance to affect the world around it. As a level 3 creature with substance,

it has a target number of 9 and a health of 9. It doesn't attack creatures, but while substantial, it can use its action to serve as an asset for any one attack you make on your turn.

While corporeal, the spirit can't move through objects or fly. A spirit remains corporeal for up to ten minutes at a time, but fades back to being insubstantial if not actively engaged. If your spirit accomplice is destroyed, it reforms in 1d6 days, or you can attract a new spirit in 2d6 days. **Enabler.** (An insubstantial creature can't affect or be affected by anything unless indicated otherwise, such as when an attack is made with a special weapon. An insubstantial creature can pass through solid matter without hindrance, but solid energy barriers, such as magical fields of force, keep it at bay.)

Spot Weakness: If a creature that you can see has a special weakness, such as a vulnerability to fire, a negative modification to perception, or so on, you know what it is. (Ask and the GM will tell you.) **Enabler.**

Spray (2 Speed points): If a weapon has the ability to fire rapid shots without reloading (usually called a rapid-fire weapon, such as a crank crossbow or submachine gun), you can spray multiple shots around your target to increase the chance of hitting. This ability uses 1d6 + 1 rounds of ammo (or all the ammo in the weapon, if it has less than the number rolled). You are trained in making this attack. If the attack is successful, it deals 1 less point of damage than normal. You can also use this ability on multiple thrown weapons (stones, shuriken, daggers, and so on) if you're carrying them on your person or they are all within reach. **Action.**

Spring Away (5 Speed points): Whenever you succeed on a Speed defense roll, you can immediately move up to a short distance. You cannot use this ability more than once in a given round. **Enabler.**

Sprint and Grab (2 Speed points): You can run a short distance and make a melee attack to grab a foe of your size or smaller. A successful attack means you grab the foe and bring it to a halt if it was moving (this can be treated as a tackle, if appropriate). **Action.**

Spur Effort (5 Intellect points): You select an ally within immediate range. If that character applies Effort to a task on their next turn, they can apply a free level of Effort on that task. **Enabler.**

Stalker: You gain an asset to all types of movement tasks (including climbing, swimming, jumping, and balancing). **Enabler.**

Stand Watch (2 Intellect points): While standing watch (mostly remaining in place for an extended period of time), you unfailingly remain awake and alert for up to eight hours. During this time, you are trained in perception tasks as well as stealth tasks to conceal yourself from those who might approach. **Action to initiate.**

Stare Them Down: One doesn't play games of chicken with other maniac drivers without gaining mental strength. You're trained in Intellect defense tasks. **Enabler.**

Stasis (3 Intellect points): You surround a foe of your size or smaller with scintillating energy, keeping it from moving or acting for one minute, as if frozen solid. You must be able to see the target, and it must be within short range. While in stasis, the target is impervious to harm, cannot be moved, and is immune to all effects. **Action.**

Stay the Course (5 Intellect points): When your companions are flagging, you can help inspire them with a well-timed word or two. Any ally (except you) within immediate range can make a recovery roll that is not an action and does not count to-

ward their daily limit. **Action.** **Steal Power:** When you use Copy Power to copy an ability, the creature you copied it from loses access to that ability for about a minute. While you have their ability, any attempt by the creature to use their ability requires them to succeed at a task (Might, Speed, or Intellect, as appropriate to the stolen ability) opposed by your eased Intellect task. If they succeed, they regain the use of their ability and you lose it. **Enabler.**

If you want to make it more difficult for someone to take back their stolen power, become skilled in the Steal Power ability, or put a power shift in power for it.

Stealth Skills: You are trained in your choice of two of the following skills: disguise, deception, lockpicking, pickpocketing, seeing through deception, sleight of hand, or stealth. You can choose this ability multiple times, but you must select different skills each time. **Enabler.**

Still As a Statue (5 Might points): Drawing upon the power of your Golem Body, you freeze in place, burying your essence deep in your stone core. During this time, you lose all mobility as well as the ability to take physical actions. You cannot sense what's happening around you, and no time seems to pass for you. While Still As a Statue, you gain +10 to Armor against damage of all sorts. Under normal circumstances, you automatically rouse to normal wakefulness and mobility a day later. If an ally you trust shakes you hard enough (with a minimum cost of 2 Might points), you rouse earlier. **Action to initiate.**

Stimulate (6 Intellect points): Your words encourage a target you touch who can understand you. The next action it takes is eased by three steps. **Action.**

Stone Breaker: Your attacks against objects inflict 4 additional points of damage when you use a melee weapon that you wield in two hands. **Enabler.**

Store Energy: When you drain energy with your focus abilities, you can store some of it for later in a Siphon Pool. You can spend points from your Siphon Pool as if they were from your Might or Speed Pool, or use an action to spend them to restore an equal number of points to your Might or Speed Pool. Your Siphon Pool can safely store up to 3 points; each point beyond that hinders all of your tasks. **Enabler.**

Storm Seed (3 Intellect points): If outside or in a large-enough enclosed space, you can seed a natural storm of a kind common to the area. Doing so requires at least an hour's concentration as you use your connection to the air (whether this is due to nanobots, elemental spirits, magic, or some other source) to initiate proper conditions, though it could take longer if the GM feels there are additional obstacles at play. Once the storm begins, it lasts for about ten minutes. Once during that period, you can create a more dramatic and specific effect appropriate to that kind of storm, such as a lightning strike, a squall of giant hailstones, the brief touchdown of a twister, a single gust of hurricane-force winds, and so on. These effects must occur within long range of your location. You must spend your turn concentrating to create the effect, which occurs a round later. The effect inflicts 6 points of damage, after which the storm begins to disperse. **Action to initiate, an hour or more to complete.** (Storm Seed usually calls thunderstorms, but in an area where stranger weather is common, a Storm Seed could call that instead. For instance, some settings have particular kinds of magical weather.)

Straightforward: You are trained in one of the following tasks (choose one): breaking things, climbing, jumping, or running. **Enabler.**

Strategize (6 Intellect points): Having an action plan in

place before facing a challenge improves the odds of success, even if that plan is eventually changed or discarded once it's put into play. If you and your allies spend at least ten minutes going over a plan of action, all of you gain one free level of Effort that can be applied to one task you attempt during the execution of that plan within the next 24 hours. The plan of action must be something concrete and executable in order to gain this benefit. Action to initiate, ten minutes to complete.

Stronger Together: When you and your companion from the Beast Companion ability are within immediate distance of each other, you inflict 2 additional points of damage when you attack and both of you gain an asset to defense actions. Enabler.

Stun Attack (6 Speed points): You attempt a difficulty 5 Speed task to stun a creature as part of your melee or ranged attack. If you succeed, your attack inflicts its normal damage and stuns the creature for one round, causing it to lose its next turn. If you fail, you still make your normal attack roll, but you don't stun the opponent if you hit. If you also have this ability from another source (such as having it as a type ability and a focus ability), using this costs you only 3 points instead of 6 points. Action.

Sturdy: You are trained in Might defense tasks. Enabler.

Subconscious Defense: Your subconscious constantly runs predictive models for avoiding danger. You gain an asset on your Speed defense tasks. Enabler.

Subsonic Rumble (2 Intellect points): For one minute or until you use some other sound manipulation ability, you emit a subsonic rumble that most living creatures can't hear but which has an effect on them all the same. The effect lasts for one minute and affects all creatures you select within short range. All tasks related to resisting persuasion, intimidation, and fear are hindered by two steps for affected targets. Action to initiate.

Subtle Steps: When you move no more than a short distance, you can move without making a sound, regardless of the surface you move across. Enabler.

Subtle Tricks: You can use your skills and special abilities in ways that don't look like you're doing anything. If the skill or ability would normally require an obvious movement, phrase, or other action by you, it instead seems to happen on its own. Instead of using your tools to pick a lock, the lock clicks open as you stand near it. Instead of manipulating a computer screen, the information you want appears on the screen when you look at it. Instead of bluffing your way past some guards, they step aside as you approach and let you through. This ability usually only works up to an immediate distance. You still must spend points and make rolls to use your skills and abilities with Subtle Tricks. Using a skill or ability in a subtle way hinders the task. This ability can't be used to conceal your attack or defense rolls. Enabler.

Successive Attack (2 Speed points): If you take down a foe, you can immediately make another attack on that same turn against a new foe within your reach. The second attack is part of the same action. You can use this ability with melee attacks and ranged attacks. Enabler.

Suggestion (5+ Intellect points): You suggest an action to a creature within immediate range. If the action is something that the target might normally do anyway, it follows your suggestion. If the suggestion is something that is outside of the target's nature or express duty (such as asking a guard to let an

intruder pass), the suggestion fails. The creature must be level 2 or lower. The effect of your suggestion lasts for up to a minute.

In addition to the normal options for using Effort, you can choose to use Effort to increase the maximum level of the target you can affect by 1. Thus, to affect a level 5 target (three levels above the normal limit), you must apply three levels of Effort.

When the effects of the ability end, the creature remembers following the suggestion but can be persuaded to believe that it chose to do so willingly.

Action to initiate.

Summon Demon (7+ Intellect points): A demon appears within immediate range. If you applied a level of Effort as part of the summoning, the demon is amenable to your instructions; otherwise, it acts according to its nature. Regardless, the demon persists for up to one minute before it fades away—you hope. Action to initiate.

Summon Giant Spider (4+ Intellect points): A giant spider appears within immediate range. If you applied a level of Effort as part of the summoning, the spider is amenable to your instructions; otherwise, it acts according to its nature. Regardless, the creature persists for up to one minute before it fades away. Action to initiate.

Sun Siphon: The safe limit of your Siphon Pool from the Store Energy ability increases by 3 points. If you spend an hour in sunlight (or an hour in contact with a suitable powerful energy source), you automatically fill your Siphon Pool to its safe limit. You can't refill your Siphon Pool this way again until after your next ten-hour recovery roll. Enabler.

Sunlight (3 Intellect points): A mote of light travels from you to a spot you choose within long range. When the mote reaches that spot, it flares and casts bright light in a 200-foot (60 m) radius, and darkness within 1,000 feet (300 m) of the mote becomes dim light. The light lasts for one hour or until you use an action to dismiss it. Action.

Superb Explorer: You are trained in searching, listening, climbing, balancing, and jumping tasks. Enabler.

Superb Infiltrator: You are trained in lockpicking and tinkering with devices in an effort to make them work, or at least work for you. Enabler.

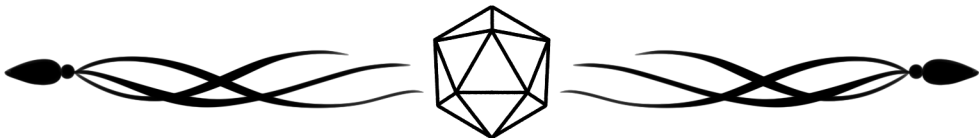
Superior Duplicate (2 Might points): When you use your Duplicate ability, you can create a superior duplicate instead of a normal duplicate. A superior duplicate is a level 3 NPC with 15 health. Enabler.

Surging Confidence (1 Might point): When you use an action to make your first recovery roll of the day, you immediately gain another action. Enabler.

Surprise Attack: If attacking from a hidden vantage, with surprise, or before your opponent has acted, you get an asset on the attack. On a successful hit, you inflict 2 additional points of damage. Enabler.

Swim (1+ Intellect points): You can swim like a fish through water and similar liquid for one hour. For each level of Effort applied, you can extend the duration by one hour. You swim about 10 miles (16 km) per hour, and you are not affected by currents in the water. Action to initiate.

Swipe (1 Speed point): This is a quick, agile melee attack. Your attack inflicts 1 less point of damage than normal but dazes your target for one round, during which time all tasks it performs are hindered. Action.



7.21 Abilities—T

Take Command (3 Intellect points): You issue a specific command to another character. If that character chooses to listen, any attack they attempt on their next turn is eased, and a hit deals 3 additional points of damage. If your command is to perform a task other than an attack, the task is eased as if it benefited from a free level of Effort. Action.

Taking Advantage: When your foe is weakened, dazed, stunned, moved down the damage track, or disadvantaged in some other way, your attacks against that foe are eased beyond any other modifications due to the disadvantage. Enabler.

Tall Tale (3 Intellect points): You tell a short anecdote to a foe that can understand you about something you've witnessed in your life that's so over the top yet so convincing that, if you are successful, the foe is dazed for one minute, during which time its tasks are hindered. Action.

Targeting Eye: You are trained in any physical ranged attack that is a character ability or comes from a device. For example, you are trained when using an Onslaught force blast because it's a physical attack, but not when using an Onslaught mindslice because it's a mental attack. Enabler.

Task Specialization: Choose one task (other than attacks or defense) that you are trained in. You become specialized in that task. (You can instead use this ability as Task Training to become trained in a task you aren't trained in.) Enabler.

Task Training: Choose one task (other than attacks or defense) that you are not trained or specialized in. You become trained in that task. Enabler.

Taunt Foe (4 Might or Intellect points): You can make an attack on a foe as part of drawing an attack (which is not something you can do normally when attempting to draw an attack). In cases where an intelligent or determined foe isn't drawn to you, you can attempt an Intellect action as part of the attack. If that Intellect action is successful, the foe attacks you. Your defenses against that attack are hindered by one step, instead of being hindered by two steps as normal when drawing an attack. Enabler.

Teach Trick (5+ Intellect points): You spend an hour instructing someone on how to perform a type ability that you know. The ability must be no higher than fourth tier. For one hour after you teach them, the student can perform that ability as if it were natural for them. They must pay the Might, Speed, or Intellect cost (if any) to use that ability. The student must be able to understand your instructions. In addition to the normal options for using Effort, you can choose to use Effort to increase how long the student can use the ability or to teach additional students at the same time; each level of Effort used in this way increases the duration by one hour or the number of students by one. One hour to initiate. Action; hour to complete.

Teamwork: Through example, acts of camaraderie, stories of martial prowess, or other forms of instruction, you and your allies work better together as a cohesive unit. During any round in which you rally your team (by spending 2 Intellect points as part of another action), you and your allies inflict 1 additional point of damage in combat. This benefit applies only to allies with whom you have spent the last 24 hours. It ends if you leave, but it resumes if you return to your allies' company within 24 hours. If you leave for more than 24 hours, you must spend another 24 hours together to reactivate the benefit. Enabler.

Tech Skills: You are trained in two skills in which you are not already trained. Choose two of the following: crafting, computers, identifying, machines, piloting, repairing, or vehi-

cle driving. You can select this ability multiple times. Each time you select it, you must choose two different skills. Enabler.

Telekinesis (2 Intellect points): You can exert force on objects within short range. Once activated, your power has an effective Might Pool of 10, a Might Edge of 1, and an Effort of 2 (approximately equal to the strength of a fit, capable adult human), and you can use it to move objects, push against objects, and so on. For example, you could lift and pull a light object anywhere within range to yourself or move a heavy object (like a piece of furniture) about 10 feet (3 m). This power lacks the fine control to wield a weapon or move objects with much speed, so in most situations, it's not a means of attack. You can't use this ability on your own body. The power lasts for one hour or until its Might Pool is depleted, whichever comes first. Action. (If you're using Telekinesis to move an object across the room, and an average fit human could do it with their arms, you can do it with your psychokinesis. You have to use the power's Might Pool, Might Edge, and Effort only if a PC would have to do so, such as if a character tried to push open a barred door.)

Telepathic (1+ Intellect points): You can speak telepathically with others who are within short range. Communication is two-way, but the other party must be willing and able to communicate. You don't have to see the target, but you must know that it's within range. You can have more than one active contact at once, but you must establish contact with each target individually. Each contact lasts up to ten minutes. If you apply a level of Effort to increase the duration rather than ease the task, the contact lasts for 24 hours. Action to establish contact.

Telepathic Network (0+ Intellect points): When you wish it, you can contact up to ten creatures known to you, no matter where they are. All targets must be willing and able to communicate. You automatically succeed at establishing a telepathic network; no roll is required. All creatures in the network are linked and can communicate telepathically with one another. They can also "overhear" anything said in the network, if they wish. Activating this ability doesn't require an action and doesn't cost Intellect points; to you, it's as easy as speaking out loud. The network lasts until you choose to end it. If you spend 5 Intellect points, you can contact twenty creatures at once, and for every 1 Intellect point you spend above that, you can add ten more creatures to the network. These larger networks last for ten minutes. Creating a network of twenty or more creatures does require an action to establish contact. Enabler.

Teleportation (6+ Intellect points): You instantaneously transmit yourself to any location that you have seen or been to, no matter the distance, as long as it is on Earth (or whatever world you're currently on). In addition to the normal options for using Effort, you can choose to use Effort to bring other people with you; each level of Effort used in this way affects up to three additional targets. You must touch any additional targets. Action.

Teleportation Burst (3 Intellect points): You rapidly teleport multiple times in an immediate area, confusing your opponents and allowing you to make an additional melee attack this round. You can use this ability once per round. Enabler. **Teleportive Wound** (7+ Intellect points): You touch a creature and, if your attack succeeds, you teleport away (up to your normal maximum teleportation distance) with a significant portion of their body. If the target is level 2 or lower, it dies. If the target is level 3 or higher, it takes 6 points of damage and is stunned on its next action. If the target is a PC of any tier, they move down one step on the damage track. In addition to the normal

options for using Effort, you can choose to use Effort to affect a more powerful target (one level of Effort means a target of up to level 3 dies or a target of level 4 or higher takes damage and is stunned, and so on). Action.

Telling (2 Intellect points): This ability provides an asset to any tasks for attempting to deceive, persuade, or intimidate. Each use lasts up to a minute; a new use (to switch tasks) replaces the previous use. Action to initiate.

Temporal Acceleration (5 Intellect points): You or one willing creature you touch moves more quickly through time. The effect lasts for one minute. Everything moves more slowly for the affected character, while to all others, the character seems to move at preternatural speed. The character has an asset on all tasks until the effect ends. After the effect ends, the target is exhausted and disoriented by the experience, hindering all tasks for one hour. Action.

Temporal Dislocation (7 Intellect points): You disappear and travel up to one hour into the future or the past. While dislocated in time, you perceive events as they transpire from your position using your normal senses, but you can't interact with or change anything. If you project yourself into the past, you remain there for one hour, at which point you've caught up to the present (to anyone with you in the present, you only seem to flicker out of existence for a moment). If you project yourself into the future, you remain there until the present catches up to you (to anyone with you in the present, you vanish for one hour and reappear in the place you left). Action.

Temporary Light (2 Intellect points): You create an object of solid light in any shape you can imagine that is your size or smaller, and it persists for about a minute (or longer, if you concentrate on it after that time). The object appears in an area adjacent to you, but afterward you can move it up to a short distance each round as part of another action. It is crude and can have no moving parts, so you can make a sword, a shield, a short ladder, and so on. The object has the approximate mass of the real object and is level 2. Action.

Terrifying Gaze (6 Intellect points): You project a chilling gaze at all living creatures within short range who can see you. Make a separate Intellect attack roll for each target. Success means that the creature is frozen in fear, not moving or taking actions for one minute or until it is attacked. Some creatures without minds (such as robots) might be immune to Terrifying Gaze. Action.

Terrifying Image (6 Intellect points): You use a bit of subtle telepathy to learn which images would appear terrifying to creatures that you choose within long range. Those images appear within that area and menace the appropriate creatures. Make an Intellect attack roll against each creature you want to affect. Success means the creature flees in terror for one minute, pursued by its nightmares. Failure means the creature ignores the images, which do not hamper it in any way. Action.

Terrifying Presence (2+ Intellect points): You convince one intelligent target of level 3 or lower that you are its worst nightmare. The target must be within short range and be able to understand you. For as long as you do nothing but speak (you can't even move), the target is paralyzed with fear, runs away, or takes some other action appropriate to the circumstances. In addition to the normal options for using Effort, you can choose to use Effort to increase the maximum level of the target. Thus, to terrorize a level 5 target (two levels above the normal limit), you must apply two levels of Effort. Action.

There's Your Problem: You are trained in tasks related to figuring out how to solve problems with multiple solutions

(like the best way to pack a truck, calm an enraged customer, give a cat a shot of insulin, or find a route through the city for maximum speed). Enabler.

Thief's Luck: Luck is not the chaotic ocean of random chance most people believe it to be. If you fail on a task (including an attack roll or a defense roll), you can change the die result to a natural 20. That still might not be enough to succeed if the difficulty is higher than 6. Once you use this ability, it is not available again until after you make a ten-hour recovery roll. (Thief's Luck doesn't work if you roll a natural 1 for an attempted task, unless you also have and use the ability *Wrest From Chance*.) Enabler.

Think Your Way Out: When you wish it, you can use points from your Intellect Pool rather than your Might Pool or Speed Pool on any noncombat action. Enabler.

Thinking Ahead (variable Intellect points): You produce a remedy that removes a negative condition because you've previously spent considerable time thinking ahead and preparing for your current situation. For instance, if another character is poisoned, you produce an antidote, or if they're blinded, you produce a salve that returns sight (assuming they weren't blinded because their eyes were destroyed). The Intellect cost for using this ability is equal to the level of effect or creature that caused the negative condition. Action.

Third Eye (1 Intellect point): You visualize a place within short range and cast your mind to that place, creating an immobile, invisible sensor for one minute or until you choose to end this ability. While using your third eye, you see through your sensor instead of your eyes using your normal visual abilities. You may perceive the area around your body using your other senses as normal. Action.

Throw (2 Might points): When you are using *Enlarge* and deal damage to a creature of your size or smaller with an unarmed attack, you can choose to throw that creature up to 1d20 feet away from you. The creature lands prone. Enabler.

Throw Enchanted Weapon: You can throw your enchanted weapon up to short range as a light ranged weapon. Whether it hits or misses, it immediately flies back to your hands, and you can automatically catch it or allow it to land at your feet. Enabler. **Throw Force Shield:** You can throw your Force Field Shield up to short range as a light ranged weapon. Whether the shield hits or misses, it immediately dissipates and then reforms in your grasp. Enabler.

Thrust (1 Might point): This is a powerful melee stab. You make an attack and inflict 1 additional point of damage if your weapon has a sharp edge or point. Action.

Thunder Beam (2 Might points): You direct a beam of focused sound at a target within long range, inflicting 2 points of damage and inducing a resonant destructive wave in their body. Each round after this initial attack, you can make another roll for the destructive wave to inflict an additional 1 point of damage to the target. If you fail this roll, the destructive wave ends. Unlike the initial attack, the destructive wave ignores Armor.

Alternatively, you can set up a destructive resonance in a physical melee weapon for one minute or until you let go of it. All attacks made with the target weapon inflict 1 additional point of damage.

Action to initiate.

Time Doppelganger (6+ Intellect points): A perfect copy of you appears within an immediate distance. This doppelganger is probably a version of you from another timeline or the past. The doppelganger is a level 5 NPC with 15 health. It has your mind and memories, and you control it as if it were

you in another body. In effect, while this ability is active, you have two bodies. If the doppelganger uses any of your abilities that cost points, those points come from your Pools (including spending Effort). Controlling two bodies at once is difficult and distracting; while this ability is active, all tasks performed by you or the doppelganger are hindered. The doppelganger has no equipment other than simple clothing.

It remains for up to one minute, but disappears if killed or if you use an action to dismiss it. If the doppelganger is killed, you take 5 points of damage that ignore Armor, and you lose your next action. If you are killed while the doppelganger is present, you live on as the doppelganger (it becomes your character instead of being an NPC that disappears). In addition to the normal options for using Effort, you can choose to use Effort to increase the duration of this ability; each level of Effort used in this way adds one minute to the doppelganger's existence.

If you also have this ability from another source, you may use either ability, the doppelganger is 1 level higher, and it has 3 additional health. Action.

Time Loop (4 Intellect points): You call yourself from a few moments in the future to help you in the present. On the round you use this ability, your future self appears anywhere you choose within immediate range and takes an action. On the second round, you and your future self both take actions, and your future self's action is eased. On the third round, you and your future self both disappear. On the fourth round, you catch up to your future self, reappear wherever your future self initially appeared in the first round, and can take your actions normally.

Your future self shares your stats, so any damage that either of you takes applies to the same stat Pools. If your future self is killed, you and your future self disappear in the third round (as normal) and you reappear, dead, in the fourth round. Neither you nor your future self can use Time Loop again until you reappear as your future self in the fourth round.

Action.

(In effect, Time Loop lets "you" take an action on the round you use it, two actions on the second round, and zero actions on the third round, and then you're back to normal after that.)

Time Travel (10+ Intellect points): You and up to three willing characters you choose within immediate range travel to a point in time that you specify when you use this ability. The point in time must be within ten years of the present. For each level of Effort applied, you can travel ten more years or bring three more creatures with you. When you appear in the new moment in time, you do so in the same position you were in when you used this ability. Upon arriving at your temporal destination, you and the other time travelers are stunned for one minute. In order to return to your original time, you must use this ability again. Action.

Tinker (1 Intellect point): You make a device do something different from its original purpose. For example, a blaster becomes a bomb. A scanner becomes a signal booster for a radio transmitter. A music player becomes a battery for another device. The effective level of the modified device is 1 lower than normal, and the device is rendered unusable (for its original purpose) until repaired. Action to initiate.

Tiny: When you use Shrink, you can choose to shrink down to about one-sixteenth of an inch (.2 cm). When you do, you add 5 more temporary points to your Speed Pool (plus any from Smaller), and because your attacks are concentrated into a very small area, you deal an additional 2 points of damage. For each level of Effort you apply to shrink even more, you become

one-tenth as tall (one one-hundredth for two levels of Effort, one one-thousandth for three, and so on) and you add 1 more point to your Speed Pool. Enabler.

In campaigns where characters can travel to parallel dimensions, using Tiny to shrink to one-thousandth of your normal height may be a means of doing so.

Tool Mastery: When you have an asset from using a tool, the time required to perform the task is cut in half (minimum one round). Enabler.

Total Awareness: You possess such a high level of awareness that it's very difficult to surprise, hide from, or sneak up on you. When you apply a level of Effort to initiative and perception tasks, you gain two free levels of Effort. Enabler.

Totally Chill: Your ten-minute recovery roll takes you only one round. Enabler.

Tough As Nails: When you are impaired or debilitated on the damage track, Might-based tasks and defense rolls you attempt are eased. If you also have Ignore the Pain, make a difficulty 1 Might defense roll when you reach 0 points in all three of your Pools to immediately regain 1 Might point and avoid dying. Each time you attempt to save yourself with this ability before your next ten-hour recovery roll, the task is hindered. Enabler. (A character can't apply Effort or other abilities to any task accomplished using Tough As Nails.)

Tough It Out: Working for a living has toughened you over time. You have +1 to Armor against any kind of physical damage, even damage that normally ignores Armor. Enabler.

Tower of Intellect: You are trained in Intellect defense tasks. If you are already trained, you are specialized in those tasks instead. Enabler.

Tower of Will: You are trained in Intellect defense tasks and gain +3 points to your Intellect Pool. Enabler.

Tracker: You are trained in following and identifying tracks. Enabler.

Trained Basher: You are trained in using the stone fists from your Golem Body as a medium weapon. Enabler.

Trained Excavator: You are trained in perception, climbing, and salvaging tasks. Enabler.

Trained Gunner: You can choose from one of two benefits. Either you are trained in using guns, or you have the Spray ability (which costs 2 Speed points): If a weapon has the ability to fire rapid shots without reloading (usually called a rapid-fire weapon, such as an automatic pistol), you can spray multiple shots around your target to increase the chance of hitting. This move uses 1d6 + 1 rounds of ammo (or all the ammo in the weapon, if it has less than the number rolled). The attack roll is eased. If the attack is successful, it deals 1 less point of damage than normal. Enabler (being trained in using guns) or action (Spray).

Trained Interlocutor: Through wit, charm, humor, and grace (or sometimes rudeness, threatening posture, and obscenity), you're better able to talk others into what you want. You are trained in all interactions. Enabler.

Trained Slayer: You are trained in using swords. Enabler.

Trained Swimmer: While underwater, you are trained in escaping, perception, sneaking, and swimming tasks, as well as in tasks to identify aquatic creatures and geography. Enabler.

Trained Without Armor: You are trained in Speed defense tasks when not wearing armor. Enabler.

Transcend the Script (5 Intellect points): Whether they are lines you wrote, acted, reported on, or otherwise incorporated into your talent, you compose an oratory on the fly that is so wonderful that even you believe it. For each ally who hears

it (and you too), a task attempted within the next hour is eased by two steps. Action.

Trapfinder (3+ Intellect points): You find any traps (like a floor that would give way beneath you) or mechanical triggers to a trap or defense system that might pose a threat. You can do this without setting them off and in lieu of making a roll to find them. This ability can find traps of level 4 or below. In addition to the normal options for using Effort, you can choose to use Effort to increase the level of traps that can be found by 2, so using two levels of Effort can find all traps of level 8 or below. Action.

Trapster: You are trained in creating simple traps for human-sized or smaller targets, especially many varieties of deadfalls and snares using natural objects from the surrounding environment. When you lay a trap, decide whether you want to hold the victim in place (a snare) or inflict damage (a deadfall). Creating a snare is a difficulty 3 task, while the difficulty of creating a deadfall is equal to the number of points of damage you want it to inflict. For example, if you want to inflict 4 points of damage, that's a difficulty 4 task (the training that comes with this ability eases the task). On a success, you create your one-use trap in about one minute, and it is considered level 3 for the purposes of avoiding detection before it is sprung and for a victim trying to struggle free (if a snare).

Action to initiate, one minute or one hour to complete.

Travel Skills: You are trained in two skills in which you are not already trained. Choose two of the following: navigation, riding, running, piloting, or vehicle driving. You can select this ability multiple times. Each time you select it, you must choose two different skills. Enabler.

Traverse the Worlds (8+ Intellect points): You instantaneously transmit yourself to another planet, dimension, plane, or level of reality. You must know that the destination exists; the GM will decide if you have enough information to confirm its existence and the level of difficulty to reach the destination. In addition to the normal options for using Effort, you can choose to use Effort to bring other people with you; each level of Effort used in this way affects up to three additional targets. You must touch any additional targets. Action.

Tree Companion (5+ Intellect points): You animate a tree of approximately your size or smaller, creating a level 3 creature with 1 Armor. The tree follows your verbal commands for one hour, after which it reverts to a normal tree (and roots itself where it stands). Unless the tree is killed by damage, you can animate it again when the ability duration expires, but any damage it has carries over to its newly animated state. In addition to the normal options for using Effort, you can choose to use Effort to affect more trees; each level of Effort used affects one additional tree. Action.

Tree Travel (4+ Intellect points): You enter one tree and instantaneously and safely emerge from another one within long distance. You don't need to specify which tree you're exiting from (if you know there are trees in that direction, you can decide how far to go and you will step out of a tree in that area).

If the starting tree's trunk isn't as large as your body, you must apply a level of Effort to enter it. You can choose to use Effort to increase the distance you travel; one level of Effort used in this way increases the range to very long, two levels raise it to one mile (1.5 km), and each additional level of Effort beyond that increases it by an additional mile. Action.

Trick Driver: While driving a car, truck, or motorcycle, your Might Edge, Speed Edge, and Intellect Edge increase by 1. When you make a recovery roll while driving, you recover 5 additional points. When you attempt a driving task or an extreme trick—such as jumping a ravine or other vehicle, spinning in the air, landing safely on another vehicle, and so on—the task is eased. Enabler.

Trick Shot (2 Speed points): As part of the same action, you make a ranged attack against two targets that are within immediate range of each other. Make a separate attack roll against each target. The attack rolls are hindered. Action.

True Defender (6 Might or Intellect points): This ability functions as the Devoted Defender ability, except the benefit applies to up to three characters you choose. If you choose just one character, you become specialized in the tasks described under the Devoted Defender ability. Action to initiate.

True Guardian (2 Might or Intellect points): When you stand guard as your action, allies within immediate range of you gain an asset to their defense tasks. This lasts until the end of your next turn. Enabler.

True Necromancy (8+ Intellect points): This ability works like the Necromancy ability except that it creates a level 5 creature. Action to animate.

True Senses: You can see in complete darkness up to 50 feet (15 m) as if it were dim light. You recognize holograms, disguises, optical illusions, sound mimicry, and other such tricks (for all senses) for what they are. Enabler.

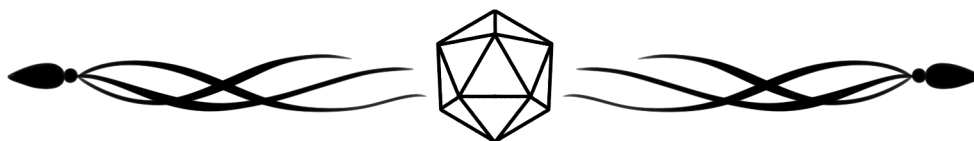
Trust to Luck (3 Intellect points): Sometimes, you've just got to roll the dice and hope things add up in your favor. When you use Trust to Luck, roll a d6. On any even result, the task you're attempting is eased by two steps. On a roll of 1, the task is hindered. Enabler.

Tumbling Moves (5 Speed points): When you use an action to move, Speed defense rolls are eased until the end of your next turn. Enabler.

Twist of Fate: Experience has taught you a lot, including that sometimes luck is something that you have to make for yourself. When you roll a 1, you can reroll. You must use the new result, even if it's another 1. Enabler.

Twisting the Knife (4 Speed points): In a round after successfully striking a foe with a melee weapon, you can opt to automatically deal standard damage to the foe with that same weapon without any modifiers (2 points for a light weapon, 4 points for a medium weapon, or 6 points for a heavy weapon). Action.

Two Things at Once (6 Intellect points): The ultimate test: you divide your attention and take two separate actions this round. Enabler.



7.22 Abilities—U

Ultra Enhancement: You gain +1 to Armor and +5 to each of your three stat Pools. Enabler.

Unarmed Fighting Style: You are trained in unarmed attacks. Enabler.

Unarmored Fighter: While unarmored, you are trained in Speed defense tasks. Enabler.

Uncanny Luck (4 Speed points): When you roll for a task and succeed, roll again. If the second number rolled is higher than the first, you get a minor effect. If you roll the same number again, you get a major effect. If you have Uncanny Luck from another source or a similar ability, it's your choice (no roll required) whether you get a minor effect, a major effect, or a free activation of one of your tier 1–3 focus abilities. Enabler.

Understanding (1 Intellect point): You observe or study a creature or object. Your next interaction with that creature or object gains one asset. Action.

Underworld Contacts: You know many people in a variety of communities who engage in illegal activities. These people are not necessarily your friends and might not be trustworthy, but they recognize you as a peer. You and the GM should work out the details of your underworld contacts. Enabler.

Undo (5 Intellect points): You turn back time a few seconds, effectively undoing a single creature's most recent action. That creature can then immediately repeat the same action or try something different. Action.

Unexpected Betrayal: Within a round or two of successfully using Enthrall, Fast Talk, or a similar ability on a target within short range, the first attack you make on that target is eased by two steps. Once you use Unexpected Betrayal on a target, using your abilities or attempting simple persuasion on that target is permanently hindered by two steps. Enabler.

Unmovable (3 Might points): You avoid being knocked down, pushed back, or moved against your will as long as you are upright and able to take actions. Enabler.

Unraveling Consumption: You can drain energy from a living creature by touching it and concentrating for a minute or more. Each minute you spend in contact with and concentrating on the creature deals it 1 point of damage (ignores Armor) and restores 1 point to your Might or Speed Pool. Because of the extended contact required for this ability, normally you can use it only on a willing or helpless creature. If the creature takes enough damage to knock it unconscious or kill it, it crumbles into ash, dust, or some other inert material. Action to initiate.

Untouchable (6 Intellect points): You change your phase state for the next minute so that you can't affect or be affected by normal matter or energy. Only mental attacks and special

transdimensional energies, devices, or abilities can affect you, but likewise you can't attack, touch, or otherwise affect anything. Action to initiate.

Untouchable While Moving (4 Intellect points): You change your phase state for the next minute so that you can't affect or be affected by normal matter or energy, as long as you move at least an immediate distance each round while phased. If you don't move on your turn, the effect ends. While you are phased, only mental attacks and special transdimensional energies, devices, or abilities can affect you, but likewise you can't attack, touch, or otherwise affect anything. Action to initiate.

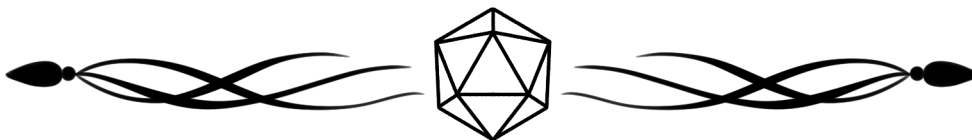
Up to Speed: If you do nothing but move for three actions in a row, you accelerate greatly and can move up to 200 mph (about 2,000 feet each round) for up to ten minutes (about 35 miles), after which you must stop and make a recovery roll. (Move up to 322 kph [about 600 m each round] for up to ten minutes [about 56 km].) Enabler.

Use Senses of Others (4 Intellect points): You can see, hear, smell, touch, and taste through the senses of anyone with whom you have telepathic contact by using Telepathic or similar abilities. You can attempt to use this ability on a willing or unwilling target within long range; an unwilling target can try to resist. You don't need to see the target, but you must know that it's within range. Your shared senses last ten minutes. Action to establish.

Using the Environment (4 Intellect points): You find some way to use the environment to your advantage in a fight. For the next ten minutes, attack rolls and Speed defense rolls are eased. Action to initiate.

Using What's Available (4 Intellect points): If you have the time and the freedom to scrounge for everyday materials in your environment, you can fashion a temporary asset that will aid you once to accomplish a specific task. For example, if you need to climb a wall, you could create some sort of climbing assistance device; if you need to break out of a cell, you can find something to use as a lockpick; if you need to create a small distraction, you could put together something to make a loud bang and flash; and so on. The asset lasts for a maximum of one minute, or until used for the intended purpose. One minute to assemble materials; action to create asset.

Usurp Cypher: Choose one cypher that you carry. The cypher must have an effect that is not instantaneous. You destroy the cypher and gain its power, which functions for you continuously. You can choose a cypher when you gain this ability, or you can wait and make the choice later. However, once you usurp a cypher's power, you cannot later switch to a different cypher—the usurping ability works only once. Action to initiate.



7.23 Abilities—V

Vacuum Skilled: You are trained in two of the following skills: vacuum welding, algae farming, ecosystem design, circuit design, spacecraft maintenance and repair, or some similar skill related to traveling and colonizing planets, moons, and stations located in the solar system. Enabler.

Vanish (2 Intellect points): You become invisible for a short amount of time. While invisible, you have an asset on stealth and Speed defense tasks. The invisibility ends at the end of your next turn, or if you do something to reveal your presence or position—attacking, using an ability, moving a large object, and so on. Action.

Verbal Misdirection (2+ Intellect points): With fast talk and bewildering words, you can confuse and distract anyone that you're speaking with, giving you an asset on social interactions with that person for ten minutes. In addition to the normal options for using Effort, you can choose to use Effort to affect additional creatures (one per level of Effort). Enabler.

Versatile Mind: When you make a Speed defense roll, you can use your Intellect in place of your Speed. Enabler.

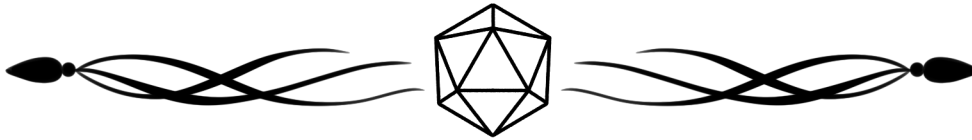
Very Long Sprinting: When you use Phase Sprint, you can travel up to a very long distance as your action instead of a long distance. Enabler.

Vigilance (2 Intellect points): You take a cautious approach to combat, focusing more on protecting yourself than on hurting your opponents. While this ability is active, you gain an asset on Speed defense rolls against melee and ranged attacks, and your melee and ranged attacks are hindered. This effect lasts for as long as you wish, but it ends if no combat is taking place within range of your senses. Action to initiate.

Vigilant (5 Might points): When affected by an attack or effect that would daze or stun you, you are not dazed or stunned. Enabler.

Vindictive Performance (5 Intellect points): When you tell a joke, perform a song or poem, draw a picture, relate an anecdote, or otherwise provide entertainment, you can select one individual from the audience who is able to understand you. During your performance, you heap indirect but biting derision on this target. If you succeed, the target doesn't realize that they've become the victim of your performance until you wrap up the entertainment at a moment you choose in a way that strikes home. The target suffers 6 points of Intellect damage (ignores Armor) and loses their next turn. One or more actions to initiate.

Void Wings (3 Intellect points): Swirling ribbons of weird matter grasp you and lift you up, allowing you to fly for one round as quickly as you can move. Enabler.



7.24 Abilities—W

Walk Through Walls (2 Intellect points): You can slowly pass through physical barriers at a rate of 1 inch (2.5 cm) per round (minimum of one round to pass through any barrier). You can't act (other than moving) or perceive anything until you pass entirely through the barrier. You can't pass through energy barriers. Action.

Wall of Lightning (6 Intellect points): You create a barrier of crackling electricity up to 2,500 square feet (230 sq. m) in size, shaped as you wish. The wall is a level 7 barrier. Anyone within immediate distance of the wall automatically takes 10 points of damage. The wall lasts for one hour. Action to create.

Wall With Teeth: You inflict 2 additional points of damage with all attacks when using your Living Wall ability. Enabler. **War Flesh:** You can instantly transform your hands and feet into claws, and your human teeth into fangs, or revert to your normal human appearance. When you make attacks with your claws or fangs, they count as medium weapons instead of light weapons. Enabler.

Ward: You have a shield of energy around you at all times that helps deflect attacks. You gain +1 to Armor. Enabler.

Warding Shield: You have +1 to Armor while you are using a shield. Enabler.

Water Adaptation: You can breathe water as easily as you breathe air. Enabler.

Weapon and Body (5 Speed points): After making a melee weapon or ranged weapon attack, you follow up with a punch or kick as an additional attack, all as part of the same action in one round. The two attacks can be directed at different foes. Make a separate attack roll for each attack. You remain limited by the amount of Effort you can apply on one action. Anything that modifies your attack or damage applies to both attacks, unless it is tied specifically to your weapon. Action.

Weapon Crafter: You are trained in crafting tasks associated with your chosen weapon. For instance, if your weapon is a bow, you are trained in tasks related to crafting bows and fletching arrows; if your weapon is a sword, you are trained in tasks for forging swords and sharpening blades; and so on. Enabler.

Weapon Defense: While your chosen weapon is in your hand(s), you are trained in Speed defense rolls. Enabler.

Weapon Master: You inflict an additional 1 point of damage with your chosen weapon. Enabler.

Weaponization: One light or medium melee weapon of your choice is built into your body, and you are trained in using it. The weapon is concealed until you wish to use it. Enabler.

Wear It Well: When you wear armor of any kind, you gain an additional +1 to Armor. Enabler.

Weather the Vicissitudes: Helping your friends means being able to stand up to everything the world throws at you. You have +1 to Armor. Also, you resist heat, cold, and similar extremes and have an additional +1 to Armor against ambient damage or other damage that would normally ignore Armor. Enabler.

Weight of the World (6+ Intellect points): You can increase a target's weight dramatically. The target is pulled to the ground and can't move physically under its own power for one minute. The target must be within short range. In addition to the normal options for using Effort, you can choose to use Effort to affect additional creatures (one per level of Effort). Action.

Weightless Shot: You have a sixth sense when it comes to lining up trajectories and moving in low-gravity and zero-gravity environments, which also translates to making ranged attacks. When you hit a target with a ranged attack in micro-gravity conditions, you can choose to reduce the damage by 2 points but hit the target in a precise spot. Some of the possible effects include (but are not limited to) the following:

- You punch a hole in the target's suit, so it begins to leak air into the vacuum slowly, or all at once (your choice).
- You hit the reaction mass of the target's maneuvering pack, which means the target can no longer change their trajectory, or they go spinning off in a random direction (your choice).
- You can shoot a spacecraft, and degrade one ship system by one step (systems include engines, weapons, and atmosphere).

Enabler.

Weighty (1 Intellect point): You briefly increase the weight of a target within short range enough to stop them in their tracks, preventing the target from moving and hindering any attempted tasks on their next turn. Action.

Weird Science Breakthrough (5+ Intellect points): Your research leads to a breakthrough, and you imbue an object with a truly amazing property, though you can use the item only once. To do so, you must buy spare parts equivalent to an expensive item, have a field science kit (or a permanent lab, if you have access to one), and succeed at a difficulty 4 Intellect-based roll to create a random manifest cypher of up to level 2. The GM decides the nature of the cypher you create. Attempting to create a specified cypher hinders the task by two steps. Creating a cypher does not allow you to surpass your normal cypher limit. In addition to the normal options for using Effort, you can choose to use Effort to increase the level of the cypher you create; each level of Effort increases the level of the cypher and the difficulty of the Intellect task to create it. Action to initiate, one hour to complete.

Whirlwind of Throws (5 Speed points): With a large handful of small objects—tiny knives, shuriken, stones, jagged bits of metal, coins, or whatever is on hand—you attack every creature in an immediate area within short range. You must make attack rolls against each target. Each attack is hindered. You inflict 3 points of damage on targets you hit. Action.

Wild Camouflage (4 Intellect points): By drawing your clothing about you just so and using various tricks and your deep knowledge of your surroundings, you become invisible in the wilderness for ten minutes. While you are invisible, this asset eases your stealth and Speed defense tasks by two steps. This effect ends if you do something to reveal your presence or position—attacking, using an ability, moving a large object, and so on. If this occurs, you can regain the remaining invisibility effect by taking an action to focus on hiding your position. Action to initiate or reinitiate.

The Wild Is on Your Side (5 Intellect points): While you're in the wilderness, foes within short range are tripped by rocks, tangled in vines, bitten by insects, and distracted or confused by small animals, which hinders all their tasks for ten minutes. Action to initiate.

Wild Insight: You gain a momentary perfect understanding of the flow of magic around you at this moment. When preparing your magic, choose one specific subtle cypher and make a magical lore skill roll against level 6. If you succeed,

you gain that subtle cypher (the cypher's level is 6); if you fail, you get a random subtle cypher. If you aren't sure what specific subtle cypher you want, you can ask for a broad category such as "healing," "movement," or "skill"; this eases the magical lore task, and if you succeed, the GM chooses a random cypher that fits that category. You can't use this ability again until after you've taken a ten-hour recovery action. Enabler.

Wild Vitality (4 Intellect points): You attune with the life force of a natural creature (your size or bigger) within long range that you can see. This is a level 2 Intellect task. If you succeed, the creature is not harmed, but through resonance with its wild vitality, you gain several benefits for up to one minute: an asset to all your Might-based tasks (including attacks and defenses), +2 to your Might Edge and Speed Edge, and 2 additional points of damage on all successful melee attacks. Action to initiate.

Wildcard Powers: You have a gift with using copied powers in unusual ways. Whenever you try a power stunt and use a level of Effort on the special roll to modify the ability, you get a free level of Effort on that roll. Enabler.

Wilderness Awareness (4 Intellect points): Your connection to the natural world extends to a degree that some would call supernatural. While in the wilderness, you can extend your senses up to a mile in any direction and ask the GM a very simple, general question about that area, such as "Where is the orc camp?" or "Is my friend Deithan still alive?" If the answer you seek is not in the area, you receive no information. Action.

Wilderness Encouragement (3 Intellect points): While in the wilderness, or when talking about your time in the wilderness, your stirring words of encouragement grant a target within short range that can understand you 1d6 points to one Pool. You can't use this ability on the same creature again until they've made a recovery roll. Action.

Wilderness Explorer: While taking any action (including fighting) in the wild, you ignore any penalties due to natural causes such as tall grass, thick brush, rugged terrain, weather, and so on. Enabler.

Wilderness Life: You are trained in two of the following: climbing, swimming, navigation, or identifying plants and creatures. Enabler.

Wilderness Lore: You are trained in wilderness navigation and in identifying plants and creatures. Enabler.

Will of a Leader (9 Intellect points): You harden your allies' dedication and capabilities. Each ally within immediate range gains +1 Edge to one stat of their choice for one hour. You also gain this benefit to one stat of your choice. Action.

Will of Legend: You are immune to attacks that would captivate, mesmerize, charm, or otherwise influence your mind. Enabler.

Willing Sacrifice: When you take an attack meant for another character, you know how to take the attack in a way that minimizes its effect. The attack automatically strikes you, but instead of taking 1 additional point of damage, you take 1 less point of damage (to a minimum of 1 point). Additionally, you can take more than one attack in a given round provided that all the attacks were originally meant for one target. Enabler. (Two characters attempting to draw an attack at the same time cancel each other out.)

Wind Armor (1 Intellect point): When you wish it, a cyclone of wind surrounds your body for ten minutes, giving you +1 to Armor and an additional +2 to Armor against physical projectile weapons specifically. While the cyclone is active, you feel no discomfort from the wind, and you can interact with

other creatures and objects normally because the wind flow automatically diverts to enable such interaction. Enabler.

Wind Chariot (7+ Intellect points): You summon winds that pick you up and allow you to fly for up to a long distance each round in combat or with an overland speed of up to 200 miles per hour (320 kph) for up to ten hours. For each level of Effort you apply, you can bring one ally of about your size with you through the air or increase the duration of the effect by one hour. Action to initiate.

Windrider (4+ Intellect points): You summon winds that pick you up and allow you to fly for one minute at a rate of up to a long distance each round. For each level of Effort you apply, you can carry one ally of about your size with you through the air or increase the duration of the effect by one minute. Action to initiate.

Windracked Traveler (4+ Intellect points): You condense a wide wing of dark matter that can carry you through the air for a period of up to one hour. For each level of Effort applied, you can add one hour to the duration or carry one additional creature of your size or smaller. You must touch the additional creatures for them to be tucked under your wing. They must remain relatively still while the wing lasts or they will fall. In terms of overland movement, you fly at about 20 miles (32 km) per hour and are not affected by terrain. Action to initiate.

Wings of Fire (4 Intellect points): While your Shroud of Flame is active, you can spread wings of fire and can levitate, moving at a rate of up to 20 feet (6 m) per round in any direction for one minute. You can also take one other non-movement action on your turn. Action.

Wing Weapons: You can use your wings to make melee attacks (even when flying), leaving your hands and feet free. Your wings are medium bashing or bladed weapons (your choice). You are practiced with this attack. Enabler.

Winter Gauntlets: When you use Frost Touch, you inflict an additional 3 points of damage if you touch a creature, or an additional 2 points of damage if you infuse a weapon. In addition, damaged targets are frozen in place (if standing on a solid surface) and can't move from their location until they use an action to break free. The target can still attack and defend. Action for touch; enabler for weapon.

Wooden Body (1+ Might points): You transform your body into living wood for ten minutes, which grants you several benefits. You gain +1 to Armor and you are practiced in using your limbs as medium weapons. You need about one-tenth as much air as a human. Hiding among trees or on a tree is eased. However, in your wooden form you move more stiffly than a creature of flesh, hindering your Speed defense rolls. Action to change or revert.

Your wooden body might be smooth like a polished board, rough like tree bark, or a mix of both.

Word of Command (6 Intellect points + level 6 cypher): You utter a word so powerful that to fully invest it, you sacrifice a cypher in your possession that is level 6 or higher. You issue the word to one creature within long range that you can see. The affected target must obey the command for several hours before it is free to act as it wishes. Targets that are attacked while under the effect of the command can defend themselves. Typical commands include "retreat," "calm," "come," and "stay." The GM decides how the target acts once a command is given. Action.

Word of Death (5+ Intellect points): Your attack is the utterance of a magic word so terrible that it snuffs the life from a living target within short range. The target must be level 1. In

addition to the normal options for using Effort, you can choose to use Effort to increase the maximum level of the target. Thus, to kill a level 5 target (four levels above the normal limit), you must apply four levels of Effort. Action.

Work the Friendship (4 Intellect points): You know just what to say to draw a little extra effort from an ally. This grants one creature you choose within short range an additional, immediate action, which it can take out of turn. The creature uses the additional action however it wishes. Action.

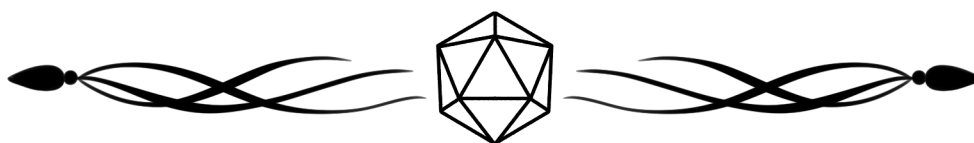
Wormhole (6 Intellect points): You create a doorway through time and space. The shortcut manifests as a hole in reality large enough to accommodate you and creatures of your size or smaller. One side of the doorway appears anywhere within immediate range, and the other side opens at a spot you choose anywhere within long range. Any character or object moving into one side exits from the other. The door remains open for one minute or until you use an action to close it. Action to initiate.

Wound Tender: You are trained in healing. Enabler.

Wraith Cloak: At your command, the spirit from your Spirit Accomplice ability wraps itself around you for up to ten minutes. The spirit automatically inflicts 4 points of damage to anyone who tries to touch you or strike you with a melee attack. While the wraith cloak is active, all tasks to evade the perceptions of others are eased. Enabler.

Wreck: Using two hands, you wield a weapon or a tool with a powerful swing. (If fighting unarmed, this attack is made with both fists or both feet together.) When using this as an attack, you take a –1 penalty to the attack roll, and you inflict 3 additional points of damage. When attempting to damage an object or barrier, you are trained in the task. Action.

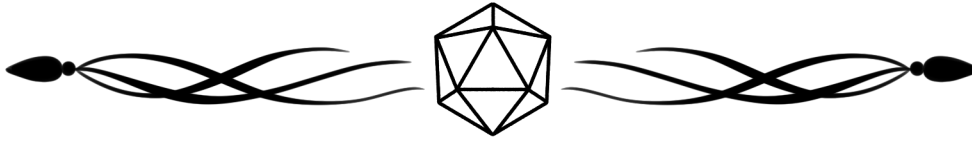
Wrest From Chance: If you roll a natural 1 on a d20, you can reroll the die. If you reroll, you avoid a GM intrusion—unless you roll a second 1—and might succeed on your task. Once you use this ability, it is not available again until after you make a ten-hour recovery roll. Enabler.



7.25 Abilities—Y

You Studied: To be able to put two and two together to reach a deduction, you have to know a few things. You are trained in

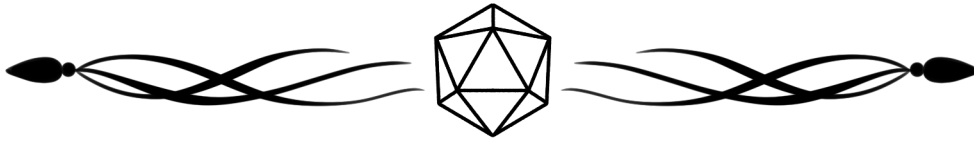
two areas of knowledge of your choosing (as long as they are not physical actions or combat related) or specialized in one area. Enabler.



7.26 Abilities—Z

Zero Dark Eyes: Some people's eyes are degraded by constantly playing games. And maybe that'll happen to you, but

not yet. You're still young and instead of degrading, your vision is actually better thanks to all your practice. You can see in very dim light as though it were bright light. You can see in total darkness as if it were very dim light. Enabler.



Chapter 8

Equipment

Equipment in the Cypher System plays only a small role. It's far more important to focus on what you can do than on what you have. Still, sometimes it's important to know if you've got enough rope, or what kind of gun your space pilot has at their hip.

8.1 Currency and Prices

Dollars, pounds, euros, credits, gold pieces, Martian solval beads, Corso moons and stars, bottle caps—a lot of different currencies might be used in your game, depending on the setting and the genre. You should use whatever you like. In the Cypher System rules, we talk in generalities rather than specifics. Not unlike saying immediate or short distance rather than giving precise numbers, we talk about goods and services in terms of inexpensive, moderately priced, expensive, very expensive, or exorbitant.

The GM can figure out what those things mean in their setting. In a fantasy setting, an inexpensive item might be 1 or 2 copper pennies, while an expensive item might require gold on the table. The exact amount can vary, and in many campaigns, the exact amount will matter. The GM will develop a detailed price list for their setting, and players will track their money on their character sheets to determine what they can afford, often ignoring the terms inexpensive, moderately priced, and so on.

But some GMs might want to keep things simple and use only the general terms, indicating currency just as flavor now and then. In a space opera game, where the PCs are the crew of a starship blazing about the galaxy in search of adventure and profit, fuel and upkeep for the ship might be expensive. Hauling a few passengers from Epsilon Eridani back to Earth might earn enough to purchase six expensive items but cost the equivalent of two expensive items, leaving the crew with the means to refuel and maintain the ship for two further voyages. In such a game, where money only means keeping the ship flying, no one has to talk in specific amounts. Characters might refer to “galactic credits” or something similar, but amounts might not be tracked on the character sheets.

8.2 Price Categories

There are five price categories for goods and services.

An inexpensive item is something that common people buy. A simple meal or a drink in the bar. A pen and some paper. A book or magazine.

A moderately priced item is something that common people buy, but not too often and not in great quantities. A small

piece of furniture. A major entertainment. An expensive meal. A new outfit.

An expensive item is something that would strain a common person's finances. Rent on a simple apartment. A major piece of furniture. A very nice outfit. The cost to travel a long distance (if appropriate to the setting).

A very expensive item is probably out of the reach of most people except in very special circumstances. Jewelry. Luxury furnishings.

An exorbitant item is something only the very rich can afford. A very nice house. A ship. Extremely expensive jewelry or art.

Think of the categories as powers of 10. That is to say, a moderately priced item is ten times more costly than an inexpensive item. An expensive item is ten times more costly than a moderately priced item, and thus 100 times the cost of something inexpensive. A very expensive item is ten times the cost of an expensive one, 100 times the cost of a moderate one, and 1,000 times the cost of an inexpensive one. An exorbitant item is priced ten times beyond that.

(In some settings, even the generalization offered by the pricing categories might be too specific or cumbersome. In many superhero games, for example, prices are relatively moot. After saving the city, typical superheroes don't worry about paying rent or how much dinner will cost. On the other hand, in a grittier superhero game, maybe that's exactly what they worry about.)

8.3 Using The Price Categories

Regardless of how precise you want to be with prices and currency, you can use the price categories in a variety of ways.

It's easy for a GM to say to a player “You can afford two extra moderately priced things at the start of the game.” The player can look on the list and pick two moderately priced items without worrying about their cost. Plus, this approach makes it clear that they get two items, not twenty inexpensive items or one more expensive item that perhaps would not be appropriate for a starting character. The categories make it easy to lump similar items together.

The GM can also say “You can have whatever inexpensive items you want, and don't worry about the cost.” At higher tiers, when the PCs have more wealth, followers, and so on, the GM can do this with moderate or even expensive items. This allows the group to skip over playing through a shopping trip to get supplies, and players don't have to track prices down to the last coin.

Finally, the categories can be shorthand when evaluating loot, dividing up the spoils among the PCs, and resolving other story-based occurrences that crop up in the game without dealing in the minutiae of exact prices. This is of particular use in high-powered games where the PCs are rich and powerful.

8.4 Level of Equipment

Mundane equipment is about level 4—less if of inferior quality or materials, more if of superior quality or materials. This means that in a setting based on the distant past, the default level might be 3, while in the future it might be 5 or 6. So an average serf's tool in the Dark Ages is level 3, easily broken, while an average tool on a space station is level 6, made of advanced polymers.

8.5 Armor

Characters expecting danger frequently wear armor. Even the simplest protective covering helps against stabs and cuts, and more sophisticated or heavier armor protects against graver threats.

You can wear only one type of armor at a time—you cannot wear chainmail hauberk and scale armor together, for example. However, Armor bonuses from multiple sources combine to provide a total Armor rating. For example, if you have subdermal implants that give you +1 to Armor, a force field that offers another +1 to Armor, and beastskin that grants +2 to Armor, you have a total of +4 to Armor.

In general, light armor is a moderately priced item, medium armor is expensive, and heavy armor is very expensive. The Genre chapter offers more specific details on the kinds of armor available in a given setting. Keep in mind that in many

genres, it’s quite odd, at best, to run around in armor tougher than a leather jacket.

8.5.1 Using Armor

Anyone can wear any armor, but it can be taxing. Wearing armor increases the cost of using a level of Effort when attempting a Speed-based action. So if you’re wearing light armor and want to use two levels of Effort on a Speed-based roll to run across difficult terrain, it costs 7 points from your Speed Pool rather than 5 (3 for the first level of Effort, plus 2 for the second level of Effort, plus 1 per level for wearing light armor). Edge reduces the overall cost as normal. If you are not experienced with a certain type of armor but wear it anyway, this cost is further increased by 1. Having experience with a type of armor is called being practiced with the armor.

Table 8.1: Armor Additional Speed Effort

Armor	Speed Effort Additional cost per level
Light	+1
Medium	+2
Heavy	+3

8.5.2 Fantasy Armor Descriptions

You can wear only one kind of armor at a time (wearing more than one only gives the Armor from the best one and the Speed Effort cost of the worst one).

Beastskin: An improved form of hides and furs, usually crafted from a creature with especially tough skin such as a giant lizard or rhinoceros.

Breastplate: A fitted metal plate or set of plates that protect your torso but not your arms or legs, giving you greater movement than full plate at the cost of some protection.

Brigandine: Long strips of metal attached to a cloth or leather backing. Often called “splint mail.”

Chainmail: Mail armor made from hundreds of interlocking metal rings or links. Often called “chain” or “chain armor.”

Dwarven breastplate: A high-quality breastplate crafted by a skilled dwarf, providing good protection and great mobility. Dwarven breastplate is medium armor (2 Armor) but encumbers the wearer as if it were light armor (it has a Speed Effort cost of 1). Not all dwarf-crafted breastplates count as this type of armor (only exceptionally skilled dwarven smiths know how to make it).

Elven chainmail: A high-quality suit of chainmail crafted by a skilled elf, providing good protection and excellent mobility. Elven chainmail is medium armor (2 Armor) but is no more encumbering than a typical outfit of normal clothing (it has no Speed Effort cost). Not all elf-crafted chainmail counts as this type of armor (only exceptionally skilled elven smiths know how to make it).

Full plate: A complete suit of fitted metal plates that give excellent coverage and protection against attacks. The joints are protected by small layered plates over flexible chain. Some-

times called “plate mail.”

Heavy cloth: Clothing that’s heavy enough to reduce the effect of attacks against you, such as winter clothing or a fashionable leather outfit. Heavy cloth provides 1 Armor against piercing or slashing attacks like arrows and swords, but not bashing attacks like clubs or hammers. Heavy cloth doesn’t have a Speed Effort cost. It can’t be worn with other kinds of armor.

Hides and furs: Made from thick or poorly cured animal skins. It’s heavier and bulkier than other kinds of leather armor, but easier to make, especially by resource-poor crafters.

Leather jerkin: Armor made of hardened pieces of leather (usually boiled or treated with chemicals) that mainly covers your torso. It’s stiffer than leather used for clothing, but still flexible enough that you can bend and twist in it. Some jerkins are reinforced with metal studs (and may be called “studded leather”), and brigandine improves upon that concept.

Padded: Cloth armor that is deliberately designed with multiple layers to be thick and protective. This is sometimes called “quilted armor” because it is a layer of padding sewn between two layers of cloth. Padded armor provides 1 Armor against piercing or slashing attacks like arrows and swords, but not bashing attacks like clubs or hammers. Padded armor doesn’t have a Speed Effort cost. It can’t be worn with other kinds of armor.

Scale: Mail armor made from overlapping scales or plates attached to a leather or cloth backing. Often called “scale mail.”

Shield: Provides an asset to Speed defense. Shield sizes vary from a small buckler to a large kite shield (in the Cypher System, the difference is mainly flavor, and for game purposes they all grant the wearer the same benefit).

Table 8.2: Armor Info

Light Armor	Armor	Speed Effort Additional Cost	Price
Heavy cloth	1*	0	3 gp
Hides and fur	1	1	10 gp
Leather jerkin	1	1	10 gp
Padded	1*	0	5 gp
Medium Armor	Armor	Speed Effort Additional Cost	Price
Beastskin	2	2	10 gp
Breastplate	2	2	400 gp
Brigandine	2	2	200 gp
Chainmail	2	2	75 gp
Dwarven breastplate	2	1	8 000 gp
Elven chainmail	2	0	8 000 gp
Heavy Armor	Armor	Speed Effort Additional Cost	Price
Full plate	3	0	1 500 gp
Scale	3	0	50 gp
Shield	asset**		10gp

* Only against piercing and slashing attacks

** Using a shield provides the wearer with an asset on Speed defense tasks

If the GM prefers the simpler method of not tracking whether an attack is bashing, slashing, or stabbing, heavy cloth and padded armor should provide no Armor at all.

Shields

Shields provide an asset to Speed defense rolls. You must have one free hand to use a shield.

8.6 Weapons

Not all characters are familiar with all weapons. Warriors know their way around most types, but Explorers prefer light or medium weapons, and Adepts and Speakers usually stick to light weapons. If you wield a weapon that you have no experience with, an attack with that weapon is hindered. Having experience with a weapon is called being practiced with the weapon.

Light weapons inflict only 2 points of damage, but attacks with them are eased because they are fast and easy to use. Light weapons are punches, kicks, knives, handaxes, darts, very small pistols, and so on. Weapons that are particularly small are light weapons.

Medium weapons inflict 4 points of damage. Medium weapons include broadswords, battleaxes, maces, crossbows, spears, typical handguns, light rifles, sawed-off shotguns, and so on. Most weapons are medium. Anything that could be used in one hand (even if it's often used in two hands, such as a quarterstaff or spear) is a medium weapon.

Heavy weapons inflict 6 points of damage, and you must use two hands to attack with them. Heavy weapons are huge swords, great hammers, massive axes, halberds, heavy crossbows, rifles, regular shotguns, assault rifles, and so on. Anything that must be used in two hands is a heavy weapon.

Table 8.3: Weapon Damage

Weapon	Damage
Light	2 points (attack eased)
Medium	4 points
Heavy	6 points

In general, light weapons are moderately priced items, medium weapons are expensive, and heavy weapons are very expensive. Ammunition for a ranged weapon is inexpensive. The Genre chapter offers more specific details on weapons available in a given setting. Keep in mind that in many genres, it's not acceptable to run around carrying dangerous weapons.

8.6.1 Fantasy Weapons Descriptions

Battleaxe: A wooden pole with a blade on one end.

Blowgun: A long hollow tube used to shoot darts. You can fire it with one hand, but you need two hands to load it.

Bow: A bent piece of flexible wood with a taut string con-

nected to each end. It fires arrows. You need two hands to fire it.

Broadsword: A long-bladed sword, longer than a dagger, heavier than a rapier, but not as large as a greatsword.

Club: A simple bludgeon, such as a sturdy tree branch, board, or improvised weapon.

Crank crossbow: A weapon similar to a light crossbow, but it has a magazine that holds five bolts. You turn a small crank to advance to the next bolt (this is not an action). Action to load an empty magazine with five bolts, action to reload the crossbow with a new magazine. It can be used as a rapid-fire weapon.

Dagger: A very short blade for stabbing or slicing.

Flail: A handle with a chain on one end and a ball or spiked ball at the end of the chain.

Greataxe: A larger, heavier version of the battleaxe, sometimes with two opposing blades instead of one.

Greatsword: A two-handed version of the broadsword.

Hammer: A wooden handle with a heavy metal head, either one-sided (like a carpenter's hammer) or two-sided (like a sledgehammer).

Hand crossbow: A smaller and weaker version of a light crossbow. It fires crossbow bolts. You can fire it with one hand. You need two hands to load it.

Handaxe: A light, one-handed axe that's good for melee or throwing.

Heavy crossbow: A heavier, more powerful version of a light crossbow. You need two hands to fire or load it. Action to reload.

Heavy mace: A larger, two-handed version of a mace.

Javelin: A light spear that's designed to be thrown.

Light crossbow: A bow with a handle and mechanism for drawing and holding the string. It fires crossbow bolts. You can fire it with one hand. You need two hands to load it. Action to reload. **Mace:** A wooden handle with a heavy metal head that's spherical, flanged, or knobbed.

Maul: A larger version of the hammer, such as a sledgehammer.

Net: A net designed for battle rather than fishing. It has metal hooks at each intersection to help catch your enemy. You can throw it with one hand. Action to refold it so it can be thrown again. If you hit an opponent with the net, all of their

physical actions are hindered until they take an action to remove it.

Pick: A hafted weapon with a sideways metal spike on the end, similar to a miner's tool.

Polearm: Various kinds of spears, sometimes with hooks or additional blades for special purposes like tripping a foe or pulling an opponent from their mount.

Quarterstaff: A wooden pole about 4 to 5 feet (1.2 to 1.5 m) long.

Rapier: A light sword with a thin blade used for stabbing and slashing.

Scimitar: A medium-length sword with a strongly curved blade.

Sickle: A one-handed hafted weapon with a sharply curved blade, originally used for harvesting crops but adapted for use as a weapon.

Sling: A small pouch connected to two cords. You put a stone or bullet (metal slug) in the pouch, hold the end of the cords, spin it, and let go of one of the cords to hurl the projectile. You can fire it with one hand. You need two hands to load it. Action to reload.

Spear: A one-handed pole about 3 to 5 feet (1 to 1.5 m) long with a stabbing blade on the end.

Throwing dart: A very short, light spear meant to be thrown rather than used in melee.

Trident: A three-pronged spear, often used for spear fishing.

Unarmed: A typical punch, kick, or other weaponless attack.

Whip: A leather cord with a handle, used more for tricks and inflicting punishments than for deadly combat.

Table 8.4: Weapons Details

Weapon	Price	Notes
Light Weapons (2 points of damage)		
Blowgun	5 gp	Short range
Blowgun darts (20)	1 gp	
Dagger	2 gp	Can be thrown up to short range
Hand crossbow	75 gp	Short range
Crossbow bolts (20)	1 gp	
Handaxe	5 gp	Can be thrown up to short range
Net	1 gp	Can be thrown up to short range
Rapier	25 gp	
Sickle	1 gp	Short range
Sling	1 sp	Short range
Sling bullets (20)	5 cp	
Throwing dart	5 cp	Short range
Unarmed (punch, kick, etc.)	-	
Whip	2 gp	
Medium Weapons (4 points of damage)		
Battleaxe	10 gp	
Bow	30gp	Long range
Arrows (20)	1 gp	
Broadsword	15 gp	
Club	1 sp	
Crank crossbow	250 gp	Long range
Crossbow bolts (20)	1 gp	
Light crossbow	25 gp	Long range
Crossbow bolts	1 gp	
Continued on the next page		

Table 8.4		
Weapon	Price	Notes
Flail	10 gp	
Hammer	15 gp	
Javelin	5 gp	Can be thrown up to long range
Mace	10 gp	
Pick	10 gp	
Polearm	10 gp	
Quarterstaff	2 sp	
Scimitar	25 gp	
Spear	1 gp	Can be thrown up to long range
Trident	5 gp	
Heavy Weapons (6 points of damage)		
Greataxe	30 gp	
Greatsword	50 gp	
Heavy crossbow	50 gp	Long range
Crossbow bolts (20)	1 gp	
Heavy mace	16 gp	
Maul	10 gp	

8.6.2 Explosive Weapons

Bombs, grenades, missiles, and other explosives operate differently than other weapons. They affect all targets within an area (usually an immediate area) and inflict damage to all of them. A separate attack roll is required for each (or a Speed defense roll if the PCs are the targets of such an attack), although to simplify, the player can make one attack roll and compare it to the difficulty to attack each target. Usually, even if the attack roll fails (or the Speed defense roll succeeds), the targets still suffer a smaller amount of damage, often 1 point.

Explosives like grenades can be thrown a short distance. Otherwise, another launcher weapon is needed to project them a long distance (or farther).

8.7 Adventuring Equipment Descriptions

Acid: A flask of strong acid. Can be thrown up to short range, inflicting acid damage as a light weapon (ignores Armor). If poured carefully, it can damage or destroy a small item or areas made of stone or metal.

Adventuring pack: Includes 50 feet (15 m) of rope, three days' iron rations, three spikes, small hammer, a set of warm clothes, boots, and three torches.

Alchemist fire: A flask of chemicals that burst into flames upon contact with air. The flames burn out after one round. Can be thrown up to short range, inflicting fire damage as a light weapon (ignores Armor).

Alchemist tools: A sturdy wooden case with tiny flasks, stirring rods, droppers, and other materials used in alchemy. It grants an asset for identifying potion cyphers and similar mysterious liquids.

Bag of heavy tools: Contains a hammer, six spikes, crowbar, large tongs, chisel, and 10 feet (3 m) of strong rope.

Bag of light tools: Contains a small hammer, small tongs, pliers, small pry bar, awl, lockpicks, 10 feet (3 m) of string, 3 feet (1 m) of metal wire, and a handful of nails.

Battering ram: This sturdy plank is capped with hard metal. It provides an asset for breaking down doors.

Book: A book with information on a particular topic, such

as geography, history, magic, or religion. Provides an asset on appropriate rolls if the character reads or skims the book for at least ten minutes before attempting the task (this assumes the character has already read the book and is looking for relevant information).

Caltrops, bag: A bag of hard things you scatter on the ground to slow or injure anyone walking through an area. One bag covers an immediate area and makes that area count as difficult terrain. A creature can safely move through it as if it were difficult terrain (half speed). If a creature moves through the area at normal speed, they must make a difficulty 2 Speed defense roll or take 2 points of Speed damage (ignores Armor).

Candle: A candle burns for one hour and creates dim light in an immediate area.

Climbing kit: A set of crampons, pitons, ropes, and tools. Provides an asset on climbing tasks.

Crowbar: This bent length of metal grants an asset on tasks to open doors, treasure chests, and similar objects.

Disguise kit: Makeup, simple prosthetics, and a wig or two, suitable for disguises for a theatrical production. Provides an asset on disguise tasks. Some parts are reusable, but the kit runs out after about five uses.

Healing kit: A collection of bandages, needles, thread, and basic medicines. Provides an asset on healing tasks. Some parts are reusable, but the kit runs out after about five uses.

Lamp: A hollow container filled with oil that slowly burns to provide light (often resembling a "genie lamp"). A lamp creates normal light in an immediate area and dim light out to the short area beyond that. It burns for three to four hours on 1 pint (.5 L) of oil. If dropped, it might spill oil, break, or both.

Lantern: An improved version of a lamp, with a wick that draws oil and glass or metal panes to protect it from wind. A lantern creates normal light in an immediate area and dim light out to the short area beyond that. It burns for three to four hours on 1 pint (.5 L) of oil. If dropped, it is less likely to spill than a lamp.

Lockpicks: Also known as thieves' tools, this set provides everything a skilled person needs to pick locks and disarm traps.

Manacles: Metal or heavy wooden restraints that hold an enemy's wrists or ankles in place and are secured with a pin. A common set of manacles is level 5.

Oil: A pint (.5 L) of lamp oil in a leather flask. It burns for three to four hours in a lantern or lamp. If prepped with a burning wick, it can be thrown, inflicting fire damage as a light weapon (ignores Armor). If poured on a flat surface, it makes an immediate area slippery. A creature can safely move through the oil slick as if it were difficult terrain (half speed). If a creature moves through the area at normal speed, they must make a difficulty 3 Speed defense roll or slip on the oil and fall prone. Lighting the oil slick makes it burn for one or two rounds and inflicts 1 point of fire damage (ignores Armor) on anyone in or moving through the area.

Signal horn: This horn can be heard up to a mile away.

Spyglass: This device grants an asset on perception tasks to see things at long range or longer.

Tent: This has enough room for two humans or three smaller people.

Torch: A wooden stick with some kind of fuel on one end (such as burlap and wax). It burns for one hour, creating normal light in an immediate area and dim light in the short area beyond that. A torch is fragile and usually breaks if used to hit something

Table 8.5: Adventuring Equipment Price

Item	Price
Acid (flask)	25 gp
Adventuring pack	6 gp
Alchemist fire (flask)	50 gp
Alchemist tools	50 gp
Backpack	2 gp
Bag of heavy tools	25 gp
Bag of light tools	10 gp
Battering arm	10 gp
Badroll	1 gp
Book	25 gp
Caltrops, bag	1 gp
Candle	1 sp
Climbing kit	25 gp
Crowbar	2 gp
Disguising kit	25 gp
Grappling hook	2 gp
Healing kit	5 gp
Hourglass	25 gp
Ink (flask)	10 gp
Ink pen	2 cp
Iron spikes (10)	1 gp
Ladder (3m)	1 sp
Lamp	5 sp
Lantern	5 gp
Lockpicks	25 gp
Manacles	2 gp
Mirror	5 gp
Musical instrument	2-50 gp
Oil (flask)	1 cp
Piton	5 cp
Pole, wooden	5 cp
Pouch or other small rations	5 sp
Rations (1 day)	5 sp
Rope (15m)	1 gp
Sack	1 cp
Signal horn	2gp
SPyglass	1 000 gp
Tent	2 gp
Torch	1 cp
Waterskin	2 sp

8.8 Miscellaneous Items and Services

Although the types of items for sale vary greatly based on the setting, a few things are always present, like food, lodging, and clothing. However, these goods and services can span the price

categories. For example, you can get an inexpensive meal, a moderately priced meal, an expensive meal, and so on. An inexpensive meal is light and probably not very nutritious. An expensive meal is available only in nice restaurants in certain locations. An exorbitant meal is probably a feast for a crowd,

with the finest foods and drink available.

Nightly lodging is similar, although the bottom end starts out worse. An inexpensive night's lodging is probably a flea-ridden mat on the floor of a room filled with other lodgers. Typical lodging (a private room with a decent bed) is probably in the moderately priced range. Very expensive lodging might be a suite of rooms with delicious meals and personal services (such as massages and grooming) included.

Inexpensive clothing is just a step up from rags, but moderately priced clothing is decent enough. For a formal party, you'd want expensive clothing. The very rich likely wear very expensive clothing most of the time, and exorbitant clothing (and jewelry) when they go to their elite galas.

Other sorts of miscellaneous items can be found in the Genre chapter.

8.9 Fantasy Clothing Descriptions

Specific pieces of clothing vary by climate and local custom, but usually include a hat, shirt, belt, pants or skirt, shoes, and underclothes.

Artisan's outfit: A suitable outfit for a person who performs a trade (blacksmith, cobbler, and so on). Often includes an apron and a belt for holding tools.

Ascetic's outfit: A simple outfit worn by monks and other people who eschew displays of wealth and status. Specific styles vary by climate and the philosophical tenets of the wearer, but a typical example is a loose shirt, loose breeches, sandals, a cap, and several cloth straps that can serve as a belt, scarf, or simple

adornments.

Cold-weather outfit: A heavier set of clothing for protection against cold weather.

Entertainer's costume: Interesting (and usually colorful) clothing appropriate for an entertainer such as an actor, bard, juggler, or acrobat.

Explorer's outfit: A set of sturdy clothing for adventurers and experienced travelers who want to be prepared for various activities and environments.

Fancy outfit: A stylish set of clothes according to the local fashions and customs. Generally the minimum required for meeting with important townsfolk such as a mayor or noble. Higher-status events require outfits that cost up to four times as much.

Peasant's outfit: Very simple clothing for free people of low social status. Includes a kerchief or cap, shirt or blouse, trousers or skirt, and heavy cloth shoes or foot wrappings.

Priestly vestments: Garments appropriate for performing ceremonies for a specific religion. A common example is a hat or headdress, long tunic or dress, tabard or stole, and shoes, with the outer pieces marked with appropriate symbols.

Traveler's outfit: A comfortable set of clothes that includes gloves, a protective hat, a jacket, and a cloak with a hood.

Wizard's outfit: Clothing that identifies the wearer as a practitioner of arcane magic. A typical outfit includes an interesting hat or cap, a robe with long sleeves and many pockets, and shoes, often adorned with runes or representations of magical creatures such as dragons. Scholars and sages wear very similar garments that lack the mystical aspects of wizard clothing.

Table 8.6: Fantasy Clothing Price

Item	Price
Artisan's outfit	2 gp
Ascetic's outfit	1 gp
Cold-weather outfit	6 gp
Entertainer's costume	3 gp
Explorer's outfit	8 gp
Fancy outfit	25 gp
Peasant's outfit	1 sp
Priestly bestments	5 gp
Traveler's outfit	2 gp
Wizard's outfit	5 gp
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8.10 Animal And Gear Descriptions

Draft horse: A strong horse able to carry or pull heavy loads.

Guard dog: A dog specially trained to guard. Better suited for watching or patrolling an area against thieves and intruders than it is for accompanying adventurers into dangerous locations.

Pony: A smaller type of horse, suitable for pulling a cart,

carrying smaller loads than a full-sized horse, or serving as a mount for a smaller-than-human creature such as a dwarf or halfling.

Riding horse: A horse trained for riding and able to carry a typical adult human. Riding horses tend to panic in combat.

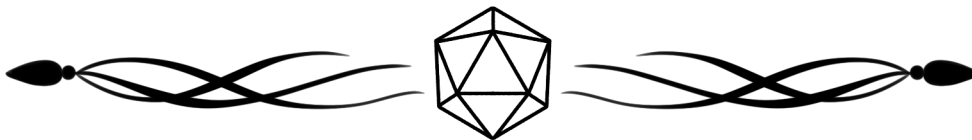
Warhorse: A horse trained to be calm during the noise and action of combat, used either as a mount or to pull a vehicle such as a chariot.

Table 8.7: Animals Price

Item	Price
Draft horse	50 gp
Guard dog	25 gp
Pony	30 gp
Riding horse	75 gp
Saddle	10 gp
Warhorse	300-500 gp
Continued on the next page	

Table 8.8: Food and Lodging Price

Item	Price
Ale, gallon	2 sp
Ale, mug	4 cp
Banquet (1 person)	10 gp
Bread, loaf	2 cp
Inn stay (per night)	
Good	8 sp
Common	5 sp
Poor	1 sp
Meals (per day) Good	5 sp
Common	3 sp
Poor	6 cp
Meat (one serving)	3 sp
Wine (bottle)	10 gp
Wine (pitcher)	2 sp
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Chapter 9

Cyphers & Artifacts

9.1 CYPHERS

Cyphers can sometimes be physical items like equipment, but they work very differently. To be entirely accurate, cyphers might have the veneer of equipment, but don't fall into the trap of confusing the two. Cyphers are far more akin to PC special abilities than to gear. In a fantasy game, they might be potions, scrolls, or charms. In a science fiction game, cyphers might be interesting throwaway devices or alien crystals of unknown providence. In other games, they might just represent good fortune or sudden inspiration. See the Cyphers chapter for more details.

9.2 Artifacts

Artifacts are more powerful than equipment and can't simply be purchased. The Genre chapter offers a few sample artifacts appropriate for various settings.

Each artifact has a level and a rate of power depletion. When an artifact is used or activated, the player rolls the designated die (1d6, 1d10, 1d20, or 1d100). If the die shows the depletion number(s), the item works, but that is its last use. A

depletion entry of “—” means that the artifact never depletes, and an entry of “automatic” means that it can be used only once.

Depowered artifacts can sometimes be recharged using the repair rules, depending on the item's nature. Other special abilities can also repower an expended item, but probably for only one use.

For GM information on artifacts, see the Running the Cypher System chapter.

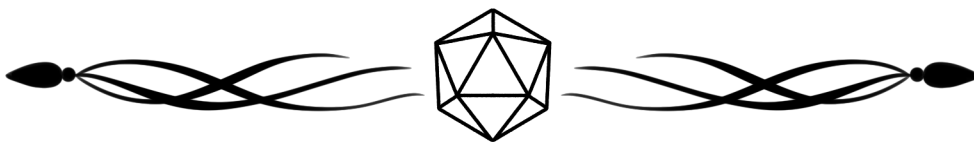
9.2.1 Finding, Identifying, and Using Artifacts

Characters can sometimes find artifacts while on adventures. They might be in ancient ruins, either intact or in need of manipulation to get them working. They could have been stolen from well-guarded military installations. They might be granted as rewards or taken from fallen foes. Sometimes they can even be purchased from a specialized source, but this occurs more rarely than most PCs would probably like.

After the characters find an artifact, identifying it is a separate Intellect task. The GM sets the difficulty of the task, but it is usually equal to the artifact's level. Identifying it takes fifteen minutes to three hours. If the PCs can't identify an artifact, they can bring it to an expert to be identified or, if desired, traded or sold.

Characters can attempt to use an artifact that has not been identified, which is usually an Intellect task equal to the artifact's level + 2. Failure might mean that the PCs can't figure out how to use the artifact or they use it incorrectly (GM's discretion). Of course, even if characters use an unidentified artifact correctly the first time, they have no idea what the effect might be.

Once characters identify an artifact, using it for the first time requires an additional Intellect action; this process is far more complex than pushing a button. It can involve manipulating touchscreens, reciting the proper arcane words, or anything else that fits the setting. The GM sets the difficulty, but it is usually equal to the artifact's level.



Chapter 10

Rules of the Game

Cypher System games are played in the joint imagination of all the players, including the GM. The GM sets the scene, the players state what their characters attempt to do, and the GM determines what happens next. The rules and the dice help make the game run smoothly, but it's the people, not the rules or the dice, that direct the action and determine the story—and the fun. If a rule gets in the way or detracts from the game, the players and the GM should work together to change it.

This is how you play the Cypher System:

1. The player tells the GM what they want to do. This is a character action.
2. The GM determines if that action is routine (and therefore works without needing a roll) or if there's a chance of failure.
3. If there is a chance of failure, the GM determines which stat the task uses (Might, Speed, or Intellect) and the task's difficulty—how hard it will be on a scale from 1 (really easy) to 10 (basically impossible).
4. The player and the GM determine if anything about the character—such as training, equipment, special abilities, or various actions—can modify the difficulty up or down by one or more steps. If these modifications reduce the difficulty to less than 1, the action is routine (and therefore works with no roll needed).
5. If the action still isn't routine, the GM uses its difficulty to determine the target number—how high the player must roll to succeed at the action (see the Task Difficulty table). The GM doesn't have to tell the player what the target number is, but they can give the player a hint, especially if the character would reasonably know if the action was easy, average, difficult, or impossible.
6. The player rolls a d20. If they roll equal to or higher than the target number, the character succeeds. That's it. That's how to do anything, whether it's identifying an unknown device, calming a raging drunk, climbing a treacherous cliff, or battling a demigod. Even if you ignored all the other rules, you could still play the Cypher System with just this information. The key features here are: character actions, determining task difficulty, and determining modifications.

10.1 Key Concepts

ACTION: Anything a character does that is significant—punch a foe, leap a chasm, activate a device, use a special power, and

so on. Each character can take one action in a round.

CHARACTER: Any creature in the game capable of acting, whether it is a player character (PC) run by a player or a nonplayer character (NPC) run by the game master (GM). In the Cypher System, even bizarre creatures, sentient machines, and living energy beings can be “characters.”

DIFFICULTY: A measure of how easy it is to accomplish a task. Difficulty is rated on a scale from 1 (lowest) to 10 (highest). Altering the difficulty to make a task harder is called “hindering.” Altering it to make a task easier is called “easing.” All changes in difficulty are measured in steps. Difficulty often equates directly with level, so opening a level 3 locked door probably has a difficulty of 3.

EASE: A decrease in a task's difficulty, usually by one step. If something doesn't say how many steps it eases a task, then it reduces the difficulty by one step.

EFFORT: Spending points from a stat Pool to reduce the difficulty of a task. A PC decides whether or not to apply Effort on their turn before the roll is made. NPCs never apply Effort.

HINDER: An increase in a task's difficulty, usually by one step. If something doesn't say how many steps it hinders a task, then it increases the difficulty by one step.

INABILITY: The opposite of trained—you're hindered whenever you attempt a task that you have an inability in. If you also become trained in the task, the training and the inability cancel each other out and you become practiced.

LEVEL: A way to measure the strength, difficulty, power, or challenge of something in the game. Everything in the game has a level. NPCs and objects have levels that determine the difficulty of any task related to them. For example, an opponent's level determines how hard they are to hit or avoid in combat. A door's level indicates how hard it is to break down. A lock's level determines how hard it is to pick. Levels are rated on a scale from 1 (lowest) to 10 (highest). PC tiers are a little like levels, but they go only from 1 to 6 and mechanically work very differently than levels—for example, a PC's tier does not determine a task's difficulty.

PRACTICED: The normal, unmodified ability to use a skill—not trained, specialized, or an inability. Your type determines what weapon skills you're practiced in; if you aren't practiced with a type of weapon, you have an inability in it.

ROLL: A d20 roll made by a PC to determine whether an action is successful. Although the game occasionally uses other dice, when the text simply refers to “a roll,” it always means a d20 roll.

ROUND: A length of time about five to ten seconds long. There are about ten rounds in a minute. When it's really important to track precise time, use rounds. Basically, it's the length of time to take an action in the game, but since everyone more or less acts simultaneously, all characters get to take an action each round.

SPECIALIZED: Having an exceptional amount of skill in a task. Being specialized eases the task by two steps. So, if you are specialized in climbing, all your climbing tasks are eased by two steps.

STAT: One of the three defining characteristics for PCs: Might, Speed, or Intellect. Each stat has two values: Pool and Edge. Your Pool represents your raw, innate ability, and your Edge represents knowing how to use what you have. Each stat Pool can increase or decrease over the course of play—for example, you can lose points from your Might Pool when struck by an opponent, spend points from your Intellect Pool to activate a special ability, or rest to recover points in your Speed

Pool after a long day of marching. Anything that damages a stat, restores a stat, or boosts or penalizes a stat affects the stat's Pool.

TASK: Any action that a PC attempts. The GM determines the difficulty of the task. In general, a task is something that you do and an action is you performing that task, but in most cases they mean the same thing.

TRAINED: Having a reasonable amount of skill in a task. Being trained eases the task. For example, if you are trained in climbing, all climbing tasks for you are eased. If you become very skilled at that task, you become specialized instead of trained. You do not need to be trained to attempt a task.

TURN: The part of the round when a character or creature takes its actions. For example, if a Warrior and an Adept are fighting an orc, each round the Warrior takes an action on their turn, the Adept takes an action on their turn, and the orc takes an action on its turn. Some abilities or effects last only one turn, or end when the next turn is started.

10.2 Taking Action

Each character gets one turn each round. On a character's turn, they can do one thing—an action. All actions fall into one of three categories: Might, Speed, or Intellect (just like the three stats). Many actions require die rolls—rolling a d20.

Every action performs a task, and every task has a difficulty that determines what number a character must reach or surpass with a die roll to succeed.

Most tasks have a difficulty of 0, which means the character succeeds automatically. For example, walking across a room, opening a door, and throwing a stone into a nearby bucket are all actions, but none of them requires a roll. Actions that are usually difficult or that become difficult due to the situation (such as shooting at a target in a blizzard) have a higher difficulty. These actions usually require a roll.

Some actions require a minimum expenditure of Might, Speed, or Intellect points. If a character cannot spend the minimum number of points needed to complete the action, they automatically fail at the task.

10.3 Determining Task Stat

Every task relates to one of a character's three stats: Might, Speed, or Intellect. Physical activities that require strength, power, or endurance relate to Might. Physical activities that require agility, flexibility, or fast reflexes relate to Speed. Mental activities that require force of will, memory, or mental power relate to Intellect. This means you can generalize tasks into three categories: Might tasks, Speed tasks, and Intellect tasks. You can also generalize rolls into three categories: Might rolls, Speed rolls, and Intellect rolls.

The category of the task or roll determines what kind of Effort you can apply to the roll and may determine how a character's other abilities affect the roll. For example, an Adept may have an ability that makes them better at Intellect rolls, and a Warrior may have an ability that makes them better at Speed rolls.

10.4 Determining Task Difficulty

The most frequent thing a GM does during the game—and probably the most important thing—is set a task's difficulty. To make the job easier, use the Task Difficulty table, which associates a difficulty rating with a descriptive name, a target number, and general guidance about the difficulty.

Every difficulty from 1 to 10 has a target number associated with it. The target number is easy to remember: it's always three times the difficulty. The target number is the minimum number a player needs to roll on a d20 to succeed at the task. Moving up or down on the table is called hindering or easing, which is measured in steps.

For example, reducing a difficulty 5 task to a difficulty 4 task is “easing the difficulty by one step” or just “easing the difficulty” or “easing the task.” Most modifiers affect the difficulty rather than the player's roll. This has two consequences:

Low target numbers such as 3 or 6, which would be boring in most games that use a d20, are not boring in the Cypher System. For example, if you need to roll a 6 or higher, you still have a 25

The upper levels of difficulty (7, 8, 9, and 10) are all but impossible because the target numbers are 21 or higher, which you can't roll on a d20. However, it's common for PCs to have abilities or equipment that ease a task and thus lower the target number to something they can roll on a d20.

A character's tier does not determine a task's level. Things don't get more difficult just because a character's tier increases—the world doesn't instantly become a more difficult place. Fourth-tier characters don't deal only with level 4 creatures or difficulty 4 tasks (although a fourth-tier character probably has a better shot at success than a first-tier character does). Just because something is level 4 doesn't necessarily mean it's meant only for fourth-tier characters. Similarly, depending on the situation, a fifth-tier character could find a difficulty 2 task just as challenging as a second-tier character does.

Therefore, when setting the difficulty of a task, the GM should rate the task on its own merits, not on the power of the characters.

10.5 Modifying The Difficulty

After the GM sets the difficulty for a task, the player can try to modify it for their character. Any such modification applies only to this particular attempt at the task. In other words, rewiring an electronic door lock normally might be difficulty 6, but since the character doing the work is skilled in such tasks, has the right tools, and has another character assisting them, the difficulty in this instance might be much lower. That's why it's important for the GM to set a task's difficulty without taking the character into account. The character comes in at this step.

By using skills and assets, working together, and—perhaps most important—applying Effort, a character can ease a task by multiple steps to make it easier. Rather than adding bonuses to the player's roll, reducing the difficulty lowers the target number. If they can reduce the difficulty of a task to 0, no roll is needed; success is automatic. (An exception is if the GM decides to use a GM intrusion on the task, in which case the player would have to make a roll at the original difficulty.)

There are three basic ways in which a character can ease a task: skills, assets, and Effort. Each method eases the task by at least one step—never in smaller increments.

(By using skills, assets, and Effort, a character can ease a task by a maximum of ten steps: one or two steps from skills, one or two steps from assets, and one to six steps from Effort.)

10.6 Skills

Characters may be skilled at performing a specific task. A skill can vary from character to character. For example, one character might be skilled at lying, another might be skilled at trickery, and a third might be skilled in all interpersonal interactions. The first level of being skilled is called being trained, and it eases that task by one step. More rarely, a character can be incredibly skilled at performing a task. This is called being specialized, and it eases the task by two steps instead of one. Skills can never decrease a task by more than two steps—any more than two steps from being trained and specialized don't count.

10.7 Assets

An asset is anything that helps a character with a task, such as having a really good crowbar when trying to force open a door or being in a rainstorm when trying to put out a fire. Appropriate assets vary from task to task. The perfect awl might help when woodworking, but it won't make a dance performance much better. An asset usually eases a task by one step. Assets can never ease a task by more than two steps—any more than two steps from assets don't count.

(The important thing to remember is that a skill can reduce the difficulty by no more than two steps, and assets can reduce the difficulty by no more than two steps, regardless of the situation. Thus, no task's difficulty will ever be reduced by more than four steps without using Effort.)

10.8 Effort

A player can apply Effort to ease a task. To do this, the player spends points from the stat Pool that's most appropriate to the task. For example, applying Effort to push a heavy rock off a cliff requires a player to spend points from the character's Might Pool; applying Effort to activate an unusual machine interface requires them to spend points from the character's Intellect Pool. For every level of Effort spent on a task, the task is eased. It costs 3 points from a stat Pool to apply one level of Effort, and it costs 2 additional points for every level thereafter (so it costs 5 points for two levels of Effort, 7 points for three levels of Effort, and so on). A character must spend points from the same stat Pool as the type of task or roll—Might points for a Might roll, Speed points for a Speed roll, or Intellect points for an Intellect roll.

Every character has a maximum level of Effort they can apply to a single task. Effort can never ease a task by more than six steps—any more than six steps from applying Effort doesn't count.

Free Level of Effort: A few abilities give you a free level of Effort (these usually require you to apply at least one level of Effort to a task). In effect, you're getting one more level of Effort than what you paid for. This free level of Effort can exceed the Effort limit for your character, but not the six-step limit for easing a task.

10.9 Rolling the Die

To determine success or failure, a player rolls a die (always a d20). If they roll the target number or higher, they succeed. Most of the time, that's the end of it—nothing else needs to be done. Rarely, a character might apply a small modifier to the roll. If they have a +2 bonus when attempting specific actions, they add 2 to the number rolled. However, the original roll matters if it's a special roll.

If a character applies a modifier to the die roll, it's possible to get a result of 21 or higher, in which case they can attempt a task with a target number above 20. But if there is no possibility for success—if not even rolling a natural 20 (meaning the d20 shows that number) is sufficient to accomplish the task—then no roll is made. Otherwise, characters would have a chance to succeed at everything, even impossible or ridiculous tasks such as climbing moonbeams, throwing elephants, or hitting a target on the opposite side of a mountain with an arrow.

If a character's modifiers add up to +3, treat them as an asset instead. In other words, instead of adding a +3 bonus to the roll, reduce the difficulty by one step. For example, if a Warrior has a +1 bonus to attack rolls from a minor effect, a +1 bonus to attack rolls from a special weapon quality, and a +1 bonus to attack rolls from a special ability, they do not add 3 to their attack roll—instead, they reduce the difficulty of the attack by one step. So if they attack a level 3 foe, they would normally roll against difficulty 3 and try to reach a target number of 9, but thanks to their asset, they roll against difficulty 2 and try to reach a target number of 6.

This distinction is important when stacking skills and assets to decrease the difficulty of an action, especially since reducing the difficulty to 0 or lower means no roll is needed.

10.10 The Player Always Rolls

In the Cypher System, players always drive the action. That means they make all the die rolls. If a PC leaps out of a moving vehicle, the player rolls to see if they succeed. If a PC searches for a hidden panel, the player rolls to determine whether they find it. If a rockslide falls on a PC, the player rolls to try to get out of the way. If a PC and an NPC arm wrestle, the player rolls, and the NPC's level determines the target number. If a PC attacks a foe, the player rolls to see if they hit. If a foe attacks the PC, the player rolls to see if they dodge the blow.

As shown by the last two examples, the PC rolls whether they are attacking or defending. Thus, something that improves defenses might ease or hinder their rolls. For example, if a PC uses a low wall to gain cover from attacks, the wall eases the player's defense rolls. If a foe uses the wall to gain cover from the PC's attacks, it hinders the player's attack rolls.

10.11 Special Rolls

If a character rolls a natural 1, 17, 18, 19, or 20 (meaning the d20 shows that number), special rules come into play. These are explained in more detail in the following sections.

1: GM Intrusion. The GM makes a free intrusion (see below) and doesn't award experience points (XP) for it.

17: Damage Bonus. If the roll was a damage-dealing attack, it deals 1 additional point of damage.

18: Damage Bonus. If the roll was a damage-dealing attack, it deals 2 additional points of damage.

19: Minor Effect. If the roll was a damage-dealing attack, it deals 3 additional points of damage or the PC gets a minor effect in addition to the normal results of the task. If the roll was something other than an attack, the PC gets a minor effect in addition to the normal results of the task.

20: Major Effect. If the roll was a damage-dealing attack, it deals 4 additional points of damage or the PC gets a major or minor effect in addition to the normal results of the task. If the roll was something other than an attack, the PC gets a major effect in addition to the normal results of the task. If the PC spent points from a stat Pool on the action, the point cost for the action decreases to 0, meaning the character regains those points as if they had not spent them at all.

10.12 GM Intrusion

GM intrusion is explained in more detail in the Running the Cypher System chapter, but essentially it means that something occurs to complicate the character's life. The character hasn't necessarily fumbled or done anything wrong (although perhaps they did). It could just be that the task presents an unexpected difficulty or something unrelated affects the current situation.

For GM intrusion on a defense roll, a roll of 1 might mean that the PC takes 2 additional points of damage from the attack, indicating that the opponent got in a lucky blow.

(For complete details about GM intrusion and how to use it to best effect in the game, see the Running the Cypher System chapter.)

10.13 Minor Effect

A minor effect happens when a player rolls a natural 19. Most of the time, a minor effect is slightly beneficial to the PC, but not overwhelming.

A climber gets up the steep slope a bit faster. A repaired machine works a bit better. A character jumping down into a pit lands on their feet. Either the GM or the player can come up with a possible minor effect that fits the situation, but both must agree on what it should be.

Don't waste a lot of time thinking of a minor effect if nothing appropriate suggests itself. Sometimes, in cases where only success or failure matters, it's okay to have no minor effect. Keep the game moving at an exciting pace.

In combat, the easiest and most straightforward minor effect is dealing 3 additional points of damage with an attack. The following are other common minor effects for combat:

Damage object: Instead of striking the foe, the attack strikes what the foe is holding. If the attack hits, the character makes a Might roll with a difficulty equal to the object's level. On a success, the object moves one or more steps down the object damage track.

Distract: For one round, all of the foe's tasks are hindered.

Knock back: The foe is knocked or forced back a few feet. Most of the time, this doesn't matter much, but if the fight takes place on a ledge or next to a pit of lava, the effect can be significant.

Move past: The character can move a short distance at the end of the attack. This effect is useful to get past a foe guarding a door, for example.

Strike a specific body part: The attacker strikes a specific spot on the defender's body. The GM rules what special effect, if any, results. For example, hitting a creature's tentacle that

is wrapped around an ally might make it easier for the ally to escape. Hitting a foe in the eye might blind it for one round. Hitting a creature in its one vulnerable spot might ignore Armor.

Usually, the GM just has the desired minor effect occur. For example, rolling a 19 against a relatively weak foe means it is knocked off the cliff. The effect makes the round more exciting, but the defeat of a minor creature has no significant impact on the story. Other times, the GM might rule that an additional roll is needed to achieve the effect—the special roll only gives the PC the opportunity for a minor effect. This mostly happens when the desired effect is very unlikely, such as pushing a 50-ton battle automaton off a cliff. If the player just wants to deal 3 additional points of damage as the minor effect, no extra roll is needed.

10.14 Major Effect

A major effect happens when a player rolls a natural 20. Most of the time, a major effect is quite beneficial to the character. A climber gets up the steep slope in half the time. A jumper lands with such panache that those nearby are impressed and possibly intimidated. A defender makes a free attack on a foe.

Either the GM or the player can come up with a possible major effect that fits the situation, but both must agree on what it should be. As with minor effects, don't spend a lot of time agonizing over the details of a major effect. In cases where only success or failure matters, a major effect might offer the character a one-time asset (a modification of one step) to use the next time they attempt a similar action. When nothing else seems appropriate, the GM can simply grant the PC an additional action on their turn that same round.

In combat, the easiest and most straightforward major effect is dealing 4 additional points of damage with an attack. The following are other common major effects for combat.

Disarm: The foe drops one object that it is holding.

Impair: For the rest of the combat, all tasks the foe attempts are hindered.

Knock down: The foe is knocked prone. It can get up on its turn.

Stun: The foe loses its next action.

As with minor effects, usually the GM just has the desired major effect occur, but sometimes the GM might require an extra roll if the major effect is unusual or unlikely.

10.15 Retrying a Task after failure

If a character fails a task (whether it's climbing a wall, picking a lock, trying to figure out a mysterious device, or something else) they can attempt it again, but they must apply at least one level of Effort when retrying that task. A retry is a new action, not part of the same action that failed, and it takes the same amount of time as the first attempt did.

Sometimes the GM might rule that retries are impossible. Perhaps a character has one chance to convince the leader of a group of thugs not to attack, and after that, no amount of talking will stop them.

This rule doesn't apply to something like attacking a foe in combat because combat is always changing and fluid. Each round's situation is new, not a repeat of a previous situation, so a missed attack can't be retried.

10.16 Initial Cost

The GM can assign a point cost to a task just for trying it. Called an initial cost, it's simply an indication that the task is particularly taxing. For example, let's say a character wants to try a Might action to open a heavy cellar door that is partially rusted shut. The GM says that forcing the door open is a difficulty 5 task, and there's an initial cost of 3 Might points simply to try. This initial cost is in addition to any points the character chooses to spend on the roll (such as when applying Effort), and the initial cost points do not affect the difficulty of the task. In other words, the character must spend 3 Might points to attempt the task at all, but that doesn't help them open the door. If they want to apply Effort to ease the task, they have to spend more points from their Might Pool.

Edge helps with the initial cost of a task, just as it does with any expenditure from a character's Pool. In the previous example, if the character had a Might Edge of 2, they would have to spend only 1 point (3 points minus 2 from their Might Edge) for the initial cost to attempt the task. If they also applied a level of Effort to open the door, they couldn't use their Edge again—Edge applies only once per action—so using the Effort would cost the full 3 points. Thus, they'd spend a total of 4 points (1 for the initial cost plus 3 for the Effort) from their Might Pool.

The rationale of the initial cost rule is that even in the Cypher System, where things like Effort can help a character succeed on an action, logic still suggests that some actions are very difficult and taxing, particularly for some PCs more than others.

10.17 Distance

Distance is simplified into four basic categories: immediate, short, long, and very long.

Immediate distance from a character is within reach or within a few steps; if a character stands in a small room, everything in the room is within immediate distance. At most, immediate distance is 10 feet (3 m). Immediate distance is sometimes referred to as close, or even point-blank, particularly when referring to ranges.

(The words "immediate" and "close" can be used interchangeably to talk about distance. If a creature or object is within arm's reach of the character, it can be considered both immediate and close.)

Short distance is anything greater than immediate distance but less than 50 feet (15 m) or so.

Long distance is anything greater than short distance but less than 100 feet (30 m) or so.

Very long distance is anything greater than long distance but less than 500 feet (150 m) or so.

Beyond that range, distances are always specified—1,000 feet (300 m), 1 mile (1.5 km), and so on.

All weapons and special abilities use these terms for ranges.

For example, all melee weapons have immediate range—they are close-combat weapons, and you can use them to attack anyone within immediate distance. A thrown knife (and most other thrown weapons) has short range. A small handgun also has short range. A rifle has long range.

A character can move an immediate distance as a part of another action. In other words, they can take a few steps to the light switch and flip it on. They can lunge across a small room to attack a foe. They can open a door and step through.

A character can move a short distance as their entire action for a turn. They can also try to move a long distance as their entire action, but the player might have to roll to see if the character slips, trips, or stumbles for moving so far so quickly.

GMs and players don't need to determine exact distances. For example, if the PCs are fighting a group of guards, any character can likely attack any foe in the general melee—they're all within immediate range. However, if one trooper stays back to fire a blaster, a character might have to use their entire action to move the short distance required to attack that foe. It doesn't matter if the trooper is 20 feet (6 m) or 40 feet (12 m) away—it's simply considered short distance. It does matter if the trooper is more than 50 feet (15 m) away because that distance would require a long move.

10.18 Other Distances

In rare cases where distances beyond very long are needed, real-world distances are best (1 mile, 100 kilometers, and so on). However, the following shorthand distances can be useful in some settings:

Planetary: On the same planet.

Interplanetary: Within the same solar system.

Interstellar: Within the same galaxy.

Intergalactic: Anywhere in the same universe.

Interdimensional: Anywhere.

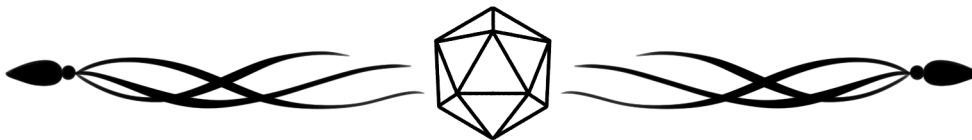
10.19 Timekeeping

Generally, keep time the same way that you normally would, using minutes, hours, days, and weeks. Thus, if the characters walk overland for 15 miles (24 km), about eight hours pass, even though the journey can be described in only a few seconds at the game table. Precision timekeeping is rarely important. Most of the time, saying things like "That takes about an hour" works fine.

This is true even when a special ability has a specific duration. In an encounter, a duration of "one minute" is mostly the same as saying "the rest of the encounter." You don't have to track each round that ticks by if you don't want to. Likewise, an ability that lasts for ten minutes can safely be considered the length of an in-depth conversation, the time it takes to quickly explore a small area, or the time it takes to rest after a strenuous activity.

Table 10.1: Timekeeping

Action	Time Usually Required
Walking a mile over easy terrain	About 15 minutes
Walking a mile over rough terrain (forest, snow, hills)	About 30 minutes
Walking a mile over difficult terrain (mountains, thick jungle)	About 45 minutes
Moving from one significant location in a city to another	About 15 minutes
Sneaking into a guarded location	About 15 minutes
Having an in-depth discussion	About 10 minutes
Resting after a fight or other strenuous activity	About 10 minutes
Resting and having a quick meal	About 30 minutes
Making or breking camp	About 30 minutes
Shopping for supplies in a market or store	About an hour
Meeting with an important contact	About 30 minutes
Referencing a book or website	About 30 minutes
Searching a room for hidden things	At least 30 minutes, maybe an hour
Searching for cyphers or otger valuables amid a lot of stuff	About an hour
Identifying or understanding a cypher	15 to 30 minutes
Identifying and understanding an artifact	At least 15 minutes maybe 3 hours
Repairing a device (assuming parts and tools available)	At least an hours, maybe a day
Building a device (assuming parts and tools available)	At least a day, maybe a week



Chapter 11

Encounters, Rounds, And Initiative

Sometimes in the course of the game, the GM or players will refer to an “encounter.” Encounters are not so much measurements of time as they are events or instances in which something happens, like a scene of a movie or a chapter in a book. An encounter might be a fight with a foe, a dramatic crossing of a raging river, or a stressful negotiation with an important official. It’s useful to use the word when referring to a specific scene, as in “My Might Pool is low after that encounter with the soul sorcerer yesterday.”

A round is about five to ten seconds. The length of time is variable because sometimes one round might be a bit longer than another. You don’t need to measure time more precisely than that. You can estimate that on average there are about ten rounds in a minute. In a round, everyone—each character and NPC—gets to take one action.

To determine who goes first, second, and so on in a round, each player makes a Speed roll called an initiative roll. Most of the time, it’s only important to know which characters act before the NPCs and which act after the NPCs. On an initiative roll, a character who rolls higher than an NPC’s target number takes their action before the NPC does. As with all target numbers, an NPC’s target number for an initiative roll is three times the NPC’s level. Many times, the GM will have all NPCs take their actions at the same time, using the highest target number from among all the NPCs. Using this method, any characters who rolled higher than the target number act first, then all the NPCs act, and finally any characters who rolled lower than the target number act.

(An initiative roll is a d20 roll. Since your initiative depends on how fast you are, if you spend Effort on the roll, the points come from your Speed Pool.)

The order in which the characters act usually isn’t important. If the players want to go in a precise order, they can act in initiative order (highest to lowest), by going around the table, by going oldest to youngest, and so on.

For example, Charles, Tammie, and Shanna’s characters are in combat with two level 2 security guards. The GM has the players make Speed rolls to determine initiative. Charles rolls an 8, Shanna rolls a 15, and Tammie rolls a 4. The target number for a level 2 creature is 6, so each round Charles and Shanna act before the guards, then the guards act, and finally Tammie acts. It doesn’t matter whether Charles acts before or after Shanna, as long as they think it’s fair.

After everyone—all PCs and NPCs—in the combat has had a turn, the round ends and a new round begins. In all rounds after the first, everyone acts in the same order as they did in the

first round. The characters cycle through this order until the logical end of the encounter (the end of the fight or the completion of the event) or until the GM asks them to make new initiative rolls. The GM can call for new initiative rolls at the beginning of any new round when conditions drastically change. For example, if the NPCs gain reinforcements, the environment changes (perhaps the lights go out), the terrain changes (maybe part of the balcony collapses under the PCs), or something similar occurs, the GM can call for new initiative rolls.

Since the action moves as a cycle, anything that lasts for a round ends where it started in the cycle. If Umberto uses an ability on an opponent that hinders its defenses for one round, the effect lasts until Umberto acts on his next turn.

11.1 A Closer Look At Situations That Don’t Involve PCs

Ultimately, the GM is the arbiter of conflicts that do not involve the PCs. They should be adjudicated in the most interesting, logical, and story-based way possible. When in doubt, match the level of the NPCs (characters or creatures) or their respective effects to determine the results. Thus, if a level 4 NPC fights a level 3 NPC, the level 4 NPC will win, but if they face a level 7 NPC, they’ll lose. Likewise, a level 4 creature resists poisons or devices of level 3 or lower but not those of level 5 and above.

The essence is this: in the Cypher System, it doesn’t matter if something is a creature, a poison, or a gravity-dispelling ray. If it’s a higher level, it wins; if it’s a lower level, it loses. If two things of equal level oppose each other, there might be a long, drawn-out battle that could go either way.

11.2 Actions

Anything that your character does in a round is an action. It’s easiest to think of an action as a single thing that you can do in five to ten seconds. For example, if you use your dart thrower to shoot a strange floating orb, that’s one action. So is running for cover behind a stack of barrels, prying open a stuck door, using a rope to pull your friend up from a pit, or activating a cypher (even if it’s stored in your pack).

Opening a door and attacking a security guard on the other side are two actions. It’s more a matter of focus than time. Drawing your sword and attacking a foe is all one action. Putting away your bow and pushing a heavy bookcase to block a door are two actions because each requires a different train of thought.

If the action you want to accomplish is not within reach, you can move a little bit. Essentially, you can move up to an immediate distance to perform your action. For example, you can move an immediate distance and attack a foe, open a door and move an immediate distance into the hallway beyond, or grab your hurt friend lying on the ground and pull them back a few steps. This movement can occur before or after your action, so you can move to a door and open it, or you can open a door and move through it.

The most common actions are:

- Attack
- Activate a special ability (one that isn’t an attack)

- Move
- Wait
- Defend
- Do something else

11.2.1 Action: Attack

An attack is anything that you do to someone that they don't want you to do. Slashing a foe with a curved dagger is an attack, blasting a foe with a lightning artifact is an attack, wrapping a foe in magnetically controlled metal cables is an attack, and controlling someone's mind is an attack. An attack almost always requires a roll to see if you hit or otherwise affect your target.

In the simplest kind of attack, such as a PC trying to stab a thug with a knife, the player rolls and compares their result to the opponent's target number. If their roll is equal to or greater than the target number, the attack hits. Just as with any kind of task, the GM might modify the difficulty based on the situation, and the player might have a bonus to the roll or might try to ease the task using skills, assets, or Effort.

A less straightforward attack might be a special ability that stuns a foe with a mental blast. However, it's handled the same way: the player makes a roll against the opponent's target number. Similarly, an attempt to tackle a foe and wrestle it to the ground is still just a roll against the foe's target number.

Attacks are sometimes categorized as "melee" attacks, meaning that you hurt or affect something within immediate reach, or "ranged" attacks, meaning that you hurt or affect something at a distance.

Melee attacks can be Might or Speed actions—player choice. Physical ranged attacks (such as bows, thrown weapons, and blasts of fire from a mutation) are almost always Speed actions, but those that come from special abilities tend to be Intellect actions.

Special abilities that require touching the target require a melee attack. If the attack misses, the power is not wasted, and you can try again each round as your action until you hit the target, use another ability, or take a different action that requires you to use your hands. These attempts in later rounds count as different actions, so you don't have to keep track of how much Effort you used when you activated the ability or how you used Edge. For example, let's say that in the first round of combat, you activate a special ability that requires you to touch your foe and you use Effort to ease the attack, but you roll poorly and miss your foe. In the second round of combat, you can try attacking again and use Effort to ease the attack roll.

The GM and players are encouraged to describe every attack with flavor and flair. One attack roll might be a stab to the foe's arm. A miss might be the PC's sword slamming into the wall. Combatants lunge, block, duck, spin, leap, and make all kinds of movements that should keep combat visually interesting and compelling. The Running the Cypher System chapter has much more guidance in this regard.

Common elements that affect the difficulty of a combat task are cover, range, and darkness. The rules for these and other modifiers are explained in the Attack Modifiers and Special Situations section of this chapter.

Damage

When an attack strikes a character, it usually means the character takes damage.

An attack against a PC subtracts points from one of the character's stat Pools—usually the Might Pool. Whenever an attack simply says it deals "damage" without specifying the type, it means Might damage, which is by far the most common type. Intellect damage, which is usually the result of a mental attack, is always labeled as Intellect damage. Speed damage is often a physical attack, but attacks that deal Speed damage are fairly rare.

NPCs don't have stat Pools. Instead, they have a characteristic called health. When an NPC takes damage of any kind, the amount is subtracted from its health. Unless described otherwise, an NPC's health is always equal to its target number. Some NPCs might have special reactions to or defenses against attacks that would normally deal Speed damage or Intellect damage, but unless the NPC's description specifically explains this, assume that all damage is subtracted from the NPC's health.

Objects don't have stat Pools or health. They have an object damage track, just like how PCs have a damage track. Attacking objects might move them down their damage track.

Damage is always a specific amount determined by the attack. For example, a slash with a broadsword or a blast with a spike thrower deals 4 points of damage. An Adept's Onslaught deals 4 points of damage. Often, there are ways for the attacker to increase the damage. For example, a PC can apply Effort to deal 3 additional points of damage, and rolling a natural 17 on the attack roll deals 1 additional point of damage.

Armor

Pieces of equipment and special abilities protect a character from damage by giving them Armor. Each time a character takes damage, subtract their Armor value from the damage before reducing their stat Pool or health. For example, if a Warrior with 2 Armor is hit by a gunshot that deals 4 points of damage, they take only 2 points of damage (4 minus 2 from their Armor). If Armor reduces the incoming damage to 0 or lower, the character takes no damage from the attack. For example, the Warrior's 2 Armor protects them from all physical attacks that deal 1 or 2 points of damage.

The most common way to get Armor is to wear physical armor, such as a leather jacket, a bulletproof vest, a chainmail hauberk, bioengineered carapace grafts, or something else, depending on the setting. All physical armor comes in one of three categories: light, medium, or heavy. Light armor gives the wearer 1 point of Armor, medium gives 2 points of Armor, and heavy gives 3 points of Armor.

When you see the word "Armor" capitalized in the game rules (other than in the name of a special ability), it refers to your Armor characteristic—the number you subtract from incoming damage. When you see the word "armor" in lowercase, it refers to any physical armor you might wear.

Other effects can add to a character's Armor. If a character is wearing chainmail (+2 to Armor) and has an ability that covers them in a protective force field that grants +1 to Armor, their total is 3 Armor. If they also use a cypher that hardens their flesh temporarily for +1 to Armor, their total is 4 Armor.

Some types of damage ignore physical armor. Attacks that specifically deal Speed damage or Intellect damage ignore Armor; the creature takes the listed amount of damage without

any reduction from Armor. Ambient damage (see below) usually ignores Armor as well.

A creature may have a special bonus to Armor against certain kinds of attacks. For example, a protective suit made of a sturdy, fire-resistant material might normally give its wearer +1 to Armor but count as +3 to Armor against fire attacks. An artifact worn as a helmet might grant +2 to Armor only against mental attacks.

Ambient Damage

Some kinds of damage aren't direct attacks against a creature, but they indirectly affect everything in the area. Most of these

are environmental effects such as winter cold, high temperatures, or background radiation. Damage from these kinds of sources is called ambient damage. Physical armor usually doesn't protect against ambient damage, though a well-insulated suit of armor can protect against cold weather.

Damage From Hazards

Attacks aren't the only way to inflict damage on a character. Experiences such as falling from a great height, being burned in a fire, and spending time in severe weather also deal damage. Although no list of potential hazards could be comprehensive, the Damage From Hazards table includes common examples.

Table 11.1: Damage from Hazards

Source	Damages	Notes
Falling	1 point per 3 m fallen (ambient damage)	-
Minor fire	3 points per round (ambient damage)	Torch
Major fire	6 points per round (ambient damage)	Engulfed in flames; lava
Acid splash	2 points per round (ambient damage)	-
Acid bath	6 points per round (ambient damage)	Immersed in acid
Cold	1 point per round (ambient damage)	Below freezing temperature
Severe Cold	3 points per round (ambient damage)	Liquid nitrogen
Shock	1 point per round (ambient damage)	Often involves losing next action
Electrocution	6 points per round (ambient damage)	Often involves losing next action
Crush	3 points	Object or creature falls on character
Huge crush	6 points	Roof collapse; cave-in
Collision	6 points	Large, fast object strikes character

Space Hazards

A few specific hazards that you can include as part of an encounter involving a spacecraft follow. These hazards are more site specific than the general threats presented in Chapter 5: Conflicts of the Future.

Gravity Well All bodies in space produce a gravitational field, though usually only things the size of a small moon or larger pose a hazard to unprepared (and sometimes even to prepared) spacecraft. The larger the body, the “deeper” and wider the associated gravity field. Any time a spacecraft launches from a moon or planet, it must escape the gravity well. For RPG purposes, that's either a routine task, or a low-difficulty one (assuming no complicating factors are at play).

Gravity wells become a hazard when a spacecraft encounters one unexpectedly— usually because of a navigational or sensor error, but occasionally because of a moon or extreme gravity source being someplace unforeseen.

Slingshot Trajectory: An unexpected encounter with a gravity well can sling a spacecraft off on a new and unwanted trajectory on a failed piloting task, the difficulty determined by the situation.

Captured: An unexpected encounter with a gravity well can also capture a spacecraft in the gravity well's orbit, forcing the craft to expend additional power to get free (power it may or may not have)

Black Hole Black holes are just extreme gravity wells. All the dangers associated with a gravity well also apply to black holes. A couple of additional hazards are also associated with

black holes, notably tidal destruction (“spaghettification”), time dilation, and being swallowed.

Tidal Desctruction: Mechanically speaking, while a spacecraft feels tidal forces by passing too close to a black hole's event horizon, all tasks aboard the craft are hindered, Void Rules are in effect, and if a GM intrusion is triggered thereby, the ship sustains major damage and risks coming apart. Meanwhile, PCs in the ship (assuming some sort of fantastic tech-rated gravity nullifier isn't in use) suffer 1 point of ambient damage each round.

A ship near a very large black hole (like Sagittarius A*, the supermassive black hole at the center of the Milky Way Galaxy) can avoid tidal effects because the gravity gradient is so much wider, but still feel relativistic time dilation.

Relativistic Time Dialation: From a mechanical perspective, spacecraft that survive close encounters with black holes and return to normal space discover that more time has passed than expected, which could range from fairly inconsequential minutes or hours, to far more serious days, months, years, centuries, or more.

Past the Event Horizon: The event horizon is the point of no return, where not even light can escape the clutch of gravity. If a spacecraft falls into a black hole, assuming it is not spaghettified by tidal forces, it is still lost from the universe of its origin. At least, it's lost assuming no intervention from a fantastic tech-rated post-singularity AI or ancient ultra.

Radiation Belt/Solar Flare Radiation belts of intensely charged particles trapped by magnetic fields around some planets and moons can surge, causing radiation exposure. An unexpected solar flare, or the drive plume of a massive spacecraft,

can cause the same unexpected exposure.

Ship Damage: The ship suffers minor or major damage, requiring repair and perhaps even replacement of parts. This damage is as serious as you require for the purposes of creating an interesting story.

Radiation Sickness: When PCs are exposed to intense radiation, they suffer 3 points of ambient radiation damage for each minute the character fails a difficulty 3 Might defense task. If the character fails three such defense rolls during any single period of radiation exposure, they suffer acute radiation sickness, a level 8 disease that drops them one step on the damage track for each day they fail a Might defense roll until they expire.

Asteroid/Debris Field Movies often depict asteroid belts as densely packed fields of tumbling rock that ships must constantly swerve through to avoid a collision. Such locations are not easy to find in the solar system. But such situations can occur in fantastic settings, or possibly in solar systems other than Earth's.

Evasive Asteroid Piloting: During any round a spacecraft moves through a densely packed asteroid or debris field, the pilot (or shipmind) must succeed on a piloting task, whose difficulty is set by the situation. On a failed roll, a collision occurs. Each time a collision occurs, the ship (and possibly its crew) is damaged according to the track laid out below. Collisions are assumed to be major rocks or pieces of debris, or possibly a series of smaller pieces of debris all impacting nearly simultaneously, with one getting through the shielding.

Finding Shelter: The best way to find shelter in order to effect repairs, or hide from pursuers, is to try to find an asteroid or piece of debris large enough for the spacecraft to land on or find a crevice to slide into. To land a spacecraft on an asteroid or big piece of debris is a challenging (difficulty 5) piloting task to match the asteroid's spin, then slide into the cramped space.

The Effects of Taking Damage

When an NPC reaches 0 health, it is either dead or (if the attacker wishes) incapacitated, meaning unconscious or beaten into submission.

As previously mentioned, damage from most sources is applied to a character's Might Pool. Otherwise, stat damage always reduces the Pool of the stat it affects. If damage reduces a character's stat Pool to 0, any further damage to that stat (including excess damage from the attack that reduced the stat to 0) is applied to another stat Pool. Damage is applied to Pools in this order:

1. Might (unless the Pool is 0)
2. Speed (unless the Pool is 0)
3. Intellect

Even if the damage is applied to another stat Pool, it still counts as its original type for the purpose of Armor and special abilities that affect damage. For example, if a character with 2 Armor is reduced to 0 Might and then is hit by a creature's claw for 3 points of damage, it still counts as Might damage, so their Armor reduces the damage to 1 point, which then is applied to their Speed Pool. In other words, even though they take the damage from their Speed Pool, it doesn't ignore Armor like Speed damage normally would.

In addition to taking damage from their Might Pool, Speed Pool, or Intellect Pool, PCs also have a damage track. The damage track has four states (from best to worst): hale, impaired, debilitated, and dead. When one of a PC's stat Pools reaches 0, they move one step down the damage track. Thus, if they are hale, they become impaired. If they are already impaired, they become debilitated. If they are already debilitated, they become dead.

Some effects can immediately shift a PC one or more steps on the damage track. These include rare poisons, cellular disruption attacks, and massive traumas (such as falls from very great heights, being run over by a speeding vehicle, and so on, as determined by the GM).

Some attacks, like a serpent's poisonous bite or a Speaker's Enthral, have effects other than damage to a stat Pool or shifting the PC on the damage track. These attacks can cause unconsciousness, paralysis, and so on.

(When NPCs (who have only health) suffer Speed or Intellect damage, normally this is treated the same as Might damage. However, the GM or the player has the option to suggest an appropriate alternate effect—the NPC suffers a penalty, moves more slowly, is stunned, and so on.)

The Damage Track As noted above, the damage track has four states: hale, impaired, debilitated, and dead.

Hale is the normal state for a character: all three stat Pools are at 1 or higher, and the PC has no penalties from harmful conditions. When a hale PC takes enough damage to reduce one of their stat Pools to 0, they become impaired. Note that a character whose stat Pools are much lower than normal can still be hale.

Impaired is a wounded or injured state. When an impaired character applies Effort, it costs 1 extra point per level applied. For example, applying one level of Effort costs 4 points instead of 3, and applying two levels of Effort costs 7 points instead of 5.

An impaired character ignores minor and major effect results on their rolls, and they don't deal as much extra damage in combat with a special roll. In combat, a roll of 17 or higher deals only 1 additional point of damage. When an impaired PC takes enough damage to reduce one of their stat Pools to 0, they become debilitated.

Debilitated is a critically injured state. A debilitated character may not take any actions other than to move (probably crawl) no more than an immediate distance. If a debilitated character's Speed Pool is 0, they can't move at all. When a debilitated PC takes enough damage to reduce a stat Pool to 0, they are dead.

Dead is dead.

(The damage track allows you to know how far from death you are. If you're hale, you're three steps from death. If you're impaired, you're two steps from death. If you're debilitated, you are only one small step from death's door.)

Recovering Points in a Pool

After losing or spending points in a Pool, you recover those points by resting. You can't increase a Pool past its maximum by resting—just back to its normal level. Any extra points gained go away with no effect. The amount of points you recover from a rest, and how long each rest takes, depends on how many times you have rested so far that day.

When you rest, make a recovery roll. To do this, roll a d6 and add your tier. You recover that many points, and you can divide them among your stat Pools however you wish. For exam-

ple, if your recovery roll is 4 and you've lost 4 points of Might and 2 points of Speed, you can recover 4 points of Might, or 2 points of Might and 2 points of Speed, or any other combination adding up to 4 points.

The first time you rest each day, it takes only a few seconds to catch your breath. If you rest this way in the middle of an encounter, it takes one action on your turn.

The second time you rest each day, you must rest for ten minutes to make a recovery roll. The third time you rest each day, you must rest for one hour to make a recovery roll. The fourth time you rest each day, you must rest for ten hours to make a recovery roll (usually, this occurs when you stop for the day to eat and sleep).

After that much rest, it's assumed to be a new day, so the

next time you rest, it takes only a few seconds. The next rest takes ten minutes, then one hour, and so on, in a cycle.

If you haven't rested yet that day and you take a lot of damage in a fight, you could rest a few seconds (regaining 1d6 points + 1 point per tier) and then immediately rest for ten minutes (regaining another 1d6 points + 1 point per tier). Thus, in one full day of doing nothing but resting, you could recover 4d6 points + 4 points per tier.

Each character chooses when to make recovery rolls. If a party of five PCs rests for ten minutes because two of them want to make recovery rolls, the others don't have to make rolls at that time. Later in the day, those three can decide to rest for ten minutes and make recovery rolls.

Table 11.2: Recovery Roll

Recovery Roll	Rest Time Needed
1st recovery roll	1 action
2nd recovery roll	10 minutes
3rd recovery roll	1 hour
4th recovery roll	10 hours

Restoring the Damage Track Using points from a recovery roll to raise a stat Pool from 0 to 1 or higher also automatically moves the character up one step on the damage track.

If all of a PC's stat Pools are above 0 and the character has taken special damage that moved them down the damage track, they can use a recovery roll to move up one step on the damage track instead of recovering points. For example, a character who is debilitated from a hit with a cell-disrupting biotech device can rest and move up to impaired rather than recover points in a Pool.

Special Damage In the course of playing the game, characters face all manner of threats and dangers that can harm them in a variety of ways, only some of which are easily represented by points of damage.

Dazed and Stunned: Characters can be dazed when struck hard on the head, exposed to extremely loud sounds, or affected by a mental attack. When this happens, for the duration of the daze effect (usually one round), all of the character's tasks are hindered. Similar but more severe attacks can stun characters. Stunned characters lose their turn (but can still defend against attacks normally).

Poison and Disease: When characters encounter poison—whether the venom of a serpent, rat poison slipped into a burrito, cyanide dissolved in wine, or an overdose of acetaminophen—they make a Might defense roll to resist it. Failure to resist can result in points of damage, moving down the damage track, or a specific effect such as paralysis, unconsciousness, disability, or something stranger. For example, some poisons affect the brain, making it impossible to say certain words, take certain actions, resist certain effects, or recover points to a stat Pool.

Diseases work like poisons, but their effect occurs every day, so the victim must make a Might defense roll each day or suffer the effects. Disease effects are as varied as poisons: points of damage, moving down the damage track, disability, and so on. Many diseases inflict damage that cannot be restored through conventional means.

Paralysis: Paralytic effects cause a character to drop to the ground, unable to move. Unless otherwise specified, the character can still take actions that require no physical movement.

Other Effects: Other special effects can render a character blind or deaf, unable to stand without falling over, or unable to breathe. Stranger effects might negate gravity for the character (or increase it a hundredfold), transport them to another place, render them out of phase, mutate their physical form, implant false memories or senses, alter the way their brain processes information, or inflame their nerves so they are in constant, excruciating pain. Each special effect must be handled on a case-by-case basis. The GM adjudicates how the character is affected and how the condition can be alleviated (if possible).

NPCs and Special Damage The GM always has final say over what special damage will affect an NPC. Human NPCs usually react like characters, but nonhuman creatures might react very differently. For example, a tiny bit of venom is unlikely to hurt a gigantic dragon, and it won't affect an android or a demon at all.

If an NPC is susceptible to an attack that would shift a character down the damage track, using that attack on the NPC usually renders it unconscious or dead. Alternatively, the GM could apply the debilitated condition to the NPC, with the same effect as it would have on a PC.

Attack Modifiers and Special Situations

In combat situations, many modifiers might come into play. Although the GM is at liberty to assess whatever modifiers they think are appropriate to the situation (that's their role in the game), the following suggestions and guidelines might make that easier. Often the modifier is applied as a step in difficulty. So if a situation hinders attacks, that means if a PC attacks an NPC, the difficulty of the attack roll is increased by one step, and if an NPC attacks a PC, the difficulty of the defense roll is decreased by one step. This is because players make all rolls,

whether they are attacking or defending—NPCs never make attack or defense rolls.

When in doubt, if it seems like it should be harder to attack in a situation, hinder the attack rolls. If it seems like attacks should gain an advantage or be easier in some way, hinder the defense rolls.

(Precise ranges are not important in the Cypher System. The broadly defined “immediate,” “short,” “long,” and “very long” ranges let the GM quickly make a judgment call and keep things moving. Basically, the idea is: your target is right there, your target is close, your target is pretty far away, or your target is extremely far away.)

Cover If a character is behind cover so that a significant portion of their body is behind something sturdy, attacks against the character are hindered.

If a character is entirely behind cover (their entire body is behind something sturdy), they can't be attacked unless the attack can go through the cover. For example, if a character hides behind a thin wooden screen and their opponent shoots the screen with a rifle that can penetrate the wood, the character can be attacked. However, because the attacker can't see the character clearly, this still counts as cover (attacks against the character are hindered).

Position Sometimes where a character stands gives them an advantage or a disadvantage.

Prone Target: In melee, a prone target is easier to hit (attacks against them are eased). In ranged combat, a prone target is harder to hit (attacks against them are hindered).

Higher Ground: In either ranged or melee combat, attacks by an opponent on higher ground are eased.

Surprise When a target isn't aware of an incoming attack, the attacker has an advantage. A ranged sniper in a hidden position, an invisible assailant, or the first salvo in a successful ambush are all eased by two steps. For the attacker to gain this advantage, however, the defender truly must have no idea that the attack is coming.

If the defender isn't sure of the attacker's location but is still on guard, the attacks are eased by only one step.

Range In melee, you can attack a foe who is adjacent to you (next to you) or within reach (immediate range). If you enter into melee with one or more foes, usually you can attack most or all of the combatants, meaning they are next to you, within reach, or within reach if you move slightly or have a long weapon that extends your reach.

The majority of ranged attacks have only two ranges: short range and long range (a few have very long range). Short range is generally less than 50 feet (15 m) or so. Long range is generally from 50 feet (15 m) to about 100 feet (30 m). Very long range is generally 100 feet (30 m) to 500 feet (150 m). Greater precision than that isn't important in the Cypher System. If anything is longer than very long range, the exact range is usually spelled out, such as with an item that can fire a beam 1,000 feet (300 m) or teleport you up to 1 mile (1.5 km) away.

Thus, the game has four measurements of distance: immediate, short, long, and very long. These apply to movement as well. A few special cases—point-blank range and extreme range—modify an attack's chance to successfully hit.

Point-Blank Range: If a character uses a ranged weapon against a target within immediate range, the attack is eased.

Extreme Range: Targets just at the limit of a weapon's range are at extreme range. Attacks against such targets are hindered.

(The GM might allow a character with a ranged weapon to attack beyond extreme range, but the attack would be hindered by two steps for each range category beyond the normal limit. Attacks with hard limits, such as the blast radius of a bomb, can't be modified.)

(In certain situations, such as a PC on top of a building looking across an open field, the GM should allow ranged attacks to exceed their maximum range. For example, in perfect conditions, a good archer can hit a large target with a bow and arrow at 500 feet (150 m), much farther than a bow's typical long range.)

Illumination What characters can see (and how well they can see) plays a huge factor in combat.

Dim Light: Dim light is approximately the amount of light on a night with a bright full moon or the illumination provided by a torch, flashlight, or desk lamp. Dim light allows you to see out to short range. Targets in dim light are harder to hit. Attacks against such targets are hindered. Attackers trained in low-light spotting negate this modifier.

Very Dim Light: Very dim light is approximately the amount of light on a starry night with no visible moon, or the glow provided by a candle or an illuminated control panel. Very dim light allows you to see clearly only within immediate range and perceive vague shapes to short range. Targets in very dim light are harder to hit. Attacks against targets within immediate range are hindered, and attacks against those in short range are hindered by two steps. Attackers trained in low-light spotting modify these difficulties by one step in their favor. Attackers specialized in low-light spotting modify these difficulties by two steps in their favor.

Darkness: Darkness is an area with no illumination at all, such as a moonless night with cloud cover or a room with no lights. Targets in complete darkness are nearly impossible to hit. If an attacker can use other senses (such as hearing) to get an idea of where the opponent might be, attacks against such targets are hindered by four steps. Otherwise, attacks in complete darkness fail without the need for a roll unless the player spends 1 XP to “make a lucky shot” or the GM uses GM intrusion. Attackers trained in low-light spotting ease the task. Attackers specialized in low-light spotting ease the task by two steps.

Visibility Similar to illumination, factors that obscure vision affect combat.

Mist: A target in mist is similar to one in dim light. Ranged attacks against such targets are hindered. Particularly dense mist makes ranged attacks nearly impossible (treat as darkness), and even melee attacks are hindered.

Hiding Target: A target in dense foliage, behind a screen, or crawling amid the rubble in a ruin is hard to hit because they're hard to see. Ranged attacks against such targets are hindered.

Invisible Target: If an attacker can use other senses (such as hearing) to get an idea of where the opponent might be, attacks against such targets are hindered by four steps. Otherwise, attacks against an invisible creature fail without the need for a

roll unless the player spends 1 XP to “make a lucky shot” or the GM uses GM intrusion.

Water Being in shallow water can make it hard to move, but it doesn’t affect combat. Being in deep water can make things difficult, and being underwater entirely can seem as different as being on another world.

Deep Water: Being in water up to your chest (or the equivalent thereof) hinders your attacks. Aquatic creatures ignore this modifier.

Underwater Melee Combat: For nonaquatic creatures, being completely underwater makes attacking very difficult. Attacks with stabbing weapons are hindered, and melee attacks with slashing or bashing weapons are hindered by two steps. Aquatic creatures ignore these penalties.

Underwater Ranged Combat: As with melee combat, nonaquatic creatures have problems fighting underwater. Some ranged attacks are impossible underwater—you can’t throw things, fire a bow or crossbow, or use a blowgun. Many firearms also do not work underwater. Attacks with weapons that do work underwater are hindered. Ranges underwater are reduced by one category; very-long-range weapons work only to long range, long-range weapons work only to short range, and short-range weapons work only to immediate range.

Moving Targets Moving targets are harder to hit, and moving attackers have a difficult time as well.

Target Is Moving: Attackers trying to hit a foe who is moving very fast are hindered. (A foe moving very fast is one who is doing nothing but running, mounted on a moving creature, riding on a vehicle or moving conveyance, and so on.)

Attacker Is Moving: An attacker trying to make an attack while moving under their own power (walking, running, swimming, and so on) takes no penalties. Attacks from a moving mount or moving vehicle are hindered; an attacker trained in riding or driving ignores this penalty.

Attacker Is Jostled: Being jostled, such as while standing on a listing ship or a vibrating platform, makes attacking difficult. Such attacks are hindered. Characters trained in balancing or sailing would ignore penalties for being on a ship.

Special Situation: Combat Between NPCs

When an NPC ally of the PCs attacks another NPC, the GM can designate a player to roll and handle it like a PC attacking. Often, the choice is obvious. For example, a character who has a trained attack animal should roll when their pet attacks enemies. If an NPC ally accompanying the party leaps into the fray, that ally’s favorite PC rolls for them. NPCs cannot apply Effort. Of course, it’s perfectly fitting (and easier) to have the NPC ally use the cooperative action rules to aid a PC instead of making direct attacks, or to compare the levels of the two NPCs (higher wins).

Special Situation: Combat Between PCs

When one PC attacks another PC, the attacking character makes an attack roll, and the other character makes a defense roll, adding any appropriate modifiers. If the attacking PC has a skill, ability, asset, or other effect that would ease the attack if it were made against an NPC, the character adds 3 to the roll for each step reduction (+3 for one step, +6 for two steps, and so on). If the attacker’s final result is higher, the attack hits.

If the defender’s result is higher, the attack misses. Damage is resolved normally. The GM mediates all special effects.

Special Situation: Area Attack

Sometimes, an attack or effect affects an area rather than a single target. For example, a grenade or a landslide can potentially harm or affect everyone in the area.

In an area attack, all PCs in the area make appropriate defense rolls against the attack to determine its effect on them. If there are any NPCs in the area, the attacker makes a single attack roll against all of them (one roll, not one roll per NPC) and compares it to the target number of each NPC. If the roll is equal to or greater than the target number of a particular NPC, the attack hits that NPC.

Some area attacks always deal at least a minimum amount of damage, even if the attacks miss or if a PC makes a successful defense roll.

For example, consider a character who uses Shatter to attack six cultists (level 2; target number 6) and their leader (level 4; target number 12). The PC applies Effort to increase the damage and rolls an 11 for the attack roll. This hits the six cultists, but not the leader, so the ability deals 3 points of damage to each of the cultists. The description of Shatter says that applying Effort to increase the damage also means that targets take 1 point of damage if the PC fails the attack roll, so the leader takes 1 point of damage. In terms of what happens in the story, the cultists are caught flat-footed by the sudden detonation of one of their knives, but the leader ducks and is shielded from the blast. Despite the leader’s quick moves, the blast is so intense that a few bits of metal slice them.

Special Situation: Attacking Objects

Attacking an object is rarely a matter of hitting it. Sure, you can hit the broad side of a barn, but can you damage it? Attacking inanimate objects with a melee weapon is a Might action. Objects have levels and thus target numbers. Objects have a damage track that works like the damage track for PCs.

Intact is the default state for an object.

Minor damage is a slightly damaged state. An object with minor damage reduces its level by 1.

Major damage is a critically damaged state. An object with major damage is broken and no longer functions.

Destroyed is destroyed. The object is ruined, no longer functions, and cannot be repaired.

If the Might action to damage an object is a success, the object moves one step down the object damage track. If the Might roll exceeded the difficulty by 2 levels, the object instead moves two steps down the object damage track. If the Might roll exceeded the difficulty by 4 levels, the object instead moves three steps down the object damage track. Objects with minor or major damage can be repaired, moving them one or more steps up the object damage track.

Brittle or fragile objects, like paper or glass, decrease the effective level of the object for the purposes of determining if it is damaged. Hard objects, like those made of wood or stone, add 1 to the effective level. Very hard objects, like those made of metal, add 2. (The GM may rule that some exotic materials add 3.)

The tool or weapon used to attack the object must be at least as hard as the object itself. Further, if the amount of damage

the attack could inflict—not modified by a special die roll—does not equal or exceed the effective level of the object, the attack cannot damage the object no matter what the roll.

11.2.2 Action: Activate a Special Ability

Special abilities are granted by foci, types, and flavors, or provided by cyphers or other devices. If a special ability affects another character in any kind of unwanted manner, it's handled as an attack. This is true even if the ability is normally not considered an attack. For example, if a character has a healing touch, and their friend doesn't want to be healed for some reason, an attempt to heal their unwilling friend is handled as an attack.

Plenty of special abilities do not affect another character in an unwanted manner. For example, a PC might use Hover on themselves to float into the air. A character with a matter-reorganizing device might change a stone wall into glass. A character who activates a phase changer cypher might walk through a wall. None of these requires an attack roll (although when turning a stone wall to glass, the character must still make a roll to successfully affect the wall).

If the character spends points to apply Effort on the attempt, they might want to roll anyway to see if they get a major effect, which would reduce the cost for their action.

11.2.3 Action: Move

As a part of another action, a character can adjust their position—stepping back a few feet while using an ability, sliding over in combat to take on a different opponent to help a friend, pushing through a door they just opened, and so on. This is considered an immediate distance, and a character can move this far as part of another action.

In a combat situation, if a character is in a large melee, they're usually considered to be next to most other combatants, unless the GM rules that they're farther away because the melee is especially large or the situation dictates it.

If they're not in melee but still nearby, they are considered to be a short distance away—usually less than 50 feet (15 m). If they're farther away than that but still involved in the combat, they are considered to be a long distance away, usually 50 to 100 feet (15 to 30 m), or possibly even a very long distance away, usually more than 100 feet to 500 feet (30 to 150 m).

In a round, as an action, a character can make a short move. In this case, they are doing nothing but moving up to about 50 feet (15 m). Some terrain or situations will change the distance a character can move, but generally, making a short move is considered to be a difficulty 0 action. No roll is needed; they just get where they're going as their action.

A character can try to make a long move—up to 100 feet (30 m) or so—in one round. This is a Speed task with a difficulty of 4. As with any action, they can use skills, assets, or Effort to ease the task. Terrain, obstacles, or other circumstances can hinder the task. A successful roll means the character moved the distance safely. Failure means that at some point during the move, they stop or stumble (the GM determines where this happens).

A character can also try to make a short move and take another (relatively simple) physical action, like make an attack. As with the attempt to make a long move, this is a Speed task with a difficulty of 4, and failure means that the character stops

at some point, slipping or stumbling or otherwise getting held up.

Long-Term Movement

When talking about movement in terms of traveling rather than round-by-round action, typical characters can travel on a road about 20 miles (32 km) per day, averaging about 3 miles (5 km) per hour, including a few stops. When traveling overland, they can move about 12 miles (19 km) per day, averaging 2 miles (3 km) per hour, again with some stops. Mounted characters, such as those on horseback, can go twice as far. Other modes of travel (cars, airplanes, hovercraft, sailing ships, and so on) have their own rates of movement.

Movement Modifiers

Different environments affect movement in different ways.

Rough Terrain: A surface that's considered rough terrain is covered in loose stones or other material, uneven or with unsure footing, unsteady, or a surface that requires movement across a narrow space, such as a cramped corridor or a slender ledge. Stairs are also considered rough terrain. Rough terrain does not slow normal movement on a round-by-round basis, but hinders move rolls. Rough terrain cuts long-term movement rates in half.

Difficult Terrain: Difficult terrain is an area filled with challenging obstacles—water up to waist height, a very steep slope, an especially narrow ledge, slippery ice, a foot or more of snow, a space so small that one must crawl through it, and so on. Difficult terrain hinders move rolls and halves movement on a round-by-round basis. This means that a short move is about 25 feet (8 m), and a long move is about 50 feet (15 m). Difficult terrain reduces long-term movement to a third of its normal rate.

Water: Deep water, in which a character is mostly or entirely submerged, hinders move rolls and reduces round-by-round and long-term movement to one quarter its normal rate. This means that a short move is about 12 feet (4 m), and a long move is about 25 feet (7.5 m). Characters trained in swimming halve their movement only while in deep water.

Low Gravity: Movement in low gravity is easier but not much faster. All move rolls are eased.

High Gravity: In an environment of high gravity, treat all moving characters as if they were in difficult terrain. Characters trained in high-gravity maneuvering negate this penalty. High gravity reduces long-term movement to a third of its normal rate.

Zero Gravity: In an environment without gravity, characters cannot move normally. Instead, they must push off from a surface and succeed at a Might roll to move (the difficulty is equal to one-quarter the distance traveled in feet). Without a surface to push off from, a character cannot move. Unless the character's movement takes them to a stable object that they can grab or land against, they continue to drift in that direction each round, traveling half the distance of the initial push.

Special Situation: A Chase

When a PC is chasing an NPC or vice versa, the player should attempt a Speed action, with the difficulty based on the NPC's level. If the PC succeeds at the roll, they catch the NPC (if chasing), or they get away (if chased). In terms of the story,

this one-roll mechanic can be the result of a long chase over many rounds.

Alternatively, if the GM wants to play out a long chase, the character can make many rolls (perhaps one per level of the NPC) to finish the pursuit successfully. For every failure, the PC must make another success, and if they ever have more failures than successes, the PC fails to catch the NPC (if chasing) or is caught (if chased). As with combat, the GM is encouraged to describe the results of these rolls with flavor. A success might mean the PC has rounded a corner and gained some distance. A failure might mean that a basket of fruit topples over in front of them, slowing them down. Vehicle chases are handled similarly.

11.2.4 Action: Wait

You can wait to react to another character's action.

You decide what action will trigger your action, and if the triggering action happens, you get to take your action first (unless going first wouldn't make sense, like attacking a foe before they come into view). For example, if an orc threatens you with a halberd, on your turn you can decide to wait, stating "If it stabs at me, I'm going to slash it with my sword." On the orc's turn, it stabs, so you make your sword attack before that happens.

Waiting is also a good way to deal with a ranged attacker who rises from behind cover, fires an attack, and ducks back down. You could say "I wait to see them pop up from behind cover and then I shoot them."

(Waiting is also a useful tool for cooperative actions (see below).)

11.2.5 Action: Defend

Defending is a special action that only PCs can do, and only in response to being attacked. In other words, an NPC uses its action to attack, which forces a PC to make a defense roll. This is handled like any other kind of action, with circumstances, skill, assets, and Effort all potentially coming into play. Defending is a special kind of action in that it does not happen on the PC's turn. It's never an action that a player decides to take; it's always a reaction to an attack. A PC can take a defense action when attacked (on the attacking NPC's turn) and still take another action on their own turn.

The type of defense roll depends on the type of attack. If a foe attacks a character with an axe, they can use Speed to duck or block it with what they're holding. If they're struck by a poisoned dart, they can use a Might action to resist its effects. If a psi-worm attempts to control their mind, they can use Intellect to fend off the intrusion.

Sometimes an attack provokes two defense actions. For example, a poisonous reptile tries to bite a PC. They try to dodge

the bite with a Speed action. If they fail, they take damage from the bite, and they must also attempt a Might action to resist the poison's effects.

If a character does not know an attack is coming, usually they can still make a defense roll, but they can't add modifiers (including the modifier from a shield), and they can't use any skill or Effort to ease the task. If circumstances warrant—such as if the attacker is right next to the character—the GM might rule that the surprise attack simply hits.

A character can always choose to forgo a defense action, in which case the attack automatically hits.

Some abilities (such as the Countermeasures special ability) may allow you to do something special as a defense action.

11.2.6 Action: Do Something Else

Players can try anything they can think of, although that doesn't mean anything is possible. The GM sets the difficulty—that's their primary role in the game. Still, guided by the bounds of logic, players and GMs will find all manner of actions and options that aren't covered by a rule. That's a good thing.

Players should not feel constrained by the game mechanics when taking actions. Skills are not required to attempt an action. Someone who's never picked a lock can still try. The GM might hinder the task, but the character can still attempt the action.

Thus, players and GMs can return to the beginning of this chapter and look at the most basic expression of the rules. A player wants to take an action. The GM decides, on a scale of 1 to 10, how difficult that task is and what stat it uses. The player determines whether they have anything that might modify the difficulty and considers whether to apply Effort. Once the final determination is made, they roll to see if their character succeeds. It's as easy as that.

As further guidance, the following are some of the more common actions a player might take.

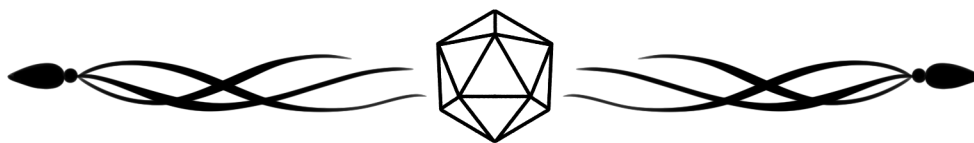
(Players are encouraged to come up with their own ideas for what their characters do rather than looking at a list of possible actions. That's why there is a "do something else" action. PCs are not pieces on a game board—they are people in a story. And like real people, they can try anything they can think of. (Succeeding is another matter entirely.) The task difficulty system provides GMs with the tools they need to adjudicate anything the players come up with.)

Climbing

When a character climbs, the GM sets a difficulty based on the surface being climbed. Climbing is like moving through difficult terrain: the move roll is hindered and the movement is half speed. Unusual circumstances, such as climbing while under fire, pose additional step penalties.

Table 11.3: Climbing Difficulty

Difficulty	Surface
2	Surface with lots of handholds
3	Stone wall or similar surface (a few handholds)
4	Crumbling or slippery surface
5	Smooth stone wall or similar surface
6	Metal wall or similar surface
8	Smooth, horizontal surface (climber is upside down)
10	Glass wall or similar surface



Part II

Appendices

List of Tables

1.1	Task Difficulty	17
2.1	Warrior Stat Pools	19
2.2	Warrior Background Connection	20
2.3	Adept Stat Pools	22
2.4	Adept Background Connection	23
2.5	Explorer Stat Pools	24
2.6	Explorer Background Connection	25
2.7	Speaker Stat Pools	27
2.8	Speaker Background Connection	28
7.1	Animal Form Minor Abilities	99
8.1	Armor Additional Speed Effort	172
8.2	Armor Info	173
8.3	Weapon Damage	173
8.4	Weapons Details	174
8.5	Adventuring Equipment Price	176
8.6	Fantasy Clothing Price	177
8.7	Animals Price	178
8.8	Food and Lodging Price	178
10.1	Timekeeping	186
11.1	Damage from Hazards	189
11.2	Recovery Roll	191
11.3	Climbing Difficulty	196

Index

- Abilities, 79
 - Ability Categories
 - Attack Skill, 79
 - Companion, 80
 - Control, 81
 - Craft, 81
 - Cure, 82
 - Environment, 83
 - Information, 83
 - Meta, 84
 - Movement, 87
 - Protection, 87
 - Senses, 89
 - Social, 90
 - Special Attack, 90
 - Support, 92
 - Task, 93
 - Transform, 95
 - Ability Categories and Relative Power, 79
- Alphabetic
 - A Smile and a Word, 97
 - Able Assistance, 97
 - Absorb Energy, 97
 - Absorb Kinetic Energy, 97
 - Absorb Pure Energy, 97
 - Accelerate, 97
 - Acrobatic Attack, 97
 - Action Processor, 97
 - Adaptation, 97
 - Adroit Cypher Use, 97
 - Advanced Command, 97
 - Advantage to Disadvantage, 97
 - Advantages of Being Big, 97
 - Advantages of Being Small, 97
 - Advice From a Friend, 97
 - Again and Again, 97
 - Ageless, 97
 - Agent Provocateur, 97
 - Aggression, 97
 - Agile Wit, 97
 - All-Out Con, 97
 - Alleviate, 97
 - Alley Rat, 97
 - Always Tinkering, 98
 - Amazing Copying, 98
 - Amazing Effort, 98
 - Amazing Leap, 98
 - Ambusher, 98
 - Amplify Sounds, 98
 - Anecdote, 98
 - Animal Scrying, 98
 - Animal Senses and Sensibilities, 99
 - Animal Shape, 98
 - Answering Attack, 99
 - Anticipate Attack, 99
 - Anticipation, 99
 - Applying Your Knowledge, 99
 - Apportation, 99
 - Aquatic Combatant, 99
 - Arc Spray, 99
 - Arcane Flare, 99
 - Artifact Scavenger, 100
 - Artifact Tinkerer, 100
 - As Foretold in Prophecy, 100
 - As If One Creature, 100
 - Assassin Skills, 100
 - Assassin Strike, 100
 - Asserting Your Privilege, 100
 - Assume Control, 100
 - Athlete, 100
 - Attack and Attack Again, 100
 - Attack Flourish, 100
 - Autodoctor, 100
 - Automatic Glow, 99
 - Awareness, 100
 - Babel, 101
 - Balance, 101
 - Band of Desperados, 101
 - Band of Followers, 101
 - Bash, 101
 - Basic Follower, 101
 - Battle Management, 101
 - Battlefield Tactician, 101
 - Beast Call, 101
 - Beast Companion, 101
 - Beast Eyes, 101
 - Beast Form, 101
 - Beneath Notice, 101
 - Bestiary Knowledge, 101
 - Betrayal, 101
 - Better Living Through Chemistry, 101
 - Better Surprise Attack, 101
 - Bigger, 101
 - Bigger Animal Shape, 101
 - Bigger Beast Form, 102
 - Biomorphic Detonation, 102
 - Biomorphic Healing, 102
 - Blameless, 102
 - Blend In, 102
 - Blessing of the Gods, 102
 - Blind Machine, 102
 - Blinding Attack, 102

- Blink of an Eye, 102
- Block, 102
- Block for Another, 102
- Blood Fever, 102
- Bloodlust, 102
- Blurring Speed, 102
- Body Morph, 103
- Bolster Illusion, 103
- Bolt Rider, 103
- Bolts of Power, 103
- Boost Manifest Cypher, 103
- Boost Manifest Cypher Function, 103
- Bouncing Shield, 103
- Bound Magic Creature, 103
- Brainwashing, 103
- Break the Line, 103
- Break the Ranks, 103
- Break Their Mind, 103
- Breaker, 104
- Brute Strike, 104
- Buddy System, 104
- Built-in Weaponry, 104
- Burning Light, 104
- Burst of Escape, 104
- Bypass Barrier, 104
- Call Dead Spirit, 105
- Call in Favor, 105
- Call Otherworldly Spirit, 105
- Call Swarm, 105
- Call the Storm, 105
- Call Through Time, 105
- Calm, 105
- Calm Stranger, 105
- Capable Warrior, 105
- Captivate or Inspire, 105
- Captivate With Starshine, 105
- Car Surfer, 105
- Careful Aim, 105
- Careful Shot, 105
- Cast Illusion, 105
- Castigate, 105
- Celebrity Talent, 105
- Center of Attention, 105
- Chamber of Dreams, 106
- Change the Paradigm, 106
- Charge, 106
- Charge Weapon, 106
- Charging Horde, 106
- Charm Machine, 106
- Cloak of Opportunity, 106
- Closed Mind, 106
- Cloud Personal Memories, 106
- Coaxing Power, 106
- Cognizant Offense, 106
- Cold Burst, 106
- Colossal, 106
- Combat Challenge, 106
- Combat Prowess, 106
- Command, 106
- Command Beast, 106
- Command Machine, 106
- Command Metal, 107
- Command Spirit, 107
- Communication, 107
- Community Activist, 107
- Community Knowledge, 107
- Computer Programming, 107
- Concussion, 107
- Concussive Blast, 107
- Confidence Artist, 107
- Confounding Banter, 107
- Confuse Enemy, 107
- Conjuration, 107
- Connected, 107
- Contortionist, 107
- Control Machine, 107
- Control Swarm, 107
- Control the Field, 107
- Control the Savage, 107
- Control Weather, 107
- Controlled Change, 107
- Controlled Fall, 108
- Coordinated Effort, 108
- Copy Power, 108
- Counter Danger, 108
- Countermeasures, 108
- Courageous, 108
- Crafter, 108
- Create, 108
- Create Deadly Poison, 108
- Create Water, 108
- Creature Insight, 108
- Critter Companion, 108
- Crowd Control, 108
- Crushing Blow, 108
- Crystal Lens, 108
- Crystalline Body, 108
- Curious, 109
- Cutting Light, 109
- Cypher Casting, 109
- Cypher Surge, 109
- Cyphersmith, 109
- Damage Dealer, 110
- Damage Transference, 110
- Damn the Guilty, 110
- Danger Instinct, 110
- Danger Sense, 110
- Dark Explorer, 110
- Dark Matter Shell, 110
- Dark Matter Shroud, 110
- Dark Matter Strike, 110
- Dark Matter Structure, 110
- Datajack, 110
- Daydream, 110
- Dazing Attack, 110
- Dazzling Sunburst, 110
- Deactivate Mechanisms, 110
- Deadly Aim, 110
- Deadly Strike, 110
- Deadly Swarm, 110
- Death Touch, 110
- Debate, 110
- Debilitating Strike, 111
- Decipher, 111
- Deep Consideration, 111
- Deep Reserves, 111

- Deep Resources, 111
- Deep Water Guide, 111
- Defend All the Innocent, 111
- Defend the Innocent, 111
- Defending Weapon, 111
- Defense Against Robots, 111
- Defense Master, 111
- Defensive Augmentation, 111
- Defensive Blinking, 111
- Defensive Field, 111
- Defensive Phasing, 111
- Define Down, 111
- Deflect Attacks, 111
- Defuse Situation, 111
- Demeanor of Command, 111
- Designation, 111
- Destined for Greatness, 111
- Destroy Metal, 112
- Destroyer, 112
- Detect Life, 112
- Device Insight, 112
- Devoted Defender, 112
- Diamagnetism, 112
- Dimensional Squeeze, 112
- Dirty Fighter, 112
- Disable Mechanisms, 112
- Disappear, 112
- Disarming Attack, 112
- Disarming Strike, 112
- Discerning Mind, 112
- Discipline of Watchfulness, 112
- Disguise, 112
- Disguise Other, 112
- Disincentivize, 112
- Disrupting Touch, 113
- Distance Viewing, 113
- Distant Interface, 113
- Distortion, 113
- Divert Attacks, 113
- Divide Your Mind, 113
- Divine Intervention, 113
- Divine Knowledge, 113
- Divine Radiance, 113
- Divine Symbol, 113
- Do You Know Who I Am?, 113
- Dodge and Resist, 113
- Dodge and Respond, 113
- Double Strike, 113
- Dragon's Maw, 113
- Drain at a Distance, 113
- Drain Charge, 113
- Drain Creature, 113
- Drain Machine, 113
- Drain Power, 113
- Draw Conclusion, 114
- Drawing on Life's Experiences, 114
- Dreadwood, 114
- Dream Becomes Reality, 114
- Dream Thief, 114
- Dreamcraft, 114
- Driver, 114
- Driving on the Edge, 114
- Dual Defense, 114
- Dual Distraction, 114
- Dual Light Wield, 114
- Dual Medium Wield, 114
- Dual Wards, 114
- Duel to the Death, 114
- Duplicate, 114
- Dust to Dust, 114
- Earthquake, 115
- Echolocation, 115
- Effective Skill, 115
- Elastic Grip, 115
- Electric Armor, 115
- Electrical Flight, 115
- Elemental Protection, 115
- Elusive, 115
- Embrace the Night, 115
- Embraced by Darkness, 115
- Enable Others, 115
- Enchanted Movement, 115
- Encouragement, 115
- Encouraging Presence, 115
- Endurance, 115
- Energize Creature, 115
- Energize Crowd, 116
- Energize Object, 116
- Energized Shield, 116
- Energy Protection, 116
- Energy Resistance, 116
- Enhance Strength, 116
- Enhanced Beast Form, 116
- Enhanced Body, 116
- Enhanced Intellect, 116
- Enhanced Intellect Edge, 116
- Enhanced Might, 116
- Enhanced Might Edge, 116
- Enhanced Phased Attack, 116
- Enhanced Physique, 116
- Enhanced Potential, 116
- Enhanced Speed, 116
- Enhanced Speed Edge, 116
- Enlarge, 116
- Enlightened, 116
- Entangling Force, 116
- Enthrall, 116
- Entourage, 116
- Enveloping Shield, 116
- Erase Memories, 117
- Escape, 117
- Escape Plan, 117
- Evanesce, 117
- Evasion, 117
- Everything Is a Weapon, 117
- Exile, 117
- Experienced Defender, 117
- Experienced Finder, 117
- Experienced in Armor, 117
- Expert Crafter, 117
- Expert Cypher Use, 117
- Expert Driver, 117
- Expert Follower, 117
- Expert Pilot, 117
- Expert Skill, 117
- Explains the Ineffable, 117

- Exploit Advantage, 117
Exploratory Experience, 117
Explosive Release, 117
Extra Recovery, 117
Extra Skill, 117
Extra Use, 117
Extreme Mastery, 117
Eye for Detail, 117
Eye Gouge, 118
Eyes Adjusted, 118
Face Morph, 119
Familiarize, 119
Far Step, 119
Fast Kill, 119
Fast Talk, 119
Fast Travel, 119
Faster Wild Magic, 119
Fearsome Reputation, 119
Feat of Strength, 119
Feint, 119
Fellow Explorer, 119
Fetch, 119
Field of Destruction, 119
Field of Gravity, 119
Field-Reinforced Armor, 119
Fiery Hand of Doom, 119
Fight On, 119
Final Defiance, 119
Find an Opening, 119
Find the Guilty, 119
Find the Hidden, 119
Find the Way, 120
Finishing Blow, 120
Fire and Ice, 120
Fire Bloom, 120
Fire Servant, 120
Fire Tendrils, 120
Fists of Fury, 120
Flamboyant Boast, 120
Flameblade, 120
Flash, 120
Flash Across the Miles, 120
Flee, 120
Fleet of Foot, 120
Flesh of Stone, 120
Flex Lore, 120
Flex Skill, 120
Flex Weapon Skill, 120
Flight, 120
Flight Exertion, 120
Flight Not Fight, 120
Fling, 120
Flying Companion, 121
Foil Danger, 121
Font of Healing, 121
Force and Accuracy, 121
Force at Distance, 121
Force Bash, 121
Force Blast, 121
Force Field, 121
Force Field Barrier, 121
Force Field Shield, 121
Force to Reckon With, 121
Force Wall, 121
Fortification Builder, 121
Fortified Position, 121
Foul Aura, 121
Freakishly Large, 121
Free to Move, 121
Freezing Touch, 121
Frenzy, 121
Friendly Help, 121
From the Shadows, 122
Frost Touch, 122
Further Mathematics, 122
Fury, 122
Fusion, 122
Fusion Armor, 122
Gain Unusual Companion, 123
Gambler, 123
Game Lessons, 123
Gamer, 123
Gamer's Fortitude, 123
Gaming God, 123
Gargantuan, 123
Gather Intelligence, 123
Generate Force Field, 123
Get Away, 123
Ghost, 123
Go Defensive, 123
Go to Ground, 123
Goad, 123
Golem Body, 123
Golem Grip, 123
Golem Healing, 123
Golem Stomp, 123
Good Advice, 123
Got a Feeling, 124
Grab, 124
Grand Deception, 124
Grandiose Illusion, 124
Granite Wall, 124
Grasping Foliage, 124
Gravity Cleave, 124
Great Tree, 124
Greater Beast Form, 124
Greater Controlled Change, 124
Greater Designation, 124
Greater Enhanced Intellect, 124
Greater Enhanced Might, 124
Greater Enhanced Physique, 124
Greater Enhanced Potential, 124
Greater Enhanced Speed, 124
Greater Frenzy, 124
Greater Healing Touch, 124
Greater Necromancy, 124
Greater Skill With Attacks, 124
Greater Skill With Defense, 124
Group Friendship, 124
Guide Bolt, 124
Guild Training, 125
Gunner, 125
Hack the Impossible, 126
Hacker, 126
Hand to Eye, 126
Handy, 126

- Hard Choices, 126
- Hard Target, 126
- Hard to Distract, 126
- Hard to Hit, 126
- Hard to Kill, 126
- Hard to See, 126
- Hard-Won Resilience, 126
- Harder Light, 126
- Have Spacesuit, Will Travel, 126
- Heads-Up Display, 126
- Healing Pulse, 126
- Healing Touch, 126
- Hedge Magic, 126
- Heightened Skills, 126
- Hemorrhage, 126
- Heroic Monster Bane, 126
- Hidden Closet, 126
- Hidden Reserves, 126
- Higher Mathematics, 126
- Hold Breath, 126
- Horde Fighting, 126
- Horde Tactics, 127
- Hover, 127
- How Others Think, 127
- Huge, 127
- Hunter's Drive, 127
- Hurl Flame, 127
- Ice Armor, 128
- Ice Creation, 128
- Ice Storm, 128
- Ignition, 128
- Ignore Affliction, 128
- Ignore the Pain, 128
- Illuminating Touch, 128
- Illusory Disguise, 128
- Illusory Duplicate, 128
- Illusory Evasion, 128
- Illusory Selves, 128
- Immovable, 128
- Impart Ideal, 128
- Impart Understanding, 128
- Impersonate , 128
- Impetus, 128
- Impossible Walk, 128
- Impressive Display, 128
- Improved Absorb Kinetic Energy, 128
- Improved Apportation, 128
- Improved Command Spirit, 129
- Improved Companion, 129
- Improved Copying, 129
- Improved Designation, 129
- Improved Edge, 129
- Improved Field Reinforcement, 137
- Improved Gravity Cleave, 129
- Improved Machine Companion, 129
- Improved Monster Bane, 129
- Improved Object Bond, 129
- Improved Recovery, 129
- Improved Sculpt Light, 129
- Improved Sensor, 129
- Improved Success, 129
- Improvise, 129
- In Harm's Way, 129
- Incomparable Pilot, 129
- Increased Effects, 129
- Increasing Determination, 129
- Incredible Feat of Science, 129
- Incredible Health, 129
- Incredible Recovery, 130
- Incredible Running Speed, 130
- Infer Thoughts, 130
- Inferno Trail, 130
- Infiltrator, 130
- Influence Swarm, 130
- Information Gathering, 130
- Informer, 130
- Infuse Spirit, 130
- Inhabit Crystal, 130
- Innate Power, 130
- Innovator, 130
- Insect Eruption, 130
- Insight, 130
- Inspiration, 130
- Inspire Action, 130
- Inspire Aggression, 130
- Inspire Coordinated Actions, 130
- Inspire the Innocent, 130
- Inspiring Ease, 130
- Inspiring Success, 131
- Intelligent Interface, 131
- Intense Interaction, 131
- Interaction Skills, 131
- Interface, 131
- Interruption, 131
- Inventor, 131
- Investigate, 131
- Investigative Skills, 131
- Investigator, 131
- Invisibility, 131
- Invisible Phasing, 131
- Iron Fist, 131
- Iron Punch, 131
- Jaunt, 132
- Juggernaut, 132
- Jump Attack, 132
- Junkmonger, 132
- Jury-Rig, 132
- Just a Bit Mad, 132
- Knock Out, 133
- Know Their Faults, 133
- Know Where to Look, 133
- Knowing, 133
- Knowing the Unknown, 133
- Knowledge Is Power, 133
- Knowledge of the Law, 133
- Knowledge Skills, 133
- Lab Analysis, 134
- Late Inspiration, 134
- Lead by Inquiry, 134
- Lead From the Front, 134
- Learned a Few Things, 134
- Learning the Path, 134
- Legal Intern, 134
- Legerdemain, 134
- Lend Animal Shape, 134
- Lethal Damage, 134

- Lethal Ploy, 134
- Lethal Vibration, 134
- Levity, 134
- Life Lessons, 134
- Like the Back of Your Hand, 134
- Link Senses, 134
- Living Armor, 134
- Living Light, 135
- Living Off the Land, 135
- Living Wall, 135
- Lock, 135
- Lost in the Chaos, 135
- Lunge, 135
- Machine Affinity, 136
- Machine Bond, 136
- Machine Companion, 136
- Machine Efficiency, 136
- Machine Enhancement, 136
- Machine Hunting, 136
- Machine Interface, 136
- Machine Telepathy, 136
- Machine Vulnerabilities, 136
- Magic Shield, 136
- Magic Training, 136
- Magical Repertoire, 136
- Magical Training, 136
- Magnetic Field, 136
- Magnificent Moment, 136
- Major Illusion, 136
- Make Judgment, 136
- Maneuvering Adept, 136
- Mask, 136
- Master Crafter, 136
- Master Cypher Use, 136
- Master Entertainer, 136
- Master Identifier, 136
- Master Machine, 136
- Master of Unarmed Fighting Style, 136
- Master Thief, 136
- Masterful Armor Modification, 137
- Mastery in Armor, 137
- Mastery With Attacks, 137
- Mastery With Defense, 137
- Matter Cloud, 137
- Maximize Cypher, 137
- Mechanical Telepathy, 137
- Medium Teleportation, 137
- Memory Becomes Action, 137
- Mental Link, 137
- Mental Projection, 137
- Mentally Tough, 138
- Meticulous Planner, 138
- Microgravity Adept, 138
- Microgravity Avoidance, 138
- Mind Control, 138
- Mind for Might, 138
- Mind Games, 138
- Mind of a Leader, 138
- Mind Reading, 138
- Mind Surge, 138
- Minor Illusion, 138
- Minor Wish, 138
- Miraculous Health, 138
- Misdirect, 138
- Misdirect Blame, 138
- Mist Cloud, 138
- Mobile Fighter, 139
- Moderate Wish, 139
- Modify Artifact Power, 139
- Modify Cyphers, 139
- Modify Device, 139
- Momentum, 139
- Monster Bane, 139
- Monster Lore, 139
- Moon Shape, 139
- Mount, 139
- Move Metal, 139
- Move Mountains, 139
- Movement Skills, 139
- Moving Like Water, 139
- Multi-Vanish, 140
- Multiple Copying, 139
- Multiple Quarry, 140
- Multiple Skills, 140
- Multiplicity, 140
- Murderer, 140
- Muscles of Iron, 140
- Natural Charisma, 141
- Natural Crafter, 141
- Necromancy, 141
- Negate Danger, 141
- Negotiate, 141
- Network Tap, 141
- Never Fumble, 141
- Nightmare, 141
- Nightstrike, 141
- Nimble Swimmer, 141
- No Need for Weapons, 141
- No One Knows Better, 141
- Noble's Courage, 141
- Not Dead Yet, 141
- Nothing but Defend, 141
- Nullify Sound, 141
- Object Bond, 142
- Object Bond Mastery, 142
- Obstacle Running, 142
- One With the Wild, 142
- Oneirochemistry, 142
- Onslaught, 142
- Open Mind, 142
- Opening Statement, 142
- Opportunist, 142
- Oratory, 142
- Out of Harm's Way, 142
- Outlast the Foe, 142
- Outlaw Reputation, 142
- Outside Reality, 142
- Outwit, 142
- Overawe, 142
- Overcharge Device, 142
- Overcharge Energy, 142
- Overcome All Obstacles, 142
- Overload Machine, 142
- Overwatch, 143
- Parry, 144
- Passing Mechanic, 144

- Patient Recovery, 144
Perfect Control, 144
Perfect Speed Burst, 144
Perfect Stranger, 144
Perks of Stardom, 144
Permanent Illusion, 144
Phase Detonation, 144
Phase Door, 144
Phase Foe, 144
Phase Sprint, 144
Phased Attack, 144
Phased Pocket, 144
Physical Skills, 144
Physically Gifted, 144
Pierce, 144
Pilot, 144
Play to the Crowd, 144
Poetic License, 144
Poison Crafter, 145
Poison Resistance, 145
Post-Apocalyptic Survivor, 145
Power Crash, 145
Power Memory, 145
Power Strike, 145
Powered Armor, 145
Powerful Rhetoric, 145
Practiced in Armor, 145
Practiced With All Weapons, 145
Practiced With Guns, 145
Practiced With Medium Weapons, 145
Practiced With Swords, 145
Precise Cut, 145
Precision, 145
Precognition, 145
Predictive Equation, 145
Predictive Model, 145
Premonition, 145
Preternatural Senses, 145
Privileged Nobility, 145
Projection, 145
Protective Wall, 146
Protector, 146
Pry Open, 146
Psychic Burst, 146
Psychic Passenger, 146
Psychic Suggestion, 146
Psychokinetic Attack, 146
Psychosis, 146
Pull a Fast One, 146
Punish All the Guilty, 146
Punish the Guilty, 146
Push, 146
Push Off and Throw, 146
Push on Through, 146
Quarry, 147
Question the Spirits, 147
Quick Block, 147
Quick Death, 147
Quick Recovery, 147
Quick Strike, 147
Quick Study, 147
Quick Switch, 147
Quick Throw, 147
Quick to Flee, 147
Quick Wits, 147
Quick Work, 147
Quicker Than Most, 147
Rally to Me, 148
Range Increase, 148
Rapid Attack, 148
Rapid Processing, 148
Rapid Recovery, 148
Ray of Confusion, 148
Reaction, 148
Reactive Field, 148
Read the Signs, 148
Reading the Room, 148
Recruit Deputy, 148
Recycled Cyphers, 148
Regenerate, 148
Regenerate Other, 148
Regeneration, 148
Reinforcing Field, 148
Release Energy, 148
Reload, 148
Relocate, 148
Remote Control, 148
Remote Viewing, 149
Repair Flesh, 149
Repel Metal, 149
Reshape, 149
Resilience, 149
Resilient Duplicate, 149
Resilient Ice Armor, 149
Resist the Elements, 149
Resist Tricks, 149
Resist Underwater Hazards, 149
Resonance Field, 149
Resonant Frequency, 149
Resonant Quake, 149
Restful Presence, 149
Restorative Bloom, 149
Restore Life, 149
Resuscitate, 149
Retinue, 149
Retrieve Memories, 149
Return to Sender, 150
Return to the Obelisk, 150
Reveal, 150
Ribbons of Dark Matter, 150
Rider, 150
Roaming Third Eye, 150
Robot Assistant, 150
Robot Builder, 150
Robot Control, 150
Robot Evolution, 150
Robot Fighter, 150
Robot Fleet, 150
Robot Improvement, 150
Robot Upgrade, 150
Ruin Lore, 150
Run and Fight, 150
Runner, 150
Safe Fall, 152
Sailor, 152
Salvage and Comfort, 152

- Scan, 152
- Scramble Machine, 152
- Scratch Existence, 152
- Sculpt Flesh, 152
- Sculpt Light, 152
- Sea Legs, 152
- See History, 152
- See the Future, 152
- See the Unseen, 152
- See Through Matter, 152
- See Through Time, 152
- Seeds of Fury, 152
- Seize the Initiative, 153
- Seize the Moment, 153
- Sense Ambush, 153
- Sense Attitudes, 153
- Sensing Package, 153
- Sensor, 153
- Sensor Array, 153
- Serv-0, 153
- Serv-0 Aim, 153
- Serv-0 Brawler, 153
- Serv-0 Defender, 153
- Serv-0 Repair, 153
- Serv-0 Scanner, 153
- Serv-0 Spy, 153
- Share Defense, 153
- Share Senses, 153
- Share the Power, 153
- Sharp Senses, 153
- Sharp-Eyed, 153
- Shatter, 153
- Shatter Mind, 153
- Shattering Shout, 153
- Shepherd's Fury, 153
- Shield Burst, 153
- Shield Master, 154
- Shield Training, 154
- Ship Footing, 154
- Shipspeak, 154
- Shock, 154
- Short Teleportation, 154
- Show Them the Way, 154
- Shred Existence, 154
- Shrink, 154
- Shrink Others, 154
- Shroud of Flame, 154
- Silent As Space, 154
- Skill With Attacks, 154
- Skill With Defense, 154
- Sleuth, 154
- Slice, 154
- Slip Into Shadow, 154
- Slippery, 154
- Slippery Customer, 154
- Small Flight, 154
- Smaller, 155
- Snap Shot, 155
- Sneak, 155
- Snipe, 155
- Sniper's Aim, 155
- Something in the Road, 155
- Soothe Mind and Body, 155
- Soothe the Savage, 155
- Soul Interrogation, 155
- Sound Conversion Barrier, 155
- Space Fighting, 155
- Speaker for the Dead, 155
- Special Shot, 155
- Specialized Basher, 155
- Specialized Throwing, 155
- Speed Burst, 155
- Speedy Recovery, 155
- Spin Attack, 155
- Spin Identity, 155
- Spirit Accomplice, 155
- Spot Weakness, 156
- Spray, 156
- Spring Away, 156
- Sprint and Grab, 156
- Spur Effort, 156
- Stalker, 156
- Stand Watch, 156
- Stare Them Down, 156
- Stasis, 156
- Stay the Course, 156
- Stealth Skills, 156
- Still As a Statue, 156
- Stimulate, 156
- Stone Breaker, 156
- Store Energy, 156
- Storm Seed, 156
- Straightforward, 156
- Strategize, 156
- Stronger Together, 157
- Stun Attack, 157
- Sturdy, 157
- Subconscious Defense, 157
- Subsonic Rumble, 157
- Subtle Steps, 157
- Subtle Tricks, 157
- Successive Attack, 157
- Suggestion, 157
- Summon Demon, 157
- Summon Giant Spider, 157
- Sun Siphon, 157
- Sunlight, 157
- Superb Explorer, 157
- Superb Infiltrator, 157
- Superior Duplicate, 157
- Surging Confidence, 157
- Surprise Attack, 157
- Swim, 157
- Swipe, 157
- Take Command, 159
- Taking Advantage, 159
- Tall Tale, 159
- Targeting Eye, 159
- Task Specialization, 159
- Task Training, 159
- Taunt Foe, 159
- Teach Trick, 159
- Teamwork, 159
- Tech Skills, 159
- Telekinesis, 159
- Telepathic, 159

- Telepathic Network, 159
- Teleportation, 159
- Teleportation Burst, 159
- Telling, 160
- Temporal Acceleration, 160
- Temporal Dislocation, 160
- Temporary Light, 160
- Terrifying Gaze, 160
- Terrifying Image, 160
- Terrifying Presence, 160
- The Wild Is on Your Side, 165
- There's Your Problem, 160
- Thief's Luck, 160
- Think Your Way Out, 160
- Thinking Ahead, 160
- Third Eye, 160
- Throw, 160
- Throw Enchanted Weapon, 160
- Thrust, 160
- Thunder Beam, 160
- Time Doppelganger, 160
- Time Loop, 161
- Time Travel, 161
- Tinker, 161
- Tiny: When you use Shrink, 161
- Tool Mastery, 161
- Total Awareness, 161
- Totally Chill, 161
- Tough As Nails, 161
- Tough It Out, 161
- Tower of Intellect, 161
- Tower of Will, 161
- Tracker, 161
- Trained Basher, 161
- Trained Excavator, 161
- Trained Gunner, 161
- Trained Interlocutor, 161
- Trained Slayer, 161
- Trained Swimmer, 161
- Trained Without Armor, 161
- Transcend the Script, 161
- Trapfinder, 162
- Trapster, 162
- Travel Skills, 162
- Traverse the Worlds, 162
- Tree Companion, 162
- Tree Travel, 162
- Trick Driver, 162
- Trick Shot, 162
- True Defender, 162
- True Guardian, 162
- True Necromancy, 162
- True Senses, 162
- Trust to Luck, 162
- Tumbling Moves, 162
- Twist of Fate, 162
- Twisting the Knife, 162
- Two Things at Once, 162
- Ultra Enhancement, 163
- Unarmed Fighting Style, 163
- Unarmored Fighter, 163
- Uncanny Luck, 163
- Understanding, 163
- Underworld Contacts, 163
- Undo, 163
- Unexpected Betrayal, 163
- Unmovable, 163
- Unraveling Consumption, 163
- Untouchable, 163
- Untouchable While Moving, 163
- Up to Speed, 163
- Use Senses of Others, 163
- Using the Environment, 163
- Using What's Available, 163
- Usurp Cypher, 163
- Vacuum Skilled, 164
- Vanish, 164
- Verbal Misdirection, 164
- Versatile Mind, 164
- Very Long Sprinting, 164
- Vigilance, 164
- Vigilant, 164
- Vindictive Performance, 164
- Void Wings, 164
- Walk Through Walls, 165
- Wall of Lightning, 165
- Wall With Teeth, 165
- Ward, 165
- Warding Shield, 165
- Water Adaptation, 165
- Weapon and Body, 165
- Weapon Crafter, 165
- Weapon Defense, 165
- Weapon Master, 165
- Weaponization, 165
- Wear It Well, 165
- Weather the Vicissitudes, 165
- Weight of the World, 165
- Weightless Shot, 165
- Weighty, 165
- Weird Science Breakthrough, 165
- Whirlwind of Throws, 165
- Wild Camouflage, 165
- Wild Insight, 165
- Wild Vitality, 166
- Wildcard Powers, 166
- Wilderness Awareness, 166
- Wilderness Encouragement, 166
- Wilderness Explorer, 166
- Wilderness Life, 166
- Wilderness Lore, 166
- Will of a Leader, 166
- Will of Legend, 166
- Willing Sacrifice, 166
- Wind Armor, 166
- Wind Chariot, 166
- Windrider, 166
- Windwacked Traveler, 166
- Wing Weapons, 166
- Wings of Fire, 166
- Winter Gauntlets, 166
- Wooden Body, 166
- Word of Command, 166
- Word of Death, 166
- Work the Friendship, 167
- Wormhole, 167

- Wound Tender, 167
- Wraith Cloak, 167
- Wreck, 167
- Wrest From Chance, 167
- You Studied, 168
- Zero Dark Eyes, 169
- Assets, 183
- Core Rules, 9
 - Introduction, 9
 - Character Descriptor, Type and Focus, 13
 - Character Stats, 11
 - Character Tiers, 13
 - Combat, 9
 - Creating Your Character, 11
 - Cyphers, 11
 - Defense Task, 15
 - Experience Points, 11
 - Glossary, 10
 - How to Play Cypher System, 9
 - Other Dice, 11
 - Player Intrusion, 15
 - Range and Speed, 10
 - Skills, 14
 - Special Abilities, 14
 - Special Rolls, 10
 - Type, 15
 - When Do You Roll?, 9
- Cyphers and Artifacts, 179
 - Artifacts, 179
 - Cyphers, 179
- Descriptors, 37
 - Appealing, 38
 - Beneficent, 38
 - Brash, 38
 - Calm, 38
 - Chaotic, 39
 - Charming, 39
 - Clumsy, 39
 - Craven, 40
 - Creative, 40
 - Cruel, 40
 - Dishonorable, 41
 - Doomed, 41
 - Empathic, 41
 - Exiled, 42
 - Fast, 42
 - Foolish, 42
 - Graceful, 42
 - Guarded, 43
 - Hardy, 43
 - Hideous, 43
 - Honorable, 43
 - Impulsive, 44
 - Inquisitive, 44
 - Intelligent, 44
 - Intuitive, 45
 - Jovial, 45
 - Kind, 45
 - Learned, 45
 - Lucky, 46
 - Mad, 46
 - Mechanical, 46
 - Mysterious, 46
 - Mystical, 47
 - Naive, 47
 - Perceptive, 47
 - Resilient, 47
 - Risk-taking, 48
 - Rugged, 48
 - Sharp-eyed, 48
 - Skeptical, 48
 - Stealthy, 49
 - Strong, 49
 - Strong-willed, 49
 - Swift, 49
 - Tongue-tied, 49
 - Tough, 50
 - Vicious, 50
 - Virtuous, 50
 - Weird, 50
- Die, 183
- Distance, 185
 - Other Distances, 185
- Effort, 183
- Encounters, Rounds, And Initiative, 187
 - Actions, 187
 - Activate a Special Ability, 194
 - Attack, 188
 - Defend, 195
 - Do Something Else, 195
 - Move, 194
 - Wait, 195
 - Ambient Damage, 189
 - Armor, 188
 - Attack Modifiers and Special Situations, 191
 - A Chase, 194
 - Area Attack, 193
 - Attacking Objects, 193
 - Combat Between NPCs, 193
 - Combat Between PCs, 193
 - Cover, 192
 - Illumination, 192
 - Moving Targets, 193
 - Position, 192
 - Range, 192
 - Surprise, 192
 - Visibility, 192
 - Water, 193
 - Damage, 188
 - Damage from Hazards, 189
 - Restoring the Damage Track, 191
 - Special Damage, 191
 - The Damage Track, 190
 - The Effect of Taking Damage, 190
- Equipment, 171
 - Adventuring Equipment Descriptions, 175
 - Armor, 172
 - Fantasy Armor Descriptions, 172
 - Using Armor, 172
 - Currency and Prices, 171
 - Fantasy Clothing Descriptions, 177
 - Level of Equipment, 171
 - Miscellaneous Items and Services, 176

- Price Categories, 171
- Using the Price Categories, 171
- Weapons, 173
 - Explosive Weapons, 175
 - Fantasy Weapons Descriptions, 173
- Fantasy Character Options, 31
 - Prepared vs. Spontaneous Spellcasting, 32
- Focus, 53
 - Choosing Foci, 53
 - Creating New Foci, 68
 - Abilities That Reference Other Abilities, 69
 - Ability Guidelines are not Prescriptive, 69
 - Ability Swap, 69
 - Balancing Activities, 69
 - Choose GM Intrusions, 70
 - Choosing Abilities By Relative Power, 69
 - Concept and Category, 69
 - Creating Brand-New Abilities, 70
 - Focus Categories, 68, 70
 - Customizing Foci, 78
 - Foci, 55
 - Abides in Stone, 55
 - Absorbs Energy, 55
 - Awakens Dreams, 56
 - Battles Robots, 56
 - Bears a Halo of Fire, 56
 - Blazes with Radiance, 56
 - Brandishes an Exotic Shield, 56
 - Builds Robots, 56
 - Calculates the Incalculable, 56
 - Channels Divine Blessings, 56
 - Commands Mental Powers, 57
 - Conducts Weirds Science, 57
 - Consorts with the Dead, 57
 - Controls Beasts, 57
 - Controls Gravity, 57
 - Copies Superpowers, 57
 - Crafts illusions, 57
 - Crafts Unique Objects, 57
 - Dances with Dark Matter, 58
 - Defends The Gate, 58
 - Defends the Weak, 58
 - Descends From Nobility, 58
 - Doesn't Do Much, 58
 - Drives Like A Maniac, 58
 - Emerged From the Obelisk, 58
 - Employs Magnetism, 58
 - Entertains, 58
 - Exists in Two Places at Once, 59
 - Exists Partially Out of Phase, 59
 - Explorer Dark Places, 59
 - Fights Dirty, 59
 - Fights With Panache, 59
 - Flies Faster Than a Bullet, 59
 - Focuses Mind Over Matter, 59
 - Fuses Flesh and Steel, 59
 - Fuses Mind and Machine, 59
 - Grows to Towering Heights, 60
 - Has a Thousand Faces, 60
 - Helps Their Friends, 60
 - Howls at the Moon, 60
 - Hunts, 60
 - Ignores Physical Distance, 60
 - Infiltrates, 60
 - Interprets the Law, 60
 - Is Idolized by Millions, 61
 - Is Licensed to Carry, 61
 - Is Wanted by the Law, 61
 - Keeps a Magic Ally, 61
 - Leads, 61
 - Learns Quickly, 61
 - Lives in the Wilderness, 61
 - Looks for Trouble, 61
 - Loves The Void, 62
 - Masters Defense, 62
 - Masters Spells, 62
 - Masters the Swarm, 62
 - Masters Weaponry, 62
 - Metes Out Justice, 62
 - Moves Like a Cat, 62
 - Moves Like the Wind, 62
 - Murders, 63
 - Needs No Weapon, 63
 - Never Says Die, 63
 - Operates Undercover, 63
 - Performs Feats of Strength, 63
 - Pilots Starcraft, 63
 - Plays Too Many Games, 63
 - Rages, 63
 - Rides the Lightning, 64
 - Runs Away, 64
 - Sailed Beneath the Jolly Roger, 64
 - Scavenges, 64
 - Sculpts Hard Light, 64
 - Sees Beyond, 64
 - Separates Mind From Body, 64
 - Shepherds Spirits, 65
 - Shepherds the Community, 64
 - Shreds the Walls of the World, 65
 - Shrinks to Minute Size, 65
 - Siphons Power, 65
 - Slays Monsters, 65
 - Soars on Amazing Wings, 65
 - Solves Mysteries, 65
 - Speaks for the Land, 65
 - Stands Like a Bastion, 66
 - Stretches, 66
 - Takes Animal Shape, 66
 - Talks to Machines, 66
 - Throws With Deadly Accuracy, 66
 - Thunders, 66
 - Touches the Sky, 66
 - Travels Through Time, 66
 - Uses Wild Magic, 68
 - Walks the Wild Woods, 68
 - Was Foretold, 67
 - Wears a Shen of Ice, 67
 - Wears Power Armor, 67
 - Wields an Enchanted Weapon, 68
 - Wields Invisible Force, 67
 - Wields Two Weapons at Once, 67
 - Works for a Living, 67
 - Works Miracles, 67
 - Works the Back Alleys, 67
 - Works the System, 68

- Would Rather Be Reading, 68
 - Focus Connections, 53
 - Story Behind the Focus, 55
- Further Customisation, 33
 - Drawbacks and Penalties, 33
 - Flavors, 33
 - Combat Flavor, 35
 - Magic Flavor, 35
 - Skills and Knowledge Flavor, 36
 - Stealth Flavor, 33
 - Technology Flavor, 34
 - Modifying Type Aspects, 33
- GM Intrusion, 184
- Initial Cost of a Roll, 185
- Major Effect, 184
- Minor Effect, 184
- Retrying Rolls, 184
- Rules of the Game, 181
 - Key Concepts, 181
- Skills, 183
- Space Hazards, 189
 - Asteroid/Debris Field, 190
 - Black Hole, 189
 - Gravity Well, 189
 - Radiation Belt/Solar Flare, 189
- Special Rolls, 183
- Task Difficulty, 182
 - Modifying Stat Difficulty, 182
- Task Stat, 182
- Timekeeping, 185
- Types, 19
 - Adept, 21
 - 1st Tier Adept, 22
 - 2nd Tier Adept, 22
 - 3rd Tier Adept, 22
 - 4th Tier Adept, 23
 - 5th Tier Adept, 23
 - 6th Tier Adept, 23
 - Adept Example, 24
 - Background Connection, 22
 - Player Intrusions, 22
 - Stat Pools, 22
 - Explorer, 24
 - 1st Tier Explorer, 24
 - 2nd Tier Explorer, 25
 - 3rd Tier Explorer, 26
 - 4th Tier Explorer, 26
 - 5th Tier Explorer, 26
 - 6th Tier Explorer, 26
 - Background Connection, 24
 - Explorer Example, 26
 - Player Intrusions, 24
 - Stat Pools, 24
 - Speaker, 27
 - 1st Tier Speaker, 27
 - 2nd Tier Speaker, 27
 - 3rd Tier Speaker, 28
 - 4th Tier Speaker, 28
 - 5th Tier Speaker, 28
 - 6th Tier Speaker, 29
 - Background Connection, 27
 - Player Intrusions, 27
 - Speaker Example, 29
 - Stat Pools, 27
 - Warrior, 19
 - 1st Tier Warrior, 19
 - 2nd Tier Warrior, 20
 - 3rd Tier Warrior, 20
 - 4th Tier Warrior, 20
 - 5th Tier Warrior, 21
 - 6th Tier Warrior, 21
 - Background Connection, 19
 - Player Intrusions, 19
 - Stat Pools, 19
 - Warrior Example, 21